Indian Hermeneutics of Suspicion

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Edited by
Francis Arackal

Association of Christian Philosophers of India

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Contents

Introduction vii
Keynote Address xiii

Part 1: Indian Hermeneutics of Suspicion: Conceptual Clarifications 1

1. "A Hermeneutics of Suspicion as a Tool for Transformation of Society" 3
Ashley Miranda
2. The Suspicious Indian: Programmatic, Pragmatic and Prophetic Critique 15
Keith D'Souza
3. Re-inventing Hermeneutics of Suspicion from Contemporary Indian Realities 29
Victor Ferrao
4. From Śṛamaṇism to Scholactivism: The Future of Indian Hermeneutics of Suspicion 45
Martin Sebastian Kallungal
5. Independent Thinking and the Politics of Knowledge-Production 59
Johnson J. Puthenpurackal

Part 2: Indian Hermeneutics of Suspicion: Thematic Developments 71

6. Science as a Hermeneutical Enterprise: Implications for India, Science, and Humanity 73
S. Stephen Jayard
7. *Cârvâka* as an Indian Philosophical System with Scientific Outlook: A Critical Analysis Focusing on *Cârvâka's* Stance on Consciousness 85
Gregory Mathew Malayil
8. *SphoṬa* Theory of Meaning and Its Relevance Today 97
Ivan D'Souza

9. Sacred India Losing the Sense of Sacredness: An Ecological Perspective 111
Wyman Gonsalves
10. The Indian Media: Watchdog or Lapdog? 123
Francis Arackal Thummy
11. Challenging the Process of A-signification of Tribal Land 137
Raju Felix Crasta
12. Alternative Interpretations of the *Ramayana* 151
Gayatri Mendanha and Ananya Dutta

Part 3: Indian Hermeneutics of Suspicion: Insightful Leaders 165

13. Against Indian Majoritarianism - The Views of Ambedkar as the Leader of the Little Flock 167
James Ponniah
14. Gandhian Hermeneutics of Suspicion 179
John Peter Vallabadoss
15. Asghar Ali Engineer: A Muslim with a Difference 191
Jose Pennaparambil
16. Bishop as a Patriot: Azariah's Negotiations Between Indigenization and Nationalism 205
Jose D Maliekal, SDB
17. Re-Claiming Sree Narayana Guru for a Kerala Today 219
Biju Pallippadan
18. 'Deconstruction' in J. Krishnamurthy's Teachings: A Hermeneutical Approach 231
Kamladevi Kunkolienkar
19. Osho's Redefinition of Spirituality: A Necessary Paradigm Shift to End Religious Violence in Multi-Religious India 243
Varadhai Xavier
20. Kancha Ilaiah and Post-Hindu India: Possibilities and Challenges 257
James D. Chellappa
21. The Tenets of Humanism in Different Stalwarts 265
S. Sekar Sebastin
22. "Creative and Critical (Un) Reading of Dravidianism – Caldwell and Periyar" 279
Antonysamy Thomai

Contributors 289
Index

Introduction

Philosophy is about asking questions though satisfactory answers may never be found. Today, we live in a society where persons who ask questions are either banished from society or eliminated altogether. We have become acutely aware of the Right to Information (RTI) activists who were murdered; and judges and journalists (the latest being Gauri Lankesh) who sought to stand for truth being eliminated. Or the rationalists – Kalburgi, Dhabolkar, Pansare – who were done away with. Their lives and their martyrdom remind each of us that no human being endowed with a rational faculty should accept anything or anyone on face-value.

Anything in this world can be a matter of interpretation; the list of matters that can be interpreted is endless. In Philosophy, the subject-matter of interpretation are thoughts which are related to the physical and the metaphysical realms. From time immemorial human beings have conjured up innumerable thoughts. Successive generations have interpreted them for what they themselves are or what they mean in a particular context or situation. Such rational activities by the human mind gave rise to various systems, and Schools of thought both in the West and the East.

We cannot really separate the thoughts and their originators. Hence, when a thought is being interpreted its originator too is subjected to interpretation. In the present volume, we have two broad categories which are considered under the hermeneutics of suspicion: Systems and Individuals. Before we introduce each of them briefly let us take a look at the very origin of the phrase 'hermeneutics of suspicion': Paul Ricoeur coined the phrase 'hermeneutics of suspicion' to capture a common thread running through great thinkers such as Karl Marx, Sigmund Freud, and Friedrich Nietzsche. Ricoeur argued that in spite of their obvious differences these thinkers jointly constitute a 'school of suspicion'. That is to say, they share a commitment to unmasking 'the lies and illusions of consciousness'; "they are the architects of a distinctively modern style of interpretation that circumvents obvious or self-evident meanings in order to draw out less visible and less flattering truths."[1]

Ricoeur produced an enormous corpus of work on literature, history, historiography, politics, theology and ethics, all the while debating 'truth' and ethical solutions to life. At the same time, he was aware of the widespread and growing suspicion about whether such a search is either possible or worthwhile. Hence, it came as no surprise that later in his life he distanced himself from hermeneutics of suspicion and took to the 'hermeneutics of recovery'.

In the same spirit of clarifying the term 'hermeneutics of suspicion' the first paper in this volume written by Ashley Miranda speaks about "A Hermeneutics of Suspicion as a Tool for Transformation of Society". Miranda tells us that a 'hermeneutic of suspicion' must not give way to a 'culture of suspicion'; instead it must be directed to the creation of a 'civilization of trust'. It is obvious that Marx, Freud, and Nietzsche, the three great 'masters of suspicion' used hermeneutics as a tool for transformation of society. For instance, all three of them were vehemently critical of religion, which in effect helped to purify some of the religious practices in their own life-time and still later. Miranda on the other hand, drawing inspiration from Bernard Lonergan, explores how 'hermeneutics of suspicion' can actually be a tool for the transformation of society.

Keith D'Souza's paper appears somewhat in the same vein, especially when the reader comes to the third suspicion – Prophetic suspicion – that he mentions. According to D'Souza, "prophetic critique is aimed at integral social wellbeing - it involves self-critique as well as the desire to build bridges across borders rather than favour sectarian perspectives and strategies". The other two suspicions that he elaborates – Programmatic and Pragmatic - in his paper in fact amplifies the significance and relevance of prophetic suspicion in India and the world over at the present critical moment.

The next paper by Victor Ferrao, 'Re-inventing Hermeneutics of Suspicion from Contemporary Indian Realities' highlights the dominance of 'programmatic suspicion', which is being spearheaded by a "Brahmino-centric" world-view, which is an unfortunate contemporary Indian reality. "The brahmino-centricity has grown into a body where all aspects of our life have become its organs. Everything – [debates around nationalism, beef politics, women's attires, vedic science, love jihad, etc.] in contemporary India is an organ of a brahminical body", claims Ferrao.

Martin Kallungal highlights Ricoeur's distinction between a "hermeneutics of recollection and hermeneutics of suspicion". The latter can and should give rise to scholar-activists. Hence, Kallungal proposes in his paper 'from Śṛamaṇism to Scholactivism: The Future of Indian Hermeneutics of Suspicion' that "Indian philosophers have to become scholar-activists if they wish to continue the legacy of the great ancient activist hermeneuts of suspicion such as Śṛamaṇās, Nairuktakās, Mīmāmsakās, and so on".

Independent thinking enables hermeneutics of suspicion, argues Johnson Puthenpurackal in his paper 'Independent Thinking and the Politics of Knowledge-Production'. "The need and urgency to think critically and differently on the way knowledge got 'shaped'" produced hermeneuts of suspicion in the past. Such a need exists even in our time, especially in the Indian context. Puthenpurackal's paper makes an attempt "towards bringing to light the dark situation of truth and knowledge being controlled and manipulated, against which the ideal of independent thinking" is proposed.

Having introduced the papers which to some extent threw some light on the whole concept of the 'hermeneutics of suspicion', let us take a brief glimpse into the papers which deal with entire systems, which can be examined from the point of view of the said concept and later the individuals who can be viewed from a vantage point of the same concept. Stephen Jayard presents science as a hermeneutical enterprise discussing its implications for India, for science itself, and for humanity. Jayard's paper makes an attempt to discuss: a) the very existential nature of the hermeneutical dimension of science, with the example of the complex nature of matter, and b) to spell out some implications of such understanding of science for both the enterprise of science and humanity as well.

Gregory Mathew Malayil argues for Cârvâka (an Indian Philosophical System) as having a scientific outlook. By presenting a critical analysis focusing on Cârvâka's stance on consciousness Malayil says Cârvâka is unique as an ancient scientific school of thought, which had the potentials to initiate research in material science.

Ivan D'Souza highlights the spirit of hermeneutics of suspicion through the theory of *Sphoṭa*. According to D'Souza, *Sphoṭa* is the integral linguistic symbol which is the unit of meaning but which cannot be written or pronounced. The theory is being revisited for our context today to critique and challenge the social, cultural, and political situations of India.

Vandana Shiva has been one of the leading environmental activists of India. She has published many works on environmental protection. Wyman Gonsalves does a detailed study of these works and argues that from an ecological perspective sacred India is losing the sense of sacredness.

According to the Social Responsibility Theory of the Press, the media is supposed to be a watchdog of all that goes on in society, especially the government. In a democracy this role gets amplified more than in other forms of government. For the press is the fourth pillar of democracy. Taking a critical look at the Indian media Francis Arackal Thummy bemoans the loss of the watchdog role of the Indian media and states that it has become like a lapdog.

Raju Felix Crasta's paper aims to critically reflect the nature of tribal land, the life associated with it, the complications involved when it is dispossessed, and the purpose behind the systematic denigration of tribals. Crasta is of the

firm view that tribals wherever they are, should hold on to their language, culture, ethnicity, and values which will be the real weapons to combat the forces of evil out to destroy them.

The *Ramayana* is a text that opens itself up to several interpretations, both within the text as well as in the several "tellings" of this relatively straightforward narrative. Ananya Dutta's and Gayatri Mendanha's paper titled 'Alternative Interpretations of Ramayana' returns to the living tradition of the *Ramayana* which has always been one of a hermeneutics of suspicion, according to the authors. Quoting Dinesh Sakalani, Dutta and Mendanha emphasize that a living tradition in flux warrants that "no interpretation of the Indian past can be claimed as a final and authentic one."

James Ponniah's paper 'Against Indian Majoritarianism - The Views of Ambedkar as the Leader of the Little Flock' draws one's attention to Ambedkar's critique of Hindu majoritarianism which showed its ugly head at the time of India's Independence and partition. Ambedkar feared that as far as Dalits are concerned – whom he considered as a minority–the British masters will be replaced by the majoritarian Indian masters (the Hindus) that would then dominate and rule. The paper is all the more relevant for today since majoritarian chauvinism has raised its ugly head as never before.

A Gandhian hermeneutics of suspicion is vivid in critiquing all that is non-Indian: Western systems and notions, and outmoded traditions. At the same time it offers an alternative vision. Gandhi's suspicion about the relevance of modern ideas to a country like India provides a systemic, insightful, significant, and relevant interpretation of traditions, argues John Peter Vallabadoss in his paper 'Gandhian Hermeneutics of Suspicion'.

Jose Pennaparambil is of the view that Asghar Ali Engineer is an exceptional Islamic progressive Indian thinker of the 21st century. He is a Muslim with a difference because of his bold and radical approach to Islam. Pennaparambil in his paper 'Asghar Ali Engineer – A Muslim with a Difference' goes on to add that Engineer's contribution to the reform movements in Islam is commendable and unparalleled, especially in the field of secularism, human rights, inter-faith dialogues, women empowerment, and Islamic democratic thinking.

Jose D. Maliekal's paper 'Bishop as a Patriot: Azariah's Negotiations between Indigenization and Nationalism' describes the courageous negotiations undertaken by Bishop Azariah in Dornakal and surrounding areas. The paper challenges one – drawing inspiration from Azariah – to embark on a journey towards the emergence of a post-denominational and post-ritual indigenous Indian Church.

The paper 'Re-Claiming Sree Narayana Guru for the Kerala of Today' aims to enable the readers to an emphatic understanding of the role and

contributions of Sree Narayana Guru in awakening the socio-religious consciousness of the *Ezhavas* in their historical struggles in getting acceptance and respect in Indian society. The author Biju Pallippadan hopes that the paper would contribute to a deeper understanding of the socio-religious situation of Kerala in the 21st century.

Kamaladevi Kunkolienkar in her paper '"Deconstruction" in J. Krishnamurthy's Teachings: A Hermeneutical Approach' makes an attempt to present Krishnamurthy as a 'master of suspicion' in the light of the 'deconstruction' of traditionally established epistemological forms and a traditional understanding of religion and God that he aimed at.

Varadhai Xavier, drawing inspiration from Osho's hermeneutics of suspicion, forcefully argues that the new existence-based spirituality propounded by Osho would make our common religious environment still richer whereby peaceful coexistence of all religions will be possible. Xavier's paper titled 'Osho's Redefinition of Spirituality: A Necessary Paradigm Shift to End Religious Violence in Multi-Religious India' makes an attempt to present a paradigm shift in the foundational principle of spirituality, a shift from old paradigms of religions to a new paradigm of spirituality.

James D. Chellappa in his paper 'Kancha Ilaiah and Post-Hindu India: Possibilities and Challenges' reflects on Ilaiah's political philosophy, his critique of Hindutva and presents Ilaiah's views on "why he is not a Hindu". According to Chellappa, Ilaiah has exhorted "the Dalits to join with other downtrodden communities such as the OBCs, tribals, and SCs and revolt against the oppressors even if it leads to violence".

One of the hermeneutic suspicions to be highlighted concerns humanism focusing on some leading thinkers, who firmly support the cause of human persons. Humanism as a trend or philosophy contains different tenets with its own suspicion developed and presented by different thinkers, states Sekar Sebastin in his paper titled 'The Tenets of Humanism in Different Stalwarts'. Robert Caldwell and E.V. Ramasamy Periyar are considered two great thinkers-defenders of Dravidianism. Both of them are said to have rendered enormous service for the upliftment of low-caste people and worked for the empowerment of women, writes Antonysamy Thomai in his paper, 'Creative and Critical (Un) Reading of Dravidianism – Caldwell and Periyar'.

Ram Puniyani, in his key-note address highlighted the conflict between Indian Nationalism and Hindu Nationalism. Indian Nationalism which had its origin in the independence movement and thereafter embraced by the Indian population in general is sought to be replaced by Hindu Nationalism by a section of Hindus, being ideologically influenced by the Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh (RSS) and its affiliate organizations. Ultimately, Hindu Nationalism is a divisive political ploy to grab power at the Centre and in the

States in order to implement the Sangh agenda, devised mainly by the upper-castes, with the purpose of creating a Hindu Rashtra, which seeks to infiltrate and dominate every aspect of Indian life, whereby the minorities, Dalits, and Tribals will be condemned to the status of second-class citizens.

At the end of reading all these very useful and relevant papers especially in the Indian cultural, political, and social context of today there might be a lingering question in the readers' mind: Is there a real difference between 'critique' and 'hermeneutics of suspicion'? If so what is it? And what is the rationale for preferring one term over the other? Critique is generally employed in literary and cultural studies whereas hermeneutics of suspicion has a philosophical connotation to it. Besides, the latter term gives the impression of being more in-depth than critique. More importantly, hermeneutics of suspicion convey a specific social concern, which critique does not immediately imply this. As Ashley Miranda pointed out in the first paper, the hermeneutics of suspicion is a tool used for social transformation. This is the denotation that is running through almost all the papers in this volume.

I am immensely grateful to all the contributors to this volume. They have invested much time and intellectual energy to write and re-write these papers in spite of their busy schedules. I am thankful in a very special way to Dr. Keith D'Souza, President of the Association of Christian Philosophers of India (ACPI) for his timely facilitations to get the papers ready, for his constant support, and valuable suggestions throughout the process of getting this volume ready. My thanks go also to the Executive Committee of ACPI for entrusting me with the task of editing this book. Finally, I thank the co-publishers, Christian World Imprints (CWI) for their association towards bringing out this collection and for working on it with professionalism. May this volume encourage its readers to commit themselves to "prophetic suspicion", for the betterment of local communities, the nation, and the larger human family.

Notes

1 Rita Felski, 2012 <http://journal.media-culture.org.au/index.php/mcjournal/article/view/431./0> 10 May 2018.

Keynote Address

Ram Puniyani

1. Introduction

The concepts of Nationalism influence citizenship and have a great impact on the human rights. Lately, Hindu nationalism has started impacting the nature of state and citizenship in a very strong way. The origin of Hindu nationalism can be traced to the colonial period. During this period, when the rising freedom movement was articulating the concepts and values of Indian nationalism, the section of Hindus, from the kings of princely states and upper caste elite to begin with, kept aloof from freedom movement and asserted the concept of Hindu Nationalism. Hindu nationalism is political and a category with a specific meaning and agenda of the RSS-BJP.

2. Hindu Nationalism: Historical Roots

During the colonial period, rising classes of industrialists, businessmen, workers, and educated classes came together and formed different organizations like Madras Mahajan Sabha, Pune Sarvajanik Sabha, Bombay Association, etc. These organizations felt the need for an overarching political organization and so they went on to form the National Congress in 1885. The declining sections of society, Muslim and Hindu landlords and kings, also decided to come together to oppose the all inclusive politics of Congress, which in due course eventually became the major vehicle of the values of the freedom movement. These declining sections were feeling threatened due to the social changes. To hide their social decline they they projected that their religion. They also did not like the Congress, who were standing up to the colonial masters, who had started putting forward demands/proposals to different social

groups and thereby for India. Congress saw this country as 'India is a Nation in the making.'[1]

As per the declining sections of landlords and kings: standing up to the ruler, not bowing in front of, is against the teachings of 'our' religion of 'our' religion. Therefore, what was needed according to them, was to promote loyalty to the British. They, i.e. the Hindu and came together and formed the United India Patriotic Association in 1888. The lead was taken by Nawab of Dhaka and Raja of Kashi. Later, due to British machinations, the Muslim elite from this association separated and formed the Muslim league in 1906, while in parallel to this the Hindu elite first formed the Punjab Hindu Sabha in 1909 and then the Hindu Mahasabha in 1915. These communal formations argued for Muslim Nationalism and Hindu nationalism respectively. Hindu nationalists also developed the political ideology of Hindutva, articulated particularly by Savarkar in 1923 in his book 'Hindutva or 'Hindutva or Who is a Hindu?' is a Hindu?' This was an enviable situation for British, as such groups would weaken the rising national movement. Therefore, on one side the British quietly supported the Muslim League but on the other they handled they handled Hindu Mahasabha with velvet gloves.[2]

Taking a cue from the ideology of Hindutva, the RSS came up in 1925, with the path of Hindu Nationalism and goal of Hindu Nation. The values of rising classes embodied in the persona of Bhagat Singh, Ambedkar, Gandhi, Maulana Abul Kalam Azad and many others, mainly revolved around Indian Nationalism built around the principles of Liberty, Equality, and Fraternity. The ideology of the Muslim League selectively drew from some Muslim traditions to assert the caste and gender hierarchy of feudal society. On the other hand, the Mahasabha and RSS had tomes like the Manusmriti to talk about similar graded hierarchies of caste and gender. Muslim and Hindu communalists were not part of the freedom movement as as it was all inclusive and aimed at secular democratic values. Muslim and Hindu communalists drew from glories of therir respective kings of the past and so kept aloof from the anti-British struggle; struggle; however, some exceptions are always there to show the evidence of their participation in the freedom struggle.[3]

Gandhi's attempt to draw the masses in to anti-British struggle was the major point due to which the Constitutionalists like Jinnah, the traditionalists of Muslim League and the Hindu Mahasabha further drifted away and consolidated themselves after the 1920s. The trajectory of Hindu Nationalism from the decade of 1920 becomes very clear; to be on the side of the British and to oppose the Muslim Nationalists. The same applies to the Muslim League, as it regarded Congress as a Hindu party. The Eventually, the freedom of the country and tragic partition led to the Muslim Leaguers going to Pakistan while leaving sufficient backlog to sustain Muslim communalism here. Hindu Nationalists in the form of the Hindu Mahasabha and RSS gradually started

asserting themselves, beginning with the murder of Mahatma Gandhi, who surely was amongst the best of the Hindus of that century and probably of many a centuries put together. Hindu Nationalists Hindu Nationalists first formed the Jan Sangh and later the present BJP. The major issue taken up by these nationalists was opposition to cooperative farming, public sector, and the undertaking of a programme called the 'Indianization of Muslims'.[4]

Identity related issues have been the staple diet for religious nationalist tendencies. 'Cow as our mother,' Ram Temple, Ram Setu, abolition of article 370, and the uniform Civil Code have been the foundation around which emotive hysterical movements have been built.[5] While they keep bringing to our notice as to under whose rule more riots have taken place, one forgets that the root of communal violence lies in a 'hate other' ideology spread by communal streams. And most of the communal violence has led to the coming to power of a communal party. Its major offshoot is polarization of communities along religious lines. Modi's claim that democracy leads to polarization is misplaced and wrong, as in democratic politics, polarization is along social issues like we see in the Republican-Democrat parties in America. Polarization around social policies and political issues is part of the process of democracy. The polarization brought about by the politics of Hindu Nationalism or Muslim Nationalism is around the identity of religions. This is not comparable to the processes in the US or UK. The polarization along religious lines is against the spirit of democracy, and against Indian Constitution. A major pillar of democracy is Fraternity, which cuts across across identities of religion, caste, and region.

Modi-BJP is part of Hindu nationalist ideology. They gloss over the fact that the large mass of Indian people, i.e. Hindus, never called and do not call themselves Hindu Nationalists. Gandhi was not a Hindu Nationalist despite being a Hindu in the moral and social sense. Maulana Abul Kalam Azad was not a Muslim nationalist, despite being a devout Muslim and a Muslim scholar of highest caliber. During the freedom movement also, most of the people of all religions identified with Indian Nationalism and not with religious nationalism as being projected by Modi and company. Even today, people of different religions identify with Indian Nationalism and not with religious nationalism on the lines of Modi and his ilk. The nationalism practiced by Azad and Gandhi is inclusive.[6]

Hindu Nationalism will require a Ram Temple; Indian Nationalism requires schools, universities and factories for employing the youth. Hindu Nationalism is exclusive and divisive, Indian Nationalism is inclusive and unitive, rooted in the issues of this world, that too not the identity related ones. Unfortunately, Hindu nationalists have been raising the pitch around identity issues undermining the issues of the poor and marginalized. Indian Nationalism, the product of our freedom movement, is being challenged by

the Hindu Nationalism in India and Buddhist Nationalism in Myanmar and Sri Lanka, and is a major threat to the process of democratization; Muslim Nationalism Muslim Nationalism has wrecked havoc in Pakistan, and many other places.

Incidentally, we are living in the dark tunnel of History, where such invocations of religion in the arena of politics take a semi-respectful place, as is being witnessed in many parts of the World and more so in India.. One hopes the distinction between religious nationalism and Indian Nationalism will not be lost in focus!

Hindu Nationalism, does not subscribe to affirmative action, and so the term appeasement of minorities has been floated. For Hindu nationalists, the proactive supportive action for vulnerable religious minorities is a strict no, while for democratic nationalism, this is the norm. One has to see the clever ploy of the Prime Minister Modi is already elected...this word needs to be removed or substituted accordingly to call himself a Hindu nationalist. This is one more attempt to indulge in dividing the Indian society along religious lines.

3. Hindu Nationalism in the Political Arena

Bharatiya Jansangh was the first political party floated by Shyama Prasad Mukherjee of the Hindu Mahasabha with some Pracharaks, like Deen Dayal Upadhyay, Atal Bihari Vajpayee and L.K. Advani, who came from RSS. Its major agenda was that of opposing cooperative farming and public sector industries. It tried to put forward a Hindutva agenda later, through supporting a cow slaughter ban. It also demanded that the Muslims of India should be Indianized. Its golden moments came when the socialist Jaya Prakasha Narayan allied with Jansangh's parent organization to launch a movement. After the lifting of emergency, Janasangh merged into Janata Party, which won a massive victory and many of its leaders became ministers in the Central cabinet.

Soon, there was a demand from erstwhile socialists that Jansangh members give up their membership of RSS, to which they responded by leaving the Janta Party and regrouping as the Bharatiya Janata Party. This party put forward the agenda of Gandhian Socialism.[7] It was not on electoral path till it picked up the agenda of the Ram temple. With the temple becoming its agenda it started climbing up the path of power and after the Babri demolition it got unprecedented success at elections. It first formed a minority government in 1996, which lasted 13 days, then again in 1998, when they lasted for 13 months. Finally in 1999, they came to power as NDA, in alliance with many other parties. With its defeat in 2004, it went into a bit of hibernation till 2014, when it emerged with substantial majority in the Lok Sabha.

4. Modi Sarkar: BJP's Coming to Power with Majority

The change in the ruling dispensation (May 2014) (May 2014) affected more than one aspect of the social-cultural-political map of India. Narendra Modi won the elections (2014) with an electoral success, 282 seats for BJP, with 31% of vote polled, which is a landmark for a party after nearly 30 years. It took meticulous meticulous planning to come to power and there were many factors which contributed to their ascent. One was the communal polarization carried forward from the Gujarat carnage of 2002; this went right up to the one witnessed in Muzaffarnagar 2013. The unrestrained support of the corporate world was another, as Modi had given all the facilities to the to them in Gujarat and elsewhere in the country. Corporates in 2007 declared that they would like to see Modi as the future Prime Minister of India. The backbone for the campaign was lakhs of RSS volunteers, who acted as the steel frame of the campaign. The projected factor that helped BJP win nationally was the myth of Gujarat's development, the so-called 'Gujarat Model'. In fact however, there was nothing on the ground to call it a 'model'. The media management and discrediting of the ruling Congress as a corrupt party, portraying its youthful leader Rahul Gandhi as 'Pappu' by the BJP IT cell IT cell, were effective tools for swinging the votes in BJP's favor. RSS-BJP-Modi dreamt to form a Hindu nation trampling upon the values of the Indian Constitution, which has laid the foundation of a democratic ethos, which has provided the ground for social transformation of caste-gender.[8]

4.1 Pattern of Power

The previous time, in 1999, when BJP came to power as the head of the NDA, it did not have a simple majority; therefore it suspended it did not have the simple majority so it suspended its 'Hindutva' agenda. This Hindutva agenda stands for the abolition of Article 370, passing of the Uniform Civil Code, and building of the Ram Temple on the site where the Babri Masjid stood. From 2014, with the majority in parliament, the march towards this Hindutva agenda has been unleashed. Modi has already instilled an authoritarian streak in the new government. Secretaries of different departments have been asked to directly report to him, and he has not permitted the meeting of the Cabinet in his absence, which was the norm with previous governments. Though there is a Cabinet, major power is being centralized around the prime minister.

4.2 *Acche Din*

The major plank of winning the elections was the slogan of *Acche Din* (Good Times). The people at large, who were victims of the rising prices and inflation (due to very high prices of oil in the international market), were sold the dream of better days in the offing with the victory of Modi. The relentless rise in prices

(though oil prices came down drastically in the international market) despite Modi coming to power has created a sense of disillusion amongst the people; since high hopes were created earlier through propoganda. Demonetization jobs from the common man. Introduction of the GST has affected traders in a big way has affected the traders in a big way as the taxes are very high now. FDA in retail has been raised from 26% to 49% in a single swoop. While in While in opposition, BJP was opposing these both. Privatization of of the public sector is being steadily unrolled with the privatization of Air India well underway. The desired amendments to the Land Acquisition Bill (2013) were going to affect the interests of the farmers in a very adverse way. The proposed amendments were to dilute the consent of a majority of farmers, so as to acquire land for the so-called development.

4.3 Changed Dispensation: Sectarian Mindset

Many times we express more by keeping silence than by by speaking. The Pune techie Mohsin Sheikh's muder, allegedly by the Hindi Jagran Sena, was part of a well designed communalization process. The violence in Saharanpur, Rampur, and other parts of UP and some parts of MP were part of the process to process of communalizing assembly areas, which were going to face the polls soon. The silence of the Prime Minister on these issues is more than eloquent. It gives signals which are not very healthy. There are scattered incidents which give us a more realistic glimpse of the Modi Sarkar. The shrewdest part of the new government is that it has solid backing of vast Sangh Parivar, so that it can speak in different languages; these different tongues make the whole picture confusing for the audience. In case of the tennis star Sania Mirza being appointed as the brand ambassador of the newly formed Telangana state, the BJP leaders on TV openly opposed this saying that she is the daughter-in-law of Pakistan, while the top level functionaries of the government said that she is the pride of the nation.

Similarly, one of the outstanding lawyers, Gopal Subramaniam was denied the judgeship in Supreme Court. Gopal Subramaniam as an Amicus Curie in the Supreme Court had brought out the connection between Soharabuddin's fake encounter, the present BJP President, and Modi's confidante Amit Shah. Gopal was also criticized by Subramaniam Swami, a top BJP leader, on the grounds that Gopal had hurt the Hindu sentiments on the Ram Setu issue. The Minorities Affairs Minister Najma Heptulla went on to declare that Muslims are not a minority while Parsis are. One knows that the provision of minorities should be for deprived sections; Muslims do fall in the category while the miniscule Parsis do not the category.[9]

4.4 Education

All said and done the major impact of Hindu nationalist politics is going to be the changes in education, which will alter the thinking pattern of the coming generations. The goal is to instill a pattern in consonance with the Brahminical norms, to promote an orthodox medieval mind set and to undermine the scientific temper. One recalls that in the previous BJP led NDA regime, apart from other things, its major impact was the changes in the history and social science books, where the divisive history taught in RSS shakhas, the communal history, the history where the kings are looked at through the prism of religion, was introduced. One knows that the communal historiography introduced by the British was the main tool in implementing their 'divide and rule' policy which formed the ideology of the communal streams of the Muslim League and Hindu Mahasabha-RSS. This type of history, by focusing on the glories of 'our' kings, also promotes the feudal values of caste and gender hierarchy. Mercifully, the BJP led NDA lost in 2004 and the rational, national historiography was brought back.

Now already there are signs that RSS volunteers are out to change the total education system and the content of history, social sciences and other books. Even before this government came to power, with the rise of Modi on the political firmament, with the perception that he is likely to come to power, the Right wing organizations intensified their offensive against genuine scholarship. Dinanath Batra, by now is a well known name; he has been heading the RSS outfits, Shiksha Bachao Abhiyan Samiti and RSS-affiliated Shiksha Sanskriti Utthan Nyas (SSUN) since many decades. He succeeded in pressuring Penguin, the World's largest publisher, to pulp Wendy Doniger's scholarly book 'The Hindus: An Alternate History'. This book brings out, through the interpretation of mythology, the need to understand the caste and gender aspects in a sensitive manner. The history she has focused on goes against the hierarchical mind set of the RSS and so combine and so pressure was put to pulp it. Now Mr. Batra emerges as a writer himself and a set of nine books written by him have been translated into Gujarati and was introduced in 42,000 schools in Gujarat. This may be a trial run before doing similar things at a larger scale. Former BJP president and Union Minister M. Venkaiah Naidu (the present Vice-President of India) had explicitly stated in as early as June 23, 2013 that "it (the BJP) will change textbook syllabi, if it returns to power". Batra is also quoted as saying that a nationalistic education system has to be developed to address the requirements and through this we have to develop a young generation that is committed to Hindutva and Nationalism".

The sampling of Batra's books gives a good idea of what is in store for us. A quote from one of the set of books, 'Tejonmaya Bharat', (Radiant Bharat) tells us the "America wants to take the credit for invention of stem cell research,

but the truth is that India's Dr. Balkrishna Ganpat Matapurkar has already got a patent for regenerating body parts…You would be surprised to know that this research is not new and that Dr. Matapurkar was inspired by the Mahabharata. Kunti had a bright son like the Sun itself. When Gandhari, who had not been able to conceive for two years, learnt of this, she underwent an abortion. From her womb a huge mass of flesh came out. (Rishi) Dwaipayan Vyas was called. He observed this hard mass of flesh and then he preserved it in a cold tank with specific medicines. He then divided the mass of flesh into 100 parts and kept them separately in 100 tanks full of ghee for two years. After two years, 100 Kauravas were born of it. On reading this, he (Matapurkar) realized that stem cell was not his invention. This was found in India thousands of years ago. (Page 92-93)"[10]

Indian rishis, using their yogvidya, would attain *divyadrishti (divine vision)*. There is no doubt that the invention of television goes back to this! In the Mahabharata, Sanjaya sitting inside a palace in Hastinapur and using his divyashakti, would give a live telecast of the battle of battle of Mahabharata to the blind Dhritarashtra (Page 64). Further, what we know today as the motorcar existed during the Vedic period. It was called anashvarath. Usually a rath (chariot) is pulled by horses but an anashvarath means the one that runs without horses or yantra-rath, what is today a motorcar. The Rig Veda refers to this (Page 60).

The RSS has already set up a consultative body called the Bharatiya Shiksha Niti Ayog (BSNA) to put pressure on Modi's government to "correct or Indianize" the national education system. In the new syllabus "the passages in the textbooks which pointed out to any unsavory aspect of the Hindu faith like the oppressive caste system in ancient Hindu society, untouchability of the low-caste people and consumption of beef during Vedic ages were scrapped, and anyone who resisted or opposed the changes was dubbed as 'anti-national.'.[11]

4.5 Caste and Gender

While these changes in the text books give us a full idea of the agenda of this government, which will have to follow the guidelines set by its parent organization, a further manifestation of their agenda can be seen in the appointment of Prof. Y. Sudarshan Rao as the chief of ICHR. This national body guides the research into Indian history. Prof. Rao is not much known in the circles of academic history, as he has hardly written any academic, peer reviewed papers or books. He has been engaged with writing a few blogs on his understanding of history, which is more of a fiction suiting the agenda of Hindu Rashtra, in particular, the reinstating of the caste system. In one of his blogs he emphasizes that caste system served the society very well and there are no complaints against it. As per his observations, "Most of the questionable

social customs in the Indian society as pointed out by the English educated Indian intellectuals and the Western scholars could be traced to this period of Muslim rule in north India spanning over seven centuries." He argues that "the (caste) system was working well in ancient times and we do not find any complaint from any quarters against it." This is a distortion. The customs related to caste oppression were integral to the so-called Hindu scriptures: Vedas (Rig Veda, Purush Sukta) Upanishad,[12] the scriptures which were written in the Pre-Historic period. Even in the Manusmriti the caste division is well articulated. The Manusmriti was written around 1-2 Century CE. Contrary to this Prof. Rao states that distortion in the caste system came with the coming of the Muslim kings. He had so far been working on proving the historicity of our mythological Mahabharat as a part of history. Interestingly, the RSS unitedly present only one version of the Ramayana but there are nearly 400 versions of it. The scholarly essay by A. K. Ramanujam on the diversity of the Ramayana was withdrawn from the Delhi University curriculum, and the publisher was forced to withdraw the book.

With the coming of this government the peripheral elements have started talking about making these scriptures as a part of our curriculum. Justice Dave talks about bringing in the Gita and others are talking of Ramayana. Both these holy tomes have heavy projections of caste. In Gita, Lord Ram? talks of taking birth whenever Dharma is in danger. And this Dharma is Varnashram Dharma (Varna system). In Ramayana Lord Ram kills Shambuk, as Shambuk a Shudra is doing penance and this is something not permitted by the Caste system.

4.6 Fringe Elements or Division of Labor

VHP supremo and RSS member Ashok Singhal has also called Modi "an ideal swayamsevak" (RSS worker) and emphatically declared that Muslims must respect the sentiments of the Hindu culture, threatening that "they cannot survive for long by opposing Hindus". He has also asked Muslims to give up their claims on Ayodhya, Mathura, and Kashi. The idea is to reduce Muslims to second class citizens with no privileges and rights. Another firebrand VHP leader Pravin Togadia, known for his 'hate speeches,' has endorsed these views by issuing a warning to the Muslims, saying they may have forgotten the 2002 Gujarat riots but would remember the Muzaffarnagar riots of last year.[13]

On the long term agenda of RSS-BJP-Modi one needs to see the statement of RSS worker Joshi, "During a question-and-answer session, a volunteer asked Yadavrao Joshi, then the head of Sangh workers across all of south India, "We say RSS is a Hindu organisation. We say we are a Hindu nation, India belongs to Hindus. We also say in the same breath that Muslims and Christians are welcome to follow their faith and that they are welcome to remain as they are so long as they love this country. Why do we have to give this concession? Why don't we be very clear that they have no place if we are

a Hindu country?" Joshi replied, "As of now, RSS and Hindu society are not strong enough to say clearly to Muslims and Christians that if you want to live in India, convert to Hinduism. Either convert or perish. But when the Hindu society and RSS will become strong enough we will tell them that if you want to live in India and if you love this country, you accept that some generations earlier you were Hindus and come back to the Hindu fold."[14]

So where are we heading to becomes clear with Modi Sarkar in power. The government will be trying to stick to the language which will be subtle while undertaking steps in Hinduization gradually. Its associates, VHP-RSS will tell us bluntly about their agenda. Needless to repeat that this agenda being unfolded is that of a Hindu nation, where religious minorities will be relegated to secondary position and the Chaturvarnya system will be slipped will be slipped in, in a subtle manner.

4.7 Lynching and More Lynchings

The major expression of the BJP agenda is exhibited in the ongoing lynchings in the name of cow, beef and the merciless beatings of Dalits on the issues related to their trade.

The lynching of Junaid (June 2017) in the outskirts of Delhi, in a train, did come as a saturation point in the conscience of large sections of society. To express their anguish people came to streets in great numbers in a largely spontaneous protest - 'Not in My name'. While many people criticized and undermined this expression of pain and anguish of the sections of society, it did catch the attention of the national and international media. The result was that the Prime Minister who was keeping silence on the issue came forward to say that 'violence in the name of the Cow is not acceptable'; and that Mahatma Gandhi would not have approved it. This bland statement was hardly of any effect as just few hours after this, two more Muslims were sent to death in Jharkhand.[15]

The earliest such statement from the Prime Minister was after the lynching of Mohammad Akhlaq (October 2015). At that time, as well, nearly two weeks after the lynching he opened his mouth on the issue. That statement was also bland and hardly had any effect on the *Gautankwad* (terrorism related to cow protection) as lynchings continued. So either Mr. Modi is ineffectual in controlling his cabal, the Hindu nationalists involved in such violence, or that they also know that the Prime Minster is making such statements for namesake, as an eye-wash, and that they can continue their business irrespective.

Mr. Amit Shah, the BJP President, defending the present regime said that the lynchings taking place in earlier regimes in 2011, 2012, and 2013 were more in number. This is a total lie. According to the data collected by India Spend, based on the content analysis of media reporting,

"Muslims were the target of 51% of violence centered on bovine issues over nearly eight years (2010 to 2017) and comprised 86% of 28 Indians killed in 63 incidents. As many of 97 per cent of these attacks were reported after Prime Minister Narendra Modi's government came to power in May 2014, and about half the cow-related violence — 32 of 63 cases –were from states governed by the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) when the attacks were reported, revealed our analysis of violence recorded until June 25, 2017."[16]

How easily Mr. Shah wants to distort the facts to defend the present government!

In case of lynchings in the name of the cow, the factors involved are multiple. With the rise of Hindu nationalist politics many Dalits were earlier killed in Gohana (Haryana) for example when they were skinning a dead cow. Adding on to this agenda of polarizing society on the issue of cow, the last few years since Modi Sarkar has come to power there have been overt statements for Gau Raksha (Cow Protection). While the laws of cow slaughter ban had already been there, with the BJP's ascendancy, the laws these laws underwent a rigid twist, along with demonization of those eating beef. In Gujarat, the first laboratory of Hindu Rashtra, even the consumption of non-vegetarian food had been looked down upon. Now all over the 'holiness of Mother Cow' is being propagated and imposed on the society with state patronage.

In the context of Akhlaq's lynching Mr. Mahesh Sharma, the Union Culture Minister, stated that the murder was an accident. He was also the one to go and put the tricolor on the body of the accused in the murder, when he died in the prison due to some illness. Another BJP leader, Mr. Sangeet Som had threatened that if those who had been arrested for Akhlaq's murder were punished, a befitting reply would be given.

What are the major observations on these cases of lynchings? Eating beef, slaughtering cows, and transporting them had been the major pretext for violence. The victims of this constructed anger are mostly Muslims, while Dalits have also been flogged and tortured. Muslims are presented as beef eaters, cruel, not respecting Hindu sentiments about the cow, apart from other biases which have already been spread against them. The social scene has been so constructed that due to these biases and regular instigations, the popular adage, 'innocent until proved guilty' has been made to stand on its head and to mean 'guilty unless proved innocents' for Muslims. The 'silent social sanction' for the killings and the upholding of the act is couched under the pretext of the 'defense of Hindu religion' and now the Hindu symbol of cow rules the roost. The benign animal is the pretext for ghastly violence. To jack up their agenda there are false claims by the BJP spokesperson that Gandhi wanted a cow slaughter ban. He opposed the idea on the ground that there are many who consume beef, and that the country belongs to all.[17]

Lynchings are not just a law and order problem. These are a part of, or rather byproduct of a Hindu nationalist propaganda against Muslims. The propaganda pertains to the Holiness of the Cow and Muslims violating that. It is not a coincidence that such brutal acts have become part of the social phenomenon, after Modi came to power. Gradually the intensity has been intentionally, and deliberately stepped up. Beginning from Modi's own statements about the Pink revolution, of the greatness of Rana Pratap as he gave his life for the protection of cows, to the demonization of Muslims in the name of the Cow, it makes clear as to what is the underlying social psychology which leads to these acts. The claims of 'good governance' bite the dust in the light of these atrocities.

4.8 Modi Regime: Authoritarian or Fascist?

Since this dispensation, Modi Sarkar, has come to power there is a qualitative change in the political scenario. Right at the beginning we witnessed many attacks on Churches. We saw interference in the institutions of national importance like FTII, IITs, IIMC, ICHR, Film Censor Board, JNU, and HCU among many others. The incompetent persons with 'right wing' leanings were installed and have been brought in at most of these. The places of learning are a special target. The JNU was targeted labeling it as the den of anti-nationals. A cooked up video was used to defame the student leaders of JNU, in HCU Rohith Vemula had to commit suicide. The growing intolerance led to the returning of awards by luminaries of our society. The issue of beef was raised sky-high; the emotive hysterical projections were propped up leading to the death of Mohammad Akhlaq, many other traders, and later the dastardly attack on the Dalits in Una in Gujarat. Many sections of the media have been brow beating the liberals and secular elements while giving a free run to Hindu nationalists.

To begin with the dominance of the corporate and doing away with the rights of workers and farmers, along with undermining schemes like MNREGA, Right to Food, Right to Health and Right to Education show that the orientation of this government is to ally with the big capital. The complimentary part of this phenomenon is the promotion of Hindu Nationalism. Right from the word go, the sentence, 'I am a nationalist and I am born in a Hindu family' by Modi set the tone and shape of things to come. The ultra-nationalism is manifest in the handling of Kashmir and relations with Pakistan in particular. The use of Uri and consequent surgical strike to bloat the chest of this political dispensation is very much in the air. The permissions of thousands of NGOs working in the social sector have been stopped on frivolous grounds. The attack on Pakistani artists is another instance where sectarian nationalism is having an unrepentant march. It is to be remembered that we have bilateral trade to the tune of thousands of crores with Pakistan. With China similar sentiments have been flashed by talking about boycott of Chinese goods, despite the fact

that the contract of a proposed Sardar Patel statue, running into thousands of crores, has been given to China. The popular sentiments are being guided into negativity and hate towards neighboring countries, religious minorities and the human rights activists.

The stifling of democratic freedoms, welfare of the poor, the intimidation of minorities, and human rights defenders are running parallel to the creation of mass hysteria and mobilization of masses to uphold the agenda of the ruling party. Those questioning the State are being put in the dock. In a democracy, the State is answerable to the people. Now this formula is being reversed. In a democracy questioning the authorities is the bedrock of the Constitution. So something is seriously amiss, something which is more sinister than the emergency. Something which has deeper portents for democracy is being legitimized and glorified by the ruling party and the parent organization of the ruling party.

So how does one characterize it is the matter not of mere academic concern. Recently CPM leader Prakash Karat had stated that the present dispensation is mere authoritarian and not fascist.[18] The distinction between the two has been a matter of historical debate. The main features of fascism has been centrality of state over people, overarching Leader, dominance of the Corporate, doing away with the rights of poor, targeting of minorities, ultra-nationalism, and aggressive policies towards the neighbors. The crucial point for those wanting to preserve the democracy and Indian Constitution is to build up social and political alliances, irrespective of some differences, to fight this raging politics of hate, a politics of sectarian nationalism.

During the 1990s, BJP did project itself as a '*Party with a Difference,*' and that is so much true. It is the only party whose agenda is guided by the Hindu nationalist RSS, which rejects democracy and secularism as Western imports and wants to stick to the laws of Hindu Holy Scriptures. These scriptures are the same, one of which was burnt by Ambedkar as a mark of protest against its values of caste and gender hierarchy, and values of Brahminism. Debates can continue but politics to defend the Indian Constitution cannot wait!

4.9 Anti-Dalit Atrocities

During these years the atrocities on Dalits have been manifest in various forms. One recalls that during this time Ambedkar Periyar Study Circle was banned in IIT Madras. In Hyderabad Central University, the anti-Dalit policies of the administration led to the institutional murder of Rohith Vemula and to cap it all the Holy Cow agenda of this politics led to the brutal beatings of Dalits in Una, Gujarat.[19] The politics of Hindu Nationalism is the polar opposite of the path and goal of those oppressed by the caste system. One recalls Bhimrao Ambedkar, standing for social justice; democracy went on to support the burning of Manusmriti, while it has been the core book eulogized by RSS

ideologues like M. S. Golwalkar. It is people like Golwalkar who opposed the formation of the Indian Constitution on the grounds that we already have a 'wonderful' constitution in the form of the Manusmriti. While Ambedkar said that the Gita is Manusmriti in a nut shell, this government is promoting Gita to the hilt.

5. Conclusion

The last four years have shown that the BJP led NDA Government is working as per the agenda of RSS, the agenda of Hindu nation. In most of the arena of social and political life the policies of the government are leading to a marginalization of religious minorities and undermining the policies of social welfare. Dalits are equal victims in the recent times. The need to save freedom of expression, tolerance, the upholding of democratic norms of affirmative action need to be brought to the fore in times to come.

Notes

1 http://www.frontline.in/the-nation/the-making-of-india/article9511551.ece
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Part 1

Indian Hermeneutics of Suspicion: Conceptual Clarifications

"A Hermeneutics of Suspicion as a Tool for Transformation of Society"

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Abstract: This paper proposes the thesis that 'hermeneutics of suspicion' is part of the larger quest for truth and authenticity. It is part of the human effort to create a more just, equitable, and humane society. India today needs men and women who have the courage to challenge the dominant narratives, to think differently, to propose alternative ways of perceiving reality and of living our lives. Using insights from Ricoeur, this paper goes on to point out that suspicion and skepticism are not the same thing. Suspicion is a strategy that seeks to prepare the ground for a 'new reign of truth'. Suspicion and the quest for the truth are part of the same dynamic. However, the link between the two is fragile. It does not take much, for what is primarily a form of ascesis for the renewal and infusion of new life and spirit within communities, to decay into something that is energy draining and radically self defeating. A 'hermeneutic of suspicion' must not give way to a 'culture of suspicion'; instead it must be directed to the creation of a 'civilization of trust'. Drawing inspiration from Lonergan this essay explores how this can be done.

Books are passé! Not in the sense that people don't read anymore but because books do not have the social impact they once had. Books, and other forms of print media such as magazines, journals, newspapers are not about to go extinct, even though it is very possible that one or two of these 'print-forms' could end up as museum pieces. Social media has taken the world by storm. In fact, social media has redefined what we mean by the world. It has turned

the world upside down and has blurred the distinction between real and unreal, between fact and fiction, between truth and untruth.

Books and other forms of print media came with a certain credibility. It was assumed that books and news articles were the fruit of unbiased observation, careful research, and objective judgment. The fact that something was found in a book or even in a newspaper or newsmagazine meant that it was true, at least in its main claims. Of course, this did not mean that all books agreed on a particular issue or that all newspaper articles carried the very same account of particular events. Multiple interpretations and rival versions were accepted as part of the social effort to get to the heart of any matter. Different views and interpretations had to be backed with reasons, balanced arguments, and convincing evidence.

Books and newspapers, by and large, inspired trust and confidence. People found them credible and it was these media, and also the television in the last forty years or so, that shaped their understanding of the world, of right and wrong, of good and bad, of true and untrue. But the new social media has changed all that.

Social media has been amazing; first of all in its 'wild-fire' character, and secondly in how it has changed our perception of the world. Social media has put news, information, history, wisdom, even science into the hands of the common man and woman. It has 'democratized the social space,' as one commentator puts it.[1] In addition to this, it first blurred and then practically wiped out the distinction between the creators of information and consumers of information. This is definitely a good thing. Prior to the advent of social media, others - i.e. 'those who has power' - determined what was newsworthy and what was not. They also determined who was newsworthy and who was not. Social media has changed both the what and the who. Simple people, who did not matter, could now enjoy their moments in the spot light. To add to this, social media gave them a podium from which to express their views on various matters ranging from the trivial to the profound, from the private to the social to the political. So much for the wonders and the magic of social media!

Media pundits have different regarding the purpose of media as such and social media in particular. Prominent among these purposes are (1) to bring people together (2) to inform (3) to educate (4) to entertain (5) to create public opinion on important social issues, and (6) to stimulate discussion and exchange of views on such issues. If traditional media has the potential to do all this and more, the power of the new social media to pursue and to achieve these goals is nothing short of tremendous.

Media is a world in itself. And as a world it has its own eco-system, its own environment. The health of this world depends on how healthy its environment is. The world of social media once had an environment characterized by euphoria and excitement. While the euphoria and excitement has not as yet

worn out, today, more and more, the climate, especially in India, has become turbulent – as if we are in the middle of a cyclone.[2] There is so much news generated every day that it is hard to make sense of what is happening. In this part of the world, while it still makes sense to ask, "Is this true or not?," we have practically no parameters by which to judge the authenticity, or lack thereof, of what is placed before us. The air is heavy with suspicion and doubt. Conspiracy theories are woven practically every day. This touches the whole spectrum of social life, be it the economic sphere, the political arena, or the area of health care or education. Aspersions are cast, motives are questioned, rumours are spread, words are selectively quoted out of context, history is doctored, news items are planted and then finally armies of trolls are let loose.[3]

Just by way of example, we could consider the conspiracies surrounding healthcare and medicine. We are told that many sickness are the creation of unscrupulous doctors[4] who delight in subjecting the gullible to unnecessary suffering while making pots of money in the bargain. Many lament that what was once a profession – the medical profession – has now become an industry.[5] We are told similarly that many of the medicines we are so earnestly urged by doctors to take really do not make a positive difference. Some medicines even harm us. But it does not matter to the doctors in question and the pharmaceutical industry as a whole, who are just interested in the profits they can make and very little else.[6] In fact, in India, there is so much 'alternate information' on medical matters that a couple of young entrepreneurs have set up a site just to get facts cross checked in case of doubt.[7] However, the atmosphere surrounding social media tends to get so charged that people do not seem too interested in cross checking facts; they tend to go by their feelings, giving the impression that people believe what they want to believe!

Similar conspiracies surround the school and education sector. Many are quite vociferous in expressing the view that what was once a service has now become a racket.[8] In India, after a number of unfortunate incidents involving the abuse and even death of children, these voices of suspicion have grown and have become even more shrill.

However, all this can be likened to child's play when one considers the atmosphere that is prevalent in the area of politics and its connected fields of economics and social development. Suspicion and cynicism are the order of the day. Distrust and ill feeling hang like a heavy cloud over the horizon and refusing to clear away. While this atmosphere of suspicion is fairly widespread across the world, in India it is especially stifling. The powers in place wrested power from those who held it for many years by presenting an alternative narrative, by rekindling long dead dreams and by unleashing an army of trolls to systematically undermine all the works and achievements of the previous dispensations. While it may be tempting to blame one group as responsible for this air of suspicion and distrust, the fact is that very few among the groups

occupying the available social space have resorted to reasoned argumentation based on evidence and fact as a means of resolving differences. Debates, both on social media and other media such as TV/newspapers, have been largely polemical, person-centric rather than theme-centric, accusatory, angry and divisive. The focus has very rarely, if ever, been on building bridges of understanding between different groups. Instead each group, in its own way, has contributed to the widening of the fault lines of suspicion, hatred and division. The situation has not yet deteriorated to the 'point of no return,' but we are not very far. If we have the misfortune of reaching that point the only option left for us would be the path downhill.

How is it that we reached this point? Is this something that is inevitable and part of the dynamic of human interaction? Can we say that man is basically a suspicious animal and that cynicism and hatred and doubt are the only ways he knows; perhaps part of his evolutionary inheritance. In order to survive, he had to be suspicious, he had to watch his back, just in case someone has uncharitable intentions. What I would like to suggest is that while suspicion and cynicism are the new normal in many societies, it has not always been the case. What began as a strategy for renewal and infusion of new life and spirit within communities has deteriorated into something that is energy draining and radically self defeating. The 'hermeneutic of suspicion' has been corrupted and has given way to a 'culture of suspicion'.

Hermeneutics is as old as philosophy itself. All philosophy involves interpretation after all. Philosophy progressed because people who were not satisfied with the explanations given for various phenomena and experience challenged these views and came up with alternate explanations of their own. It was not enough, however, to present alternative explanations; these explanations had to be backed with good reason and evidence that were accessible to others as well. They 'suspected' that something was not quite right with the explanations provided for various socially sanctioned practices and customs. Some of these practices and customs were sacrosanct and could not be questioned without great personal risk. If they were lucky, they had to pay the relatively small price of being socially ostracized and being considered as social outcasts. Quite a few, however, were not so fortunate and had to pay the ultimate price of coming up with a new idea that threatened to shake up the status quo, namely the price of sacrificing their own lives.

In 1970, Paul Ricoeur published a book entitled *Freud & Philosophy: An Essay on Interpretation*, in which he spoke of three 'masters of suspicion' – Marx, Nietzsche and Freud – who together could be considered members of a single 'school of suspicion'. What is significant about these three thinkers, in spite of their radically different approaches to life's important questions, is that they shifted the locus of suspicion from things known through consciousness to the 'consciousness that knows things'.[9] They held that human consciousness

is falsified by an 'unconscious process of ciphering'. This fills consciousness with a number of illusions that one must be aware of and unmask. Ricoeur does not go into the details, but just to refresh our minds with the facts, we need to recall that all all three masters of suspicion cast their suspicions on the phenomena of religion. Marx said that 'religion is the opium of the people'. With its promise of heaven, religion shifts the attention of the oppressed from their present state of economic distress to some future where everything will be fine. He held that religion is an illusion that must be given up in order to work at giving up 'conditions that need illusions'.[10] Nietzsche spoke of the 'will to power' that is at work in all human interactions, and for that matter in the whole cosmos. He held that this 'will' is evidenced both in the mastery over self, others and environment as seen in the free spirited actions of the *Ubermensch* on the one hand, and in the subtle, sly maneuverings of the embittered, the depressed and the weak – the mediocre majority – who seek to impose their will and their misery on one and all.[11] Freud came up with the theory that religion is essentially an attempt to escape the hard realities of life. He held that it is just an expression of man's infantile need for a powerful father figure. He was unequivocal in his view that it was time to get rid of religion and grow up using the resources provided to us by science and reason. Religion belongs to the childhood of humankind.[12]

Commenting on the suspicions these three thinkers raised with regard to 'religion,' Ricouer admits that they can be called the three great 'destroyers'.[13] However, he adds that it would be incorrect to think of them as 'masters of skepticism'. Citing Heidegger he says that destruction is part of the process of laying new foundations. He holds that these three thinkers are basically telling us that 'consciousness is not what it thinks it is' and therefore 'a new relation must be instituted between the patent and the latent'.[14] By pointing out to us the factors that operate below the surface of human consciousness these philosophers not only indulge in a destructive critique but also provide us with new exegetical tools to interpret experiences. His conclusion is that these three "clear the horizon for a more authentic word, for a new reign of Truth."[15] Using idioms found in Freud's writings, Ricoeur says that these thinkers seek the 'healing of consciousness' by subjecting it to the discipline of reductive and even destructive interpretation.[16] In their critique guile meets guile. The falsification that is generated by the unconscious work of ciphering that is at work in the man of guile, is countered by the 'conscious' methods of deciphering proposed by the man of suspicion.[17]

We must quickly add that all are not as positive of the 'critique of consciousness' proposed by these three thinkers as Ricoeur was. In his *A Theology of the Body,* John Paul II says that the ethos represented by the 'hermeneutics of suspicion' is antithetical to the vision of man present in the Sermon on the Mount. The masters of suspicion accuse the human heart of an

irreversible concupiscence that it cannot overcome. The Christian vision of the human person, the vision presented by Jesus instead, while acknowledging the reality of concupiscence and its powerful attractive force, does not stop at suspicion; but instead presents to humankind the liberating truth of its integral redemption – both in body and spirit–in Christ. Man's heart does feel within it the deep impulse of lust, but in that very same heart is also found a deep impulse to preserve the dignity of human relations, to respect, and to love.[18] The teachings of Jesus, especially those found in the Sermon of the Mount, more than just being an accusation, are an appeal to man. Eros is more than just carnal lust. In its truest form it is the interior force that attracts man to what is true, good and beautiful. God's grace is ever present and this makes us capable of a 'purity of heart' that the masters of suspicion did not think humans mas was capable of overcoming.[19]

Whatever the merits of Ricoeur's claim that the 'masters of suspicion' were not 'masters of skepticism' but instead stewards preparing the ground for a 'new reign of Truth,' there is no denying that the link between 'suspicion' and 'truth' could easily be severed and 'suspicion' could become an end in itself. What can we do to ensure that this link is not broken? What can we do to ensure that the 'hermeneutic of suspicion' does not give rise to a 'culture of suspicion'? I want to suggest, drawing inspiration from Bernard Lonergan, among others, that 'hermeneutics of suspicion' can preserve its link with the truth and be something truly energizing and invigorating, only if it is part of an effort to build a 'civilization of trust'. Before going on to reflect on how that can be done, we need to first clarify the distinction between a 'hermeneutics of suspicion' and a 'culture of suspicion'. A 'hermeneutics of suspicion' seeks to go beyond the obvious and the apparent and explore hidden and alternate meanings of events, experiences and other data as part of a larger quest for the truth. It accepts that truth is larger than we are and that when it comes to the truth what matters is not only that one knows it but also how one holds it. A genuine 'hermeneutics of suspicion' by its very nature cannot be dogmatizing. It should be willing to suspect its suspicions and the 'one doing the suspecting' as well. A 'hermeneutics of suspicion' is rooted in humility. It begins with the acknowledgement that even the best of us has our blind spots and can be victims of bias that prevents us from seeing ourselves, others and life as much as it truly is. It is not cynical however. It seeks to devise strategies by which biases can be overcome so that individuals and groups may align themselves to the truth. A 'hermeneutics of suspicion' fosters honesty and integrity, it forces one to look at oneself first before directing one's critical gaze towards others. A 'hermeneutics of suspicion' does not focus exclusively on the past in order to dismantle or destroy. It does destroy illusions but it does so with a view towards building up bonds of understanding, mutual support and harmony.[20]

For Ricoeur, 'Demystifying hermeneutics'[21] is a form of discipline, an ascesis, that enables us to recognize our slavery and understand it so as to be able to rediscover our possibilities within the necessities that define our lives. This hermeneutics is not an end in itself. He concludes his work *Freud & Phiosophy* by asserting that the 'discipline of reality' is nothing without the grace of imagination. Accepting and facing our necessity is the first step towards the evocation and the realization of our possibility.[22]

This becomes clearer if we look at the Indian social scene as a case in point. Over the years we have had many courageous individuals who could be labeled 'Indian masters of suspicion'. Some names that immediately come to the mind are: Jyothiba Phule, Dr. Ambedkar, Tilak, Gandhi, Nehru, Raja Ram Mohan Roy, Pandita Ramabai, Vinoba Bhave, and Baba Amte. We notice about each one of them that they were driven by a vision of a better life, of a better world. Their criticism of social structures or apparent cynicism about certain cultural values was geared primarily to the renewal and transformation of society. Each of them believed in the power of individuals and groups to make a difference. They not only pointed out shortcomings but also worked out strategies to work on these shortcomings. They not only said 'this state of affairs cannot carry on' but also went on to add 'this is the kind of world we can create together.' However, in recent times we have not been so fortunate; while we still have enlightened and courageous individuals who have the courage to 'suspect', ask questions, challenge and resist, their voices have been drowned out by aggressive and even violent polemical voices that express themselves both on television and on social media, often resorting to threats, shaming and abuse. Sometimes, one wonders whether truth – and things such as justice, equitable development, peace and harmony – matters to them at all. They are in the business of fault finding, creating a ruckus, spreading suspicion and hatred. This is what a 'culture of suspicion' is all about. It is a culture where casting aspersions on the good will of others and finding people to blame for the mess we are in are more important than creating an atmosphere of introspection and self correction so that people from different parts of the social and political spectrum may cooperate to envision a new future, and work together to realize it. A 'culture of suspicion' is about diverting attention from the issue at hand; it is about hidden agendas, about creating divisions, about delighting in misfortune. At first sight, there might be little to distinguish a 'hermeneutic of suspicion' from a 'culture of suspicion'. The 'hermeneutic suspicion' is part of a larger strategy to understand life and existence better. Life and truth are values that are treasured. But in a culture riddled with suspicion, life and truth are casualties. 'A culture of suspicion' is basically unsustainable. It is something that is likely to implode at any moment and take everyone with it.

As I've said before it does not take much for a 'hermeneutics of suspicion' to deteriorate into a 'culture of suspicion'. Once it is unanchored from its

commitment to life and truth, it quickly drifts into a whirlpool of confusion, dissipation and destruction. Putting it positively, we could say that a genuine 'hermeneutics of suspicion' must be rooted in a 'culture of trust'. A culture in which 'unmasking' goes hand in hand with acknowledging and appreciating what is true, good and beautiful in people and in life. A 'civilization of trust' is a civilization in which, to use the phrase used by Marcel and Levinas, humans 'extend credit' to each other and in doing so build up a network of support, so that each individual might develop his or her full potential and each society may flourish in the fullest sense of the word.

To reflect further on how to actually create and sustain a civilization of trust and at the same time to keep intact its link with a 'hermeneutics of suspicion,' I would like to draw our attention to Lonergan's insights on this issue. Lonergan may not have reflected on these issues using the concepts we have used thus far, nevertheless the truth is that few have matched him in his acknowledgement that the best of men can fall prey to a number of biases that can highjack not just one's personal growth as a human person but also the progress of society into genuine confraternity of persons who may not agree completely about every single thing but work together nevertheless in a spirit of respect and dialogue to pursue the integral welfare of all.[23]

Lonergan defines development as the emergence, accumulation, and implementation of higher viewpoints. When for some reason or the other the emergence of new and higher viewpoints is hampered, sciences, cultures, and communities begin to decline. He speaks of healthy communities as communities or cosmopolis which make operative timely and fruitful ideas in whatever field of learning or inquiry. In such communities, timely steps are taken to ensure that unscrupulous individuals or groups which have power do not impose their sins on others by rationalizing them. The cosmopolis is concerned with ensuring that history is not falsified to serve vested interests. It seeks to safeguard the long term welfare of the community by ensuring that personal agendas, resentments, hatreds do not hamper the growth of the community. The cosmopolis, in Lonergan's view, is not a political entity or court or organization that enforces its view of things by enrolling members, or endorsing opinions or making laws. Instead we could equate it to the 'civilization of trust' that we have been speaking about. It is characterized by an atmosphere of commitment to the larger good of humankind that prompts men and women of good will to come together to create an environment that makes it possible for the 'vast potentialities' and pent-up energies of humans beings to be expressed in the flowering of all that is best in man both as an individual and as a social being.[24]

The cosmopolis or the 'civilization of trust' contributes to the development of the human community by promoting the 'full development of human intelligence'. However, there are various factors that interfere first with the full

flowering of human intelligence and second with actually acting in keeping with what 'intelligence' presents to us as true and good. Foremost among these factors are the biases that each individual and community must first be aware of and then seek to weed out. Lonergan speaks of four kinds of biases, each of which set into motion a process of decline. The development of human intelligence is hampered, the emergence of higher viewpoints is blocked; and in the resultant deterioration, both communities and individual persons become casualties. The first of these biases is individual bias. Individual bias is the state in which one's egoism interferes with the development of intelligence. One's immediate interests take priority, so much so that one cleverly avoids those questions that are inconvenient for him. The egoist is not one who is unable to think things true. His frame of reference is limited to his own selfish agenda. When it suits him then he can be quite a schemer and manipulator. He knows how to ask questions and seek solutions to the problems that matter to him. The egoist has one rule for himself and another rule for others. He is not one who acts in such a way unconsciously, merely because of an inadequately developed intelligence. It is often the case that he is aware of his self-deception. He does suffer moments of self-suspicion and disquiet. But he drowns these out by his rationalizations.[25] Next comes group bias. It is the bias that leads groups to resist change and to preserve the status quo. It can be called a kind of 'group-egoism' that is exhibited in its interaction with other groups or people outside the group. It leads groups to pursue their own advantage at the cost of the interests of other groups. This form of bias involves the use of power and force to protect unfairly gained advantages.[26] The third kind of bias is general bias. This bias is the bias of common sense. Since common sense proves to be such a wonderful tool to deal with the practical problems of life, and since acquiring specialized knowledge in different fields and a broader perspective on life's issues is so much more hard work, the individual/or the group that becomes prey to such a bias jumps to the conclusion that common sense is all that is really needed to deal with life's questions. This form of bias is one that also afflicts many specialists who tend to think that they are 'omni-competent,[27] and that their specialized knowledge is the only knowledge that is valid and useful. They fail thus to appreciate sufficiently the value of insights and the knowledge made available through other disciplines.[28] Finally the fourth kind of bias is 'dramatic bias'. It is a bias that is characterized by the inability of a person to adequately integrate within his personality certain elementary passions leading to gross distortions in the proper development of his intellectual faculties. This bias is expressed very often in scotosis, which is basically a censorship that prevents the emergence of new questions and the development of consciousness purely moved by emotional reactions of distaste, pride, dread, horror and revulsion. This bias is the result of unmet

and often exaggerated neurotic needs, unhealthy repressions and a general insecurity that prevents one from living at any level higher than the biological.[29]

For Lonergan therefore, the only way the pure, unrestricted desire to know, which is part of every human being's psyche can truly bloom and reach its fullest potential only if we constantly ask ourselves and our communities relevant questions, even if they are inconvenient; and constantly seek answers to them in a spirit of openness. This would be a true 'hermeneutics of suspicion' that would contribute to the creation of a culture of trust. Such a hermeneutics would contribute to three conversions that every individual needs – an intellectual conversion that hopefully prepares the ground for a moral conversion, that in turn opens up the possibility of a genuine religious conversion. India needs this today more than ever, and perhaps even more than any other nation/society on earth needs it. We have such a rich heritage and we are bursting with potential. Unfortunately, however there is so much dissipation of precious energy because we are afraid to look at ourselves. It may be true that there are a thousand people to blame for what is not going on well, but we don't help ourselves by consoling ourselves and saying we are not at fault. We must ask ourselves: how have we contributed to our problems? What can we do differently? How can we create a better society – more human, of all and for all?

A 'hermeneutics of suspicion' for a 'culture of trust' – this is what we must work towards. A 'hermeneutics of suspicion' contributes to the birth of a 'culture of trust'. And yet, it is only a 'culture of trust' that makes possible a genuine 'hermeneutics of suspicion' – one that does not degenerate into an ugly slanging match, a witch hunt, a bloody and brutal battle of honesty, where one falls so much in love with the brutality that the quest for honesty is abandoned altogether. That is why I would agree with Lonergan, who quoting Newman, says that a basic trust must precede doubt.[30] Descartes proposed a method of methodic doubt. Evaluate everything thoroughly and discard all that does not stand up to scrutiny. Newman proposed a radically different alternative: accept in general whatever one reasonably can, but when a mistake is pointed out or when one encounters an error then one must make no compromises. Get to the bottom of that error and weed it out right from the root. Lonergan calls this the 'self correcting process of knowing.'[31] "A 'hermeneutics of suspicion' and a 'culture of trust'" - both are part of the same dynamic, the same quest for authenticity and for truth.

Notes

1 Cfr. Gautam Bhatia, "How a culture of narcissism has made mediocrity great today", in *Sunday Times of India*, Nashik Edition, 24 September, 2017, 17.

2 Cfr. Sujata Anandan, "In truth we must always trust as journalists", in *Lokmat Times*, Nashik, 24th September, 2017.

3 To counter this phenomena the popular social media platform 'facebook' has been placing advertisements in many national newspapers providing criteria/tips to readers interested in spotting false news. Cfr. *Indian Express,* Mumbai Edition, 21 September, 2017, 3.

4 Cfr. Dave Mihalovic, Unscruplous Physicians are like Businessmen without a conscience: Doctors intentionally diagnosing Healthy people with Cancer to Make Money, SOTT, 7 January, 2015, <https://www.sott.net/article/336747-Unscrupulous-physicians-are-like-businessmen-without-a-conscience-Doctors-intentionally-diagnosing-healthy-people-with-cancer-to-make-money> (12 August, 2017).

5 Cfr. A. Aswini Kumar, Medical Profession: The Other Side of the Coin, *The Hindu*, 18 February, 2012 <http://www.thehindu.com/opinion/open-page/medical-profession-the-other-side-of-the-coin/article2907840.ece> (15 August, 2017).
Cfr. Also Nathan Mumford, The 20 Biggest Cancer Lies You have been Brainwashed to Believe by the Criminal Fraudsters who run the For Profit Cancer Industry, 6 April, 2016 <http://www.kemfoundation.org/blog/2016/4/6/the-20-biggest-cancer-lies-youve-been-brainwashed-to-believe-by-the-criminal-fraudsters-who-run-the-for-profit-cancer-industry> (20 September, 2017).
Cfr. Also Wade Frazier, The Medical Racket, June 2014 <https://ahealedplanet.net/medicine.htm> (19 September, 2017).

6 Cfr. "The Toxic Profit Motive in the Health Care Industry", *Distant Observer*, 27 July, 2011 <https://distantobserver.wordpress.com/2011/07/27/the-toxic-profit-motive-in-the-health-care-industry/> accessed on (20 September, 2017); Cfr. Also Henry Bodkin, "High Cholesterol 'does not Cause heart disease' new research finds, so treating with Statins 'a waste of time'", *The Telegraph*, 13 June, 2016 <http://www.telegraph.co.uk/science/2016/06/12/high-cholesterol-does-not-cause-heart-disease-new-research-finds/> (20 September, 2017).

7 Cfr. Chhavi Sachdev, "Fake Medical News Can Now Be fact-checked in India", npr, 12 May, 2017 <http://www.npr.org/sections/goatsandsoda/2017/05/12/526687362/fake-medical-news-can-now-be-fact-checked-in-india> (19 August, 2017).

8 Cfr. Thomas Frank, "College is Ripping you off: Students are cash cows and schools the predators", *Salon*, 10 February, 2014 <http://www.salon.com/2014/10/01/college_is_ripping_you_off_students_are_cash_cows_and_schools_the_predators/> Cfr. Also 'Education has become business', *The Hindu*, 28 July, 2013 <http://www.thehindu.com/todays-paper/tp-national/tp-tamilnadu/education-has-become-business/article4962491.ece> (15 July, 2017).

9 Paul Ricoeur, *Freud & Philosophy: An Essay on Interpretation*, trans. by Denis Savage (New Haven: Yale University Press, 1970), 33.

10 Cfr. Karl Marx, *A Contribution of the Critique of Hegel's Philosophy of Right*, 1843, <https://www.marxists.org/archive/marx/works/1843/critique-hpr/intro.htm> (14 September, 2017).

11 Emrys Westacott, "Nietzsche's Concept of the Will to Power", *Thought Co.*, 30 October, 2015 <https://www.thoughtco.com/nietzsches-concept-of-the-will-to-power-2670658> (25 September, 2017).

12 Amy Trumputer, "Sigmund Freud and His Psychoanalytic views on Religion", *Philosophyzer*, <http://www.philosophyzer.com/sigmund-freud-on-religion> (25 September, 2017).

13 Paul Ricoeur, *Freud & Philosophy*, 33.
14 Paul Ricoeur, *Freud & Philosophy,* 33.
15 Paul Ricoeur, *Freud & Philosophy,* 33.
16 Paul Ricoeur, *Freud & Philosophy,* 35.
17 Paul Ricoeur, *Freud & Philosophy*, 34.
18 Cfr. John Paul II, *Man and Woman He Created Them, Theology of the Body,* 46:1-6 (Boston: Pauline Books & Media, 2006), 309-314.
19 Cfr. John Paul II, *Man and Woman He Created Them,* Theology of the Body, 47:1-6 (Boston: Pauline Books & Media, 2006), 314-318.
Also Cfr. Jim Russell, *"Masters of Suspicion v/s The Meaning of Life: Getting 'Theology of the Body' Right",* in *Catholic Stand*, 3 December, 2013 <http://www.catholicstand.com/masters-suspicion-meaning-life-theology-body/> (10 September, 2017).
20 Bernard Lonergan on more than one occasion refers to Ricoeur's use of the phrase 'hermeneutic of recovery' along with the phrase 'hermeneutic of suspicion'. A 'hermeneutic of recovery' recognizes what is genuine and highlights what is positive, true and good, while a 'hermeneutic of suspicion' diagnoses failures, impugns, reviles or criticizes behaviours and motives. Both these hermeneutic go hand in hand and operate together. Cfr. Bernard Lonergan, *A Third Collection,* ed. by Frederick E. Crowe (New York: Paulist Press, 1985), 157, 185.
21 Cfr. Paul Ricoeur, *Freud & Philosophy*, 35.
22 Cfr. Paul Ricoeur, *Freud & Philosophy,* 551.
23 Cfr. Bernard Lonergan, *Method in Theology* (Toronto: University of Toronto Press, 1971), 39-40, 284.
24 Cfr. Bernard Lonergan, *Insight: A Study of Human Understanding*, Edited by Frederick E. Crowe and Robert M. Doran, Collected Works of Bernard Lonergan, vol. 3, (Toronto: Toronto University Press, 1992). First published by Longmans, Green, and Co., in 1957.
25 Cfr. Bernard Lonergan, *Insight,* 244-247.
26 Cfr. Bernard Lonergan, *Insight,* 247-250.
27 Cfr. Bernard Lonergan, *Method in Theology,* 231.
28 Cfr. Bernard Lonergan, *Insight,* 250-251.
29 Cfr. Bernard Lonergan, *Insight,* 214-220.
30 Cfr. Lonergan, *Method in Theology,* 223.
31 Cfr. Brian Cronin, *Foundations of Philosophy*, (PDF e-book, 1999), 186; <http://lonergan.org/wp-content/uploads/file/Foundations%20of%20Philosophy.pdf> (12 July, 2017).

2

The Suspicious Indian Programmatic, Pragmatic and Prophetic Critique

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Abstract: The hermeneutics of suspicion entails the employment of several checks and balances in discourse analysis. The article highlights a few ingredients or aspects of wholesome discourse critique, keeping in mind our contemporary global and Indian context. In the light of these aspects of critique, three primary types of suspicion are proffered. Programmatic critique is heavily ideologically based and tends to instrumentalise persons in favour of grandiose visions and plans. It features protagonists on both extremes of the socio-political spectrum. While pragmatic critique often emerges from leftist and activist thinking, it does not feature the overarching and overreaching totalitarianism of programmatic critique. The most sublime and noble form of critique is the prophetic, which entails an ongoing personal and communitarian discernment. Prophetic critique is aimed at integral social wellbeing - it involves self-critique as well as the desire to build bridges across borders rather than favour sectarian perspectives and strategies.

Introduction

Is there an Indian hermeneutics of suspicion? Given the fact that the Indian mindscape is usually associated with traditional horizons of meaning—associated with the *guru-shisya* system of education—it would appear that critical thought occupies little space within the large repertoire of Indian

intellectual speculation. However, there are different ways to interpret the term "hermeneutics of suspicion," and when one considers this range of such interpretations, it becomes evident that there are indeed numerous strands of critical thought within Indian social discourse in general and philosophical reflection in particular.

Just as Amartya Sen makes a case for the "argumentative Indian"—namely, that argumentation has always been a part of the Indian cultural tradition — in this paper I make a case for the "suspicious Indian"— namely, that there have been, and there are, a variety of modes of suspicious discourse in the Indian philosophical and social landscape.[1] I will first provide an outline of the ingredients of a salubrious bouquet of characteristics which constitute an ideal hermeneutics of suspicion. I will then go on to highlight three major forms of suspicious argumentation and theorizing prevalent in contemporary Indian thought.

1. Ingredients of a Wholesome Hermeneutics of Suspicion

Any discourse is set within specific social circumstances. These circumstances or conditions often determine the nature or texture of the relationships, associations, institutions and processes which arise from discourse. How is one to adjudicate whether these discourses—and their consequent social manifestations—meet the mark, when it comes to a salubrious or wholesome contribution to personal and social wellbeing? This concern lies at the heart of a "hermeneutics of suspicion," whose task is to lay bare those aspects of discourse—latent or obvious—which are dysfunctional in some way or the other.

Much water has flown below the proverbial bridge since Paul Ricoeur has called our attention to the three "masters of suspicion," namely, Marx, Nietzsche and Freud.[2] Each of these luminary thinkers pointed out to latent power dysfunctionalities which often lie concealed behind or beneath our more obvious manifestations of social communication and productive activity. It is opportune to identify conscious and subconscious dysfunctional forces which need to equally well come under the scrutiny of a *contemporary* "hermeneutics of suspicion."

What may be some of the issues and concerns stemming from a contemporary hermeneutics of suspicion that need to be factored into any form of communication or discourse? The following is a basic checklist—but not necessarily a comprehensive one—of key aspects or concerns which need to govern the creation, sustenance, application and institutionalisation of any form of social discourse.

1.1 Inclusiveness: Seeking the "common good"

The primary question that needs to be asked of any discourse is how inclusive—or conversely, how exclusive—it is. How vast is the embrace of a particular discourse in terms of its proposed beneficiaries? The more inclusive the discourse, the more salubrious it will be in terms of the common good. If the circle of humanity it seeks to include within some privileged social or cultural space is a limited one, it risks being chauvinistic or even xenophobic. This aspect of insularity and protectionism—collateral damage brought about by processes of globalization—has sadly come to define our zeitgeist. Today, inclusivity would also need to be applied consciously to the natural environment, which has hitherto often been relegated to a position outside the ambit of human concern, especially in the areas of scientific and technological research and interest.

1.2 Recognition: Respecting the "other"

Most discursive constructions emanate from within a particular centre or matrix of interests. What may often get ignored is the interests of other individuals or communities which do not feature prominently while the discourse is being formulated, articulated or applied. This aspect of suspicion is in continuity with inclusivity, but it needs reinforcing, as it has especially to do with "subaltern" or "minority" communities, which share an unequal power equation with the centre of discursive activity. The third-generation critical thinker Axel Honneth—along with Nancy Frazer, a post-feminist thinker—has brought the aspect of "recognition" into special philosophical focus over the last few decades.[3] Recognition may be considered to be allied to the issue and need of "care," which has rightly gained prominence within mainstream ethical theory, thanks to the contribution of numerous feminist ethical theorists.

1.3 Communicative Purity: Clarity, Transparency, Accountability, Rightness

Perhaps no contemporary philosopher has worked on the formulation of ideal conditions which need to govern communication as much as the second-generation critical thinker, Jurgen Habermas. Habermas' four criteria for ideal communication—meaningfulness, truth, truthfulness and rightness—stand out as crystal clear signposts which help to navigate conversation so that it may steer clear of suspicious or manipulative strategies in communicative action.[4] Clearly, the concept of "post-truth" communication needs to be seriously suspected, in terms of the power interests that may be at play in such communication.

1.4 Liberal Thinking and Expression: Openness to Revision

If a system of thought, action and organization is closed to interpretation and further refinement, this is a sure sign of the dynamics of protectionist power play and domination. Systemic thinking needs to be open not only to better reformulations but also to dissenting voices and concerns. Such proposals at modification or reinterpretation need to be welcomed not only from within a discursive community, but even from outside the community, as it relates with others who may believe, think and act differently.

1.5 Power Optimality: Subject to Checks and Balances

Any association or organization will understandably generate various power relations. It is important to evaluate these relations for optimal functioning both within any group and between various groups of peoples. Abuse takes place when individuals or groups or communities want to appropriate more power than they legitimately deserve or with which they are entrusted. Open communication systems within and between organized groups of peoples will help to expose power imbalances and abuse. It is important to overcome features of a "Master-Slave" dynamics—either overt or subtle. Regular feedback mechanisms will enable such dynamics—and the many games associated with it—to be appropriately exposed.

1.6 Constructiveness: Positivity and Future-focused

It may seem fashionable to be critical of any and every constructive or projective activity. However, healthy suspicion will need to employ mechanisms not only of critique and opposition, but also of positive and proactive propositioning. Critique should not metamorphose into a form of "analysis paralysis," or worse, cynicism.[5] If what is suspected are regressive tendencies, then this needs to be balanced with progressive proposals and strategies. If the past is countered because of its being subject to effete and debilitating forces, then the present should not feature unhealthy rancour and wrangling, nor should the future be jeopardized because of an inability to conceive of and commit oneself to promising productive projects.

1.7 Systemic Reform: Affirmative Structural Change

If any change proposed is to become a reality, it will need to be systematized or institutionalized. If this does not happen, it may remain at the level of good social intentions or wishful thinking. Unless there is serious structural reform, necessary social changes will be sporadic and limited, and at best only benefit the more powerful and resourceful. Discourse which meets many of the other salubrious criteria but which does not materialize in systemic change is chimerical, and at best, short-lived in terms of wholesome change.

1.8 Non-violence: Using the Language of the Strong and the Brave

This criterion of physical non-violence needs special emphasis today, since given the prevalent order of proceeding in our contemporary world, violence seems a very attractive option in order to make one's social position more recognized and legitimate. In spite of possessing the best means of social communication than ever before, the limits of tolerance seem to have lessened considerably, compared to the past. The option to be non-violent, no matter the circumstances and provocation, has become all the more noble and necessary.

2. Indian Hermeneutics of Suspicion: Primary Types

Indians may appear to be a particularly suspicious community of peoples. This is quite understandable, given the complex nature of the social and cultural composition of the country, and the variety of settlers who have made the subcontinent their home. However, not all Indian suspicion is of the same timbre or quality. Some forms of suspicion are rooted in narrow interests, largely based on fear of the "other" appropriating a limited or privileged political and cultural space. Others may be more legitimate, in terms of estimating the value of the "other" in terms of contribution to wholesome wellbeing and the common good.

I have chosen to situate Indian forms of suspicion into three categories: the programmatic, the pragmatic and the prophetic. I have borrowed the distinction between "programmatic" and "pragmatic" from Aijaz Ahmad, and applied it to the matter of suspicion. Ahmad distinguishes between "the programmatic communalism of the BJP and the pragmatic communalism of the Congress."[6] For the Congress, "communalism was played like a game of chess,"[7] whereas for the BJP, communalism is rooted in its ideological programme of *Hindutva*. Programmatic suspicion is largely ideologically-oriented, and when this happens, the logic that prevails is that of the end justifying the means. This form of suspicion is totalitarian in nature. It cares more for the wellbeing of particular or select communities of peoples, but little for the common good or for individual human sensitivities. Pragmatic suspicion, on the other hand, is more issue-based, and is far more nuanced and sophisticated. It is more focused in its critique and its objectives, and attempts to obtain redressal regarding specific social issues. Its emphasis is largely deconstructive: indicating fissures and fault lines. The alternatives it proposes—often implicitly more than explicitly—are understandably idealistic and futuristic. Finally, prophetic suspicion is a more integral and comprehensive form of critique—almost an exercise of suspicion in daily life, involving a balanced and wholesome personal and social "examination of consciousness." This purer type of suspicion does not relativize human dignity or compromise the common good as programmatic suspicion is prone

to do; nor does it use critique in a myopic manner—focusing on comparatively narrow interests—as pragmatic suspicion does. Rather it entails an ongoing, systemic critical reflection with regard to various aspects of personal and social life, in order to enhance integral wellbeing.

2.1 Programmatic Suspicion: The Lure of Ideology

Akin to the distinction between programmatic and pragmatic communalism which Aijaz Ahmad makes, Valerian Rodrigues, former Professor at the JNU *Centre for Political Studies*, also makes a distinction between "ideological and social communalism" on the one hand and "political communalism" on the other. "Political communalism employs an event, a monument, a syncretic space or a social cleavage to pit a large group of people against the other. It does not sever all ties of people forged around social division of labour, linguistic affinities, folklore."[8] Ideological communalism is comparatively more insidious, creating the conditions for dysfunctional social relations on a mass scale. For example, examining the political developments which have been unfolding in India over the past few years, some UK-based NRI human rights groups have begun to describe the nation as a "Republic of Fear."[9]

This increasing phobic consciousness — especially by liberal and left-wing thinkers — is ironically corroborated by a primary spokesperson of the present government, Ram Madhav, as he facetiously calls attention to a growing "demophobic" disposition manifested within these secular and leftist thinkers. According to Madhav, "the liberal unease is palpable. Their plight is best described by . . . a less-used Greek word demophobia — fear of the mob. The mob, humble people of the country . . . are finally at ease with a government that looks and sounds familiar. They are enjoying it."[10] This tendency to polarize people — and to exploit these divisions strategically — is typical of a programmatic agenda.

Communalism takes on the shape of a warped sense of suspicion of the "other." One is suspicious of the other's ideology, possession and management of resources and social goals and objectives. There is a systematic — hence the term programmatic — attempt to thwart the identity and aspirations of the "other." Not surprisingly, programmatic suspicion is nurtured by people on the far right as well as the far left of the intellectual, political, cultural and religious spectrum. Both these extremes often give rise to positions that are intractable and self-righteous. Within the religious sphere of influence, examples of such groups abound in India towards the far right. In Europe, on the other hand — which is as secular as India is religious — such groups may abound on the far left.

While Islamic radicalism has reared its ugly head in many parts of the world, in India we have the anomalous situation of Hindu radicalism doing the same. This is uncharacteristic, as the Hindu way of life is not a typically

organized or homogenous religion like many mainstream religions, or even one possessing a common ideology or a common religious "book." What seems to be happening is a systemic mirroring of the Western Christian way of life, in terms of theological homogeneity, better social organization, newer forms of Religious life, evangelical and missionary zeal and centralized "Magisterial" leadership. This paradoxically represents a psychological or dispositional "conversion" towards a Western, Christian organizational worldview and social and political enterprise — a development which is apparently and professedly abhorrent by adherents of the Hindu far-right, yet has come to be pragmatically, politically and even culturally seductive.

On the far left, Indian communism too is clearly influenced by Western social analysis and foreign experiments with socialism. Though Indian communists such as M.N. Roy and E.M.S. Namboodiripad experimented with Indian forms of socialism and communism, the lumpen elements within communism — as in right-wing groups - have been easily led to embrace a means-end logic involving instrumental and violent strategies towards reaching their objectives. Ramachandra Guha calls this, "an old argument, that the end must take precedence over the means. Through the 20th Century it was used most effectively by Communist parties to suppress dissent."[11]

Criticizing both left and right on account of these ideological excesses, Ramachandra Guha parodies them as simply mirroring each other. Commenting on an essay on globalization composed by Arundhati Roy, Guha says: "this essay presented a portrait of contemporary India as subtle as that of the Swadeshi Jagran Manch:[12] Government Bad, Market Worse, Multinational Corporation Worst of All."[13]

Pope Francis has often criticized such an ideological approach towards reaching social objectives, however noble the end may appear. Speaking to the Latin American Episcopal Conference in Bogota on 7 September, 2017, he says, "I want to mention the ever-present temptations of making the Gospel an ideology, ecclesial functionalism and clericalism . . . The Gospel, then, cannot be reduced to a program at the service of a trendy Gnosticism, a project of social improvement or the Church conceived as a comfortable bureaucracy, any more than she can be reduced to an organization run according to modern business models by a clerical caste."[14] This reluctance to reduce faith to an ideology, programme, project or bureaucratic organization could be extended to any form of social visioning. When these features take over such visioning, individuals get marginalized, oppressed and even exterminated, in favour of these larger goals and objectives.

2.2 Pragmatic Suspicion: The Power of Deconstruction

Pragmatic suspicion is more focused and less totalitarian in its vision and processes, as compared to programmatic suspicion. It is generally issue-based

or opposed to a particularly skewed historical condition or development or some form of systemic injustice or discrimination. Issues may range from gender, caste, class, racial or colonial discrimination to exploitation of the earth's resources for human gratification and excessive consumption. The task of suspicion entails a process of deconstruction of hitherto sacrosanct beliefs, practices, texts, received histories, hierarchies and reified social relationships.

India has been blessed to have a wide range of such theorists of suspicion. Ambedkar stands out as a preeminent apostle opposed to caste-discrimination, and he has had several followers, perhaps the most strident among them being Kancha Ilaiah.[15] If there is one area that needs severe critique, it is that of caste, which has been likened more with the skin on our bodies rather than the clothes that we wear — which are easier to put on or take off. Close to caste is the issue of gender injustice, which is rampant and takes several forms in diverse communities. Like caste, gender injustice has been legitimized on religious as well as cultural grounds, which make it more difficult to change mindsets, even though stringent laws have been introduced to deal with such injustices. Like in many other areas, there is a serious lag between legal provisions on the one hand — which are often comparable with international standards — and an antiquated and intransigent cultural mindset that will take a much longer time to change, on the other. India has had a long history of luminous feminist activists, like Savitribhai Phule, Pandita Ramabai, Kamini Roy, Rita Banerji, Vina Mazumdar, Indira Jaisingh, Shabnam Hashmi and Flavia Agnes. Besides caste and gender, child rights in India have a long way to go to gain national recognition. Kailash Satyarthi, who won the Nobel Peace Prize with Malala Yousafzai in 2014 is well known for his concerted advocacy against child labour and in favour of education for all children.

A more refined and nuanced form of suspicion has arisen in the form of postcolonial critique, articulated by Homi Bhabha, Gayatri Spivak and Dipesh Chakrabarty, among others. However, unlike caste and gender discrimination, the deleterious effect that colonization has had on the consciousness of the colonized is comparatively more debatable, given the huge Indian diaspora, with ever increasing numbers of those who wish to migrate to materially developed nations — many of which have had a colonial past, or currently engage in political, economic and even cultural neocolonialism. Paradoxically, those who provide the most severe critiques of colonialism and neocolonialism are often based in such countries.

Other forms of critique have yet to be recognized and take off on a mass scale. A good example is that of environmental suspicion as enunciated by Vandana Shiva, Medha Patkar, Arundhati Roy and others. These thinkers have attempted to provide a critique of environmental policies and practices which are related to other forms of discrimination. The most obvious correlation is that between the disrespect and callousness we have for the earth with the

systematic disregard which diverse communities have had for women in general. What perhaps needs better enunciation is the linking of environmental disregard with the way indigenous peoples have been treated the world over, especially over the past half millennium. In earlier times, Verrier Elwin,[16] and more recently figures like Soni Sori and Dayamani Barla have highlighted the tribulations and interests of the tribals who have consistently been marginalized and coopted by more powerful political and economic pressure groups.

2.3 Prophetic Suspicion: The Wisdom of Discernment

Both programmatic and pragmatic suspicions have serious limitations in terms of a wholesome hermeneutics of suspicion. Programmatic suspicion entails the enunciation of a specific and comprehensive agenda. However, this agenda — and the strategies proposed to achieve it — is often highly partisan and polarizing, and in many cases does not preclude the use of violence to meet desirable ends. Pragmatic suspicion, on the other hand, is more along the lines of a deconstruction of power-based discourse governing various social phenomena. However, the issue with which it is concerned is often a narrow one, and hence sometimes what is lacking is sufficient awareness and appreciation of the bigger picture at stake. In this form of suspicion, it is also possible that individuals are instrumentalized or relativized in favour of the ideal or objective that is to be met.

Prophetic suspicion builds upon the strengths of programmatic and pragmatic suspicion, but supersedes both of them in adding qualitatively superior values. Prophetic suspicion combines the comprehensive scope of programmatic suspicion with the genuine social concern manifested by pragmatic suspicion. It is both visionary by disposition, like the former, and activist in engagement, like the latter — two basic ingredients of a prophetic character or disposition.

But prophetic suspicion includes critical features which are nobler and purer, as compared to other forms of suspicion. First of all, in such a form of methodological critique, the ones who will benefit are not primarily the person concerned or his or her particular community. Instead, what is at stake is usually the larger and common good. Also, the critique in this case is not understood to be directed against a personal or communitarian adversary or oppressor, but instead against a group of persons who are perceived to be misguided in terms of values, dispositions and social options.

Another indicator of this higher form of suspicion is the scope of influence and inspiration that the agent of suspicion evokes or generates across peoples and borders. Here the personal integrity of the agent of suspicion comes into play, because of the moral nature of critique. In prophetic suspicion, there is a high congruence between word and deed. Yet another indicator is how these agents of suspicion deal with their opponents — either from within their

communities or from outside. Here purity of intention, tenacity of purpose, moral commitment and a disposition of compassion shine through in the case of prophetic critics. Most truly great social reformers do not employ violent language or action against their adversaries, but instead fervently appeal to noble ideals, superior argumentation, and more than that, to the better selves of their opponents. The tone or tenor of discourse is a good indicator of prophetic suspicion: the more measured, tempered, balanced and inviting, rather than shrill and raucous, the greater the efficacy associated with suspicion. Ramachandra Guha contends that,

> Public discourse in India is crippled by the disease of extremism. It is a disease encouraged and spread by television and colour magazines, which demand simple-minded positions on all topics. . . Secularism, globalisation, the environment: on these subjects of vital importance the media, or at least large swathes of it, tends to offer only the extreme positions . . . Politicians and propagandists are comfortable enough with this black-and-white view of the world. The task of the writer, and scholar, is to resist it.[17]

Unfortunately, just as communalism and communism tend to mirror each other at either ends of the programmatic spectrum, so also do politicians and activists — what Guha terms "propagandists"— mirror each other at extreme ends of the pragmatic spectrum. Thus, unfortunately, instead of activism inviting admiration, inspiration and collaboration, it often results in alienating the very people who could support it and those who may benefit from it.

Prophetic critique shares a kindred spirit with pragmatic critique, but it is more inviting, more balanced, more nuanced, and more inspiring. There are numerous persons across Indian history who may qualify to be prophetic critics, but I would like to choose three of them known widely around the globe: Buddha, Gandhi and Theresa of Kolkata. Each of them provides a critique of society by their ideas as well as the form of life they chose to live in consonance with those ideas. Buddha foregrounded the virtue of desirelessness, and the incessant need to examine the complex motives which lie at the basis of our many actions. He exposed the power mechanisms operating within the religious forms of life prevalent in his times and provided a collective alternative in order to reject the enslavement of the masses to the agents of such religiosity, and to the crippling social customs these agents generated and sustained. While Buddha privileged the virtue of freedom, Theresa of Kolkata privileged an unbridled and unconditional love towards the least and the lost of humanity. She called into question the pseudo values of "civilized societies" the world over, whose citizens stand by mutely and numbly, watching the marginalized suffer miserably — and more than that, generate sophisticated

theories to justify their indifference, disengagement and sheer callousness. This type of suspicion calls into question the mass desire to be fixated on personal success, to amass wealth and to establish social position and leverage for oneself and one's small circle of family and friends.

However, both Buddha and Theresa may suffer the loss of being themselves marginalized on account of their religious affiliations — subject to the hostility and suspicion which some may have because of their association with Buddhism and Christianity respectively. The third personage I would thus like to offer as an even better — and more neutral, though not necessarily less controversial — exemplar within this last segment is Mahatma Gandhi. Even though he was a practicing Hindu, he was open to being influenced by different literary, cultural and religious currents, and made no bones about this synthetic influence on his own moral and spiritual development. According to Avijit Pathak,

> Religiosity, for Gandhi, was a lifelong quest for self-transformation. It was an engagement with the world without *tamasic* inertia or *rajasic* ego, but with *sattvic* calmness. It was to see politics as a field of *sadhana* characterised by the Bhagavad Gita's principle of *anasakti yoga* as well as the power of love Jesus taught in the *Sermon on the Mount*. This religiosity was subversive; it sought to manifest itself in radical social practices.[18]

But Gandhi's integral matrix of suspicions went far beyond the mere critiquing of narrow religious interpretations and social applications. He suspected colonialism, capitalism, urbanization, technocracy, consumerism, and above all, violence as a means to settle social problems stemming from these modern malaises — as he understood them. Pathak points out that, "at a time when global capitalism as reinvented colonialism has reduced us into marketable resources and captive consumers, Gandhi's utopia appears to us as a protest ideology and an aspiration for a new society trying to come out of the seductive trap of technological miracles, media simulation and militarisation of consciousness."[19]

But the situating of Gandhi within this last category of suspicion or critique is perhaps the most convincing when it comes to the integrity and consonance between ideal on the one hand and personality and character on the other. Gandhi was assiduously self-critical, even though he clearly had his blind spots when it came to caste reform and his partial insensitivity towards Muslim sentiments in the light of an impending Hindu majoritarian state.[20] Like Buddha and Theresa, Gandhi too realized that, "no meaningful resistance against injustice is possible without working on one's own self; and hence *satyagraha* or *ahimsa* or *non-cooperation* with evil forces would require a

process of self-purification: eradicating the seeds of greed, violence, and lust lying within. Quite often, the external enemy, be it a colonial master, an exploitative capitalist or a patriarchal Brahmin, lies inside us, despite our adherence to supposedly radical political philosophies."[21]

Like Buddha, Theresa and others of their ilk Gandhi was a critic's critic. He suspected suspicion, if it arose from yet another form of a personally or socially dysfunctional disposition or ideology. In the final analysis, neither ideology nor deconstruction will successfully lead to holistic social change. Something similar to an ongoing spiritual, moral and social discernment — i.e., personal and collective soul-searching towards appropriate decision making — is needed. Such "experiments with truth" will need humility, the ability to listen to others, the freedom and responsibility to speak the truth — including speaking truth to power — and a recognition of human finitude. Such an experiment needs to be engaged in at a collective level if it is to bring about a change of mindsets on a mass scale.

Having made a distinction between pragmatic and prophetic suspicion, it may nevertheless turn out that some thinkers and revolutionaries who seem to fit better into the "pragmatic" category may be perceived to have made their mark within the more wholesome "prophetic" segment of the masters of suspicion. Ambedkar, for one, comes across most obviously in this regard. As is well known, "he took Buddhist vows in order to reject his Hindu birth at the very bottom of the caste order, and because as he declared: 'I like the religion that teaches liberty, equality, and fraternity.'"[22] However, these candidates for prophetic suspicion would need to satisfy a good number of conditions for integrally and coherently salubrious suspicion, as indicated above. Perhaps Gauri Lankesh — a recent martyr espousing the hermeneutics of suspicion — could qualify. Commenting on some of the stellar qualities of Lankesh, who was his first wife, Chidanand Rajghatta, a US based journalist states: "There was no doubt she was left of center, even extreme left of center. But her heart was in the right place, and there was no place in her world for violence. Only cowards took to violence."[23] True masters of suspicion are never cowards. The ones who do away with them demonstrate their cowardice time and again through human history.

Conclusion

The Indian subcontinent has had a long history featuring a variety of hermeneutics of suspicion. The contours of such suspicion may not exactly mirror those found in other parts of the world, but there are many overlapping similarities. Contemporary suspicion, however, needs to be more expansive than that advocated by the traditional "masters of suspicion," according to the taxonomy provided by Paul Ricoeur. In the first section of the article,

several aspects of suspicion or critique have been highlighted, which need to be employed in the analysis of contemporary social discourse.

There are various ways of categorizing suspicion. What has been attempted here is a ranking from the least salubrious to the most sublime and noble. Accordingly, three general categories have been proposed. The programmatic is the most totalitarian and partisan, the pragmatic is the most focused and acutely critical and the prophetic is the most integral and inspiring. Different times call for different forms of suspicion. But it is hoped that in India and elsewhere, more agents are able to enter into the arena of especially pragmatic and prophetic critique. The former group of agents constitute varied and motley voices which need to wake us up from our diverse dogmatic slumbers, while the latter — however few and far between they may be — promise to add wholesome models and ideals to the perennial stock or archetypes of exemplary human virtue and wisdom.

Notes

1 Just as Jurgen Habermas speaks of the "public sphere" of social discourse over the recent centuries in Europe, Amartya Sen has argued that such a space for argumentation has similarly existed in the Indian subcontinent. See Jurgen Habermas, *The Structural Transformation of the Public Sphere*, trans. Thomas Burger (Cambridge, MA: MIT Press, 1991) and Amartya Sen, *The Argumentative Indian* (New York: Farrar, Strauss and Giroux, 2005).

2 See Paul Ricoeur, *Freud and Philosophy: An Essay on Interpretation*, trans. Denis Savage (New Haven, CT: Yale University Press, 1970), 32 ff.

3 See the debate between Nancy Fraser and Axel Honneth in their *Redistribution or Recognition?: A Political-Philosophical Exchange* (London: Verso, 2003). While Fraser prefers the route of social justice via redistribution, Honneth argues for something which he claims is more fundamental: the need for recognition as the basis for peace and social harmony.

4 See Jurgen Habermas' two-volume magnum opus, *Theory of Communicative Action*, trans. Thomas McCarthy (Boston, MA: Beacon Press, 1984, 1987).

5 In *Freud and Philosophy*, 33, Paul Ricoeur clearly states that the "three masters of suspicion are not to be misunderstood, however, as three masters of skepticism . . . All three clear the horizon for a more authentic word, for a new reign of Truth . . ."

6 Aijaz Ahmad, *Lineages of the Present: Ideology and Politics in Contemporary South Asia* (London: Verso, 2002), 215.

7 *Ibid*.

8 Valerian Rodrigues, "Coasting towards trouble,"*The Hindu*, 3rd August, 2017.

9 See "London NRIs flag President Kovind on rights violations," in http://www.ucanindia.in/news/london-nris-flag-president-kovind-on-rights-violations/35355/daily#, accessed 18th August. 2017.

10 Ram Madhav, "Coming Full Circle at 70," *Indian Express*, 15th August, 2017.

11 Ramachandra Guha, "Perils of extremism," *The Hindu*, 17th December, 2000.

12 The Swadeshi Jagran Manch is an affiliate of the right-wing RSS.

13 Ramachandra Guha, "Perils of extremism," *The Hindu*, 17th December, 2000.

14 Pope Francis, in "Pope Says No to "Ever-Present Temptations," in https://zenit.org/articles/celam-pope-says-no-to-ever-present-temptations/, accessed 15th September, 2017.

15 Kancha Ilaiah has recently come into trouble for terming an upper-caste *vyshya* group as "social smugglers," engaging in a process which "did not allow the cash economy to come back in the form of investment either for agrarian development or for promotion of mercantile capital. The wealth . . . [got] arrested and used only within the caste borders." See "Explaining the 'Social Smuggling' that has Angered Arya Vysyas in Two States," in https://thewire.in/177385/explaining-social-smuggling-angered-arya-vysyas-two-states/, accessed 25th September, 2017. Ilaiah's works such as *Why I am not a Hindu* (Kolkata: Samya, 1996) and *Post-Hindu India* (New Delhi: Sage, 2009) have raised many hackles among upper caste Hindus.

16 See Ramachandra Guha, ed., *Makers of Modern India* (New Delhi: Penguin-Viking, 2010), Chapter 20, "The Defender of the Tribals." Guha calls Verrier Elwin "a remarkable Englishman-turned-Indian . . . the Oxford scholar who became the foremost spokesman for India's tribal peoples" (p. 469).

17 Ramachandra Guha, "Perils of extremism," *The Hindu*, 17th December, 2000.

18 Avijit Pathak, "Gandhi, the Subversive," in *Indian Express*, 2nd October, 2017.

19 *Ibid*.

20 Gandhi's apparent insensitivity towards radical caste reform seems to be the most obvious Achilles' heel in his philosophy. He also tended to downplay the fears that Muslims felt before freedom from colonial rule, in the light of the creation of a majority Hindu state.

21 Avijit Pathak, "Gandhi, the Subversive."

22 Ananya Vajpeyi, "The house on Primrose Hill," *The Hindu*, 13th October, 2017.

23 Chidanand Rajghatta, "My friend and first love, Gauri Lankesh was the epitome of amazing grace," in http://timesofindia.indiatimes.com/city/bengaluru/my-friend-and-first-love-gauri-lankesh-was-the-epitome-of-amazing-grace/articleshow/60401693.cms, accessed 15th September, 2017.

3

Re-inventing Hermeneutics of Suspicion from Contemporary Indian Realities

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Abstract: Contemporary Indian reality is Brahmino-centric. The Brahmino-centricity has grown into a body where all aspects of our life have become its organs. Everything in contemporary Indian is an organ of a brahminical body. Our society is fast becoming orgasmically over coded, losing its organic character. Orgasmic body is a libidinal body. It is looking for the satisfaction of libido. It is thirsty and is willing to chase anything that is satisfying its thirst. What is that which is seducing us all? Caste seems to have become as intoxicating as pornography. It manifests in contemporary debates around nationalism, beef politics, love, jihad, etc. In order to understand the libidinal traps that we enslave ourselves to, we have to study the trajectory of desire. Desire was studied in psychoanalysis. Lately, another mode called schizoanalysis has emerged as a profound way of understanding the trajectory of desire. Schizoanalysis focuses on the productive hermeneutics rather than semiotic hermeneutics. This means that it asks how desire works rather than seeking the meaning of desire. This paper attempts at a schizoanalysis of desire and tries to produce different paths for the emergence of hermeneutics of suspicion in India.

Introduction

This paper has an expressed desire to re-invent hermeneutics of suspicion from contemporary Indian realities. In order that our exercise is fruitful, we are

challenged to trace the trajectory of desire in our society. Desire was studied by psychoanalysis for some time. Lately, another mode called schizoanalysis has emerged as a profound way of understanding the trajectory of desire. This mode of analysis was proposed by Deleuze and Gauttari. Schizoanalysis focuses on productive hermeneutics rather than semiotic hermeneutics. The former asks how desire works while the later seeks the meaning of desire.Like psychoanalysis, schizoanalysis is both a clinical and a critical tool. We shall strive to conduct a schizoanalysis of desire in this paper and try to produce different paths for the emergence of hermeneutics of suspicion. We shall find that schizoanalysis is an important tool in this regard. India has plural traditions of hermeneutics of suspicion. Unfortunately, their critical power is often silenced and overshadowed by the social location of Brahmanism, which is anthropocentric, patriarchal and casteist. Indian society is Brahmino-centric. The Brhamino-cenricity has grown into a body where all aspects of our life have become its organs. Everything contemporary Indian is an organ of a brahminical body. This is the reality of contemporary India. We hope schizoanalysis might help us to disentangle these Brahmino-centric chains and thus set their emancipative potentials free.

The first three parts of this paper are mainly an exposition of schizoanalysis as developed by Deleuze and Gauttari, although we do try to find some parallels to their conceptual apparatus. We do not carry it out in the spirit of comparative philosophy[1] which has steadily come in vogue today. All this is done only to let us assimilate the conceptual tools of schizoanalysis so that we can apply it to our realities. The next two parts of the paper are on doing a schizoanalysis of Indian realities to develop several pathways to hermeneutics of suspicion.

To begin our task, we shall try to map the trajectory of desire with the help of schizoanalysis. To conduct this analysis, we will have to use the conceptual apparatus developed by Deleuze and Gauttari. Having opened the trajectory of desire, we then try to follow the trajectory of body without organs, the force that slows down the dynamism of the restless desire. We follow this analysis with the analysis of desiring machines. This study opens us to the dynamism of the unconscious of our society. Having mapped the unconscious of our society, we then strive to construct a hermeneutics of suspicion. We begin this task by examining how our thinking is trapped into the Oedipus complex which upholds the phallic logic. We then try to manifest how phallic logic becomes caste-rating brahmanical logic in our society and in the final section attempt to seek alternate and salubrious ways of being Indian.

Cartographies of Desire

psychoanalysis, schizoanalysis studies the trajectory of desire. It relies on the productive power of desire and manifests insightful ways that we can employ to understand our society; in its power structure.

The Eccentric Self, Desire and Emergent Unconscious

The psychoanalytic work of Lacan has already demonstrated that the self is eccentric.[2] The eccentric self became a Schizo in the work of Deleuze and Gauttari.[3] We can relate the Schizo to the non-substantive self of Buddhism. The self in Buddhism is split into a stream of new larvae self that are entangled into an ocean of desire. Buddha teaches that desire is the cause of all suffering. Deleuze and Gauttari point out that since the selves is eccentric, desire is also split or detached from the self. Desire is productive and swings to seek gratification or jouissance.[4] It does not necessarily oedipalize.[5] It is anti-oedipal. But humans are both products and agents of desire. As products and agents, humans work within social codes. Social codes belong to beliefs, myths rituals, taboos, kinship structures etc., of a society. These codes do not just operate symbolically but work economically by distributing debts[6] and obligations across the social body. Thus, we can race territorialisation as well as deterritorialisation of the dynamics of desire at play in the self. In the context of this productive desire, we also produce the unconscious. This means unconscious only exists to the extent we produce it. Desire has two poles, two regimes or two fundamental ways of organizing or distributing itself.[7] This means desire invests in two different ways at once. Desire wishes to become part of the megamachine (status quo) to keep it going, while at the same time it wishes to revolt against it.[8] Deleuze and Gauttarir revolt against Freud who taught that the infant is a *homo natura* whose subjection to the Oedipus Complex resolves the conflict between anti-social (incestuous) desire and desire in its socialized form (submission to the law of the Father). They hold that desire is social and celebrate the revolt against the law of the father.[9] Sudhir Kakar translates the Oedipus complex as Ganesha Complex. Oedipal behaviour is rendered as Ganesha afraid of losing his head.[10] From this point of view, anti-oedipal behaviour would mean standing up against the sword of Shiva.

Desiring Machine, Aggregates and Assemblages

Anti-oedipal behaviour is a refusal of the symbolic castration/beheading of Ganesha. Anti-oedipus becomes a desiring multipliciteous subject. This may relate to the no-self of Buddha. Maybe no-self of Buddha could be reinterpreted as several selves (larvae selves). It embodies what Deleuze and Gauttari call desiring production, the cycle of producing production that is

repressed by the Oedipus complex. They teach that desiring production is the function of the desiring machine. It is by being a desiring machine, that humans belong to nature. In fact, there is no real distinction between nature and humans. Humans are no special beings.[11] Humans are not Lords over created nature. Humans belong to the natural cycle of producing production. It is being coupled with other desiring machines (internal desires) that they become identifiable as aggregates. Everything is an aggregate or assemblage and stays in the flow of production.[12] That means the desiring machine carries other machines grafted onto them. Thus, for instance, mouth that is attached to the food becomes a desiring machine/assemblage. The desiring machine stays immersed in multidirectional linear binary flows.[13] The oedipal submission to the patriarchal authority is the price that we have to pay to suppress our desire. This is why it is opting to chase a death drive. It is becoming a body without organs.[14] It is trying to gain stability of identity. It is choosing death.[15] Being part of this cycle of producing production, it can be viewed as a parallel to the death-rebirth cycle of transmigration that several Indians believe. Staying with the Karmic flows, humans and other creatures become manifestations of desiring machines that seek to inter-relate. Maybe the Buddhist notion of a non-substantive self becomes a strong parallel to the perpetually becoming subject of Deleuze and Gauttari. We may even think that the stream of non-substantive selves (larvae selves) freeze into the atman of the so-called astika schools.

Body without Organs and Schizoid Subject

Deleuze and Gauttari teach that Body without Organs is produced every time the flows of desiring-production momentarily stop, before resuming again with the renewed coupling of machines.[16] It is an enormous undifferentiated thing that may be viewed at the most as a spectral subject of sorts, which evaporates as soon as it seems to materialize. To understand it we cannot ask what it means but have to consider what it does.[17] In a most general sense, it provides a relief moment for the restless desire. Let's take up an example from an Indian tradition. We may imagine that the Buddhist stream of non-self/larvae selves that are moving at quick pace are slowed down and solidified into a singular substantive self/atman. That which slows down this stream is a body without organs. Deleuze and Gauttari identify capital as a body without organs in our contemporary society. Thus, they invite us to think about capital as nothing concrete but a process of reducing-transforming ghost-like all values (intrinsic as well as use values) to exchange values. They teach that a Schizoid Subject become the result of the decoded flow of capital which they view as a body without organs. They see the capital as a body without organs as it does not exhibit a character of 'fixity' that an ego or object-identities usually display. The Schizo is the end product of these flows because the principle of exchange

value whose major signifier is money, decodes or replaces the intrinsic and use value of things. Thus, for instance, the watch given by a lover to the beloved is merely reducible to its exchange value and nothing more. The loss of the intimate value of the watch translates as surplus value via exchange value in favour of the capitalist. The love that it symbolizes is totally deterritorialized but offering other options to the watch, it recodes and reterritorializes love as a product of an exchange value. This means that, like love, everything returns under capitalism but as this flow of capital. Capitalism further splits the subject as it de-totalizes meaning and accommodates to all civilizations. India is not free from this grip of capitalism. We can clearly identify the rise of the Schizo Indian with the growth of neo-liberal economic policies of our government.

Cartographies of Body without Organs

The concept of body without organs moves beyond the notion of the body that is already gendered and degraded by patriarchy, caste and religion. It enables us to understand what makes something desirable.

Body without Organs, an Anti-production Force

Desire incessantly demands fulfilment. Deleuze and Gauttari set the Body without organs as relief from the desire's incessant desire.[18] They say that it is synonymous with Freud's death instinct.[19] It is not an object. It is a state that desire desires. It is not something that desire lacks. It is what desire desires the most. What desire desires the most is not to desire.[20] It is a point when desire is unable to exert any pressure. It is a moment of Samadhi, which brings about the cessation of the *vruthi* of desire. It is like a momentary escape from *samsara*, the wheel of continual birth and rebirth. It is this desire that takes control of the self. Thus, if the psychoanalysis of Lacan views desire as that which is pushed by a lack, Deleuze and Gauttari view desire as productive and they wish to reach a point of no desire, a body without organs. Thus, body without organs does not pre-exist desire. It is not the ultimate gatekeeper. It comes into being as an effect of the desiring process.[21] There is not a single body without organs. There can be many of them. Thus, for instance, in the case of a schizophrenic, desire goes into a hyperproductive drive and it fires off thoughts, associations at an accelerated speed that is higher than what the subject can process. In this context, body without organs emerges as a counterweight and becomes a force of anti-production, slowing things down and eventually bringing them to a halt. It is almost like the tamasic forces that counter the satvic and rajasic energies, yet within this oppositional dialectics the satvic as well as rajasic energies are released. The desire to become a Brahmin becomes a body without organs in India as it provides a relief to the demands of desire at play in our society. The desire to mimic a Brahmin ultimately castrates everyone as it halts the limitless possibilities of being and self imposes an enclosed identity of the

Brahmins which always remains at a distance, and one has to simply settle settle being a image of a Brahmin.

Body without Organs, a Death Instinct

Freud taught that a death exhibits an obsessive compulsion to repeat a particular set of ideas, rituals and behaviours almost in defiance of the pleasure principle. Freud affirms that it is the repetition process that itself gives rise to pleasure and not the set of ideas, rituals and behaviours. Using the instance of the 'fort da' game of his nephew, he asserts that repetition is a means employed by the unconscious to gain mastery over discomforting stimuli.[22] It is both a mechanism of self-defence and self-cure. The death instinct belongs to the level of drives and therefore, the subject is helpless and cannot easily resist them. When Freud speaks of a death instinct, he is speaking of the other domain, the domain before life rather than the one after. Therefore, he is not saying that in the midst of life, we wish to die.[23] The death we seek is not an end of life but a return to an inanimate state that preceded life. We seem to seek the peace and quiet of of the inanimate state which we enjoyed before we took the first breath.[24] This is exactly the point of Arthaud's body without organs.[25] Faced by so many demands from within, he longs for a body without organs. Deleuze and Gauttari borrow their view of body without organs from Arthaud. The closest that one can think about, in the power of our Indian thought, is the Purusha who gets entangled with Prakruti and sets on an evolutionary journey wishing to release itself from Prakruti. It brings out the desire of Atman for moksa from the bondage of the body, only to join the cycle of transmigration.

Body without Organs, a Driving Force of Desire

Following Melanie Klein, Deleuze and Gauttari develop the notion of desiring machines. Melanie Klein speaks of a splitting of an object, which an infant attaches itself to, both as a matter of love. This object of attachment is the maternal breast. For Klein all subsequent attachments or investment of libido follows this path of latching on to and, in the process, separating off the object. The Jaina tradition of the six blind men and the elephant may be close to the partial objects. But these partial objects are not fetishized and are inappropriate to our context. Maybe we need to look at tantric traditions[26] to seek parallels to partial objects. The 'invested' breast is disassociated from the maternal body as is the infant's mouth from its own body. In this dynamic process both, the maternal breast and the mouth of the infant, take a life of their own, thus becoming what Deleuze and Gauttari call machinic.[27] This process is highly complex and the object/machine is prone to be good and bad. The maternal breasts are good when it feeds the infant but becomes bad when it is withdrawn from the infant's eyes and its milk is withheld. Besides, these objects/machines are highly mobile and completely unstable. Hence, Deleuze and Gauttari teach

that the maternal breasts as partial objects are split into good and bad but are aggressively emptied, slashed to pieces or broken into crumbs.[28] The good partial objects/machines are adopted by the child as constitutive to its sense of self (introjections) while the bad partial objects are rejected (projection). This dynamism continues as good partial objects are further to split into good and bad, and are further absorbed and expelled (reintrojection/reprojection). This is how desiring machines operate. Thus, for instance, the mouth becomes chiefly a speaking machine; it detaches from other functions. Thus, it will have to stop eating, vomiting, crying, etc., while speaking. A speaking machine/ object enters another realm. Now what matters are the words that flow from it and not the mouth itself. Deleuze and Gauttari call it deterritorialisation. It is within this train of thought that they are talking of Body without organs; it is a plenum to which we attach ourselves, others, things, cultures, philosophies, which then functions as organs of that body and drive our desire.

Cartographies of Desiring-machines

Freud opened us to the existence of the unconscious. But for him it was terra *incognita.* Lacan taught that it is linguistically structured. Deleuze and Gauttari reveal to us the machinic nature of the unconscious.

Synthesis of Partial Objects

Schizoanalysis strives to transmute the theatre of representation (dominated by semiotics) to the order of desiring production. It attempts to discover the nature and functioning of desiring machines in a human being. Deleuze and Gauttari construct their own return to Freud. They remind us that Freud had argued that the unconscious knows no negation, contradiction, opposition or objects, but only connections. Thus, they teach that Freud views the primary process as being unmoored by any sort of representational realism or instinctual or natural relation to sexuality. But unfortunately, Freud failed to follow his own findings, and instead of relating to partial objects and flows, he views primarily attachments as attachments to fully formed objects (mother, father, son etc). Hence, schizoanalysis stays with the partial objects and examines how they are gathered together and redistributed by the passive ego or Body without organs. This process is called passive synthesis. Schizoanalysis scrutinizes how passive synthesis is capable of taking a plurality of different forms or entering different assemblages. Deleuze and Gauttari teach that different historical eras exhibit ways of organising passive synthesis, although their chief focus is on the way an individual subject has his own particular way of synthesis.[29] From the Indian point of view, Brahmanism is the chief body without organs and organises and redistributes partial objects both collectively and individually. Brahaminism is like capitalism. It drives our need for equivalence. Like capitalism, Brahmanism bridges the dissimilar through a symbolic exchange of

what may be called as caste dividend. Deleuze and Gauttari call it the process of axiomatization. Caste castrates us. It ranks and subordinates us as well as inhibits us from being our true self. We mimic the Brahamins. Brahmanism becomes the measure through which everything in India is organised. It allows everything in our country to grow organs. All these only become organs into the body of Brahmanism. Everything has to be born again and be grafted into the body of Brahmanism. Thus, all God's cultures, languages and even religion are to be born again.

Unconscious as a Desiring-machine

Deleuze and Gauttari invite us to think of the unconscious as a machine. They view a machine from the perspective of what it does and propose that a machine connects to other machines. Just like the partial objects connect so does a machine connects and forms assemblages and facilitates the flows of energy that runs through it. Thus, they reject the Freudian view that sees the unconscious as a theatre where the dramas like the Oedipus are played out. This means they shun aside the idea that the unconscious is a dark forbidden place where desire is buried. Quite contrary to these Freudian positions, they view the unconscious as a factory that produces desire and tries to plug into a variety of other machines and processes. They point out that the desire to connect with other machines begins with the desire to connect with the breast machine of the mother; and they follow it up with other social machines like the school, church, workplace, market etc. Indeed, the pursuit of desire renders us into sockets and plugs desiring to couple with other humans as well as social machines. This let them think of the unconscious without relying on the notion of lack. It allows them to conceptualize desire as productive, which emanates from our unconscious, that passes through us through connect us to the outside world. They connect as well as cut to all further connections which are unheard. It is rhizomatic. The desire to connect is at the heart of materialist psychiatry which they christened as schizoanalysis. Schizoanalysis maps the flows as they appear. It does not interprets but attempt to map where the desiring machines are heading to.[30] This is why we attempt to track the path of desiring machines in our society and consider how we can ride them to produce a hermeneutic of suspicion from the prevailing realities in our country. It is here that Indian realities become important to produce several hermeneutics of suspicion. We can take inspiration from the Indian protestant movements like the nastika darshanas or the tantric traditions that break free from Brahmanism and provides alternate ways of seeking life and emancipation.

Becomings and Desiring-machines

Becomings are always in a process of becoming and changing. All becomings are rhizomatic and do not follow any structured progression. They are creative.

We may liken them to the Buddhist doctrine of dependent origination. Delueze and Gauttari speak of three main types of becomings: becoming-animal, becoming-child and becoming-women. All becomings are attempts to become molecular. Becoming does not imitate or identify with someone. They are not molar. They position becoming-woman as primary to all becomings since they all pass through it. Becoming-women contests man/woman binary of psychoanalysis. There is no becoming-man as it cannot become-molecular. Just because women is positioned as oppositional to man/phallus/masculine, the absolute representative of the standard or norm, all becomings have to come through becoming-woman. They further teach that becoming-woman is not limited to man but women also have to become-woman. Women also have a molar identity. It concerns what is expected from a normal woman. This is imitative while becoming-woman cannot be mimetic. No one can become a woman by wearing a dress or makeup. Becoming-woman is a molecular transformation and is different for every person. Becoming-woman involves dismantling of molar identities like wife, mother, sister, virgin, prostitute etc. It involves staying in a continues process of transformation, always changing. All becoming is becoming a minoritarian. Hence, becoming-child as well as becoming-animal contest the privileged binaries of adult/child and human/animal respectively. By these becomings Deleuze and Gauttari try to dismantle the imposition of molar identities of man and woman.[31] This way of thinking and being can assist us to interrogate and dismantle the patriarchal and casteist value hierarchies that control life in our country.

Inventing a Hermeneutics of Suspicion

Schizoanalysis enables us to generate a hermeneutics of suspicion that will dislodge the one that is submissive to the Oedipus complex. Setting our thinking free from the Oedipal stranglehold can produce new emancipative hermeneutical keys to view our society.

Living beyond the Oedipus Complex

Unfortunately, we in India are trapped into webs of the binary logic. As a society dominated by the purity/pollution principle, we are also dominated by hierarchical thinking. National the anti-national, Hindus and Muslims, man and woman, dalits and upper caste, meat eaters and vegetarians etc., are well known binary oppositions that clutter our thinking. The binary structure of our thinking is trapped in the Oedipus complex and forces us to oedipalize in favour of the Law of the father, the oedipal superego. This means our thinking follows a phallic logic and maintains the power equations in our society. The phallic logic brings all our thinking into the framework of a family and we triangulate between mother, father and son, only to oediplaize in favour of the law of the father. It suppresses our desire to contest what passes off as

knowledge, tradition and an authentic mode of life. All our thinking appears to have arisen through the unfolding of the Oedipus complex. It maintains the already established caste and patriarchal hierarchies that control our societies. Hence, the anti-oediopal thinking challenges the phallic structure of our thought. It dismantles the mother, father, son triangle that strangulates and hierarchizes our thought. We can trace anti-oedipal thought visions or darshanas like the Nastika traditions of Buddhism, Jainism, Carvaka that rejected the Astika schools based on Vedic authority. Besides the above, the Agamas of the Shaivas and the Samhitas of the vaishnavas,[32] which included the Vaishnavaite Bhagvatas and the Shaivaite Pasupatas that do not toe the Vedic line, can viewed as anti-oedipal. Some Shaivaites from the south assert that the spirit of Agamas is Dravidian but the present material form that they have today is degradation in the shape of sanskritization.[33] We may also place the Upanishadic watershed that challenged the sacrificial ritualism within the anti-oedipal framework though it stays within the caste tangle and loses its critical power. Besides, we have the tantric traditions that question the mainstream beliefs and practices. Even lingayatism of Basava can provide resources to interrogate caste-laden oedipal thinking in our society. We might also find critical resources entangled, with their respective popular theologies, in the vachanas and keerthanas of the Bhakti traditions of Shaivism, Shaktism as well Vaishnavism.[34] Some may even do a deconstructive reading of the Ramayana and Mahabharata reading it through the lens of those people who are invisiblised as well as marginalised by the text. Unfortunately, these classical critical hermeneutical approaches have lost their teeth and are in need of reinterpretations and re-appropriations. Besides these systems, we can draw inspiration from contemporary Indian masters of suspicion like B. R. Ambedkar, Ramaswamy Periyar, Narayana guru etc. We have the duty to seek the critical power of the tribal and dalit thought which is rooted in the land-life symbiosis.

Embracing a Body without Organs

Caste castrates the power of the body. This is why the notion of body without organs assists us to dismantle the caste-rated bodies in our societies. Becoming body without organs is a resistance to the body stained and scripted by the caste system in our society. Caste system is a body politics that hierarchises the bodies based on the principle: purity/pollution. The operation of this principle inscribes the relation of lack into our bodies and places them on to a hierarchical ladder. The three gunas theory of the brahaminical metaphysics which characterizes the satvic, rajasic and tamasic bodies, then becomes the defining principle of hierarchy in a caste ridden society. Hence, the body without organs that we have embraced in this analysis assists us to raise our thoughts beyond the caste tainted thought that is in control of our society today.

Karl Marx thought that economics determines our society and its thought. Jean-Francois Lyotard disagrees and teaches that it is the libidinal economy of a society that determines the structure of our society.[35] Following their mode of thought, one can hold that it is the caste thinking that is structuring our society and its thought. From the Deleuzian point of view capitalism is a body without organs that has produced all the organs of our society in which that we are living today. In India, we have to critically admit that it is Brahmanism or casteism that is the body without organs which has given rise to the kind of society that we are living today. All our myths, beliefs, taboos, rituals, kinship structures, politics etc., move towards that brahmanical transcendental point. It is this point that structures our society based on the consequent distribution of caste-dividend. What we need is to castrate the cast-rated subject. This may require a total reorientation of our desire, which is today is feeding on the caste-dividend. To bring about a transformation, we require a new body without organs that will not define our desire by the principle of lack but will set its productive power free.

Accepting Organs without Body

Developments in biotechnology and cloning have made it possible today to produce organs without bodies. This movement outside the body to create organs and even babies is paradoxically supposed to give us healthy bodies. Deleuze and Gauttari teach that social production is an outcome of distribution of debts in a particular society which itself arises out of modes of energy-flows. They suggest that society organize itself on the basis of debts which take different forms in different modes of social production. It is the system of anti-production that maintains the debt relations in any society. Debt is never paid to anyone. It is a general name under which social obligations are enforced by the system of anti-productions. Social production is a result of the mode of flows of energy in a society. Deleuze and Gauttari teach that there are two ways in which this organisation takes place: qualitative or symbolic and quantitative or economic. They hold that savagery and despotism are organised symbolically via codes and over-codes, while capitalism is organized economically via axioms. Caste afflicted Indian society is organized on the basis of caste dividend which produces *homohierarchicus*. Here we may introduce the notion of organs without body. The debt distribution in our society can create a hierarchical ladder that denies some communities fuller communion in social life. These communities can be seen as organs without bodies. The Hindu Nationalism that is reigning has converted Indians other than the Hindus into organs that lack the body. The mutilation that is inscribed in Hindutva Nationalism is literally mutilating Indians from the body of Mother India. Hence, we need to reject the social production that produces organs

without organs. Thus, the deterritorialized communities can be reterritorialised into the embrace of our country.

Mapping a Disrupting Hermeneutics of Suspicion

Hermeneutics of suspicion is dynamic, embracive of the other and profoundly salubrious. Our attempt to develop sign posts for such a hermeneutics also remains open to its discomforting and disrupting power.

Contesting Processes of Passivity

Passivity takes different forms. It castrates contestations. It prefers silence. It lets the phallus be installed so that the law of the father prevails and phallic logic wins. Schizoanalysis draws our attention to the way passivity is being organised. Passivity is not inactivity. It consists of activities that produce an active submission to Oedipus complex. Brahmanism has organized passivity and oedipalization in multiple ways in our society. Our writings, paintings and even our philosophizing has often produced despotic signifiers that maintains the dominance of the upper caste. This is why schizoanlysis becomes a way of understanding and contesting processes of passive synthesis in our society. Hermeneutics of suspicion has this important task of contesting and even arresting the processes of oedipalizations or passive synthesis in our society. This means it has the task of restoring the critical power of our thought by enabling us to contest the master narratives that are reigning and producingvarious forms of infantalizations in our society. This takes us on the path of dismantling of the ways in which often the unconscious prefers the comfort of silence produced by the operation of phallic logic. If we are develop Hermeneutics of suspicion from Indian realities, we will have to discern how Brahminism produces passivity of resignation to one's fate, maintains its dominance and produces perspectives of its contestations so that new voices of interrogation and emancipation are produced in spaces of knowledge production and circulations. ACPI has an important role in the production of emancipative philosophical orientations. Hence, the production of a hermeneutics of suspicion is both urgent and inevitable. It has a significant Indian and Christian dimension.

Repositioning the Other

The Other is often viewed as a spoiler. Lacan views our unconscious as the discourse of the Other. The Other becomes the (m)other and defines the boundaries of desire. It lays out the field in which desire can appear. Brahmanism has opened the field of desire as well as closed it, as there is no room for desire beyond it. Somehow all desire in our society is echoing or mimicking the desire of the Big Other, the Brahmin. We can territorialise only within psychic as well as physical boundaries marked by Brahmanism.

This is why the Hindutva forces cannot tolerate desire that fails to mimic and reproduce within the brahmanical boundaries. It seems that our desire has to stay within the limits of the brahminical desire. Brahmanism has thus evolved as a despotic signifier and the rest of us in our cast-rated society can only mimic or repeat the desire of a Brahmin. That is why the process of sanskritzation has become a nationwide phenomenon and has to come to define what passes off as patriotism or nationalism in our country. Schizoanalysis has the power to reposition the tyrant Other which has come to constraint the boundaries of desire in our country. It takes us beyond the Phallic logic structured by the either/or structure which has a teleological closure towards the male position. This re-position of the Other becomes an important coordinate for the production of an authentic Indian Hermeneutics of suspicion. It opens fields, for desire to ride waves, other than those opened by patriarchy and the either/or Boolean logic. This means Schizoanlysis can dislodge the cast-rating brahminical logic that is rating and subordinating us according to caste. It opens us to desire alternate ways of being Indian. We can dismantle the brahamanical desire by refusing to mimic it in our thought, feeling and action. Hermeneutics of suspicion requires us to reject the brahmanical censor of our desire. Hence, ACPI has the challenge to encourage thought and life that can trigger alternate ways of Being Indian as well as Christian in India.

Seeking Therapy

Schizoanalysis, like Psychoanalysis, is both critical and therapeutic. The reigning caste-rating brahaminical logic is wounding our society continuously. It deterritorializes us constantly. Schizoanlysis does not seek to represent the existing hierarchies and power equations that play upon our desire but strives to expand desire to embrace other possible ways of being. That is why we may see how new salubrious ways of being Indian can emerge through application of schizoanlysis as alternatives to the homogenizing and wounding way of being Indian enforced by the Hindutva forces. While Hindutva forces present repeatable models from the past that are often stained with hate of the other, schizoanlysis has the challenge as well as the power to open us to new salubrious ways that can enable us to be Indians. It takes us into a future that is yet to come. But this future is not merely a utopia. It is not a platonic pie in the sky but one that focuses on actualisable salubrious possibilities. A Hermeneutics of suspicion suspects the past and opens ways to engage the future. ACPI has the imperative to seek within these multiple ways of engaging, the future salubrious way of being both Indian and Christian. In order to let all create this alternate future we will have to declare the death of Brahmanism and every other oppressive structures that afflicts our society. The Brahmin has to die so that new ways of being Indians can arise. A new body without organs has to be

constructed to replace exploitative and oppressive Brahmanism; so that new and salubrious ways of being Indian can spring forth.

Conclusion

Schizoanalysis, which we have attempted int he context of this study, opens up ways of producing Hermeneutics of suspicion. It takes us beyond the triangulation and strangulation of Oedipus complex and manifests several ways of thinking and being Indian. These expansive and dynamic processes that are unleashed by schizoanalysis have profound critical, emancipative and therapeutic power. Once we understand how the desiring machines of our society operate, we can trace several flows of desire and ride our way to contest the casteist Brahmanical body without organs that has grown organs into our society. We need to critically and therapeutically evolve other bodies without organs that would grow emancipative ways of being Indian.

Notes

1 Jin Y. Park, Ed., *Buddhisms and Deconstructions* (Delhi: Motilal Banarsidass Publishers, 2011).
2 See Dylan Evans, *An introductory Dictionary of Lacanian Psychoanalysis* (London: Routledge, 1996), 51-54.
3 Gilles Deleuze and Felix Guattari, *Anti-Oedipus: Capitalism and Schizophrenia*, trans. Robert Hurley, Mark Seem and Helen R. Lane (Minneapolis: University of Minnesota Press, 2000), 3-5.
4 *Ibid.*, 16.
5 Oedipalize mean to submit to the Oedipus complex.
6 Distribution of debts can be understood as the distribution of the symbolical capital that produces social hierarchies which then would produce mimetic desire and resistance within societies.
7 Ian Buchanan, Tim Matts and Aidan Tynan, Eds. *Deleuze and Schizoanalysis of Literature* (New Delhi: Bloomsbury Academic, 2015), 12.
8 *Ibid.*, 13.
9 *Ibid.*, 11.
10 www.academia.edu/27856855/PSYCHOANALYSIS_ALONG_THE_GANGES._An_interview_with_Sudhir_Kakar accessed 21/08/2017.
11 Gilles Deleuze and Felix Guattari, *Anti-Oedipus*, 3-5.
12 *Ibid.*, 6.
13 *Ibid*.
14 *Ibid*., 8.
15 *Ibid*.
16 *Ibid*., 8.
17 Ian Buchanan, Tim Matts and Aidan Tynan, Eds. *Deleuze and Schizoanalysis of Literature,* 26.
18 *Ibid*., 28.
19 *Ibid*., 32.
20 *Ibid.*, 35.
21 *Ibid*., 36.
22 *Ibid*., 32.

23 *Ibid.*, 33.
24 *Ibid*., 34.
25 *Ibid*.
26 Catherine Anie Harper and Robert L. Brown, Eds., *The Roots of Tantra* (Albany: St. University of New York Press, 2002).
27 Ian Buchanan, Tim Matts, Aidan Tynan, Eds. *Deleuze and Schizoanalysis of Literature*, 36-37.
28 *Ibid*., 37.
29 *Ibid*., 67-68.
30 Paul Eliot, *Gauttari Reframed* (New York: I.B. Tauris, 2012), 56-59.
31 Kathryn M Blake, *A Contemporary Feminist Critique of Psychoanalysis through Gilles Deleuze and Felix Gauttari*, A thesis submitted to the graduate school-New Brunswick, Rutgers, the State University of New Jersey, in partial fulfilment of degree of Masters of Art, 38-46.
32 J Gonda, Ed. *A History of Indian Literature*, Vol. 2, fasc.1 (weisbaden: Harrosswitz, 1977), 4.
33 *Ibid*., 5.
34 See H Shiv Praskas, *Keep Vigil of Rudra, the Vachanas*, sourced online, https://books.google.co.in/ks?id=6YUtAAAAQBAJ&pg=PT42&lpg=PT42&dq=i+keep+vigil+of+rudra+the+vachanas+pdf&source=bl&ots=4DWUcacEDU&sig=rt8A3JcxggRsfwggDTM- accessed on 25th Sept. 2017.
35 Jean-Francois Lyotard, *Libidinal Economy*, trans. Iain Hamilton Grant (Indianapolis: Indiana University Press, 1993).

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From Śṛamaṇism to Scholactivism
The Future of Indian Hermeneutics of Suspicion

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Abstract: In this paper I will approach the question of bridging understanding to action. Hermeneutical tradition has taught us that reading is also rewriting, and that interpretation is a transformative act. If reading leads to action, then readers should naturally become activists. As a matter of fact, a reader who does not emerge as an activist does not read well. Considered in this line, hermeneutic thinkers are destined to become scholar-activists. Are there scholar-activists in India who can teach us how to leverage philosophical research for social change? I will, first, make some critical-creative remarks about hermeneutics of suspicion, and briefly explain the meaning and significance of scholar-activism. Second, I will bring out the activist and critical hermeneutical aspects of Indian thought. The overall point of this paper is that Indian philosophers have to become scholar-activists if they wish to continue the legacy of the great ancient activist hermeneuts of suspicion such as Śṛamaṇās, Nairuktakās, Mīmāmsakās, and so on.

1. Hermeneutics of Suspicion: Some Preliminary Remarks

It was in a context of quarrels among various philosophical claims for hermeneutical primacy, that the French thinker Paul Ricoeur (1913-2005) proposed that a fairly good understanding of human experience requires a combination of hermeneutics and phenomenology; and to that effect he

developed phenomenological hermeneutics. In some cases a phenomenological depiction would be sufficient for understanding; but where there may be a remainder of meaning, certain hermeneutical elucidation is also necessary. Interpretive turns in the history of thought has shown that hermeneutics has actually become ubiquitous.[1] In the history of hermeneutical thought, it is again Ricoeur who has famously distinguished between two types of hermeneutics: hermeneutics of recollection and hermeneutics of suspicion. The former form of interpretation is an exercise for bringing out the inherent meaning of the interpretament whereas the latter form is meant for identifying illusions, false beliefs etc., and thus clarifying the hidden meaning of the interpretament as well as the previous interpretations. Ever since Ricoeur brought out the contributions of Marx, Nietzsche and Freud to the practice of hermeneutics of suspicion, the new sub-discipline has been gladly accepted by many. Among other takers, feminists, post-colonial thinkers and scholars of religion are some of the successful practitioners of hermeneutics of suspicion.

2. A Suspicion of Suspicion

If hermeneutics of suspicion is all-sufficient for an understanding that would lead to a certain distinct change in the situation of the interpreter is a question that we need to consider critically.[2] This is what I mean by suspicion of suspicion; in other words, it is a call for critiquing the tendency to absolutize critical rationality. It is my contention that hermeneutics of suspicion has to be practiced independently of and in parallel with all interpretive acts, and yet all practices of suspicion should eventually refine and reinforce hermeneutics of recollection which in turn will contribute to the development of tradition. It is so contended because, after all, hermeneutics is not the name of an academic game played by some select elites. The aim of conversation (interpretation) is change in the world of the conversation partners. This is possible because every instance of genuine understanding is capable of bringing about some change. Indeed, hermeneutics (of suspicion and recollection) of a social practice is undertaken not for intellectual time-pass but for tangible social change. If such is the case, then the future of hermeneutics of suspicion depends on its capacity to bridge understanding to action. Ricoeur himself considered this question in his *From Text to Action*.Will hermeneutics help us to imagine the world differently than it used to be for long? Yes, it will; scholar-activists in the recent history confirm this possibility.

3. Scholar-Activism

Academic institutions and individual researchers who produce knowledge have a very significant role to play in bringing about change in the society. However, until recently, the producers of knowledge – individual scholars and various academic institutions – had no direct relation with the social change

their knowledge brought about, notwithstanding some exceptions. For what purpose and to what extent a new knowledge must be used had all been decided by people in power. The economically rich and politically strong centers of power have been the policy makers and the actual dispensers of knowledge. Thus, a researcher is only indirectly related to his/her knowledge. Ironically, most of the producers of knowledge in various fields seem to have blindly accepted this indirectedness for various reasons. But, the situation is slowly changing.

The one way sequential relation that existed among scholars, knowledge, and social change, is now re-envisioned by many scholars.[3] Scholars have begun to move along with the knowledge they produce and take an active role in its effectuation. The variously powerful ones in society, who through their politico-economic activities used to control the nature and extent of social change brought about by new knowledge, are now being replaced by scholar-activists. Usually the center of power, which used to be the State in the past and one or another leading corporate agency in the recent times, had been the one and only activist. But in the emerging world-order, very many different scholars are becoming activists who decide (or at least make claims to make decisions regarding) how knowledge must be used and for what purpose. The new combination of scholarship and activism is conveniently named scholactivism.[4]

Scholactivism, which is obviously a mash-up of "scholarship" and "activism," denotes an approach as well as a movement. This approach/movement emerges wherever and whenever scholars, who believe in their capacity to make use of their knowledge for social change, claim a visible role in developmental processes. The specific identity of a scholar-activist has to be affirmed against a couple of seemingly similar type of scholars. First, there are scholars who are acclaimed as public intellectuals. A public intellectual finds his/her fulfillment in making what he/she knows further known to the common public. Scholar-activists are not such public intellectuals. More than making their knowledge accessible and relevant to the public, scholar-activists invest their time and resources in experimenting their knowledge in view of the betterment of the community where they find themselves. Second, there are scholars/activists. These are intellectuals who undertake scholarly works and activist ventures separately. Their life is divided between academic scholarship and public activist initiatives; they believe in and so maintain a distance between the world of scientific research and the socio-cultural life-world. Activists who occasionally retire for private study and retreat represent, I suppose, a variation of the scholar/activist type, namely, activist/scholars who undertake scholarly works in the academic world and activist initiatives in public spaces in parallel with each other. Scholar-activists, on the other hand, maintain plain continuity between their knowledge and action. For a scholar-

activist, a public activistic engagement is nothing but a natural flowering of his/her scholarly convictions.

In the following we will first bring out the activist import of Indian thought, especially in the ancient Mīmāmsa system, and second, referring to the ancient Indian scholar-activists, Śṛamaṇās, we will argue that contemporary Indian thinkers can claim the legacy of scholactivism which in our reading is the height of critical hermeneutics.

4. The Activist Aspects of Indian Thought

By and large Christian scholars' study of Indian philosophy has taken place under the purview of Western academy. We are indeed grateful for this generosity, and yet as Indians we cannot forget the fact that many of the philosophical texts we study are translated and commented upon by Western scholars, that our philosophical schools were determined and classified by Western historians of thought, and, still worse, that much of our Indian philosophical self-understanding has been a borrowed self-understanding. We are taught to believe that Indian philosophy is pessimistic and dogmatic; we are forced to start with the premise that Indian philosophy is stationary and totally indifferent to ethics.[5] Many of us have an almost innate preference for the so-called orthodox systems in Indian philosophy and among them a special preference for Vedānta, and within Vedānta for Śankara's advaitism. Indeed, for the vast majority of scholars, both in India and abroad, Indian philosophy means Vedānta, especially Śankara's Advaita Vedānta, which seems to prompt them to consider the world as an illusion produced by maya, and therefore, to return from the world of actions to a quiet world of passive contemplation. In this philosophical climate artificially created by Western Christian as well as Brāhmaṇical socio-religious hermeneutics of Indian thought, activism is short-lived. Gīta's ideal of *niṣkāma karma* is activist in kind, but it is shadowed by a double eclipse, on the one side by a mystical and mystifying knowledge (*jnāna*) and on the other side by pacific and paralyzing piety (*Bhakti*). Is there a system of thought in India which is activist through and through?

Among the many Indian philosophical systems the Mīmāmsa has promising potentials to develop specifically Indian hermeneutics, criticism, rhetoric and jurisprudence. However, for long, both Indian and Western scholars did not take this ancient aspect of Indian thought seriously, maybe because the Mīmāmsa did not present salvation as the highest goal and, still worse, consistently held a heretical view of the authorless origin of the Vedas. Yet, none can ignore the singular importance of the Mīmāmsa without which "there probably wouldn't have been the logic of Nyaya (the name itself is given by the Mīmāmsa, broadly meaning 'the line of reasoning…'), not to speak of the richness of Vedānta, which is otherwise also known as Uttara or later Mīmāmsa."[6] But in the recent decades scholars like P.T. Raju, Wilhelm Halbfass, Francis Clooney, Daya Krishna and others have begun to take Mīmāmsa for serious study. In the following, basing ourselves on P.T. Raju, we will bring out the activist import of Mīmāmsa.

In his address delivered at the Bhandarkar Oriental Research Institute, Pune, in 1958, P.T. Raju stated that Indian culture and thought in its very essence contains activism, and that Mīmāmsa is the chief activist philosophy in India.[7] Sanskritists, Orinetalists and Jurists who study Mīmāmsa have taken note of the activist aspect of this school of thought;[8] but, unfortunately philosophers practically ignored this tradition. Originally Mīmāmsa was a *dharmaśāstra*, science of right action; and it was in the course of time that Mīmāmsa thinkers accepted *mokṣa*, spiritual liberation or salvation, and thus made it subservient to Vedānta. Since then philosophy of action was considered incomplete and insignificant unless it remained related to knowledge (*jnāna*) and devotion (*bhakti*).[9] In any case, as Raju rightly notes, "the value which the Mīmāmsa wants to defend is an indispensible value of life."[10] Mimamasa takes human life to the center of philosophy. This insight is quite in consonance with the humanism that is inherent in Indian classical literature, which, for instance, is succinctly put in a śloka in Mahābhārata: "*Guhyambrahmatadidamvobravimi, namanusatsresathatararh hi kincit*," meaning, "this I tell you is the secret of Brahman: there is nothing greater than man."[11] In times when men and women are killed in the name of animals and ideological differences, and, in a country where no man is allowed to live as human, the Mīmāmsa humanism needs to be rehabilitated in Indian thought. Philosophers have been discarding Mīmāmsa because of its overwhelming ritualism. We are not defending ritualism, but on the contrary, making an effort to judiciously assess the humanistic philosophy underlying the myths and rituals in Mīmāmsa. Our overall point in this section is that the humanist philosophy in Mīmāmsa is activist in kind. In the following we will bring out the salient features of Mīmāmsa activism.

(i) *Mīmāmsa activism is ethical activism:* Indian systems consider karma as an important category along with other categories. In Mīmāmsakas' estimation, karma is not just one among many categories, but the most important category. There is the external world and different categories that constitute the world. But, Mīmāmsa believes that activity, karma, can control the world process. In other words, the world is shaped and reshaped by actions that follow ethical laws. Put differently, "determinism of nature adjusts itself to the freedom of man."[12] Mīmāmsa can be validly called an activist philosophy because it holds that various processes in the world are controlled by ethical actions.

(ii) *Mīmāmsa activism is absolute activism:* The proponents of Mīmāmsa do not think that God is necessary. The question of

creation and final dissolution does not arise because the world is believed to be eternal. Similarly, since karma is the actual controller of the world, the possibility of a preserver God is also ruled out. Karma is not only made responsible for guiding the world processes but also absolutised as the unitary power. Individual karmas are only manifestations of the unitary karma.

(iii) *Mīmāmsa activism asserts its primacy over theology:* For Mīmāmsa right action is more important than salvation; and injunctive sentences in the early layers of the Veda are more important than speculative sentences in the later layers. This is the reason why Mīmāmsa classifies Veda into two parts only, Samhitās and Brāhmaṇas; both the Āraṇyakas and the Upaniṣads, the speculative components of the Vedic corpus, are included in the Brāhmaṇas. Given the overall activist orientation, Mīmāmsa considers considers speculative texts such as the Upanishads to the earlier layers of the Veda which give direct commands for actions.

(iv) *Self (atman) is the agent of activity, and activity is the property of the self:* Mīmāmsa equates atman with *aham*; it does not accept the Vedantic view that atman transcends the ego. It must be noted that on this point Kumarila and Prabhakara differ; the latter does not agree that atman is the agent of action. It must also be noted that Prabhakara's view has been shown to be inconsistent with the spirit of Mīmāmsa.[13] An action once performed becomes the property of the self, which means that it becomes an attribute of the will of the agent. Technically, this attribute is called *apūrva*.

(v) *Good is the flip side of right:* One can find a debate between Kumarila and Prabhakara over the right and the good: what do the Vedas command, to act or to produce apūrva?. While Kumarila argues that the Vedic injunction is to act (*kriya*), Prabhakara argues that it is to produce a result (*kārya*). But the purpose of action, highlighted by Kumarila, connects the right and the good: "The injunction is indeed for action; but the action is right not merely because it is due to a command of the Veda, but also because it is directed towards the production of the Good (*prayojanavat*)."[14] Right and good are two sides of intentionality.

(vi) *Mīmāmsa epistemology is activistic:* Karma being the primary category, life, according to Mīmāmsa is activity. Life ends where activity stops. Such being the case, the theory of knowledge as well as education has to be necessarily activistic. What does this mean? One learns the meaning of a word not merely by familiarizing oneself with the referent of the word (for instance, upon hearing the word cow one looks at the animal called cow and establishes

a connection between the word and the referred object), rather by associating the word and its referent with one or another action in which the referent is involved (for instance, milking the cow, tending cow, etc.). This activistic understanding of knowledge production and dissemination has its basis in Prabhakara's doctrine of *anvitābhidhānavāda*, which states that a sentence consists of words meaningfully connected with a verb. This doctrine has been countered by Kumarila school and many Vedantins. According to the latter, a sentence consists of uttered words with independently obtained knowledge. But the point Prabhakara is making from an activistic epistemological perspective is persuasive and convincing: a noun must have already connected with a verb before it is uttered in order to make any sense.[15]

(vii) *The primacy of verbs over nouns:* The height of Indian activism is to be found in Nirukta, the ancient Indian branch of knowledge which deals with the relation between words and meaning. The Niruktas belongs to the Brāhmaṇical sect of Vedic religion, and as such, is organically related to Mīmāmsa school of thought. Like other activists Niruktas hold that activity is the essence of reality. And therefore if language wants to give a true picture of the reality it is concerned about, then it has to give primacy to verbs over nouns. Raju summarizes the Nairutkta view in this regard as follows: "In every sentence, the noun and verb are primary and the rest secondary; and of the two again, the verb is primary and the noun secondary. In the meaning of a sentence, nouns, adjectives, propositions, etc., appear as modifications of the verb. In other words, the phenomenal world is adverbial."[16]

(viii) *Being (sat, satta) is a modification of becoming (bhāva, bhāvana):* According to Nirukta doctrines, the truth of the world is Becoming or activity (bhava), and this has a causal aspect as well as an effect aspect. The causal aspect is pure Becoming; all categories such as substance, qualities, actions etc., are transformations of the original pure Becoming. This view is obviously contrary to the Vedantic view of the ultimate as pure Being or Existence (*sat*). Activists' notion of eternal pure Becoming is different also from the *puruṣa* and *prakrti* of Sānkhya and the indivisible atoms of Vaiśeşika, the ultimate indivisible elements in these systems. Only verbs can try to express the Becoming. There are many forms of the effect aspect of Becoming. Birth, existence, modification, growth, decline and death are major forms of the effect aspect of Becoming. It is not a primeval pure existence that gives rise to the world and various beings in it; rather it is the pure Becoming that passes through its

various states of self-transformations which in effect produce the world full of things. Mīmāmsa does not teach that Atman is pure Becoming; but, as was said previously, it teaches that activity in the form of dharma is the controller of the world order.[17]

(ix) *Humans are superior to deities:* One can find an exalted humanism in Mīmāmsa. As previously mentioned, atman is same as the self. Unlike deities who have no body, humans have the senses and mind which help them to perform ethical actions. The world (*samsāra*) is not looked upon as a source of sufferings, rather it is received as something to be enjoyed through ethical actions. Having been endowed with the senses and mind, humans can act and contemplate. When humans use their senses ethically and realize the atman spiritually, they become fully human. A person who is thus fully human is Brahman acting in the world. Ethical activity is all that is important; and the agent of ethical action is more important than a god who is an empty liturgical dative. In Mīmāmsa the primitive religion where gods were at the centre is transformed to a religion of ethical activism and self-help.

(x) *dharma is a category of action:* Mīmāmsa understands *dharma* in terms of *karma*, and thus Mimamsa has an activistic conception of *dharma* as well. But, this is not how other Indian systems understand *dharma*; for instance, Buddhists have a quietistic understanding of *dharma* while the Vaiśeşika understands dharma as merit which is obtained by listening to the Vedas and thinking over the categories. In Buddhism *dharma* is an empty category which can mean anything, like quality, activity, religion, law etc. For Vaiśeşikas, *dharma* can mean both action and withdrawal from action, *pravrtti* and *nivrtti.* But, for Mīmāmsa *dharma* means *karma*. If knowledge and virtue are not translatable to everyday activities, they mean nothing.

To sum up: Many might still suppose that Mīmāmsa can at best offer only a cold ritualism, lifeless legalism and outdated textual criticism. But with P.T. Raju, we want to argue that behind its ritualism, legalism and textual criticism, Mīmāmsa still contains valuable germs of activist thinking which Indian philosophy badly needs for survival. Even if all that is said in the ten points above is only a tiny splinter of the fire of activism, it is already a lot. Although, Mimamsa has always been an activistic school of thought, it could realize its activism on three fronts: ritual, jurisprudence and literary criticism. An unacquainted reader of Mīmāmsa may be easily stultified by liturgical consummation of the whole of thinking and writing, but a perceptive reader will be led to a happy discovery of the structural depth of the ancient Indian

activist thinking. Having seen the activist aspects of Indian thought, mainly in reference to Mīmāmsa, let us now examine the critical hermeneutical aspects of Indian thinking, especially in reference to the ancient Śṛamaṇā Movement and some modern Indian scholar-activists.

5. Critical Hermeneutical Aspects of Indian Thought

As G.C. Pande has rightly stated, "a leading key to the understanding of Indian history lies in the negative challenge posed by the ascetic Śṛamaṇism in its several varieties and the interaction of the Vedic tradition with it."[18] The spirit of protest and criticism was always alive in the Śṛamaṇism. Buddha, for instance, is said to have asked his monks to accept his words only after examining them, and not out of reverence for him. Śṛamaṇās opposed traditionalism and the dogmatism of Vedic tradition. In order to capture the full picture of Indian critical hermeneutics, along with the study of Śṛamaṇism one should also study many subaltern thinkers and scholar-activists.[19] But, for the time being, we will assess the hermeneutical practices of ancient Śṛamaṇās. Three important points of disagreement between Śṛamaṇism and Brahmanism were caste system, authority of the Vedas and belief in God. Let us consider, for instance, the Sramanic criticism of caste system.

According to *Sonadanda Sutta,* five pre-requisites are necessary for someone to be regarded as a Brāhmaṇa: (i) "a Brāhmaṇa is well born on both sides - on the mother's side and on the father's side, of pure descent back through seven generations, with no slur put upon him and no reproach in respect to birth;" (ii) "he is a repeater of (the sacred words), knowing the mystic verses by heart, one who has mastered the three Vedas with the indices, the ritual, the phonology and the exegesis and the legends as grammar, versed in Lokayata sophistry and in the theory of the signs of a great man;" (iii) he has to be "handsome, pleasant to look upon, inspiring trust, gifted with great beauty of complexion, fair in color, fine in presence, stately to behold;" (iv) he has to be "virtuous;" and finally (v) he has to be "learned and wise."[20] It is widely agreed among scholars that the caste system in the exact use of the term today did not exist at the time of the Śṛamaṇās;[21] some scholars disagree with this. In any case, one can find many Buddhist and Jain canons that speak against the caste-system as they perceived it, especially, how they perceived the absolute superiority of the Brāhmaṇas.

Once there was a debate between Bharadvaja and Vasiṣtha about Brāhmaṇahood. Bharadvaja argued that Brāhmaṇahood depends on birth while Vasiṣtha argued that it depends on conduct. Both approached Buddha for more light on the matter. Buddha first contrasted the differences between species and castes, and stated that the species differ in physical features but not so the human classes. Among humans there is only vocational and occupational distinctions. One might become a farmer, merchant, ruler or a

priest. None of them is a Brāhmaṇa. One does not become a Brāhmaṇa or a non-Brāhmaṇa by birth; it is by deeds that one becomes and ceases to be a Brāhmaṇa. Austerity, chastity, self-restraint and control of the senses are the ways to become a Brāhmaṇa. Asvaghosa argues that there is only one race which got functionally divided into four.

Just as the Buddhist texts, Jain texts also maintain a strong anti-caste attitude. See for instance the debate between Mīmāmsakas and Jains. Kumarila stated that Brahmanahood is not merely a collection of moral qualities or a character produced by them or a species manifested by them. It is on the other hand a physical class character which is apprehended in perception as aided by the knowledge of the person's heredity.[22] Against this view, a Jain Acarya, Prabhacandra points out that a Brāhmaṇa does not look different from a non-Brāhmaṇa, and therefore, Brahmanahood cannot be perceived as a distinctive mark. Brāhmaṇahood is only a social description. Thus, Jains explain caste system in reference to social functions.[23]

As mentioned previously, although mainline Brāhmaṇical tradition eschewed Śṛamaṇic views as unorthodox, *Sramanic* insights did find their way into later Hindu scriptures. See for instance a conversation in the Mahābhārata where the *Sramanic* view about Brāhmaṇahood is clearly reflected:

The serpent said, 'O Yudhishthira, say--Who is a *Brāhmaṇa* and what should be known? By thy speech I infer thee to be highly intelligent.'

Yudhishthira said, 'O foremost of serpents, he, it is asserted by the wise, in whom are seen truth, charity, forgiveness, good conduct, benevolence, observance of the rites of his order and mercy is a *Brāhmaṇa*. And, O serpent, that which should be known is even the supreme *Brahma*, in which is neither happiness nor misery--and attaining which beings are not affected with misery; what is thy opinion?'

The serpent said, 'O Yudhishthira, truth, charity, forgiveness, benevolence, benignity, kindness and the *Veda* which worketh the benefit of the four orders, which is the authority in matters of religion and which is true, are seen even in the *Sudra*. As regards the object to be known and which thou allegest is without both happiness and misery, I do not see any such that is devoid of these.'

Yudhishthira said, those characteristics that are present in a *Sudra*, do not exist in a *Brāhmaṇa*; nor do those that are in a *Brāhmaṇa* exist in a *Sudra*. And a *Sudra* is not a *Sudra* by birth alone--nor a *Brāhmaṇa* is *Brāhmaṇa* by birth alone. He, it is said by the wise, in whom are seen those virtues is a *Brāhmaṇa*. And people term him a Sudra in whom those qualities do not exist, even though he be a *Brāhmaṇa* by birth. And again, as for thy assertion that the object to be known (as asserted by me) doth not exist, because nothing exists that is devoid of both (happiness and misery), such indeed is the opinion, O serpent, that nothing exists that is without (them) both. But as in cold, heat

doth not exist, nor in heat, cold, so there cannot exist an object in which both (happiness and misery) cannot exist?

The serpent said, 'O king, if thou recognise him as a Brāhmaṇa by characteristics, then, O long-lived one, the distinction of caste becometh futile as long as conduct doth not come into play.'

Yudhishthira said, 'In human society, O mighty and highly intelligent serpent, it is difficult to ascertain one's caste, because of promiscuous intercourse among the four orders. This is my opinion. Men belonging to all orders (promiscuously) beget offspring upon women of all the orders. And of men, speech, sexual intercourse, birth and death are common. And to this the Rishis have borne testimony by using as the beginning of a sacrifice such expressions as--*of what caste so ever we may be, we celebrate the sacrifice*. Therefore, those that are wise have asserted that character is the chief essential requisite. The natal ceremony of a person is performed before division of the umbilical cord. His mother then acts as its *Savitri* and his father officiates as priest. He is considered as a *Sudra* as long as he is not initiated in the *Vedas*. Doubts having arisen on this point, O prince; of serpents, Swayambhuba Manu has declared, that the mixed castes are to be regarded as better than the (other) classes, if having gone through the ceremonies of purification, the latter do not conform to the rules of good conduct, O excellent snake! Whosoever now conforms to the rules of pure and virtuous conduct, him have I, here now, designated as a *Brāhmaṇa*.'

The serpent replied, 'O Yudhishthira, thou art acquainted with all that is fit to be known.'[24]

The most crucial bone of contention between Śṛamaṇism and Brāhmaṇism was the superiority of Brāhmaṇas, which both the Buddhists and Jains rejected. However, they did not try to replace the caste-wise stratified society with an egalitarian society. Rather, they tried to elevate the position of the Kṣattriyas, give more importance to the Vaiśyas and admit persons from the lower caste to their monasteries. It is important to note that scholars have proposed to "link the anti-caste attitude of Buddhist and Jaina thinkers with the fact of their affiliation with the Kṣattriya republics of north-eastern India."[25]

Although the Śṛamaṇās were generally critical of Brahmanism, and Brāhmaṇical tradition did officially discard the Śṛamaṇās as heretical, that both were mutually influenced is a simple fact. In shaping one's home tradition each one borrowed from the other. For instance, the Śṛamaṇā doctrine of karma, rebirth and mokṣa greatly influenced the Upanisadic thinking; in addition, their ascetic and monastic practices influenced Brāhmaṇism to develop and structure their fourth āṣram, namely Sanyāsa. Similarly, although the Śṛamaṇās vehemently opposed the Brāhmaṇical caste system, they nevertheless accepted the practice of social stratification, sometimes even with spiritual elitist overtones. This mutual giving and taking, even in the course of

mutual refutations, is not, however, a matter of inconsistency; rather it points to a fact of hermeneutics: hermeneutics of suspicion is not all-sufficient as far as the continuity of the home tradition is concerned; it has to be practiced as an aspect of recollection which contributes to the making of one's tradition.

Conclusion

Indian philosophical traditions have both activist and critical elements in them. The ancient Śṛamaṇās practiced hermeneutics of suspicion in a quite rigorous manner in view of attaining liberation from limiting social conditions and religious ideas, which in the course of time evolved as strong religious and philosophical persuasions such as Jainism and Buddhism. A liberative movement emerges when brave critical approach is combined with unfailing activist commitment. There is quite a lot of critical intellectual mass in India which has to be organized for creative and liberative action projects.

Notes

1 David R. Hiley, James F. Bohman and Richard Shusterman*, eds., The Interpretive Turn: Philosophy, Science, Culture* (Ithaca-London: Cornell University Press, 1991), 2.
2 Whether hermeneutics of suspicion is all-sufficient was raised by D. Z Philips. See his *Religion and Hermeneutics of Contemplation*, (Cambridge, UK: Cambridge University Press, 2001).
3 Stéphane Couture, "Activist Scholarship: The Complicated Entanglements of Activism and Research Work" *Canadian Journal of Communication,* vol. 42 (2017), 143-147.
4 Rebecca Farnum, "Scholactivism – A Growing Movement of Scholar-Activists" University World News, 03 June 2016 Issue No: 416 <http://www.universityworldnews.com/article.php?story=20160530142606345> (10 October 2017).
5 See, for instance, Albert Schweitzer, *Indian Thought and its Development*, (London: The Beacon Press, 1957).
6 Purushottama Bilimoria, "Being and Text: Dialogic Fecundation of Western Hermeneutics and Hindu Mīmāmsa in the Critical Era," in Rita D. Sherma and Arvind Sharma, eds., *Hermeneutics and Hindu Thought: Toward a Fusion of Horizons,* (New York: Springer, 2008), 64.
7 P. T. Raju, "Activism in Indian Thought," *Annals of the Bhandarkar Oriental Research Institute,* vol. xxxix, July-October 1958, 189.
8 Bilimoria, "Being and Text: Dialogic Fecundation of Western Hermeneutics and Hindu Mīmāmsa in the Critical Era," 69-70.
9 About this shift, P. T. Raju comments: "The *Mīmāmsa* preaches karma; but the fashion of treating karma (action) as subservient to *bhakti* (devotion) and *jnāna* (knowledge, gnosis) has grown. Thus by interpreting the *Mīmāmsa* as what it was not intended to be, it was represented as incomplete, imperfect and so unimportant; and thus the very spirit behind philosophy was lost sight of. But most of the protagonists of this school did not accept this interpretation." Raju, "Activism in Indian Thought," 189.
10 Raju, "Activism in Indian Thought," 191.
11 Cited and translated in H.S. Sinha, *Communism and Gita: A Philosophico-Ethical Study* (Delhi: Concept Publishing Company, 1979), 41.
12 Raju, "Activism in Indian Thought," 196.
13 Raju, "Activism in Indian Thought," 201.

14 Cited in Raju, "Activism in Indian Thought," 206. Accordingly, dharma is defined as that object which is beneficial and which is propounded by the Veda.
15 Raju, "Activism in Indian Thought," 208.
16 Raju, "Activism in Indian Thought," 209.
17 Raju identifies the crucial difference between Mīmāmsa and Nirukta as follows: "If we define will as self in action, then Nairuktas will say that the self is the same as the will and the Mīmāmsakas will say that the self possesses the will." Raju, "Activism in Indian Thought," 211.
18 G.C. Pande, *Śṛamaṇa Tradition: Its History and Contribution to Indian Culture*, (Ahmedabad: L.D. Institute of Indology, 1978), 9.
19 See, Arup Maharatna, *India's Perception, Society, and Development: Essays Unpleasant*, (New Delhi: Springer, 2013).
20 Cited in Pande, *Śṛamaṇa Tradition*, 54.
21 *Dialogues of the Buddha* (*The Dîgha-Nikâya*), Trans. from the Pāli by T. W. Rhys Davids, (London: Oxford University Press, 1899) Vol. I. 101.
22 *Tantra Vartika* of Kumarila Bhatta, 1.2.2, cited in Pande, *Śṛamaṇa Tradition*, 61.
23 Pande, *Śṛamaṇa Tradition*, 63.
24 *The Mahabharata*, Book 3: Vana Parva, Kisari Mohan Ganguli, tr., [1883-1896], Section CLXXIX.
25 Pande, *Śṛamaṇa Tradition*, 59.

5

Independent Thinking and the Politics of Knowledge-Production

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Abstract: This paper deals with two aspects of the same question: the ideal situation of the question of authentic and independent thinking, and the real situation of manipulative thinking, presented as the 'politics of knowledge-production.' It begins with an introductory clarification of a few notions, such as 'independent thinking,' 'politics,' and 'knowledge-production.' The paper elaborately considers 'the politics of knowledge-production' by pointing out the culture of domination as its philosophical 'why.' It is clarified by referring to Heidegger, Levinas, Foucault, and Derrida. Thereafter the paper looks into the question of manipulative production and communication of knowledge as the means of perpetuating oneself by stifling the different. The second part of the paper makes a strong plea for an 'independent thinking,' which is developed taking inspiration from Heidegger's 'Thinking of Being' (*Seinsdenken*), and the paper is concluded with a challenge addressed to the ACPI members.

Introduction

This paper is to be situated in the context of the Seminar on "Indian Hermeneutics of Suspicion." When 'suspicion' is subjected to hermeneutical violence, what is suspected stands out more explicitly. The title of the paper contains two aspects of the same question: the ideal situation of the question of authentic and independent thinking, and the real situation of manipulative

thinking, presented as the 'politics of knowledge-production.' But the manipulative powerful have been concealing the 'darkness' in knowledge until it was brought to light when people began to give thought to it in an authentic thinking. The edifice of knowledge has been hitherto considered as a solid and dependable deposit of truth. On this apparently 'unshakable' edifice 'cracks' began to show up in the contemporary period of postmodern thinking; the 'genuineness' of knowledge began to be questioned. The need and urgency to think critically and differently on the way knowledge got 'shaped' began to be felt among the thinking people. It is in response to such a felt need that an attempt is made in this paper towards bringing to light the dark situation of truth and knowledge being controlled and manipulated, against which the ideal of independent thinking has to be seen. As the journey of this search moves on, the direction it takes will show itself.

Before we begin our journey proper, we need to give some introductory clarification to a few notions; and we shall limit ourselves to those notions that exclusively and prominently figure in the title of this paper. The main title, 'independent thinking' refers to a thinking that is 'independent' from something or someone. But what is this something or someone from which thinking has to be independent? The subtitle, *the Politics of Knowledge-Production*, contains the answer: thinking has to be independent from the *Politics of Knowledge-Production*. Although, the term *politics* primarily means 'the art of governing,' it is taken here in a pejorative sense of 'shrewdly calculated and planned approach which is ordinarily kept concealed from the public.' Thus the meaning conveyed by the title of the paper could be presented as follows. Thinking has been manipulated with some hidden agenda, and we need to liberate it and reinstate a thinking that is free from the politics of subjective manipulation. A few questions pose themselves here: Can truth and knowledge be manufactured as any object? Can it be controlled by someone for some ulterior motive? Can we think of liberating knowledge from the subjective clutches of the powerful few? Is there a philosophical basis for such a process of controlling knowledge? Is there any philosophical reason so as to why humans want to control and manipulate truth and knowledge?

1. The Politics of Knowledge-Production

We shall dwell at length on the real situation of manipulative production of knowledge, proceeding from its *why* to its *how*.

1.1 Culture of Domination: The Philosophical 'Why' of Knowledge-Production

Humans have been developing and embracing a culture of domination which could be pointed out as the philosophical reason for the sad plight of knowledge-production. Western philosophy has been making a victorious

march of the conquest of reality by the subject; and it is philosophically explained in different ways by contemporary thinkers.

1.1.1 Domineering by Metaphysical Subjectivity: Heidegger

The journey of domination with which humans are characterized can be traced back to their metaphysical nature: *being* one's self, egoor subjectivity. According to Heidegger, Western metaphysical tradition, which has been a subject-centred thought-pattern, began with Socrates, Plato, and Aristotle, the great masters of Western thought, culminated in German idealism and became complete in Nietzsche.[1] During such a long metaphysical period of two millennia, Western thought has been developing itself into a conceptual philosophy, which grew in its intensity during the modern period—and more especially during the period of enlightenment—when metaphysics became epistemology with emphasis on the subject-object dichotomy. The subject becomes the arbiter of truth, and for the representing subject[2] the world becomes a 'picture,' an 'object' (*Gegenstand*)—that which is made to stand over against the representing subject. Such an 'objectifying' thinking by the subject gradually becomes an established fact in science and technology.

The 'intellectual domination' over reality enjoyed by metaphysical subjectivity has been growing in its depth and width; the culture of domination gradually took a more aggressive expression, extending to all the dimensions of reality: the natural, the human, and the divine. The powerful, with their thirst for domination, especially in the economic field, try to subjugate everything and to bring it under their manipulative control. The whole earth has become a market place, where everything—including humans—has become a commodity of calculated market value.[3] In such a culture of domination, laments Heidegger, not even God is spared. The 'encapsulating' of God in high-precision concepts is indicative of the humans' presumptuous monopoly over the truth of the Divine.[4] Thus the divine too has become a victim in the victorious march of metaphysical subjectivity. It gets intensified and legitimized in the onslaught of globalization,[5] which exploits and controls humans in a carefully concealed and apparently 'civilized' way, and it dictates what is 'objectively' true and what is 'morally' right. We are gradually beginning to see as to how knowledge and truth are getting produced.

1.1.2 Totalizing in Western Philosophy: Levinas

Heidegger has presented 'subjectivity' as the ultimate source of the culture of domination; Levinas[6] paints it in a language with an ethical colouring, and thus both of them agree on tracing back to the same source as the 'reason' for humans engaging themselves in knowledge-production. According to Levinas Western philosophy has been considering everything under the encompassing notion of Being, under its various guises, such as the One, the *Same* (*le Même*),

the Totality, the there-is (*il y a*) etc., as a result of which the other-than-Being [Transcendence, exteriority, Infinity, the Other, alterity (*l'Autre*) etc.] was excluded. Such a philosophy of *the Same* is a celebration of the narcissism[7] of the ego, with an over-emphasis on *autonomy* and individual freedom. By excluding the transcendent and by encompassing every Other in the Same, Western philosophy has been proclaiming "the philosophical birthright of autonomy."[8] The 'I,' in its totalizing tendency, looks at the Other in terms of 'utility' and 'profit,'[9] and draws the world into its circle and keeps on consolidating and expanding this circle of persons and things.

The 'auto-nomous' totalization of the world of persons and things into one's self implies one's never-ending control and domination over the *being* and *having* of persons—control over truth and knowledge. The ego-centrism of one subject collides with that of other subjects, giving rise to inevitable conflict![10] Everyone wants to have control over truth by having control over its production.

1.1.3 Civilizing Process of Control: Foucault

Michel Foucault finds that 'power-mechanism' is operating in humans under the guise of knowledge; and he presents it in rather blunt language. He unmasks the concealed play of power in humans with his peculiar way of unraveling the question of 'madness,' not as illness, but as a concept reinvented at different periods of time for the same purpose of *healing*, *educating* and *civilizing* the people who deviate from the 'normal.' This process had its origin in the institution of 'leprosarium,' meant to keep the lepers away from society. Although leprosy disappeared from Europe, the idea of leprosarium as a place of segregation continued to exist. Thus the 'normal' society began to segregate the 'abnormal' mad. The elements that outlasted leprosaria were the values and images attached to the figure of lepers as well as the meaning of their exclusion from the 'sacred circle' of society. Foucault finds that the process of exclusion and confinement takes on new forms, such as asylums, hospitals, prisons, houses of formation, schools, hostels etc. The deviants with '*unreason*' were put into a fortress of confinement, well planned and laid down by the 'normal.' Foucault finds that the reform movements were not motivated by humanitarian concerns, but by the fear of 'unreason'—a new disease or a new leprosy! Thus the strategy behind the exclusion-inclusion process is nothing but the exercise of power to 'normalize' the abnormal, to 'civilize' the uncivilized.

1.1.4 Process of Marginalization: Derrida

Modernity had an established thought-pattern, according to which the socio-religious system has been considered as a hierarchical structure with different groups placed one over the other or one around the other according to an assumed priority of importance. Postmodern thought has brought to light,

and destroyed such a myth of the higher and the lower, or the center and the periphery. Lyotard's definition of postmodernism, "incredulity toward meta-narratives,"[11] is indicative of this shift of thought. Jacques Derrida has given greater clarity to it by his *deconstruction* of the binary opposites. According to him, Western thought and life-pattern has been based on a hierarchical system of binary opposites of the center and the periphery. The center has been taken as that which guarantees meaning and truth, and that which does not fit in with the centre is pushed out to the periphery. What is at the periphery has meaning only in reference to the center.[12] Philosophy, morality, social structure etc., have been built exclusively *on* and *for* the center, and the periphery is totally excluded.[13] The centre not only keeps on trying to exclude, ignore and repress those at the margins, but it wants to freeze the structure of binary opposites. Such a relation of marginalization is what exists between those who take upon themselves the task of knowledge-production and those for whom it is produced.

Our journeying along with the thoughts of some of the contemporary thinkers has philosophically shown that humans by their nature have a leaning towards domineering over other humans, which shows itself by taking control over truth and knowledge, and this tendency is kept intensified down through the centuries.

1.2 Manipulative Production and Communication of Knowledge

The culture of domination began to show itself in manipulating truth and knowledge, and to establish the manipulated truth as a 'fact' for the future generations. 'Facts' are created by th 'story-makers,' who can create the story the way they want it to be; the genuineness of the fact depends on the credibility of the 'creators of facts.'[14] But is it possible to 'create facts' and/or 'to produce knowledge?'

With his reflections on 'manipulative communication' Foucault can be of great help here. He shows the hidden power behind the politics of manipulative communication and knowledge. Originally communication has been a sharing or exchange of thoughts; this original meaning got radically changed in the contemporary media of production and communication of knowledge. It has become a means to monopolize and to assert the will of those who control the media of communication.[15]

The powerful—whoever they may be—try to have control over 'truth' and 'rectitude' for others to know and to follow. What is advantageous and useful to them is presented to and imposed on others as what is true and what is right. As a result of such monopolizing communication and establishing it as the 'fact,' only *one* view is heard as the '*only view*.' The other views are silenced in the onslaught of the 'loud' view of the powerful. In imposing one's ideology as true and right, the powerful do away with the 'different'—different

perspectives on truth, and approaches to values. They keep on justifying their manipulative control of communication by convincing (*cum+vincere*: to conquer)[16] themselves and others that the powerless are infants—illiterate, inefficient, irrational—and hence, instead of them, the powerful (the grown-ups, the intelligent, the rational) will speak; their 'voice' is silenced and appropriated by the powerful who impose 'infancy' on them.[17] Thus only one voice is heard and respected, and what is communicated through that voice is unquestionably true and right!

In the context of this paper Foucault's thought-provoking analysis of the concealed presence of power-structures in producing and communicating truth and knowledge makes sense. The producers of knowledge claim themselves to be literate, capable, important, grown up, civilized and they want that all the others should accept it as truth.

1.3 Politics of Knowledge-Production: Means to Perpetuate Oneself

The craze to keep oneself enthroned is not limited only to the present, but to one's future as well. One's future is not limited to one's life; it is limitlessly extended to the future beyond one's life. One wants to remain 'enthroned' to the indefinite future!

By the caliber and depth of one's life and message, the genuinely historical persons continue to be alive even after death; their life is extended to the future, and their names are perpetuated. Through the historizing process,[18] persons and events become historically significant. They have become historical as they have been creative in their being and thought. But there are also persons who perpetuate their names by the strength of their power—by manipulatively creating knowledge and truth, and by establishing it as a fact that is perennially true. Thus, one's excessive craving for domination has taken the form of one's desire for immortalizing oneself by a manipulative creation of and tampering with knowledge and truth, so that one's person and ideology will be remembered by the future generations, and one's name will be enthroned in memory.

In the expression, 'to be enthroned in memory,' the notion of *memory* has a richer meaning than what has been hitherto popularly understood. Until recently, memory has been considered as limited only to the past.[19] Memory refers to one's ability to extend oneself to the past and to the future. In the words of Heidegger, "The gathering of thinking back [*des Andenkens*] into what must be thought is what we call memory [*Gedächtnis*]."[20] Thus it is not merely a 'recalling' (*Gedenken*) [of the past], but primarily a 're-collecting' (*An-denken)* [to the future]. 'As re-collective thinking' memory is primordial thanks (*Dank*) and devotion (*An-dacht*).[21] In remembering persons and events with devotion and thanks, they become alive and present, as a result of which the spatio-temporal interval (here and there, now and then) is done away with.

Thus memory has to do both with the past and the future. A 'thinking on' what is to come can only be a 'thinking on' what has been; … in thinking back one thinks ahead.[22] Thus, when a person has gained a place in memory, s/he is perpetuated to the future; memory takes one beyond the spatio-temporal confines of one's life. One perpetuates oneself through memory.[23]

When people enforce themselves to be perpetuated in memory by their politics of knowledge-production, there is every danger of their names gradually fading into oblivion. The 'enforcing' of the memory is carried out by the powerful and influential; but it can last as long as the 'powerless' receivers of truth and knowledge can be kept under the force of hiding the truth, namely, the *perpetuated* truth is a *manipulated* truth! Hence, the desire to perpetuate themselves and their ideology makes the powerful look for ways and means to engrave their names in memory in such a way that they do not fade away; and the easy way found is to stagnate the memory by documenting its content. Thus truth and knowledge, as different from the unfolding of reality to humans, was documented as a dead deposit. Since such recorded document of knowledge is not easily eradicable, there takes place the politics of manipulating knowledge-production.

1.4 Stifling the Different and the Politics of Knowledge-Production

In the process of perpetuating themselves through the manipulative producing and recording of truth and knowledge, the powerful producers are placed in an advantageous position in comparison to the powerless receivers. The producers of knowledge can control it in whatever way they want as they have the infra-structural means to mould the consciousness and discourse of those under them. If the rulers happen to be dictators, they can enforce ruthless censorship that allows only the state-approved version of interpretation, while all other interpretations and outlooks are kept in total darkness. Even in democratic countries there is control over the parameters of public discourse that determine the 'truth' of the events.[24] When other perspectives are kept in darkness, one is forced to accept the documented version of knowledge as the true version.

The producers of truth and knowledge—both religious and secular—are always motivated by some 'ideological interest.'[25] The colonizers had the 'ideological interest' of continuing colonization, and hence they produced truth and knowledge in such a way that it suited their purpose of colonial rule. The religious leaders too are not free from 'ideological interests.' In the *Vedas* and *Puranas*, historical myths were created to legitimize some of the prevailing aspects of social and religious life.[26] In order to freeze and solidify the desired social structure and value system, having recourse to religion and gods has been found to be very effective.[27] Conformity to law and structure is almost guaranteed, when they are presented as the *will* of the Divine. Since the

religious centre of power has the exclusive monopoly over the *will* of God, the cause of the victims could never get into the *plan* of God.[28] Thus for the sake of one's 'ideological interest,' the powerful, besides having recourse to God and religion, silence and darken every other outlook of truth and knowledge.

Summing up our reflection on the politics of knowledge-production, we reiterate that because of humans' craze and craving for domination, individuals and institutions, groups and nations are always on the watch out to establish their influence and power over others even by means of manipulating truth and knowledge. Panikkar has rightly said: "Our civilization is a civilization of armed reason. Our reason is no longer…wisdom or experience; it is experiment and power. Our reason makes conquerors of us…,"[29] con-vincing,[30] conquering every other who think and act 'otherwise.' The politics of truth-and knowledge-production continues to be at work with greater intensity.

2. A Plea for an Independent Thinking

In the light of our aforementioned elucidation of 'the politics of knowledge-production,' we have prepared the ground for giving thought to the question of independent thinking. In the above-elucidation we find that the process of knowledge-production is nothing but an activity carried out and controlled by the subject; it is a knowledge that is totally dependent on the subject. What was innocently started in the metaphysical past as intellectual domination has turned out to be a systematically executed manipulation of truth and knowledge. Contemporary thinkers, in laying bare the politics of knowledge-production, make a plea for a thinking that is free from all such manipulative politics.

Although the expression, 'independent thinking,' may connote a rather sloppy meaning of 'a thinking that is carried out in a carefree manner,' it has to be taken as a thinking that is independent of its exclusive link with the subject; thus it stands for authentic and primordial thinking. It makes sense insofar as thinking has mostly been a subjective thinking, which eventually became a process of manipulative production of truth and knowledge. Since it is manipulatively produced, the subject is free to determine the mode and content of the production; only when such a manipulative 'freedom' of the subject is extinct, it becomes an independent thinking—a thinking that is not tied down to anything except truth—and it is authentic and primordial thinking.

Among the various Western thinkers who have given thought to the question of thinking—a thinking that is delinked from all subjective control and manipulation, there is no better thinker than Heidegger.[31] According to him 'thinking' is not to be taken in the sense of having an 'opinion' or representing or forming an idea about something or a state of affairs. Nor is it same as developing a chain of premises leading to a valid conclusion. In short, thinking is not a 'conceptual enterprise.'[32] Since 'thinking' is not a logical or conceptual enterprise, it is better expressed in poetical, rather than conceptually precise

language. Heidegger, using a French expression, *l'engagement par l'Être pour l'Être*, gives us the clue that 'thinking of Being' has to be considered both as a *call* that *belongs* to Being, and as a *response* that *listens* to Being.[33] Thinking comes to pass in the belonging together of Being and the human, call and response.

Being/Truth is the process of the unfolding of reality to receptive humans. Although, human thinking is not an activity that one carries out, but a receptive openness.[34] Although humans' role is more passive, their receptive openness is needed for the presencing of Being in reality. For them the greatest wonder is: that something is! Reality is seen as a constant unfolding, coming-to-be, or event-ing (*Ereignis*). Reality does not instill any wonder in technocratic human who have stopped wondering at reality; they rather dictate and manipulate reality and truth, rather than let it show itself in its meaning or truth. For the later Heidegger the human is not the producer of truth and knowledge about reality, but the shepherd of Being in its historical happening.

Heidegger's elucidation of independent thinking becomes clearer through his clarification of the question of language. Humans do not produce language; it comes about in the speaking (*Sprechen*) by reality, and the cor-responding response (*Ent-Sprechen*) by the human.[35] Reality is the primary speaker, and humans speak by giving sound to the primary speaking by reality; the *silent speaking* by reality is responded to by a *loud listening* by humans. Hence genuine human speaking is by way of receptive openness to reality speaking in truth. In every human speaking, if it has to be genuine, one should experience an inner struggle as to whether one has 'really heard' what is spoken in the reality.[36] When humans speak without any receptive listening, it tends to be manipulative. Production of truth and knowledge is the result of manipulative speaking with ulterior and subjective motives.[37]

Panikkar's reflections on dialogue can be of help to understand the meaning of 'independent thinking.' Dialogue is a common or social search for what is true and right; nobody with a presumption of having the monopoly over truth can be a partner in dialogue. His distinction between dialectical and dialogical dialogue[38] is quite significant. In the former case one enters into dialogue in order to 'teach' the other, one's position, in the latter case, one wants to 'learn' from the other regarding one's point of view. Dialogical dialogue is not an activity carried out at a prescribed period of time; it is rather a way of life, an ongoing process. In this way, dialogue is not a means to an end, but an end without end. Dialogue presupposes one's openness to truth, and a thinking that is independent from all subjective motives. The pure motive in dialogue—arriving at the truth in collaboration with others—is not the same as a subjective motive that works towards establishing one's pre-planned conclusion. Hence, dialogical dialogue falls in line with independent thinking that delinks itself from all subjective motives.

We referred to Heidegger's notion of language and Panikkar's understanding of dialogue in order to reiterate the point that 'authentic thinking' consists in one's uncontaminated openness to truth without any personal element of human willing, neither representational nor calculative. Such an unadulterated thinking is rightly referred to as meditative and contemplative, mystical and devotional!

We are living in a world flooded with ready-mades—a world where anything can be produced according to need and demand. This process of 'producing' has reached a stage where 'truth' too can be manufactured according to need and demand. Truth, manufactured according to one's need, is the most demanded commodity; hence the production of truth and knowledge has become an organized enterprise, in the light of which, the expression, 'politics of knowledge-production,' is quite meaningful. Re-shaping the truth and re-writing the knowledge according to the ideology of the powerful is systematically carried out in all fields: political, religious, moral, legal etc.

As members of the ACPI—philosophers with Indian and Christian heritage—we are challenged, at this unfortunate predicament of systematic production and manipulation of truth and knowledge, not to flow with the prevailing current. As *philosophers*, *Indians* and *Christians*, we have to be open to truth—whichever be its source, whatever be its consequence, however be its mode of manifestation. Philosophers are called to be *seekers*, and not *producers* of truth and knowledge; what they have *found* in their search is handed down to the future generations, not for taking it as a ready-made package of knowledge, but for their being evoked to thought. As Indians we are privileged to have a philosophical wisdom that is centred on *sat* and *satya*, and that plays down the role of human subjectivity—a wisdom that is *received* and *seen* (philosophy as *Darsana*). Christians are called to follow the one for whom truth has been the way of life (way, truth, and life), and who has had the courage to question the 'producers' of truth and knowledge about religion and morality (the Pharisees).

As we, the Indian Christian Philosophers of India, reflect on 'Indian Hermeneutics of Suspicion,' we need to cast suspicion, first of all, on ourselves as to whether we are fully free from all subjective motives and interests in our being the 'seers of truth.'

Notes

1 "Mit Nietzsches Metaphysik ist die Philosophie vollendet." Heidegger, *Vorträge und Aufsätze* (4. Aufl.), Pfullingen: Neske, 1978), 79; *The End of Philosophy*, trans., J. Stambaugh (London: Souvenir Press, 1975), 95.

2 Heidegger dwells at length on this question in his "Die Zeit des Weltbildes," in *Holzwege*, 5. Aufl., (Frankfurt am Main: Vittorio Klostermann, 1972), 69-104; *The Question Concerning Technology and Other Essays*, trans., W. Lovitt (New York: Harper Torchbooks, 1977), 115-54.

3 Cf., Johnson Puthenpurackal, "The Question of the Human in the Postmodern Context of the Growth of Technology and Birth of Globalization," in *Rehumanizing the Human: Interdisciplinary Essays on Human Person in* Context, ed., Augustine Pamplany (Bangalore: Asian Trading Corporation, 2006), 34.

4 For a detailed presentation of the critique of the traditional understanding of God as a concept of human construct, cf., J.J. Puthenpurackal, "Essencing or Essence of God: The Heideggerian Perspective," *Indian Theological Studies* 29, (March-June 1992), 93-106.

5 Although, Heidegger was not alive when globalization invaded humanity, his philosophical understanding of 'domination' fits perfectly well with globalization.

6 Emmanuel Levinas was a Jewish thinker, whose intellectual growth was nourished by his two-fold background of Jewish religiosity and Western rationality. His personality is the result of his constant movement between the two poles of *Jerusalem* and *Athens*, or between prophecy and philosophy.

Although, Levinas was fascinated by Heidegger's philosophy, he was a strong critic of Heidegger's thought, which is vaguely present in almost all his writings, more explicitly in his *Totality and Infinity*.

7 The term 'narcissism' is coined by Freud, basing himself on the Greek myth of Narcissus (or Narkisos), according to which the attractive young man became so enamoured with his reflection in water, that he falls in love with himself. Thus narcissism stands for self-love.

8 Levinas, "Philosophy and the Idea of the Infinite" (No. 1), as presented by Adriaan Peperzak in his *To the Other: An Introduction to the Philosophy of Emmanuel Levinas* (West Lafayette: Purdue University Press, 1993), 93.

9 Heidegger has made a masterly interpretation of the modern technology in terms of Western metaphysical tendency of 'intellectual domination' becoming 'physical manipulation' of reality.

10 In his explanation of conflict, Levinas must have been influenced by Sartre, according to whom every subject tries to reduce the other to an object by his hateful stare. The result is mutual enslavement and conflict.

11 François Lyotard came to be known as the thinker most associated with postmodernism, especially with the publication of his book: *The Postmodern Condition: A Report on Knowledge*, published in 1979.

12 We can give a number of binary opposites in which the first term stands for the privileged center, and the second is excluded as the periphery: man-woman, Christian-pagan, reason-emotion, nature-culture, truth-falsity, sacred-profane, etc. The second term has only a negative meaning; thus, woman is one who is not a man, pagan is one who is not a Christian, etc.

13 Thus philosophy is based on what is true, ethics on what is right, aesthetics on what is beautiful, religion on what is sacred, etc. The periphery exists only as totally excluded.

14 Johnson Puthenpurackal, "History as the Story of Victors: A Postmodern reading," in *History and Historizing: Philosophical Reflections*, ed., John Peter Vallabadoss (Bangalore: Asian Trading Corporation, 2012), 11-12.

15 In order to understand as to how communication is made use of as a means of wielding power in our society we need to look back into the earlier 'regimented institutions' (leprosarium, mental asylum, hospital, prison, school, etc.) that Foucault speaks of.

16 Panikkar exploits the etymology of 'convince' to bring out the meaning of 'conquering.' Cf., Panikkar, *Cultural Disarmament*: *The Way to Peace*, trans., Robert R. Barr (Kentucky: Westminster John Knox Press, 1995), 88.

17 Cf., Aneesh Mathew, "Communication from the Standpoint of Power: A Study Based on Michel Foucault," *Vijnanadipti*, vol. 8, No. 1 (January 2006), 33.

18 The process of historizing consists in the living of the existentiell possibilities by a *choosing* from the *given*. The possibilities are rooted in the past (the already), though projected to the

future (the ahead). This process is also referred to as the 're-claiming' or 'repeating' (*Wiederholung*) from the inherited possibilities.

19 For a rather detailed study on 'memory,' cf., Sydney Shoemaker, "Memory," in *The Encyclopedia of Philosophy*, vol., 5, Reprint Edition, Paul Edwards, ed. (New York: Macmillan Publishing Co., 1972), 265-74.

20 "Wir nennen die Versammlung des Andenkens an das zu-Denkende das Gedächtnis." Heidegger, *Was heißt Denken?* 3. Auflage (Tübingen: Max Niemeyer, 1971), 95.

21 For a concise consideration of Heidegger's understanding of 'memory,' cf., Johnson Puthenpurackal, *Heidegger, through Authentic Totality to Total Authenticity* (Louvain: Leuven University Press, 1987), 152-56.

22 Heidegger, *Erläuterungen zu Hölderlins Dichtung* (Frankfurt am Main: Vittorio Klostermann, 1981), 84.

23 Johnson Puthenpurackal, "History as the Story of Victors: A Postmodern reading," in *History and Historizing*, 15.

24 All the same, it cannot be denied that the freedom of expression in a democracy contributes towards presenting the historical events with greater transparency and freedom.

25 This is the main thesis proposed by Romila Thapar in her *Interpreting Early India*. As quoted by James Massey, "History and Dalit Identity," in *Dalit Solidarity*, Bhagwan Das & James Massey, ed. (Delhi: ISPCK, 1995), 18.

26 *Ibid*., 19.

27 This technique was employed in Hinduism in order to establish some social order (caste system, the custom of *sati*, etc.) that is advantageous to the powerful high-caste people. Even Christianity is not spared of this. Its moral teachings are attached to *Divine will* or *Divine law.*

28 J. Puthenpurackal, "History as the Story of Victors: A Postmodern reading," in *History and Historizing,* 17-18.

29 R. Panikkar, *Cultural Disarmament*: *The Way to Peace*, trans., Robert R. Barr (Kentucky: Westminster John Knox Press, 1995), 88.

30 '*Vincere*' in Latin means 'to conquer'. Panikkar exploits this root-meaning in the English term: to con-vince. Cf., *Ibid*.

31 Rather than the term 'philosophy,' Heidegger in his later phase of philosophizing uses the expression, 'thinking of Being' (*Seinsdenken*).

32 Martin Heidegger, *What is Called Thinking*, trans. Fred D. Wieck and J. Glenn Grey, intro. J. Glenn Grey (New York: Harper and Row, 1968), xxi.

33 Heidegger, *Basic Writings: From 'Being and Time' (1927) to 'The Task of Thinking' (1964)*, David F. Krell, ed., (London: Routledge and Kegan Paul, 1978), 194.

34 In a detailed manner, the response is elaborated in *Heidegger: Through Authentic Totality to Total Authenticity*, 148-62.

35 Heidegger, *Poetry, Language and Thought*, 210.

36 When the professor evaluates the answer papers, s/he is trying to 'hear' what is spoken in the answer-sheets. The answer papers are 'speaking' and the professor is 'listening' to it with total openness, and expresses it in the form of the 'grade' that is given. Conscientious professors will experience an inner struggle while giving a particular grade.

37 The evident examples for such manipulative speaking are the ways in which language is used for political and ideological propaganda, and advertisements.

38 For a detailed study on Panikkar's position on dialogue, cf., George Panthanmackel, "Dialogue as a Way of Life: Panikkar's Plea," in *Raimon Panikkar, Being Beyond Borders: A Commemorative Volume*, ed., Johnson Puthenpurackal (Bangalore: Asian Trading Corporation, 2012), 297-315.

Part 2

Indian Hermeneutics of Suspicion: Thematic Developments

6

Science as a Hermeneutical Enterprise
Implications for India, Science and Humanity

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Abstract: Einstein was deeply convinced that the most incomprehensible thing about the universe is that it is comprehensible. This declares the mysterious nature of the universe. With recent discoveries, both at the micro and macro levels, and reflections upon them, humanity is increasingly becoming aware of this mysterious nature of the universe. Science, the best enterprise, one that is par excellence to investigate this mysterious nature, is also imbued with mysterious elements. Humanity knows from its long cherished memories that any mystery can never be defined, nor understood clearly once and for all; rather it has to be 'interpreted' to make any sense of it. As there is no *one* absolute way of understanding or defining a mystery, one needs to interpret it. If science also reveals mysteries, it is to be seen as a discipline of mysteries and therefore science also needs to be interpreted. Further, science is a social enterprise, because science is for humans and by humans; therefore all that affects humans - culture, language, experiences, faith, values, fears, anxieties, political upheavals and so on - will also affect science; therefore, every piece of knowledge that is produced has the element of 'situated-ness' and this demands for the task of interpreting it. Positivistic understanding of science - which attributes autonomy, insularity and a privilege form of rationality to it - has to be complemented, or even replaced, with the hermeneutically trained philosophy of science. Nevertheless, if this approach is overstressed, scientific knowledge may turn out to be 'mob psychology' as Popper would caution. In order to avoid these relativistic extremes, we need to have *a hermeneutic approach* in understanding science. This paper, thus, makes an attempt to

discuss: a) the very existential nature of the hermeneutical dimension of science, with the example of the complex nature of matter, and b) to spell out some implications of such an understanding of science for both the enterprise of science and humanity as well.

Introduction

With recent discoveries, both at the micro and macro levels, and reflections upon them, humanity is increasingly becoming aware of the mysterious nature of the universe. Of all the available knowledge enterprises, science has been rather successful in investigating nature. Because its object of investigation is mysterious it is quite understandable that science and its products also get mysterious in some way. Humanity knows from its long cherished memories that any mystery can never be defined, nor understood clearly once and for all; rather it has to be 'interpreted' to make any sense of it. As there is no *one* absolute way of understanding or defining a mystery, one needs to interpret it. If science unravels mysteries, it should be seen as a discipline of mysteries and therefore science also needs to be interpreted**.** Further, science does not take place in any abstract world; its locus is the day-to-day life-situations of the people. Scientists are not a special breed set apart, rather they are also people of flesh and blood, with the regular concerns of practical life; they have their own experiences, faith, values, fears and anxieties that affect their scientific activities too. Science is also not exempted from the effects of cultural, linguistic and political upheavals. As humans are embodied in culture and the history of knowledge produced by them also has to be interpreted. The positivistic understanding of science - which attributes autonomy, insularity, and privilege form of rationality to it - has to be complemented, or even replaced, with the hermeneutically trained philosophy of science. Nevertheless, if this approach is overstressed, scientific knowledge may turn out to be 'mob psychology.'[1] In order to avoid these relativistic extremes, we need to have a hermeneutic approach in understanding science.

I
Science – A Hermeneutical Enterprise

Hermeneutics can be seen as a study of what is meaningful. Not only words, written or spoken, even actions can be seen as meaningful. Since humans are looking for meaning and they can also create meaning, they too can be the subject matter for hermeneutics. Hermeneutics, according to Ricoeur, is "the theory of rules that govern an exegesis, that is to say, an interpretation of a particular text or collection of signs susceptible of being considered as a text."[2] It is obvious that language, spoken or written, needs to be interpreted, due to the very nature of language. The possibilities of equivocal and univocal usage,

the availability of several figures of speech, and even the very fact of thousands of languages spoken/written all over the world necessitate interpretation. Further, human actions and gestures can also be taken as language as they too communicate and need to be interpreted. For instance, Freud undertook a hermeneutical approach to decode human actions and dreams, myths and other social realities of his clients and he was very successful in that.[3] Still, going a step further, one can see even the Nature around us as a text. For instance, Galileo sees the universe as one of the "books" authored by God, while the other one is Sacred Scripture. We need to apply the principles of hermeneutics to both.

Not only philosophers of science but also sociologists of science deeply appreciate the hermeneutical insights from looking at knowledge in its historical situatedness. Harry Collins, Bruno Latour, Andrew Pickering, Simon Schaffer, Steve Shapin and all those who imbibe the principles of social constructivism, see knowledge, including scientific knowledge, as a cultural and historical product. There are concrete efforts to investigate more on these hermeneutical dimensions of science; for instance, *the International Society for Hermeneutics and Science* (ISHS), which began in 1993, was a European initiative to highlight the interpretative dimensions of science. A wide range of issues in the natural sciences are subjected to hermeneutical investigations, such as, how individual scientists or their groups handle the problem situations in which they find themselves, how meaning arises from scientific praxis, the priority of meaning over technique, the predominance of the practical over the theoretical, the cultural and historical disclosures and so on.

Even the very notion of rationality needs to be 'interpreted', today it is understood as reasonableness. Reason is primarily understood as the principle of life; rationality is its practical implementation in scientific inquiries; reasonableness can be seen as the principle that embraces all forms of human life like morality, laws, arts, psychology etc. The very notions of reason and reasonableness have to be interpreted. There is no *one* absolute way of understanding it, to be imposed from outside; it is now understood as something that emerges from the scientific community. We need to differentiate three aspects of rational principles: Reason, Rationality and Reasonableness. One way of understanding them, according to Tran von Duan, would be:

> Reason which is considered by the Greeks as the ultimate causes, *logos*, or the *principium principiorum*, expresses the ontological and metaphysical (theological) dimension of man. Rationality, taken to be the most effective instrument in dealing with technological knowledge and advance, reflects human technical interest of dominating nature and of deciding human fate. Reasonableness is constructed on human tentative solution of conflicts, on human

relationship, and understanding which is happening in our daily life.[4]

There would be a serious crisis not only for science but also for humanity, if scientists and intellectuals try to build a society and a world view based only on rationality.

The need for hermeneutics in psychoanalysis and psychotherapy is more obvious whereas the hermeneutical dimension is neglected or purposefully overlooked. But actually, "the activity of a perceiving subject confronting a world is so radically identical with the activity of an interpreter confronting a text that the natural sciences can give no account of their starting point without using the tools of hermeneutics."[5] As a reader understands a text in his/her context, "the scientist must approach the picture resulting from sensory experience in the critical spirit of an exegete confronting a complex text."[6] By the end of the 20th century radical questions were raised regarding the whole enterprise of science, like 'How can one be compelled to believe what science says about the world?' For instance, Peter Koso in his book, *Reading the Book of Nature*, touches upon such questions, but concludes that with all the limitations, science is the 'best knowledge' that we can have of nature. It is the best not because it presents us with the 'true' picture of reality, rather because of the constant on-going dialogue between the observation and the background theoretical framework that makes the investigations possible.[7] The very title of the book itself, purposefully chosen, reveals the fundamental task of the scientists. As a reader uses all his/her tools of interpretation in understanding a (written) text, scientists try to unravel the 'text' of the book of nature, to decode what has been presented in unfamiliar codes. Similarly, Patrick Heelan explains how a scientist learns to 'read nature' in order to make sense of it. The thread of hermeneutics runs throughout the scientific activity, right from the task of scientific observation. Though one may least expect the need for hermeneutics here at this stage of observation, yet one needs hermeneutical tools to clarify the theoretical background which makes the very observation possible.[8] He also discusses elsewhere how perception is not an automatic act by an isolated observer (i.e. untouched by socio-cultural conditions), rather every perception is an interpretative action, undertaken full involvement with what is perceived.[9] The long-cherished characteristics of science, like objectivity, progress, rationality etc., are radically revised. For instance, Joseph Hanna revisits the notion of objectivity to investigate the wide range of understanding this notion, including the boundaries of scientific objectivity.[10]

Scientific knowledge is not a product given to us on a platter in its pristine glory. All the epistemological issues and hermeneutical considerations that affect any knowledge process affect scientific knowledge as well, and "like all knowledge [scientific knowledge] involves a disclosure (saying) of something

to somebody. It deals with meanings that are social entities, embodied in language, altered or fulfilled in experience, and passed on in laboratory praxes, scientific literature and culture.[11] There are authors to show that hermeneutical philosophy comes as an alternative to the approaches of constructivism. The proponents of such philosophy, like Martin Eger, Heelan and Idhe, insist that a hermeneutical approach has become a must given the complexity of the contemporary science, the advanced computational algorithms, huge knowledge production, the enormous availability of information at the global level, and more importantly the impact that science has on social life in general.[12]

Joseph Kockelmans is one of the pioneers in the hermeneutical-phenomenological studies of science. He discusses how even the giants during the period of modern science unconsciously gave importance to interpretation than techniques. For instance, Kepler understood Copernicus and other astronomical knowledge in terms of religious and Pythagorean-Platonic frameworks; Aristotelian philosophy coloured the understanding of Galileo's astronomical observations; and Newton relied upon his predecessors' assumptions in his scientific investigations. All these show that assumptions and pre-judgments shape natural phenomena.[13] There is nothing like the 'original' or the 'actual' meaning of the text as it takes the meaning in the cultural milieu of the reader. Similarly, nature is understood or studied in the academic and historical milieu of the investigators; and the 'original' picture of reality, whatever that might mean, is never available to the investigators. A scientific theory is a metaphor, but even this is to be understood in a metaphorical sense. For, the fact that there is a 'given' in the scientific investigations does not allow 'anything goes' in science. So the demands for hermeneutics does not make science relative, nor does 'mob psychology' as Popper would put it.

The analysis of the notion of theory-choice in science by Thomas Kuhn is also another example to show how science involves interpretation: a) Theory choice takes place not only by the shared (or objective) criteria but also by "idiosyncratic factors dependent on individual biography and personality;"[14] and b) the latter are also of philosophical importance. He identifies five, among many other, important characteristics of a good scientific theory: *accuracy, consistency, scope, simplicity and fruitfulness of the theory.* He chooses them "because they are individually important and collectively sufficiently varied to indicate what is at stake."[15] Nevertheless, he is not unaware of the problems with these criteria; for, they are vague if considered in isolation and they might even contradict with one another, if taken together. The existing theory may have a highly positive value in any one of the criteria while the new competitor may have a high score in another criterion. Now the dilemma arises as to which of the criteria to choose. Sometimes in spite of the absence of a criterion the community seems to still accept the theory. He

gives the example of Copernicus' heliocentric theory. When it was proposed it was not more accurate than Ptolemy's. It gained more accuracy only with Kepler's sixty years of slogging in radically modifying it. If, for the lack of accuracy, Copernicus' theory had been completely ignored, we would not have remembered him today. Further, each of the five criteria can be understood or interpreted differently by different scientists. Therefore, though two scientists may use the same criteria and yet reach different conclusions, Kuhn calls these criteria *as values, rather than rules*. Along with these there are many personal or subjective criteria shaping their theory choice: one's previous experience as a scientist, the duration of his research, one's personal preferences; for instance, one may prefer originality to coherence (and therefore ready for risks!), while another may prefer vice versa and end up not taking risks. So Kuhn concludes that the theory-choice is not that easy, because "every individual choice between competing theories depends on a mixture of objective and subjective factors, or of shared and individual criteria."[16] All these, according to Kuhn, affirm the point that science is basically an interpretative enterprise.[17]

Matter – Interpretation Matters: In understanding the very nature of matter itself interpretation is involved. Twentieth century physics went through several conceptual revolutions; its two pillars are: ***Quantum Physics*** (revealing basic oneness of the universe) and ***Relativity*** (which changed our concept of space and time). Matter ceases to be material at its very bottom as it seems to be 'energy' dancing at its fundamental level. Heisenberg's principle of uncertainty, De Broglie's 'wavicle' theory of light, Neils Bohr's Principle of Complementarity and so on reveal that the full grasp of matter seems to be evading our understanding. We can never visualize matter to be out there, such that we can look at it 'undisturbingly'. For, "Quantum physicists discovered that every act of observation made of an atom by a physicist disturbed the atom… A sudden, discontinuous change brought on by observer's act of observation. This change is sudden and non-causal. It cannot be predicted even by quantum mechanics. Therefore, it is outside the ability of Quantum Physics to predict the capricious behavior of nature."[18] If every observation that we make is an interference with what is observed then there is actually no independent observer, because "Our consciousness is part of every experiment and there is a clear boundary between the subject and the object."[19] When we look at nature we impose certain patterns upon it and force it to reveal accordingly. Unfortunately, we are not aware of this fact and even if we are aware of it, we can't do much about it. Immanuel Kant's twelve categories, including that of space-time, colours and determines what we see, so we can never see reality 'as it is'. Therefore a physicist," therefore "is looking at nothing but a set of highly abstract differential equations – not at reality itself but at mathematical symbols of reality."[20]

A hermeneutical perspective, thus, is indispensable in science, especially as it grows more and more complex, inquiring the deeper dimensions of reality. It will help us avoid the extremes of *scientific realistic* claims of reaching to the hidden truths of reality and seeing nature as nothing but the arbitrary projection of our own interests. One has to carefully do a tight-rope walk; observations and experiments do play an important role and they are primarily material events in the world, and they would remove the temptation of seeing science as a mere social product. If Philosophy of Science has to retain its vitality and significance in philosophy it has to focus on the hermeneutical aspects.

However, these hermeneutical considerations don't make scientific knowledge a mere artifact of arbitrary discourses, because there is a 'given' in the whole process of inquiry. Galileo, perhaps, did not give due importance to the 'life-world' of science, as he focused only on the mathematical dimensions of the book of nature. Some of the Social Constructivists often show their inclination to see science merely as the outcome of human construction, totally independent of any touch of reality whatsoever. They tend to categorize all the activities and undertakings of scientists under one label - 'social'. For instance, Steven Shapin and Simon Schaffer argue that scientific facts are 'conventions' which emerge from 'negotiations between experimenters.[21] Hermeneutics of suspicion is good, but if one insists too much on it, one will perhaps end up seeing nothing.

II
Implications and Lessons for India and the World of Science

Treating science as an interpretative enterprise has many implications and one can draw important lessons from it. Some of them, under three aspects, namely, for India, for Science, and for Humanity, are presented here.

a) For India

One of the basic lessons that India, given the present condition of intolerance and majoritarianism, must learn is to respect unity and not uniformity; India should know that unity never implies uniformity. Unity is a virtue that leads a society towards peaceful living, tolerance, acceptance of different views, whereas uniformity looks for a society, where everyone thinks and acts in the same way, having little room for appreciating differences. While the former can easily accommodate differences of opinion and collective wisdom, the latter is, in principle, against this; the former looks for unification based on agreement, while the other for unification based on similarity; the former aspires for a harmony of opinions to form a consensus which is agreeable within a group without sacrificing everyone's uniqueness, while the latter harmonizes all members of the group by destroying the uniqueness of each

member and forcing all to conform to a single pattern. As social beings we need to learn to live while accommodating differences and celebrating diversities. Given this understanding, we, as responsible citizens, need to raise some significant questions: Are the present trends in our country insisting upon unity or uniformity? Do various measures taken in different domains encourage diversity and dialogue? Do the critics feel safe to voice out their opinions? Does the country move towards creating a mono-culture, mono-faith and mono-language, totally disrespecting the diversity that has been cherished for millennia in our land?

In protesting against the recent attempts by the Central Government to polarize the people in terms of cultural practices and religious ideologies, several intellectuals of the nation returned their *Sahitya Academy* awards. They fear that the government is ruining the multicultural and multi-religious fabric of India. The intellectuals and champions of preserving India's great heritage of multiple faces strongly protested against the killing of M. Kalgurgi, Narendare Dabholkar, Govind Pansare and Mohamed Akhlaq; Ms. Gauri Lankesh, 55, editor of *Gauri Lankesh Patrike*, a weekly newspaper, which she published from Bangalore, was brutally killed by bullets at close range in front of her residence. Her fate is widely considered a result of the intolerant attitude of the right-wing, as she was the outspoken and courageous critic of the Bharatiya Janata Party's (BJP) central rule and its anti-people policies. All these bold and committed critics were engaged in writing to criticize the ruling forces and to conscientize the public masses on important issues. These killings are heinous expressions of brutal attempts to mute the critics and to manipulate public opinion. India has had a great tradition of tolerance towards differences of opinion. The recent suppression of dissent is in fact an insult to this long cherished tradition of India. As Amartya Sen points out, the great emperors of India, like Ashoka and Akbar, not only exhibited mere tolerance but also respected and encouraged heterodox voices.[22] India has always been and still wants, as Jonardon Ganeri explains, to be "an open assimilative, and spacious [nation,] sustaining a plurality of voices, orthodox and dissenting, of many ages, regions, and affiliations." He invites modern India to study the valuable ancient traditions, to deliberate and to learn from them, how to decide "who to be, how to behave, and on what to agree. That is a fundamental freedom, one which ought not to be surrendered in binding."[23]

b) For Science

From the essential interpretative nature of science we can learn one basic lesson: Science has to go beyond itself in order to make sense of it; it has to depend on other disciplines, including religion, for its own enrichment and also to enhance humanity. Yes, this lesson paves the way for considering 'Science-Religion Dialogue' seriously.

Science has grown so much in all possible fields, both in the micro and the macro sciences, that it shapes not only our life-styles but also our very thinking and being. Yes, "microphysics and macrophysics affect our metaphysics."[24] From the origin of the universe till the present times one can identify three big bangs: "First, the matter/energy big bang in the beginning; second, biological information explosion on earth; the third, takes place within us, the mind's big bang in the explosion of cultures with radical capacities for the generation and cumulative transmission of ideas."[25] One would naturally expect that humanity can grow in peace and harmony, happiness and contentment with all such sharing of ideas and communication. But unfortunately the present achievements of science seem to threaten the very identity and destiny of humans. In spite of all powers, "we face uncertainties and unknowns. The discoveries and powers of science, once supposed to give us rationality, law, and predictability, now feed as much into this openness. We face at once both promise and peril."[26]

Science needs to be responsible to protect both the individuals and the environment. As humans are the only he means self-conscious in the universe they need to be self-conscious of their great duty for acting responsibly in dealing with nature. We have achieved great powers… but "the fate of the Earth, the fate of all who dwell thereon, depends, in the next century, on the responsible use of that power. Everything depends on how we join science, ethics, and religion, with policy, with economics in practice."[27] So science needs to enter into an open dialogue with religion and not only the need for such a dialogue, but also its feasibility seems to be very high now. Thomas E. Murray (Atomic Energy Commissioner in the US, in his thesis "Science and Religion must join if World is to survive H-bomb) writes:

> The physical discoveries which have shaken the spiritual faith of some men are also shaking the philosophical foundations of materialism... They are beginning to acknowledge that the concept of divine creation should no longer be dogmatically excluded from rational speculation about the origin of the universe. To my mind there are today, startling possibilities of a religious breakthrough into the secular mind. The time is ripening for a marriage of religion and science.[28]

Today's Quantum Physics, by removing all binary understanding, as we saw above, calls for a unified approach to understand human beings and the reality around. It paves the way for the necessary inter-connectedness of science and religion. Traditionally, religions claimed to possess all spiritual knowledge. The view that religions are reservoirs of spiritual knowledge is outdated. Now, science is also ready to provide us with this knowledge. So we can speak of not only 'science and spirituality' but also 'science of spirituality'.

N. Singh makes a clarion call, which I think all thinking humans must take seriously: "***Let us be simultaneously scientific and spiritual.*** That is the future of humanity in the 21st century. India with its long tradition of showing respect for all faiths, giving refuge to the oppressed of all nations, considering the world to be a single family, is eminently suited to lead the entire world in this direction."[29]

c) For Humanity

Though we are less than a spec, almost nothing (even less than nothing!) compared to the immense universe, both in its size and age, yet we have a capacity that no other (known) being has! We are the only beings that not only wonder but also wonder why we wonder! "In our hundred and fifty pounds of protoplasm, in our three pounds of brain, there may be more operational organization than in the whole of the Andromeda galaxy…."[30] Humans alone have the capacity for self-transcendence and to choose our destiny. This makes us "free spirits; it also makes us self-transcending spirits… With our instrumental intelligences and constructed theories, we now know the phenomena at the structural level from quarks to quasars … Nature did not give us telescopes with which to 'see' pulsars, or relativity theory with which to compute time dilation."[31]

Today we need 'conceptual integration' from various academic disciplines to study humans – evolutionary biology, cognitive science, behavioural ecology, psychology, hunter-gatherer studies, social anthropology, biological anthropology, primatology and neurobiology. One discipline alone is not enough to understand reality. As reality is interconnected it is not possible, even in principle, to isolate one domain of scientific inquiry. This existential reality makes science, as we have tried to show, an interpretative enterprise and it has to interpret all that it encounters. Another area where this interpretative dimension emerges very powerfully is the area of neuro-science, especially in its efforts to fathom the relationship between brain and consciousness. A team of neuroscientists conclude: "It is difficult to study the brain without developing a sense of awe about how well it works… Exactly how the parallel streams of sensory data are melded into perception, images and ideas remains the Holy Grail of neuroscience."[32]

Science, no doubt, gives us power. As centuries go by, it gives more power. But one needs to be careful because power can corrupt easily. "Power tends to corrupt and absolute power corrupts absolutely."[33] The challenging factor is that along with power our duty also increases.

> Yes, "With increasing knowledge and power comes increasing duty. Science demands conscience… The same science that demands a conscience has difficulty explaining and authorizing conscience, for we struggle to understand how a moral nature evolved the moral animal, how even now Homo Sapiens have duties, humans to fellow humans, and humans to the community of life on Earth. The value questions in the 20th century remain as sharp and as painful as ever in our history."[34]

Finally, in spite of all achievements of science we do face all types of uncertainties and various categories of ambiguities; human life has to go on with this struggle. Struggle is part and parcel of human lives. As birds are born to fly and fishes to swim, humans are born to struggle. "Struggle is the dark side of creativity, logically and empirically the shadow side of pleasure. One cannot enjoy a world in which one cannot suffer, any more that one can succeed in a world in which one cannot fail... To be alive is to have problems. This can go wrong just because they can also go right… The story is not merely of goings ons, but of going concerns, that is, of values that matter."[35] Let us be optimistic. Let us choose the right values which enrich humanity and nature. Yes, only that ***science*** matters where ***conscience*** matters.

Notes

1 If the social and the historical contexts are insisted upon the extent of sidelining the rational dimensions, it is pointed that the enterprise of science faces the danger of 'mob psychology'. While criticizing Kuhn's notion of paradigm, Lakatos makes it clear: "Thus, in Kuhn's view scientific revolution is irrational, a matter for mob psychology". See Lakatos and Musgrave ed., *Criticism and the Growth of Knowledge* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1970), 178.

2 P. Ricoeur, De L'interpreation: essai sur Freud (apris: Editions du Seuil, 1965), 18.

3 E. Peterfreund, "Some Critical Comments on Psychoanalytic Conceptualizations of Infancy," in *International Journal of Psychoanalysis,* 59 (1978), 427-41.

4 Tran Van Doan, *Reason, Rationality and Reasonableness* (Washington D.C.: The Culture Centre for Research on Values and Philosophy, 2001), 4.

5 James Franklin, "Natural Sciences as Textual Interpretation; The Hermeneutics of the Natural Sign", *Philosophy and Phenomenological Research*, Vol. XLIV, No. 4, June 1984, 509-520, 511.

6 *Ibid.*, 517.

7 See Peter Koso, *Reading the Book Nature* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1992).

8 Patrick A. Heelan, "Natural Science as a Hermeneutic of Instrumentation", in *Philosophy of Science*, Vol. 50, No. 2, 1983. See also "Hermeneutical Realism and Scientific Observation, in *The Philosophy of Science Association*, No. 1, 1982.

9 See Patrick A. Heelan, *Space-Perception and the Philosophy of Science* (Berkeley: University of California Press, 1983).

10 Joseph F. Hanna, "The Scope and Limits of Scientific Objectivity", in *The Philosophy of Science Association*, Vol. 71, No. 3, 2014.

11 Robert P. Crease, "Hermeneutics and the Natural Sciences", in *Man and World*, 30 (1997), 259-270, 259.

12 See: Martin Eger, "Hermeneutics and Science Education: An Introduction", *Science and Education* 1 (1992), 337-348; Patrick A. Heelan, "Quantum Mechanics and the Social

Sciences: After Hermeneutics", in *Science and Education* 4 (1995), 127-136 and Don Idhe, *Instrumental Realism* (Bloomington: Indiana University Press, 1991).

13 See Joseph Kockelmans, *Ideas for a Hermeneutic of the Natural Sciences* (Dordrecht: Kluwer, 1993).

14 [18] Thomas Kuhn, "Objectivity, Value Judgment and Theory Choice", in *Philosophy of Science – Contemporary Readings*, Yuri Balashov and Alex Rosenberg, Eds. (London & New York: Routledge, 2002), 429.

15 [19]*Ibid*., 422.

16 [20]*Ibid*., 425.

17 For more details on Kuhn's analysis, see my paper: "Are Values Valuable in Science? - A Kuhnian Perspective", in *Omega – Indian Journal of Science and Religion*, Vol. 9, No. 1, 2010, 7-24.

18 N. K. Singh, ed., *Science and Spirituality* (New Delhi: Global Vision Publishing House, 2005), 170-71.

19 N. K. Singh, ed., *Science and Spirituality* (New Delhi: Global Vision Publishing House, 2005), 172.

20 *Ibid.*

21 See Stevan Shapin and Simon Schaffer, *Leviathan and the Air-Pump: Hobbes, Boyle, and the Experimental Life* (Princeton: Princeton University Press, 1985).

22 Amartya Sen, *The Argumentative Indian: Writings on Indian History, Culture and Identity* (New York: Picador, 2006), 247.

23 Jonardon Ganeri, "Intellectual India: Reason, Identity, Dissent", *New Literary History*, Vol. 40, No. 2, India and the West (SPRING, 2009), 247-263, 263.

24 Holmes Rolston III, *Science and Religion – A Critical Survey* (Philadelphia and London: Templeton Foundation Press, 2006), xviii.

25 *Ibid*., xv.

26 *Ibid*., xii.

27 *Ibid*., xiii.

28 H. V. Divaita, *The Art of Life in the Bhagavad Gita* (Bombay: Bhartiya Vidya Bhavan, 1960), 150.

29 N. K. Singh, ed., *Science and Spirituality* (New Delhi: Global Vision Publishing House, 2005), 232.

30 Homes Rolston, *Mysteries of Mysteries*: *Is Evolution a Social Construction?* (Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press, 1999), 66.

31 Holmes Rolston, "Genes, Brains, Minds: The Human Complex", in *Soul, Psyche Brain: New Directions in the Study of Religion and Brain-Mind Science*", ed. Kelly Bulkeley (New York: Palgrave Macmillan), 2002 (???), 10-35.

32 Mark F Bear, Barry W. Conners, and Michale A Paradiso, *Neuroscience*, 2nd ed. (Baltimore: Lippincott Williams & Wilkins, 2001), 740, 434.

33 Lord Acton, *Essays on Freedom and Power*, Ed. by Gertrude Himmelfarb (Glencoe, IL: Free Press, 1949), 364.

34 Holmes Rolston, *Mystery of Mysteries: Is Evolution a Social Construction*? (Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press, 1999), 213-15. Though the author is speaking of the 20th century what he says is still relevant in the present century; in fact in the 21st century the realization about the need and role of values has increased more.

35 Holmes Rolston III, *Science and Religion – A Critical Survey* (Philadelphia and London: Templeton Foundation Press, 2006), xiii.

7

Cârvâka as an Indian Philosophical System with Scientific Outlook
A Critical Analysis Focusing on *Cârvâka's* Stance on Consciousness

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Abstract: The Cârvâka philosophical system which is famous as an ancient school of Indian materialistic thought evolved as a reaction to the extreme spiritualistic ideologies and domination of priests of the time. According to Cârvâka, matter is the substratum of the world and whatever is non-materialistic does not have existence. Consciousness is an outcome of a combination of the four elements, earth, water, fire and air and from the perspective of Cârvâka, it is an emergent property or an epi-phenomenon. In spite of the severe criticism against Carvaka philosophy, especially regarding its hedonistic ideologies, it stands with a scientific outlook, compatible in several respects with with trends of the later developments in material science. When these later developments unraveled the quantum world, the amazing observation of consciousness associated to quantum particles, though it remains as a hypothesis, seems to be a break-through in science. It conveys the message that reality is more than matter. Though the absoluteness of materialism is challenged by this development, it was through the frame of materialism that research in the field commenced. Cârvâka is unique as an ancient scientific school of thought, which had the potential to initiate research in material science. Though it could not get that recognition due to several reasons, it is a fact that the Carvaka system corresponds to a scientific outlook developed in ancient India and we can be proud of it.

Introduction

The History of philosophy tells us very clearly that philosophical insights evolve, owing to several reasons. Response or reaction to the existing ideologies, social issues, scientific developments etc., may be the nuclei of such evolutions. Renewed philosophies are always appearing as an exposition of the splendor of wisdom, and no ideology is static. In Indian philosophy around BCE 600, we see the birth of a new thought, known as Cârvâka philosophy. Cârvâka, in fact, came as a counter perspective to the spiritualism of the time. The conception of *samsara* had contributed a colour of pessimism to the Indian vision of life which conveyed that our aim is not to be attained in this life, but in the higher world: not *loka* but *nirvana* to be sought.[1] Cârvâka represents a reaction to this thought as they teach that only that which can be perceived exists. Direct experience is the only *pramana* for knowledge. So, Cârvâka may be considered as the forerunners of scientific research. It was called *lokayata* as it was prevalent among people.[2] It means 'Naturalist' or 'Worldly' in Sanskrit and Pali. As the Indian systems were other world oriented, Cârvâkas wanted to focus on 'here,' in this 'world.' Written texts from the writings of the Cârvâka/Lokayata school of thought are not available. What we know about the Cârvâka/Lokayata school of thinking is mostly based on elements gathered from the opponents of the school.

The Cârvâka school was a philosophical movement rather than a theory on the Supreme Reality. It rejected the traditional religious order which existed in India by challenging the authority of the Vedas as well as the supremacy of the priests. India has always been an entirely religious and spiritual land. This school is considered part of the heterodox systems of Indian philosophy. The name Cârvâka is not found to refer to a single person. There are two different individuals having two distinctive views referred to in the Vedic Source; namely Brhaspati Angirasa and Brhspati Laukya.[3] Only one full text, *Tatvapapalvasimha*, composed by Jayarasi (800 CE) is now available and it is taken as a treatise on the Cârvâka *darsana.* Also, it is noticed that some pre-buddhists, known as the *Ajivakas* are found to be quite close to the Cârvâkas.

1. Uniqueness of Cârvâka

As already mentioned, this school of thought claimed that the truth can never be known except through the senses: The body, not the soul, feels, sees, hears and thinks. It has its novelty in challenging all the traditional values of Indian people. Cârvâka philosophical concept may be divided into three headings; epistemology, metaphysics and ethics and in all the three, the Cârvâka philosophy stands in marked contrast to all other Indian Philosophical systems. The school of materialism in India seems to be very old and references of it are found in the Epics and in the early Buddhistic literature. The materialism

that Cârvâka school advocated continued for quite a long time and survived till 14th century.

Being one among the Nâstika schools, Cârvâkas do not accept the Vedas. It is a fact that, all the Nâstika systems of Indian philosophy owe their origin to the reaction against Vedic traditions. Though the Cârvâka school accepts the existence of Vedas as a body of literature, they do not consider the knowledge in the Vedas to be of any special origin but simply man-made like any other literature. Though Buddha and Jaina are Nâstika systems they do not criticize Vedic thought. But Cârvâka philosophers have openly and vehemently criticized and challenged the Vedas, saying that they are full of lies and repetitions; and are created by a few priests who wanted to gain their means by misguiding the insensible people. It could be reasonably inferred that all philosophical school of thoughts as a rule have their origin, directly or indirectly, from their philosophical approaches to other schools of thought.

2. Matter-Centered Metaphysics

As Cârvâka explains all doctrines materialistically, matter occupies the central place in its epistemology, metaphysics and ethical view. So, it appears as a different and unique school of Indian philosophy among all other schools. Cârvâka rejects the existence of God, eternal soul and the possibility of eternal life, because for them, 'perception is the only source of valid knowledge.' We know four things namely, earth, water, fire and air only by the five sense organs. These four physical elements are eternal as well as imperishable and may be transformed but not destroyed. The Cârvâkas say that the whole Universe including all things and beings are produced out of the combination of these four elements. They refute the existence of non-material soul besides this body. Conscious body is the soul. With the destruction of the body, consciousness is also destroyed[4] and it returns to the four elements (*Caturbhuta*).[5] The Cârvâka positive metaphysical doctrine is that there are four physical elements and these are eternal and imperishable. The negative conclusion is that, God, immaterial soul, heaven, hell, afterlife etc., do not exist. Other Indian philosophical schools severely criticize the metaphysical doctrines of Cârvâka, focusing on their negative side.

The Cârvâka philosophy does not accept the law of causation and its universality. Law of causation maintains that every effect must have a cause and the cause and the effects are necessarily related. This relation is invariable and it depends upon concomitance. Everything in the world is due to some cause. The things of the world are causally related to one other. But the metaphysics of Cârvâka philosophy does not accept such a view. According to it, the causal relation is not necessary and invariable. The law of causation does not explain the diversity of the world. The relation of cause and effect is not unconditional. The Cârvâka holds that every effect may not have a cause.

The inherent nature of things is the cause of the diversity of the world. There is no cause of the inherent energy or nature of things. They maintain that it is not true that a definite effect always arises from a definite cause, because, we cannot perceive the incidents of the future. Hence, from a definite cause many effects may arise.

According to Cârvâka metaphysics, the inherent nature or power of things is the ultimate cause of the universe. As we have already said, the things of the universe originate from the inherent power of the four basic elements; therefore Cârvâka accepts Naturalism instead of Casuality to explain the diversity of the world. They use the word '*Svabhâva*' to indicate the inherent energy of things. From this nature, the diversity of the world originates, sustains and destroys. Again, they said that behind the causal relation there is no inherent necessity. According to the nature of things, all events occur on their own. Behind the hotness of fire, coolness of water or sharpness of thorns, there is no agent or cause. These happen according to their nature. Nature has no cause; it is the cause of itself.

3. Materialism and Consciousness

3.1 Materialism: Various Perspectives

Materialism, according to certain authors, is the doctrine by which consciousness is either reducible to matter or dependent on matter. Consciousness cannot exist independent of matter.[6] In this context, materialism, as it is attributed to Cârvâka in the ontological sense, is a perspective about the nature of the world or nature of a human being. Materialism about the nature of the world is cosmological materialism whereas about the nature of human being is anthropological or psychological materialism. In each case, materialism can be either eliminative or non-eliminative. At the cosmological level, materialism is an answer to questions concerned with the status of the relation between consciousness and matter; and the nature of existence of consciousness in the world. A cosmological materialist will not accept the existence of consciousness or a conscious substance independent of matter.[7] From the viewpoint of eliminative materialism, matter is the only reality and consciousness is not there at all; or whatever appears as consciousness is reducible to matter. Non-eliminative materialism grants the reality of consciousness, but regards it as being dependent on matter. From an anthropological or physiological level, certain questions related to the nature of a human being, body or brain and behavior; consciousness and the self (I); the relation between body and self, are very relevant. In response to questions that may arise in this context, a psychological or anthropological materialist would definitely deny the existence of a conscious self or mind which can exist independent of the body. But again, the responses from the view point of eliminative materialism and

non-eliminative materialism would be different. An eliminative materialist would say that I or self is represented by the body alone,[8] and there is no role of consciousness in it,[9] whereas a non-eliminative materialist would say that the body, which includes the brain and behaviour or all these things together, represent I or the self only when they are qualified by consciousness.[10]

3.1.1 Features of Cârvâka's Materialism

From the perspective of these ontological questions, it is evident that at the Cosmological level the Cârvâkas advocate non-eliminative materialism. Although they give primary importance to matter, i.e. the four gross elements, and a secondary status to consciousness, they are not reducing consciousness to matter, but saying that consciousness arises from matter. From the Carvaka perspective, the self is the body qualified by consciousness. This is non-eliminative psychological materialism. Carvaka Materialism whether it is presented at Cosmological level or Psychological level, has to face an epistemological challenge.[11] Carvakas present their materialist argument mainly in the context of cosmological materialism that assumes the title *bhuta-caitanya–vada* which means that consciousness arises from the combination of the four gross elements. Of course, the argument also has an anthropological or biological aspect because according to this argument, the consciousness arises from that combination of matter which assumes the form of an organic body. The three aphorisms of Brhaspati seem to be relevant here.[12] (i) Earth, water, fire and air are the essential categories.[13] (ii) Their combination gets designated as body, sense organ and object.[14] (iii) Consciousness arises from the elements which have assumed the form of body, like the power of intoxication arises from molasses and the other ingredients.

The third aphorism mentioned is the core of Cârvâka's argument for Cosmological Materialism. But before considering its relevance for Cârvâka Epistemology, it is necessary to make some points of clarification regarding the first two aphorisms, as they prepare the background for the third.

Though the first one refers to four elements, it doesn't consider space (*akasa*) as an element which is accepted in the orthodox systems. The Cârvâka policy of not including *akasa* in the list of essential categories is in agreement with the attitude of other heterodox systems. It is also theoretically elegant to do so, because accepting *akasa* as an all-pervasive positive substance is problematic.[15]

In the second aphorism, Cârvâka speaks about the combination of the four elements, but never says how or why such combinations take place. Other systems accept some kind of *karmic* or divine order behind whatever takes place. Atomist systems (like Nyaya-Vaisesika, Jainism and the realist schools of Buddhism) generally argue that body, senses and external objects are all atomic combinations whereas Sankhya/Vedanta-oriented systems treat them as

combinations of three strands of primordial matter or cosmic illusion (*prakrti or maya*). All of them accept these phenomena as natural causal factors or God's will. None of these is acceptable to the Cârvâka. They would accept natural causal factors, but not the factors such as karma, God's will, or teleology of the soul. At that stage they would say that occurrence of these combinations is accidental (*yadrccha*) or rooted in the nature of things (*svabhava*).[16]

4. Non-Empirical or Speculative Inference

In order to know and then to justify that consciousness arises from matter, one needs an inference. Bur the issue remains: what kind of inference will serve the purpose? The third aphorism, as Brhaspati says 'Consciousness arises from the four gross elements, like the intoxicating power which arises from molasses,' is an empirical inference apparently. The consciousness which 'arises' cannot be known in our own person or in others. In the case of others we see only their body and not their consciousness. In case of one's own self, only when one is conscious, one can be conscious of one's own consciousness. One cannot be conscious of the stage in which one is not conscious and hence one cannot observe the transition of oneself non-conscious stage to conscious stage. Hence, empirical inference is not useful in establishing the materialist thesis.[17] On what grounds, does a Cârvâka admit the four elements as basic? Is it by *a priori* presupposition or by any prefixed dogma or prejudice? As rationalists, the Cârvâka cannot be dogmatically rigid on this issue. The classification of elements into four basic ones is itself not directly sense perceived, but definitely it is the outcome of sense-perceptual source.[18] It is clear that the very acceptance of the four basic elements is grounded on knowableness of objects and not otherwise. It is not that the metaphysical reality of material elements is first pre-assumed ontologically in the ultimate sense and perception, since the method of justification of knowledge comes later to confirm that.

Cârvâka's argument for the material origin of consciousness is a non-empirical inference.[19] Common sense empiricists can accept an empirical inference as a source of knowledge as a rule and they are inclined to accept an empirical inference only under the condition that it is *lokaprasiddha*, that is acceptable within the framework of the worldly way of life. The third aphorism of Brhaspati, and also its variant found in *Sarvasiddhantasangraha* (SSS) are practically conveying the same idea but with certain differences.[20] According to Brhaspati's version, 'Consciousness arises from the four gross elements, like the intoxicating power which arises from molasses' whereas the SSS version says that 'Consciousness which is seen in the modified insentient elements, arises in them, like the red colour arises due to the combination of betel-leaf, betel-nut and powder.'

Though both the formulations give statement of thesis and instance but no reason, they have the form of arguments which are incomplete. In order to

trace the reason one has to elaborate the contention of Cârvâka. The Cârvâka intend to express the idea of inseparability between body and consciousness.[21] Brhaspati assimilates consciousness with power (disposition) or a function. In the SSS version consciousness is assimilated with a quality. The idea is that when consciousness arises in a combination of four elements, it arises like a new quality or a new function or a new power. The emergent quality or function of power is inseparable from the material combination which has it. The main point here is that Cârvâkas try to understand consciousness on the model of a quality or function or of a disposition of a body. If a quality or the other things arise in a substance then the substance is called the material cause of that quality or function or power. In this sense the body can be called the material cause of consciousness which evolves from it.

The word 'arise' brings two versions regarding the cause of consciousness. According to the inherent version, consciousness is already inherent in the four material elements and become manifested when the elements are combined in a particular way. According to the non-inherent version, consciousness is not already present in the matter; but it emerges as something new.

5. Research on Consciousness: Contemporary Trends

A glimpse into the contemporary trends would show the novelty of Cârvâka's approach to the rise of consciousness. According to modern researchers, consciousness encompasses two different concepts: the notion of a self and the feelings of which the self is aware, especially qualia, our raw sensory experiences. Consciousness implies awareness: subjective, phenomenal experience of internal and external worlds. Consciousness also implies a sense of self, feelings, choice, control of voluntary behavior, memory, thought, language and internally-generated images (e.g. when we close our eyes, or meditate) and geometric patterns. But what consciousness actually is remains unknown. Our views of reality, of the universe, of ourselves depend on consciousness. Consciousness defines our existence.[22]

Consciousness is a kind of bipolar medium, of which the one pole, the subject is referred to the other pole, the object in a general sense - by the relation of being conscious of. If anything is conscious, it must be conscious of something. A conscious being x is conscious of y, if x is aware of y and x is aware of the awareness of x. Perhaps, the best way to understand the explication of consciousness is to contrast the conscious animals to the unconscious things.[23] Three different stances on consciousness as we find in the present approach of researchers may be classified as,[24]

(A) Science/Materialism, with consciousness having no distinctive role,
(B) Dualism/Spirituality, with consciousness (etc.) being outside science,

(C) Science, with consciousness as an essential ingredient of physical laws not yet fully understood.

Cârvâka's stance on consciousness is A, whereas in general, other Indian philosophical schools including *Advaita* follow B. The most unique feature of the Advaitic treatment of consciousness is the radical ontological distinction posited between absolute or pure, universal consciousness (*cit, saksi caitanya*) and phenomenal or modified consciousness (*citta, vrtti caitanya*).[25] C is an approach which evolved recently. A few main stream scientists are now becoming interested in research on consciousness and they change their stance from A to C.

5.1 Consciousness as Emergence

An analysis of consciousness from the frame of Emergence seems helpful according to the modern approach to consciousness**.** Certain nuances of consciousness could be better understood from the perspective of emergence. Emergentism is characterized by a middle way between two extreme positions: substance dualism and eliminative materialism.[26] There is a general agreement among all emergentists, that there are entities which are solely based on lower physical materials, but they have properties which go beyond that their physical parts.

5.1.1 Various Stances

According to the ontological position, developed by Kim,[27] a higher level property P is *reducible* if, (a) P can be functionalized-that is, defined in terms of its causal role; (b) realizers of P can be found at a lower level, and (c) there is a lower level theory that explains how the realizers operate. In contrast a property is *emergen*t, if it neither is a physical property nor reducible to physical properties in the sense just described. Kim's position retains the irreducibility, novelty, theoretical unpredictability and 'un-explainability' features of emergent phenomena, but apparently has the consequence that there is little scope for their existence, except perhaps in the case of *qualia* or consciousness. According to Paul Humphreys the original elements or their properties fuse together in a way that the identities of those elements are lost in forming the new emergent entity.[28] This position entails the irreducibility, novelty and holistic features of emergent phenomena, but allows their predictability and 'explainability'. According to Nagel, one theory is irreducible to another, if the laws of higher level theory cannot be deduced from those of a more fundamental theory by employing bridge laws, connecting the two levels. Thus if biology is irreducible to physics, then biological phenomena are emergent from physical phenomena.[29]

The novelty of emergent features is usually captured in the idea that an emergent property E must be qualitatively different from the entities from which it emerges. A popular version of this idea asserts that a property P is emergent, if it has novel causal powers not possessed by entities at lower levels. The causation involved can be horizontal (two entities at the same level), upwards (to a higher level), or downwards (to a lower level). The downward causation is ruled out on account of ontological emergence.

5.2 Cârvâka and Emergence

As described above in the positions of various emergentists, given the four elements, the self-conscious life mysteriously springs forth, just by a kind of chemical reaction. Though it is a function of matter we have no evidence of the separate existence of soul and body. We do not see the self without a body, consciousness is invariably found in connection with the body. According to Cârvâkas, as already mentioned, consciousness is the result of an emergence. It is an epi-phenomenon, a by-product of matter, given the four elements and their particular combination. Though the particular combination is not known to us, it is certain that the emergence does not happen for any combination. Consciousness manifests itself in the living body. The so-called soul is simply the conscious living body. Cârvâkas do not regard consciousness as the essence of mind or soul; on the contrary, they regard consciousness to be a product of the body.

6. Modern Science and Cârvâka

The discussions in the previous sections make clear that though the inference of 'arise' of consciousness from material combination is partially speculative, the Cârvâka's theory of consciousness is suitable to a scientific frame. When the Cârvâka interprets everything as matter-centered, there is a correspondence with physics at the least in the macroscopic level. Physics is the branch of science which deals with matter and energy; and in its frame, all the physical process that occur in the world are matter-energy interactions or exchanges. Matter and energy are inter-convertible and can be considered as the manifestations of one and the same entity. Cârvâka's materialism goes hand in hand with physics. However, when physics advanced with experimental research and unraveled the mysterious quantum world, the materialistic approach met with certain limits. The sub-atomic or quantum particles have a dual nature; or they are endowed with matter-wave duality. The materialistic approach gets uprooted in the quantum world. From the perspective of modern science, materialism (not material science), loses its absoluteness and it has become evident that reality is more than matter. However, Cârvâka enjoys the position of a pioneering scientific approach in material science, though not recognized and accepted widely. Also, it is important to note that Cârvâka's stance of emergence of life

from a particular combination of matter, is in agreement with the developments of advanced biology in the 20th century.

Stuart Alan Kauffman**,** an American medical doctor, theoretical biologist and complex systems researcher who studied the origin of life on Earth, observed that simple and complex systems can exhibit powerful self-organization. He proposes that 'when a system of chemicals reach a certain level of complexity, it undergoes a dramatic transition, akin to phase changes when liquid freezes. The molecules begin spontaneously combining to create larger molecules of increasing complexity. This process of self-organization or autocatalysis, rather than accidental formation of molecules with ability to replicate and evolve, led to life.'[30] It is obvious that Kauffman's conclusions go in line with what the Cârvâkas said several centuries ago.

Conclusion

The above said differences in the outlooks of Cârvâka and other traditional Indian systems could be viewed more or less the same as a conflict between religion or spirituality and science. Other Indian systems were spiritualistic whereas Cârvâka, at least in its materialistic approach, was scientific. It could be assumed that since no proper dialogue took place between Cârvâka and other systems, the misunderstanding aggravated and they criticized each other.

For Indian Philosophy to be studied today as a relevant and down to earth subject, we should highlight its secular and rational aspects, rather than its other-worldly and religious dimensions.[31] Our inquiry in Indian Philosophy should not be based only on scriptural authority, but it should be based on experience and reason. Studies in Indian Philosophy should become more relevant to common sense and science and should establish a critical dialogue with them. In this sense the philosophical approach of Cârvâka is very meaningful.[32] The fruit of philosophical enquiry need not be highlighted as eternal disembodied liberation or such things. What is to be emphasized is its relevance for a happy and progress oriented life.

Consciousness as described by Cârvâka as an emergent and dialectic property of matter, is an area where intensive research is going on at various levels. Cârvâka's theory, though it has the characteristics of reductionism, can be analysed through a scientific frame. Such an approach only can promote research. If consciousness was attributed to the supreme alone and treated at par with soul, nothing could be done. Immanuel Kant's philosophical proposition of *phenomena* and *noumena* may be meaningful and relevant in the case of material science too. Matter as it appears can have a transcendental realm in itself which remains hidden. As we have seen in the previous section, modern science depicts life as something emerged from a system of complex molecules with certain combinations. Though it may be questioned from the perspective of our religious faith, when we understand the real mechanism,

such apprehensions may vanish. The history of Cârvâka reminds us to maintain a critical openness and as far as possible an inclusive approach to any new ideology that would appear in the stream of knowledge.

Notes

1 G. Tucci, "A Sketch of Indian Materialism", in *Cârvâka/Lokayata*, ed. Debiprasad Chathopadhyaya (New Delhi: Indian Council of Philosophical Research, 2006), 389.
2 Debiprasad Chathopadhyaya, *Lokayata* (New Delhi: People's Publishing House, 1978), 1.
3 Bijayananda Kar, *The Philosophy of Lokayata* (New Delhi: Motilal Banarsidass, 2013), 2.
4 Sankara gives a very different interpretation, applying it to the cessation of individual existence, once the knowledge of the supreme is attained. William M. Indich, *Consciousness in Advaita Vedanta*, (Varanasi: Motilal Banarsidass, 1980),12.
5 Debiprasad Chattopadhyaya, *Carvaka/Lokayata: An Anthology of Source Materials and Some Recent Studies* (New Delhi: Indian Council of Philosophical Research, 2006), 248.
6 Pradeep P Gokhale, *Carvaka/Lokayata: A Philosophical Inquiry* (New Delhi: Oxford University Press, 2015), 122.
7 *Ibid*., 123.
8 Byrne Alex, "Behaviourism," in *A Companion to the Philosophy of Mind,* ed. Guttenplan, (Oxford: Black Well, 1995), 132.
9 Horgan Terrance, "Physicalism," in A Companion to the Philosophy of Mind ed. Guttenplan, (Oxford: Black Well, 1995), 471.
10 The reductive theory in which I is reduced to either brain or behavior can be seen in the Modern Western Theories of the mind such as identity theory, eliminative physicalism, or behaviourism.
11 Pradeep P Gokhale, *Carvaka /Lokayata: A Philosophical Inquiry*, 126.
12 *Ibid.*, 127.
13 Ramakrishna Bhattacharya, *Studies on the Carvaka/Lokayata* (Delhi : Anthem Pres India, 2012), 78.
14 *Ibid*., 9.
15 It is hard to explain that an all pervasive (and also part-less, indivisible) substance is a constituent ofthe mortal physical body. Bhattacharaya has pointed out a few thinkers who accepted *akasa* as the fifth element. (See Ramakrishna Bhattacharya, *Studies on the Carvaka/Lokayata*, 78 and Pradeep P Gokhale, 129).
16 Kirk G. S and Raven J. E, *The Pre-Socratic Philosophers* (London: Cambridge University Press, 1957), 400-427.
17 Pradeep P Gokhale, *Carvaka /Lokayata: A Philosophical Inquiry*, 131.
18 Bijayananda Kar, *The Philosophy of Lokayata*, 32.
19 It could be argued that Cârvâka's materialism is not metaphysical materialism in the sense that it is not based on any *a priori* presuppositions, but is derived on empirical grounds. But as far as their explanation on consciousness is concerned, it adopts a methodology which includes speculative reasoning. Still it is closer to science than to speculative metaphysics, because it is strongly supported by common sense and 'this worldly framework.' (Pradeep P Gokhale, *Carvaka/Lokayata: A Philosophical Inquiry*, 134).
20 *Sarvasiddhantasangraha* (SSS) of Sankaracarya, edited and translated by M. Rangacharya, (Delhi: Eastern Book Linkers, 2006).
21 Pradeep P Gokhale, *Carvaka /Lokayata: A Philosophical Inquiry*, 132.
22 Hameroff Stuart and Roger Penrose, "Consciousness in the Universe: A Review of the 'ORCH-OR' theory", *Physics of Life Reviews* 11, (2014): 39-78.

23 Joseph Wang, "Consciousness as an Emergent Property," *Disputatio Philosophica*, no.1 (2006): 107.
24 Hameroff Stuart and Roger Penrose, *Physics of Life Reviews* 11, (2014): 40.
25 William M. Indich, *Consciousness in Advaita Vedanta*, (Varanasi: Motilal Banarsidass, 1980), 12.
For Sankara, consciousness is awareness, intelligence or knowledge that can be viewed as free or bound. While consciousness as *Brahman* exists eternally, is identical with reality itself and is conceived as pure knowledge. It also persists in all phenomenal experience as well, where it is called an enjoyer *(bhoktr*).
26 Joseph Wang, *Disputatio Philosophica*, no. 1 (2006): 89.
27 Kim Jaegwon, "Making Sense of Emergence," *Philosophical Studies* 95, (1999): 3-36
28 Humphreys Paul, "How Properties Emerge?" *Philosophy of Science* 64, (1997): 1-17.
29 Nagel Ernest, *The Structure of Science* (New York: Harcourt, 1961), 275.
30 Stuart Alan Kauffman, *The Origins of Order: Self Evolution and Selection in Evolution* (New York: Oxford University Press, 1993), 207.
31 Pradeep P Gokhale, *Carvaka /Lokayata: A Philosophical Inquiry*, 198.
32 *Ibid*.

8

Sphoṭa Theory of Meaning and Its Relevance Today

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Abstract: The classical Indian thought is not far from the hermeneutics of suspicion. The spirit of hermeneutics of suspicion is highlighted in this paper through the theory of *sphoṭa*. *Sphoṭa* is the integral linguistic symbol which is the unit of meaning but which cannot be written or pronounced. It lies behind and beyond language. It addresses the issues of part and the temporary and permanent elements of language. *Sphoṭa* is proposed as the viable solution to questions like: Is it really possible to posit a unitary principle in language when sounds uttered die one by one? Amidst the external differences like variation of individual letters sounds, accents and speeds of delivery, how can there be undifferentiated and changeless manifestation of sense or meaning? The theory is revisited for our context today, to critique and challenge the social, cultural and political situation of our country.

Introduction

Indian orthodox classical philosophy identifies language with Brahman and regards speech as eternal. The study of language is not only the concern of grammarians or the rhetoricians but also of all the schools. The Vedic seers consider *vāk* as the most powerful deity. In this line, the theory of *sphoṭa* provides an alternative to the problem of word and meaning relationship in in language. It suspects other theories and dominant conventions of the time such as word, phoneme as the basic unit of meaning. In the communication

of language there is sequence, diversity and change. Hence, the questions that pop up are: What brings about wholeness and unity in the operation of language to get the meaning of the reality expressed? How is it possible to have communication between the speaker and hearer when there is diversity in their thoughts and grasping capabilities? How parts and whole are related in language? Amidst the external differences like variation of individual letters sounds, accents and speeds of delivery, how can there be undifferentiated and changeless manifestation of sense or meaning? How exactly is the speaker able to convey what he intends, to the hearer? Is it really possible to posit a unitary principle in language when sounds uttered die one by one? All these questions find their solution in the seminal doctrine of *sphoṭa* developed by Bhartṛhari.[1] The present paper attempts to highlight *sphoṭa* as the workable solution to the problem of meaning in the context of vanishing sounds during communication; and it also brings out its relevance in the context of today.

1. Various Indian Approaches to Semantics

Bhartṛhari came after Patañjali (2nd century) in the tradition of Sanskrit grammar. He synthesised grammar with philosophy. He has suspected and refuted the semantic theories of *Nyāya* and *Mīmāṁsā* schools such as relation of word-meanings intention of sentential-meaning, mutually related word-meaning as sentential meanings, etc. The different semantic theories of various schools and their later developments are discussed in the following.

Naiyāyikas contend that the word constitutes the unit of language (*padavāda*). It means that language can be analysed into meaningful words and these words denote the meaning of a sentence separately and collectively.[2] *Nyāya* and *Vaiśeṣika* schools hold that the relation which exists between word and meaning is a matter of convention (*sāmayika* or *saṅketa*) i.e. the convention chosen by the first language users of the community.[3] In *Nyāya-mañjari*, Jayanta Bhaṭṭa says that the word has several phonemes. The listener grasps the meaning of a word when he hears a last phoneme of a word together with the recollection of the previous phonemes through their impression.[4] Hence, the *padavādins* i.e. *Naiyāyikas,* assert that the denotative content lies in words alone.

According to *Navya-Naiyāyikas*, the hearer tries to understand the components of the sentence part by part when he hears the sentence. He recalls the meaning of words from the corresponding words in the next stage. In the *vākyartha* stage, the remembered meanings are associated with each other. This is followed by relating of all meanings together to arrive at the unitary meaning of the sentence. This stage is called *śabdabodha*.[5] *Naiyāyikas* hold sentence or word as a source of knowledge because its speaker is a trustworthy person. *Sphoṭa* being eternal does not consider trustworthy person. The logicians also reject the indivisibility of the sentence.[6]

Pūrva-mīmāṁsā is called '*vākya-śāstra'* (science of sentence). It maintains that a word is constitutive of phonemes even when there is no meaning. The atomistic view of *Mīmāṁsakas* says that letter or *varṇa* constitutes the unit of language. The individual letters are partless and indivisible whereas words and sentences consist of parts and hence they are nothing but *varṇas*.[7] *Mīmāṁsakas* assert that the letters or *varṇas* are permanent and all-pervading whereas their variations during the utterances are not permanent.[8] The sounds produced and heard are only revealing the permanent sound units. The relation between word and meaning according to Jaimini is 'non-derived' (*autpattika*) or 'uncreated.'[9] Hence, it can be affirmed that the power of signification is inherent in the words themselves.

Mīmāṁsā explicates two theories which deal with the nature of the sentence. They are: *anvitābhidhānavāda* and *abhitānvayavāda*. The former is held by the *Prabhākara* school and the latter is propounded by the *Bhaṭṭa* school.

Anvitābhidhānavāda (connected designation) of the *Prabhākara* school advocates that the meaning of words can be comprehended only as related to the sentence and that words have no independent meaning apart from their contextual meaning. The words in isolation cannot express isolated meanings. The purpose of words is to serve as part of a sentence. Each word in connection with another word has a designation. A word gets proper meaning only in a context of sentence. *Prabhākaras* do not deny the existence of individual words and their isolated meaning; they only assert that it is impossible to comprehend the isolated meaning of a word apart from its relation in a sentence.[10] For example, 'bring the cow' means not the isolated concept of 'cowness' but 'cow as related to the action of bringing.'

Abhihitānvayavāda (designation before connection) of the *Bhaṭṭa* school is the theory which accepts that words have separate meanings. It admits the division of the sentence into parts. According to this theory, the words convey their meanings individually first and then the sentential meaning is obtained by the mutual relationship of words.[11] In this theory the syntactic relation happens by the word-meanings and not by words. *Bhāṭṭa Mīmāṁsakas* argue that the words belonging to the sentence express only their isolated meaning which are universal. The individual word meaning constitutes the sentence meaning. Word meanings are context free. The sentence meaning is derived not from the words but indirectly through the meaning of words. The capacity of the word to convey meaning independently enables one to use a word in different contexts.[12] *Bhaṭṭa* is of the opinion that that words have designative which have the designative power (*śakti*) and not the sentence. The sentential meaning cannot be grasped if there are several unfamiliar words in a sentence.[13]

Aesthetics is a separate discipline in India which is called by names like *Alaṅkāraśāstra*, *kāvyaśāstra*, *kāvyamīmāṁsā* etc. The rhetoricians and literary

critics are interested in stylistic analysis of language, emotional experience, figures of speech etc.[14] *Kāvyaśāstra* insists on the harmony of word and meaning. *Artha* in aesthetics as usually understood is not 'sense' or 'meaning' but it means 'aesthetic value.'[15] Ānandavardhana (9th C. A.D.), one of the great proponents of aesthetics has propounded *dhvani* (literally means 'resonance,' 'echo') theory of meaning in his *Dhvanyāloka*. Besides, primary/*abhidhā* and metaphorical/*lakṣaṇa* sense, he postulates a third potency of language, which he calls 'the capacity to suggest a meaning other than its literal meaning.' This is called *vyañjana*. The utterances possess a literal meaning, they also convey a 'social-cultural meaning.'[16] The *vyañjana* applied to poetry is considered as the doctrine of *dhvani* (poetic suggestion). He recognises the indivisibility of the sentence and its meaning. While presenting about the indicators of meaning, Ānandavardhana takes into account "the contextual factors, the intonation, stress, gestures, and even the pure sounds used in the utterance."[17]

When the primary meaning does not fit the context the indicatory meaning arises. But the third power of the word called suggestive power comes to the scene only after the sentence-meaning is fully comprehended. It appeals only to the sensitive reader. The suggestive power or *vyañjanā* is considered as subjective, as per the understanding of the hearer. For example, 'The Sun has set.' It will suggest different things to different hearers like a thief, lover and priest. When there is ambiguity in the cognition of the sentence then the intention of the speaker or *tātparya* helps to resolve it.[18] The schools like *Nyāya* and *Mīmāṁsā* do not recognize the suggestive power of words at all. Ānandavardhana discusses that *dhvani*-phonetics and *dhvani*-semantics constitute the two components of language like *sphoṭa* and *dhvani* for Bhartṛhari.[19] Both context and speaker's intention are important for him to understand the meaning of a sentence.

Grammarians say that there is no meaning of words apart from the meaning of the sentence. Sentence is the real unit of language (*vākyavāda*) and not words or letters. Sentence comprises the potentiality to express meaning. They note that the analysis of words into letters, letters into their component parts etc. goes into infinitum. Hence, other than the sentence, the constructs of words letters etc., are all false and the sentence is taken as the unit of thought or speech.[20] The sounds of the words in a sentence vanish as soon as they are pronounced. If the previous elements in a sentence die away then how can the meaning of the whole sentence still be cognised? So, in order to address this issue the *Vaiyākaraṇas* have put forth the concept of *sphoṭa*. The sound (*dhvani*) only reveals the word. Hence, sound is transient and the *sphoṭa* is permanent.

2. Theory of *Sphoṭa*

The word *sphoṭa* is derived from the root word '*sphuṭ*' which literally means 'that which becomes manifest' or 'that which blossoms or develops.'[21] V. S. Apte in his Sanskrit-English Dictionary gives the meanings for *sphoṭa* such as breaking forth, bursting or disclosure, spring out - the idea which bursts out or flashes on the mind when a sound is uttered. Mādhavācārya in his *Sarvadarśanasaṅgraha* gives its meaning from the viewpoint of the speaker as 'that which expresses a meaning' and with reference to the listener he says 'that which is manifested by letters.' In metaphysical sense, *sphoṭa* stands for the self-unfolding principle, Brahman. But in the linguistic sense it means that which is revealed by letters or that by which a sense is revealed.[22] Basically, the theory of *sphoṭa* means a single meaning-bearing unit made up of different sound units arranged in a particular order. It can be a word or a sentence. *Sphoṭa* is the integral linguistic symbol which is the unit of meaning.

> B. K. Matilal gives a reasonable definition of *sphoṭa*. According to him, *Sphoṭa* is the real substratum, the proper linguistic unit, which is identical also with its meaning. Language is not the vehicle of meaning or the conveyor-belt of thought. … thought 'vibrates' through language. In this way of looking at things, there cannot be any essential difference between linguistic unit and its meaning or the thought it conveys. *Sphoṭa* refers to this non-differentiated language-principle.[23]

The first mention of the term *sphoṭa* occurs in the *Mahābhāṣya* of Patañjali who understands *sphoṭa* as a word-essence. He holds that *sphoṭa* is the 'speech' or 'language' (*śabda*) and the noise or sound (*dhvani*) is a quality of the speech. The sound element in language varies whereas the *sphoṭa* remains constant. *Sphoṭa* is the essential and permanent element in the word and the *dhvani* is the actualised and transient element.[24] For him a single letter/*varṇa* also can be *sphoṭa*. The fixed sound-series or letter-series, the unit of sound, a single letter or a letter-series is *sphoṭa*. The sound series is analysable. Later grammarians held that *sphoṭa* is a partless entity which is unanalysable.[25]

"The *sphoṭa* is an indivisible (*akhaṇḍa*) unit, a partless (*niravayava*), sequenceless whole, which is connected with the verbal dispositional ability of the speaker or the hearer."[26] According to Bhartṛhari, a sentence is to be considered as 'a single undivided utterance' (VP 2.1).[27] He conceives sentence as the unit of communication. The *vākya* is shown as composed of divisible units like words, stems, roots, affixes but they are only parts of the grammatical structure.[28] Bhartṛhari observes *sphoṭa* as an indivisible sentence in which a word or letter has no reality by itself apart from that of a sentence (VP 1.73).[29]

The grammarians like Nāgeśa Bhaṭṭa (18th century AD), Kauṇḍabhaṭṭa and Bhaṭṭoji have divided *sphoṭa* into eight parts based on the principles of indivisibility and meaningfulness (*vācakatva*): *varṇasphoṭa*, *padasphoṭa*, *vākyasphoṭa* (*vyaktisphoṭa*s); *varṇajātisphoṭa*, *padajātisphoṭa*, *vākyajātisphoṭa, akaṇḍa-pada-sphoṭa*and *akaṇḍa-vākya-sphoṭa* (VP 1.73).[30]

The first seven among them enable the beginner to know the nature of the last one, *akaṇḍa-vākya-sphoṭa*.[31] Bhartṛhari develops the threefold types of *sphoṭa* related to letters or phonemes, words and sentences in VP. His primary focus is *sphoṭa* in the form of a sentence. He holds on to *akhaṇḍa-vākya-sphoṭa* in which the meaning of words depends upon the sentence as a whole. It does not mean that the sentence is a series of meaningful units but a unitary whole denotative of a single undivided meaning.

3. Process of *Sphoṭa*

Sphoṭa is eternal and inherent in the consciousness which is present already in the mind of the speaker and the hearer. Bhartṛhari explains the transition from eternal *sphoṭa* to the form of spoken or audible words and sentences in three stages: the undifferentiated stage, *paśyantī* (non-verbal); the intermediate stage of phonological structure, *madhyamā* (pre-verbal); and stage of the spoken or articulated speech, *vaikharī* (verbal) (VP 1.47).[32] The *vaikharī* indicates *madhyamā* and *madhyamā* expresses *sphoṭa*.

In the first stage the word is known as *sphoṭa* and in the second and third stages it is called *dhvani* or *nāda*. *Sphoṭa* and *dhvani* are two forms of the word. The two aspects of sound and meaning are present in the unitary *sphoṭa*.[33] The *dhvani* in the second stage is called *prākṛta-dhvani* (primary sound) and in the third stage is called *vaikṛta-dhvani* (transformed sound). In the first stage the speaker conceives the sentence in the mind after he gets the flash of insight. It is the integral linguistic symbol. The second stage (*prākṛta*) is the construction of the sentence in a specific sequence,[34] and finally, in the *vaikṛta* stage the constructed sentence in the mind is articulated through speech sounds.[35] The *prākṛta* helps in the comprehension of unmanifested *sphoṭa* and the *vaikṛta* enables the comprehension of manifested *sphoṭa* (VP 1.76-77).[36] Though there are individual peculiarities present in the speaker or listener the *sphoṭa* remains unaffected.

We have to see the *sphoṭa* not only from the speaker's side but also also as shared by the hearer. The listener undergoes this process in the reverse order. By the utterance of the speaker, the hearer's *sphoṭa* is awakened. From the point of the speaker the *sphoṭa* is already present in the hearer. We need to know how the hearer comprehends *sphoṭa*.[37] There is *sphoṭa* in the speech act of the speaker which is expressed through *dhvani* and consequently the listener grasps and interprets it in terms of the *sphoṭa*. It can be figuratively explained as:[38]

Speaker		Hearer
Sphoṭa	**→ *Dhvani* →**	***Sphoṭa***

The cognition of *sphoṭa* as an indivisible unit is shown through the analogy of the painter. There are three stages when a painter does a painting.

Firstly, he sees the object in its parts or in a differentiated state, secondly, he has the whole sight of the picture and thirdly, he paints it part by part. In the same way the speaker and the hearer communicate and comprehend the sentence through different sounds and then get the unitary meaning.[39]

The presence of two stages before the final stage, i.e. uttered speech, implies that the person has to think of appropriate words and meanings that are supposed to be conveyed to avoid meaninglessness. Later grammarians like Nāgeśa and Kauṇḍabhaṭṭa and the *Pratyabhijña* school of philosophy have added *parā-vāk* as the fourth stage and have ascribed it to Bhartṛhari. But in actuality there is no stage higher than the *paśyantī* for Bhartṛhari.[40] It is the very subtle form of speech which is realised by *yogins*.

Bhartṛhari states that the whole comes before the parts, the words are in sentences and all language ultimately finds its root and origin in *Śabdabrahman*. The three stages of *sphoṭa* can be compared with the theory of language development proposed by a Soviet psychologist Lev Vygotsky (1896-1934 CE). He suggests three forms of language: social speech or external communication; inner speech; and private speech or thought without language.

4. *Sphoṭa* (Śabda) and Sound (*Dhvani*)

The first *kaṇḍa* of VP speaks about the nature of word or *sphoṭa* and its relation to sound or *dhvani*. The *dhvani* is the manifestor and *sphoṭa* is the manifested (*vyañjaka-vyañjana-bhāva*). *Sphoṭa* is the real basis of language, and *dhvani* is the audible sound pattern. They are produced simultaneously like the flame and the fire (VP 1.105).[41]

Bhartṛhari considers *sphoṭa* as more than a meaning-bearing unit or a linguistic sign. He claims that the language-thought relationship is eternal and given to us. When the *sphoṭa* is conveyed to others it finds its expression through sounds in the shape of letters, words and sentences. It has been explained with the illustration of the moon being reflected in the moving water. In VP 1.49, Bhartṛhari states that as the reflection of the moon in the water appears moving, so also the *sphoṭa-śabda* appears to have divisibility, duration and speed.[42] In the empirical state the moon in the water looks like it is dancing but metaphysically there is only one moon.

In the preverbal state of *sphoṭa*, the language and meaning are undifferentiated. The potential state of the word is compared to the yolk of a peahen's egg. In the manifested state of the utterance of the words the linguistic nuances and meanings are actualised like the full-grown peacock's colours (VP 1.51).[43] The issue raised about *sphoṭa* is whether *sphoṭa* can really be held as a unitary principle if the sounds revealing it are produced in succession and not simultaneously? The preceding sounds leave their impressions on the mind and the final sound strengthened by the previous impressions enable the

complete revelation of *sphoṭa* (VP 1.85).[44] VP 1.91 asserts, "Just as there is sequence (in the stages) in the transformation of milk (into curds, etc.) and the seed (into a tree), similarly, there is a graded sequence in the series of the hearer's perceptions (of the intervening words, phrases etc.)."[45]

5. *Sphoṭa* and *Pratibhā*

The word *pratibhā* literally means 'a flash of light or a revelation.'According to the grammarians, the *sphoṭa* is the meaning-bearer and *pratibhā* is the meaning of a sentence. The indivisible unit of expression is called *sphoṭa* and the indivisible unit of meaning is called *pratibhā*. *Sphoṭa* is 'the real word' and *pratibhā* is 'the real meaning.' Bhartṛhari employs the word *pratibhā* in two ways. They are: "'intuition' which is responsible for the knowledge of all the beings in a general sense and 'the flash of understanding' for the comprehension of the sentence sense in a specialised sense" (VP 2.119; 2.143-144).[46] *Sphoṭa* does not vary with individuals because it is in the word or language whereas "*pratibhā* is the individual's way of understanding the *sphoṭa* through the understanding of the words of the sentence. This varies from individual to individual and even in the case of the same individual at different times."[47] *Pratibhā* is not only indivisible but also indefinable.

6. *Sphoṭa*–A Viable Solution to the Semantics of Language

In communication there is speaker, listener and common ground between them. The problems pertaining to the relation between words and sounds are – how does the speaker convey meaning to the hearer? How come one can grasp the word or sentence as a sequenceless whole, both when the speaker expresses the thought in sequence and multiplicity, and the listener listens to it in sequence? Why in certain cases the hearer either grasps the full meaning by hearing some part of the sentence or fails to understand the meaning even after hearing each word? How is the hearer able to grasp to perceive implied meaning from the expressed meaning of the speaker?[48]

Prof. K. A. Subramania Iyer explains,

> The *sphoṭa* doctrine arose as a solution to the problem of the understanding of meaning. The problem was how to explain the understanding of meaning from the sounds which are uttered in a temporal sequence. As they are not simultaneous and cannot co-exist, they cannot co-operate in order to convey the meaning. The doctrine of *sphoṭa* is the grammarian's solution of the problem.[49]

The speaker and the hearer share the identical and eternal *sphoṭa*. All conscious human beings possess inherent linguistic potency (*śabda bīja* or *śabda bhāvanā*). If the hearer is able to grasp the sense conveyed by the

speaker even if the sentence is incomplete the communication serves the purpose. *Sphoṭa* has the potency to express and grasp meaning both in the speaker and hearer as well.[50] Bhartṛhari does not consent to the view that the recollection of impressions (*saṁskāras*) helps in the cognition of meaning, because the dependence on memory only produces what is relevant to the experience rather than the grasp of meaning.[51] The sentence is not grasped as composed of words occuring one by one but cognition takes place all at once in a flash. The whole is taken as an integral symbol and not as parts that are constituting it. Bhartṛhari admits that the listener understands certain partial meanings before understanding the meaning of the whole sentence. But he stresses that they have no reality. The word-meanings are only the means to the sentence-meaning.[52]

7. Recovering *Sphoṭa* for India Today

The *sphoṭa* theory was a 'hermeneutics of suspicion' during its time. It adopted a critical attitude towards the fixation of meaning in phoneme or word. Although we consider the text to speak for and by itself, we pick up some issues and interpret them to apply it to our context today. We try to suspect what is taken for granted as real, true and even final. In *sphoṭa* there are active and passive aspects, namely, that which manifests i.e. symbol and that which is manifested i.e. symbolized or referent. They are operative both in the speaker and the listener for the grasp of *sphoṭa*. The text or speech gives the stimulus for it. The cognitive faculty or the capacity of the mind (*buddhigrāhya*) makes understanding possible.

7.1 Analysis of the Indivisible Sentence and Non-verbal Communication

According to Bhartṛhari, the sentence is unanalysable because it is an indivisible unit. Analysis is crucial in a language for the clarification of thoughts and to make the individual understand what language actually communicates. Bhartṛhari has given place for two sorts of analysis viz., grammatical and philosophical analysis. The former includes components like words, roots, suffixes, prefixes etc. The meaning of divisions analysed in synthesis facilitate the manifestation of the indivisible sentential-meaning. The latter is the analysis done through mentally breaking down understanding and presenting the thoughts and concepts.[53] For him every component is essential, though he theoretically holds that sentence is a whole unit of sense. The parts are analysed for practical purposes because the indivisible can be clearly apprehended only through the components. Words have meaning, but only the analysed meaning. They are the unreal means for attaining the meaning (VP 2.238).[54] The analysis and examination of language cannot be done outside linguistic structures because humans are part of it. Ultimately, the words, dissections, analysis,

etymologies and grammars are for a pragmatic purpose. They are at the service of the sentence, to denote that which is behind and beyond the language.

Is *sphoṭa* operative only in verbal communication? What about non-verbal communication like gestures and signs? Bhartṛhari proposes two types of words: articulate words which are speakable and non-articulate words which are unspeakable. Even in the case of a mute child the linguistic potency is present. VP says "The subtle nature of *vāc* (speech) penetrates and permeates even such states as lack of ostensive mental activity …" (VP 1.124).[55]

7.2 Before, Between, and Behind the Language

language, Bhartṛhari opines, constitutes both immanent and transcendental, practical and metaphysical aspects. Classical Indian thinkers have seen language as *mysterium tremendum*. language remains unexhausted because of its association with Brahman. In every 'before and between' the text, the 'behind and beyond' reality is conveyed. However, this should not lead to ambiguity through a great deal of mystification. Its primary function is to show that language is not a 'problem' but a 'mystery.' Its depth and richness is unending and infinite. According to the grammarians, *dharma* or duty is the ultimate aim of *sphoṭa*. *Dharma* is not a drama but it promotes freedom of everyone and harmony of everything. It stimulates and draws people towards the unchanging first principle of the transcendental Word-essence or *Śabdatattva*. Hence, the final goal is the higher realisation of truth and a greater fulfillment of life.

7.3 Splitting the Spirit of *Sphoṭa* in the Socio-Political Arena

Bhartṛhari expresses that language is an activity in which all human beings engage.[56] He uses the term *śabdanā-vyāpāra* which is translated by B. K. Matilal as 'languageing.' Language is not a static and indelible concept but it is like a catalyst of our life, culture, thinking and acting etc. It is a communicative tool and social phenomenon. Hence, *sphoṭa* as a permanent and unitary principle is very much active and alive in all individuals, pervading all in our phenomenal world as a transcendental reality. The Word and the world are intricately interwoven in us who are 'languageing beings.'

The *sphoṭa* theory asserts that the 'seed-form' of the word meaning is in the consciousness itself. It is granted by the Divine and hence, the metaphysical reality comes into play in human words. Corresponding to the perceived there is an unperceived and partless symbol which presents meaning. Today due to the rapid growth and development of technology the actual use of language has become mechanical and object-oriented. The language of politics which is ambiguous, abusive, derogatory, defaming and shallow does not serve *sphoṭa*. The negative, hateful, appeasing and accusing language is blooming in Indian politics today and as a result the *sphoṭa* is breathing its last. Going by the root

word of *sphoṭa*, one may conclude that it is just a bursting forth or eruption of meaning. But it has to be borne in mind that there is a guiding force behind every communication. Hence, distortion, disruption or corruption of text or speech, so as to mean anything, is against the spirit of *sphoṭa*. The masking of truth, the diversion of news, the twisting of the discourse, and the silencing of just and rightful protestors - media persons, writers and whistle blowers - are attempts to deactivate the real explosion of meaning. Therefore, both the speakers and listeners have to base themselves in the ethos or horizon of *sphoṭa*. The defectless communication in uttering, accepting or receiving of speech or text solves chaos, confusion and misunderstanding. The person, group or community may not be of importance but each one communicates a *sphoṭa*. Their unspeaking, unsaying and unuttering has to be grasped and understood in their speaking, saying and uttering itself. The main aspect in *sphoṭa* is 'something is communicated from something to someone.'

The theory of *sphoṭa* invites all to make this world an enlightened place through the word. Those who engage in political gimmicks are not enlightened. They misuse *sphoṭa* in their communications. *Sphoṭa* questions and challenges the chasm between empty words and false promises of political leaders and the actual ground reality in terms of integral development, respect for cultures and language, dignity of all, food habits and so on. Today we witness a large gulf between what is expressed and what is needed to be expressed. The scriptures of one particular religion are shown exegetically as a national holy book. Bhartṛhari understands meaning in terms of communication and he does not identify meaning with the speaker's intention or the hearer's understanding.

7.4 Non-Dual *Śabdabrahman* is Plural

Bhartṛhari is known as one of the earliest pre-Śaṅkara exponents of the *Advaita* system because he deals with the Ultimate Reality, *Śabdabrahman*. He posits the principle of non-duality behind multiplicity. Bhartṛhari upholds that consciousness is Brahman and that language is nothing but the manifestation of Brahman. Hence, his philosophy is known as Linguistic Non-dualism (*Śabdādvaitavāda*). It is an *advaitic* view which encompasses everything as a whole. The divine essence is nothing but the linguistic essence. It is one and many simultaneously. "The one becomes many because it is endowed with many powers. All the powers are identical with one Reality though they appear to be different from one another" (VP 1.2).[57] In *sphoṭa*, the plurality is essentially part of non-duality. Any attempt of cultural monism, homegenisation is nothing but fixating the all-pervading and dynamic *Śabdabrahman*. When the word becomes sound, the mysterious aspects are presupposed and plurality comes along with it. The meaning is a unity of all things put together – 'identity-in-difference' of unmanifested, manifested and manifestor. In other words, *sphoṭa* too proclaims: 'unity in diversity.' Though *sphoṭa* is against the idea

that meaning remains polysemous all the time, it is not against fluidity, non-closure and slipperiness of meaning. There is a movement from monosemy to polysemy and vice-versa. *Sphoṭa* critiques the ritualism of *Mīmāṁsakas* with regard to the fixation and determinism of meaning in their diction, recitation and so on.

The *Sphoṭa* of Bhartṛhari and *Advaita* of Śaṅkara look very much similar. In the *Kevalādvaita* of Śaṅkara language operates only at the empirical or pragmatic level (*vyāvahārika*). VP asserts that the world is created by *Śabdatattva* through the power of *kālaśakti*. Grammarians consider the universe as real whereas for *Advaita* it is illusory (*māyā*).

Conclusion

Classical Indian philosophy does not lack hermeneutics of suspicion. The Indian interpretative tradition is essentially linguistic and philological. The theory of *sphoṭa* finds its source and origin in *Śabdabrahman* itself. Bhartṛhari gives a metaphysical foundation to the linguistic issue. He has convincingly synthesised the interplay between appearance and reality, unity and diversity, empirical and transcendental. He sees distinction and difference at the level of use of language and expression, but ultimately they are merged together through *sphoṭa*. The presence of sequence in utterance and grasping is part of communication which vanishes but the meaning as one whole remains due to the linguistic potency (*śabdabhāvana*). Our level of utterance, as Bhartṛhari observes, is like a tip of the iceberg. It is the last stage of linguistic communication which is the outcome of deeper level of thought. We have made an attempt to revisit the *sphoṭa* theory of meaning but it is not complete. It needs forward steps and deeper applications by and through our reflections and praxis.

Notes

1 Bhartṛhari is a grammarian-philosopher of fifth-century who was primarily a grammarian of the Pāṇinian School. His *magnumopus* '*Vākyapadīya*' is a great work in Indian philosophy of language and linguistics. It means 'Of Sentences and Words.' It deals with the science of meaning. *Vākyapadīya* has three *kāṇḍas* called *Brahma-kāṇḍa*or *Āgama-kāṇḍa*, *Vākya-kāṇḍa* and *Prakīrṇa-kāṇḍa*or *Pada-kāṇḍa*. The first two *kāṇḍas* constitute an integral unit in thought as they deal with the nature of *Śabdabrahman*, the creation of the world, the relationship among the Brahman, world, language and individual soul manifestation and comprehension of the meaning by word, nature and definition of sentence, and the process of liberation. The grammatical aspects are more focussed in the third *kāṇḍa*.

2 Punita Sharma, *Concept of Sentence Analysis in Nyāya Philosophy* (Delhi: Nag Publishers, 1998), 22.

3 K. Kunjunni Raja, *Indian Theories of Meaning* (Madras: The Adyar Library and Research Centre, 1963), 23.

4 Sharma, *Concept of Sentence Analysis in Nyāya Philosophy*, 78-79.

5 Gayatri Rath, *Linguisitic Philosophy in Vākyapadīya* (Delhi: Bharatiya Vidya Prakashan, 2000), 214.

6 Sharma, *Concept of Sentence Analysis in Nyāya Philosophy*, 80.

7 Raja, *Indian Theories of Meaning*, 152.

8 Rath, *Linguisitic Philosophy in Vākyapadīya*, 99.

9 "*autpattikastuśabdasyārthenasambandhaḥ*" (*Mīmāṁsā-sūtra* 1.1.5). Quotation is taken from N.V. Thadani, trans., *Mīmāṁsā of Jaimini* (Text with Translation in English and Notes) (Delhi: Bharatiya Kala Prakashan, 2007), 1.

10 Raja, *Indian Theories of Meaning*, 198.

11 Sharma, *Concept of Sentence Analysis in Nyāya Philosophy*, 246.

12 Bijayananda Kar, *Indian Philosophy: An Analytical Study* (Delhi: Ajanta Publications, 1985), 11.

13 Bimal Krishna Matilal, *The Word and the World: Inida's Contribution to the Study of Language* (Delhi: Oxford University Press, 1990), 110.

14 M. Sivakumara Swamy, *Saṁskṛta Kāvyaśāstrīya Siddhāṁtagalu* (Bangalore: Bharavi Prakashan, 1904), 3.

15 K. Krishnamoorthy, ed. *Abhinavagupta's Dhvanyāloka-Locana* (New Delhi: Meharchand Lachhmandas Publications, 1988), xix.

16 Raja, *Indian Theories of Meaning*, 279.

17 Raja, *Indian Theories of Meaning*, 281-282.

18 Matilal, *The Word and the World*, 23.

19 Ajodhya Nath Hota, *Sphoṭa, Pratibhā and Dhvani* (Delhi: Eastern Book Linkers, 2006), 264.

20 Rath, *Linguisitic Philosophy in Vākyapadīya*, 184.

21 Kapil Kapoor, *Text and Interpretation: The Indian Tradiition* (New Delhi: D.K. Printworld (P) Ltd., 2005), 22.

22 Hari Mohan Jha, *Treands of Linguistic Analysis in Indian Philosophy* (Varanasi: Chaukhambha Oriental, 1981), 10-11.

23 Matilal, *The Word and the World*, 85.

24 In linguistic level we may find a resonance of *sphoṭa* and *dhvani* with morpheme and phoneme. Morpheme stands for the smallest unit of meaning and phoneme is the smallest unit of sound in a language. *Sphoṭa* takes sentence as its basic unit of meaning and *dhvani* includes not only sound or variation but also it is an 'echo,' 'suggestion' of a meaning in a text for an individual or a group. Hence, *sphoṭa* and *dhvani* go beyond them even in the linguistic level.

25 Matilal, *The Word and the World*, 79.

26 Matilal, *The Word and the World*, 85.

27 "*eko'navayavaḥ śabdaḥ*" (VP 2.1). Henceforth, *Vākyapadīya* is abbreviated as VP in the text. All quotations from VP are taken from *Bhartṛhari's Vākyapadīya: Kāṇḍa 1 & 2*, J. Ouseparambil, trans. (Pune: Dr. J. Ouseparambil, 2008).

28 M. Srimannarayana Murti, *Bhartṛhari: The Grammarian* (New Delhi: Sahitya Akademi, 1997), 10-11.

29 "*pade na varṇāḥ vidyante varṇeṣvavayavāḥ na ca. Vākyāt padānāṁ atyantaṁ praviviktaḥ na kaścana*" (VP 1.73).

30 Bhartṛhari, *Vākyapadīyam* (Kannaḍa Translation of Brahma Kāṇḍa), ed. D.R. Nagaraj, trans., N. Ranganatha Sharma (Karnataka: Akshara Prakashana, 1993), 16.

31 Gaurinath Sastri, *A Study in the Dialectics of Sphoṭa* (Delhi: Motilal Banarsidass, 1980), 61.

32 Matilal, *The Word and the World*, 105.

33 "*dvāvupādānaśabdeṣuśabdauśabdavidoviduḥekonimittaṁśabdānāmaparo'rtheprayujyate*" (VP 1.44).
34 *Prakṛti* means the root of both verbal and nominal words.
35 M. Srimannarayana Murti, "Language and Mind in Grammatical Tradition as Gleaned from Patañjali and Bhartṛhari," in *Language and Mind*, ed. K. S. Prasad (New Delhi: Decent Books, 2008), 175-176.
36 Sastri, *A Study in the Dialectics of Sphoṭa*, 12.
37 Matilal, *The Word and the World*, 86.
38 Kapoor, *Text and Interpretation: The Indian Tradiition*, 23.
39 K. A. Subramania Iyer, *Bhartṛhari: A Study of the Vākyapadīya in the Light of Ancient Commentaries* (Pune: Deccan College, 1992), 153-154.
40 Rath, *Linguisitic Philosophy in Vākyapadīya*, 161.
41 Jai Singh, *Verbal Testimony in Indian Philosophy* (Delhi: Parimal Publications, 1990), 61.
42 "*pratibimbaṁ yathānyatra sthitaṁ toyakriyāvaśat tatpravṛttim ivānveti sa dharmaḥ sphoṭanādayoḥ*" (VP 1.49). Murti, "Language and Mind in Grammatical Tradition as Gleaned from Patañjali and Bhartṛhari," 177-178.
43 "*āṇḍabhāvam ivāpanno yaḥ kratuḥ śabdasaṁjñakaḥ vṛttiss tasya kriyārūpā bhāgaśo bhajate kramam*" (VP 1.51).
44 Sastri, *A Study in the Dialectics of Sphoṭa*, 6-7.
45 "*yathānupūrvniyamo vikāre kṣīrabījayoḥ thathaiva pratipattṛṇāṁ niyato buddhiṣu kramaḥ*" (VP 1.91). Translation Ouseparambil.
46 Murti, *Bhartṛhari: The Grammarian*, 39.
47 J. Ouseparampil, *Bhartṛhari's Vākyapadīya: Kāṇḍa 2* (*Sentential Hermeneutics*) (Pune: Dr. J. Ouseparampil, 2008), 24.
48 Tandra Patnaik, "Thought and Language: The Bhartṛharian Perspective," in *Language and Mind*, ed. K. S. Prasad (New Delhi: Decent Books, 2008), 138-139.
49 Iyer, *Bhartṛhari: A Study of the Vākyapadīya in the Light of Ancient Commentaries*, 160.
50 Patnaik, "Thought and Language: The Bhartṛharian Perspective," 139-140.
51 Korada Subrahmanyam, *Theories of Language: Oriental and Occidental* (New Delhi: D. K. Printworld (P) Ltd., 2008), 77.
52 Sibajiban Bhattacharyya, *Language, Testimony and Meaning* (New Delhi: Indian Council of Philosophical Research, 1998), 61.
53 D.N. Tiwari, "The Nature of the Language and the Problem of Ananlysis - a Discussion," *Journal of Indian Council of Philosophical Research,* Vol. XIX, no. 4 (2002), 176-177.
54 "*upāyāḥ śikṣamānānām bālānām upalāpanaḥ. astye vartamani sthitvā tataḥ satyam samīhat*e" (VP 2.238). Tiwari, "The Nature of the Language and the Problem of Ananlysis - a Discussion," 180-181.
55 Tandra Patnaik, *Kālaśakti: Bhartṛhari's Philosophy of Time* (New Delhi: D. K. Printworld (P) Ltd., 2014), 23-24.
56 Matilal, *The Word and the World*, 124.
57 N. Krishnaswamy, Sunita Mishra and R.V. Rāmānuja, *India's Language Philosophy: With a Focus on Comparative Study* (Delhi: Dorling Kindersley Private Limited, 2013), 94.

9

Sacred India Losing the Sense of Sacredness
An Ecological Perspective

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Abstract: Vandana Shiva invites us to reflect on the notion of sacredness as she writes that the twentieth century marked a point in time when human intelligence has outstripped its own instinct for survival, and the present century only accentuates this. There are a number of malignant indications of civilization turning upon itself (big dams; nuclear arms; genetic engineering). They represent a severing of the link, not just the link but also the understanding between human beings and the planet they live on. They scramble the intelligence that connects eggs to hens, milk to cows, food to forests, waters to rivers, air to life and the Earth to human existence – not an exaggeration! Shiva's writings posit the reclaiming of the feminine principle as a non-violent, non-gendered and humanly inclusive alternative. The sense of the sacred is emphasized.

1. Introducing 'Sacred': Here and Somewhere

Holy cow!! An expression that might just get you into a conflict with the law and powers to be in some strange and irrational nuance. But then, the human mind is able to reflect and introspect and attempt to find sense and meaning in this expression too, like so many linguistic inventions. I choose to begin this paper with this reality not with the intention to provoke or insinuate, rather with the need to be relevant and present. There are cows universally and among the many peoples that 'interact' with cattle, the Masai also revere

their cattle. However, the cow is not sacred in the South Asian context. Cattle are sacred in the daily meaning of life. Everything the Masai has, comes from the cow – his home of cow dung, his food – milk and meat, his clothes of leather, his medium of exchange and wealth. The life of a Masai is certainly determined by the cow, the places of grass and water, the times to burn down the homestead to move on to other pastures. The very form of a Masai kraal is an enclosure for cattle, with homes on the periphery. Any danger to the cattle is a danger to the Masai, and the attraction of herds of neighbouring tribes is irresistible. The Masai is a true pastoralist. Farming is anathema to him. The Masai word for farmer is *olmeg* and is truly a term of opprobrium. He uses it for everything that is non-Masai. For a Masai, the word *olmeg* means Bantu, European, barbarian.[1] How sacred are our cattle?

1.1 Vandana Shiva's Understanding of the Sacred

Vandana Shiva is a social activist, a scientist and a thinker, presently living in Dehradun, India. Among the many philosophical issues that she has thought about is how we as a society so easily turn to reductionism to defend a social position. She has dwelled on the understanding of sacredness and calls her philosophy 'seed philosophy'.

The seed, according to Shiva, has become the site and symbol of freedom in an age of manipulation and monopoly of diversity. In the seed, cultural diversity converges with social justice, peace and democracy.[2] The conservation of biodiversity is, above all, the commitment to let alternatives flourish in society and nature, in economic systems, and in knowledge systems. Shiva says that cultivating and conserving diversity is no luxury in our times. It is a survival imperative. It becomes the precondition for freedom for all. In diversity, the smallest has a place and role, and allowing the small to flourish becomes the real test of freedom.[3] Shiva points out that the word value is derived from the Latin term *valere* which means to be strong or worthy. In communities where water is sacred, the worth of water rests on its role and function as a life-force for animals, plants and ecosystems. However, commodification of water reduces its value only to its commercial value. The present definition of value is only in terms of that amount of some commodity, medium of exchange etc., which is considered to be equivalent for something else; a fair or adequate equivalent or return.[4] The proposal to give market values to all resources as a solution to the ecological crisis is like offering disease as the cure. Shiva stresses that with the arrival of the industrial revolution all value became synonymous with commercial value. In the bargain, the spiritual, ecological, cultural and social significance of resources was eroded.[5]

2. The Values of Biodiversity in Different Cultural Contexts Need Recognition

In the indigenous setting, sacredness plays an important part in conservation. This is because sacredness encompasses the intrinsic value of diversity. Sacredness denotes a relationship of the part to the whole – a relationship that recognises and preserves integrity. Profane seed violates the integrity of ecological cycles and linkages, and leads to a fragmentation of agricultural ecosystems and the relations responsible for sustainable production at different levels. Shiva says that, sacred seed is perceived as a microcosm of the macrocosm with *navdanya*, which symbolises the *Navagraha.* The influences of planets and climate are seen as essential to plant productivity. This is in contrast to high yield varieties (HYV) which break links with all seasonal climatic and cosmic cycles. Multiple cropping and photo-insensitivity are two important ways in which the HYV are separated from planetary and climatic influences. Freedom from seasonal cycles is based on dependence on large dams and intensive irrigation. Further the sacredness of seed is seen in the nutrition quotient that it offers. Seed diversity and nutrition go hand in hand. Monocultures of HYV cause nutritional deficiency and imbalance: pulses and oilseeds are sacrificed to increase the commodity production of cereal crops. Shiva indicates that purchased seeds displace women from decision making and custodianship of seeds. In fact they transform women into unskilled labour. Main cereal crop associates are called *akadi* in Karnataka and women make all decisions relating to the *akadi* crop.[6] Due to this involvement of the woman in the *akadi* crop, traditional seeds are preserved over generations. As one woman is quoted, 'they are seeds grown by me, and my mother in my native family, and it is the seeds grown by the daughter.'[7]

Social and cultural regulations have been the main mechanisms for preventing the exploitation of nature. And these mechanisms come from a sense of the sacredness of life. Communities were based on commonly accepted norms and values, which provided the organising principles and control mechanisms for all of its members. A shared resource could be managed communally through the implicit acceptance on the part of all the members of the community of a commonly shared norm. Shiva opines that, the self-sufficient nature of the traditional village economy maintained the commons despite socio-economic inequalities.[8] As a source of life, nature was venerated as sacred and human evolution was measured in terms of the human capacity to merge with her rhythms and patterns, intellectually, emotionally and spiritually. The forest thus nurtured an ecological civilization in the most fundamental sense of harmony with nature. Such knowledge that came from participation in the life of the forest was the substance not just of *Aranyakas* or forest texts, but also of the everyday beliefs of tribal and peasant society.

Shiva says that, the forest is the highest expression of the earth's fertility and productivity and it symbolizes in yet another form the Earth Mother, the *Vana Durga* or the Tree Goddess. In Bengal she is associated with the *asvathha (Ficus religiosa),* and with the *sal (Shorea robusta)*. In folk and tribal cultures especially, trees and forests are also worshipped as *Vana Devatas* or forest deities. The sacred tree thus serves as an image of the cosmos, a symbol of the inexhaustible source of cosmic fertility.[9]

Communities that derived their sustenance from the soil considered it not merely a physical property situated in Cartesian space, but rather that it was the source of all meaning. Quoting an Australian aborigine who said, 'My land is my backbone. My land is my foundation.'[10] Shiva wrote that soil and society, the earth and its people are intimately interconnected. In tribal and peasant societies, cultural and religious identity derives from the soil, which is perceived not as a mere factor of production but as the very soul of society. For most cultures, soil embodies the ecological and spiritual home. It is the womb not only for the reproduction of biological life but also of cultural and spiritual life and epitomizes all the sources of sustenance and is 'home' in the deepest sense.[11]

Shiva thinks that the simultaneous adherence to individual and community regulations began to be regarded as unimportant with the intrusion of large urban and industrial markets into the village economy. The community regulation of common property began to be threatened. The easy access to educational, bureaucratic and financial institutions initiated the process whereby privileged people were no longer subject to traditional social norms, which led gradually to the breaking down of the community.[12]

2.1 Sacred Spaces: Nature's Sanctuaries

In India sacred forests and sacred groves were created and maintained as a cultural response for their protection. There was a natural system that was in vogue where almost every hill-top was dedicated to some local deity and the trees on or about that spot were regarded with great respect so that nobody dared to touch them. There was also a general impression among people that anyone who cut down a tree should plant another in its place.[13] All religions and cultures in South Asia have been rooted in forests and these were not out of fear and ignorance but rather through ecological insight. For the tribes of central India, the forest is the context and the condition of survival. Shiva cites the example of the *mohwa* (*Bassia latifolia*) tree as being vital for the tribals of Chattisgarh, of the Santhal Parganas, of Bastar and of the Satpura range. Women collect the fleshy corollas of its flowers which are eaten raw or cooked, or fried, ground and mixed with flour for making bread, or distilled into spirit. A thick white oil that is extracted from the seed is used by tribals for cooking and burning and is sold for the manufacture of margarine, soap

and glycerine. The tree is thus, never felled owing to the value of its fruits and flowers. Even when land is cleared for cultivation, the *mohwa* trees are carefully preserved. Forests dwellers of Central India have always maintained the *mohwa* tree as the tree of life.[14]

Sacred sites like sacred forests and rivers are examples of resources that have very high value while having no price. Oceans, rivers and other bodies of water have played important roles as metaphors for our relationships to the planet. Diverse cultures have different value systems through which the ethical, ecological and economic behaviour of society is guided and shaped. Shiva is convinced that, the idea that life is sacred puts a high value on living systems and their commodification.[15] Sacred waters carry us beyond the marketplace into a world charged with myths and stories, beliefs and devotion, culture and celebration. Shiva says that, these are worlds that enable us to save and share water, and convert scarcity into abundance. The sacredness of water was inspired both by the power of rivers and water as a life source. T. S. Eliot once wrote about the Mississippi river, 'I do not know much about gods, but I think the river is a strong brown god.'[16]

Shiva argues for the acceptance of values of biodiversity in different cultural contexts at the social level. Sacred groves, sacred seeds, sacred species have been cultural means for treating biodiversity as inviolable. They have always presented us with the best examples of conservation. At the same time, we need to recognise that the market value and dollar value is only a limited value which is often perverse to biodiversity. There are other values of biodiversity, such as those providing meaning and sustenance, and these values need not be treated as subservient and secondary to market values.[17] There is a need to focus, not on the information to be transmitted by experts, but on horizontal communication that both enables local communities to identify their development needs and to establish a dialogue with all stakeholders.

3. The Gandhian Influence on Shiva's Thought and Actions

The regeneration of livelihoods was central to the process of regaining independence. Gandhi had categorically stated that what was good for one nation situated in one condition would not necessarily be good for another differently situated. One man's food is another man's poison. Gandhi thought that mechanisation is good when hands are too few for the work intended to be accomplished. However, it is an evil where there are more hands than required for the work as in the case of India.[18] Retrospecting, Shiva thinks that Gandhi had a very creative vision of *swadeshi, swaraj, satyagraha and sarvodaya*. This vision inspires people to build living economies and living democracies. Shiva says that, when governments begin to implement TRIPS (Trade Related Aspects of Intellectual Property Rights) legislation, as the Indian government has done through three amendments to the Patent Act and by creating new

plant-variety legislation, Gandhi's words can be remembered, 'As long as the superstition that people should obey unjust laws exists, so long will slavery exist.'[19] The philosophy behind the commitment to the *bija satyagraha* is this. The seed is the first link in the food chain. In Sanskrit, *bija*, the seed, means source of life and the saving of seed was a duty and the sharing of seed, a culture. Patents on seeds and genetic resources rob persons of their birth right and deprive them of their livelihoods by transforming seed saving and seed sharing into intellectual property rights. This according to Shiva is an assault on one's culture, on human rights and on the very survival of the human race.[20]

Another Gandhian concept that the seed *satyagraha* revived was that of *swadeshi*. *Swadeshi* in the mind of Gandhi was the spirit of regeneration, a method of creative reconstruction. According to the *swadeshi* philosophy, people already possess, both materially and morally, what they need to emancipate themselves from oppressive structures. Hence, for Gandhi, *swadeshi* was a positive concept which was based on building on resources, skills, and institutions of a community, and when necessary, transforming them.[21] Purity of means was as important to him as purity of goals.[22] People are not free when resources, institutions and structures are imposed on them. For Gandhi, swadeshi was central to the creation of peace and freedom. A farmer's right to produce, exchange, modify and sell seed is also an expression of *swaraj,* and *swadeshi* and unjust laws like the GATT (General Agreement on Tariffs and Trade) treaty that legalise theft of the biological and intellectual heritage of developing countries are unjust.[23]

3.1 An Integrated Activism

Shiva says that local communities need to be involved in setting the priorities for research. Researchers need to learn from existing indigenous technologies, customs and constraints. To these ends, says Shiva, measures are required to ensure an effective flow of information. Shiva also points out that since linking biotechnology research to the needs of poor farmers is especially difficult, given the gulf between the molecular sophistication of the biotechnologist and the cultural sophistication of the farmer, famers' organisations, other non-governmental organisations and local government agencies need to be supported and involved in the process.[24] Common sense would suggest that, other things being equal, scientists, conservationists, international agencies and non-government organisations could defend biodiversity by making common cause with the former than by doing so with the latter. Shiva also debunks the growing literature that seeks to blame the people from the developing world and in particular their population growth for the current ecological crisis. A prime advocate of focusing on the poor in order to address the environmental crisis of the rich nations is Garrett Hardin who, in his book *Lifeboat Ethics: the Case against Helping the Poor*, claims the poor and the weak as a surplus

population which put an unnecessary burden on the planet's resources. Shiva says that, instead of putting women and children first, Hardin's lifeboat operates on a triage basis, and in times of crisis the weak get sacrificed. This is a paradigm of security and the control over and demand for resource of the powerful is what needs to be protected.[25]

Shiva writes that, no model exists which recognises these rights of farmers and other producer communities who derive their livelihoods from biodiversities. The rights of farmers, tribals, pastoralists, herbalists and fisher-folk to the biodiversity that they have conserved can be effectively granted only when they are allowed to participate actively in the decisions that have an impact on the status of their rights and the status of biodiversity. This is only just since they have been involved with their ecological ambient since time immemorial.[26] Shiva proposes a concept of farmer's rights as a sub-category of community rights. This would serve a dual purpose, community rights would recognise the creativity and protect the livelihoods of diverse communities and at the same time they would set limits and boundaries on the domain of monopoly protection shaped by intellectual property rights. In the case of agricultural biodiversity, these community rights are farmers' rights. This change can come only through a political process which recognises the original contributors of knowledge and genetic resources and respects their value system. Community rights are a balancing mechanism for intellectual property rights as a part of building such a political process. Shiva says that, a world in which market values are the only values, is one that is impoverishing – to nature, the developing nations and the international community.[27]

Gandhi had critically articulated the fallacy of increasing labour productivity independent of the social and material context. In the present, Gandhi's followers in the Chipko movement continue to critically evaluate restricted notions of productivity. Shiva writes that, it is this concern with resources and human needs which is symbolised in Sunderlal Bahugana's well-known slogan – ecology is the permanent economy.[28] Shiva spells out the urgency of establishing a new economy of permanence, based on ecological principles especially when each new environmental disaster in the Himalayan region spells destruction for the Gangetic plains. Chipko's demand is conservation of not merely local forest resources but the entire life-support system, and with it the option for human survival. Gandhi had planned a mobilisation for a new society in which neither the person nor nature would be exploited and destroyed. This mobilisation would mark the beginning of this civilizational response to the threat to human survival.[29]

When it comes to demonstrating community participation in ecological ventures, Shiva uses social forestry as an example, wherein she shows where social forestry differs most radically from past forestry programmes is in the recognition that the rebuilding of India's forest wealth cannot be undertaken

without the participation of the local community.[30] She quotes Eckholm,[31] who said that community forestry cannot be imposed from above and carried out in the face of a hostile population. New forms of land use impinge upon, and are influenced by the daily activities of everyone. When the local people are not active participants and supporters of the project, saplings have a way of disappearing overnight. Fodder is usually as scarce as firewood and uncontrolled livestock quickly ruin a new plantation even when disgruntled peasants facing the alternative of a lengthy hike to collect fuel do not covertly cut the saplings themselves. Community involvement, then, is not just an ideologically appealing goal but a practical necessity if rural forests needs are to be met.[32] In the Indian context, social forestry programmes need to be given prime importance all over the country with the objective being to grow more trees. These trees need to be planted on farmlands, community wastelands, road, canal and railway sides and any other land that has been set aside for similar purposes. Social forestry proposes this to be done either singly or in groups, in strips or in blocks. Forest stocks are built up in two ways. First, it is expected to satisfy the basic needs of the population through the creation and regeneration of tree wealth within human settlements, and second, social forestry acts as a mechanism for reducing pressures which are presently destroying reserved forests.[33]

4. Biosemiotics and Signs

Biosemiotics has a role to play in understanding the relationship between the loss of biodiversity and the socio-economic situation of the world. At a very general level, biosemiotics would suggest a view of nature that runs counter to the belief in simplicity. When living systems are studied at different levels, they consist of historical and unique identities in obedience to a logic of semiotic functionality. The biosemiotic view implies that the neo-Darwinian ambition of reducing the majestic process of organic evolution to the chance outcome of an aimless mechanism of natural selection among competing individuals or genotypes is too simplistic.[34] On the other hand, cells, tissues, organisms, populations and ecological systems need to be seen as informationally highly self-dependent or autopoietic entities which respond to messages in ways not specified by the message themselves, but by an internal organisation, or historical individuality of the entity in question.[35] Evolution concerns survival and eventual enrichment of patterns of semiosis rather than survival of organisms or genotypes. Signs, not genes, are the basic units of life.[36]

The basic idea that the model of biosemiotics proposes implicitly is that an eventual transcendence of dualism, and thus the establishment of a fruitful programme of research into our knowledge lacunae, will presuppose the development of a semiotic, or sign-theoretic, perspective on the dynamics of nature. The 'sign' needs to be understood here as a triadic unit according to the

tradition from the American scientist and philosopher Charles Sanders Pierce. This semiotic perspective implies that natural entities and processes should be analysed as interconnected webs of sign relations, shaking hands, as it were throughout nature and between levels in the hierarchical scale stretching, along the spatial dimension, from single cell to the biosphere or, along the semantic dimension, from pheromones signalling to the human psycho-neuro-immuno-endocrine system.[37] From an environmental point of view this is a shift in the view of nature and is worth giving a thought since it challenges the authority of those simplistic assumptions which have for such a long time legitimised the technological violation of the internal dynamics of living systems on this planet. To change people's minds and inner values is always a slow process, but it may become even slower or impossible if educated people do not understand the full depth of the necessary change.[38] There is an ongoing triadic relationship between external nature, culture and internal nature that guides our understanding of life.[39]

It is pointed out that active thinking can be imprisoned by the energies of associational feeling and thought. This can be experienced directly when we have a feeling or thought fixation and cannot free ourselves from it. There are at the same time different types of fixations – technological, social, economic and more. All these have their roots in the fettered area of the soul, in the arena of past, finished thoughts and feelings. These fixations are the cause of a one-sided picture of the world and in the bargain create a distorted reality.[40]

5. Ecological Economics

Shiva points out the myth of the reality of the market economy as being the most efficient method of production. She writes that, this efficient market economy becomes highly inefficient when the destruction of nature's economy is taken into account. The efficiency and productivity of industrial agriculture hides the costs of depletion of soils, exploitation of groundwater, erosion and extinction of biodiversity. She demonstrates the fact that industrial agriculture uses ten times more water than biodiverse farming with water-prudent crops and organic practices use. As a matter of fact, when assessed from nature's economy, biodiverse, ecological farms have much higher productivity than large-scale, industrial, monoculture farms. The illusion of efficiency is produced by externalising the ecological costs.[41] Underlying the ecological paradigm that Shiva proposes, which demonstrates a switch from economics and ideology, is the realization that we live in a delicately balanced, already well designed ecosphere. 'Managing' becomes less relevant than understanding and respecting. Manipulating gives way to the art of harmonising. This insight needs to be constantly incorporated into social behaviour appropriate to the aspirations of the global community.[42]

The main contribution of the ecological paradigm is the awareness that there is no separation between mind and body, human and nature. Nature is constituted in the relationships and connections that provide the very conditions for our life and health. Therefore, the politics of connection and regeneration is one with nature and provides an alternative to the politics of separation and fragmentation that cause ecological breakdown. The implication of this is a radical transformation of nature and culture such that they are mutually permeating, not separate and oppositional. According to Shiva, there is nothing essentialist about this type of politics because it is, in fact, based on denying the patriarchal definition of passivity as the essence of women and nature. She further argues that there is nothing absolutist about it because the natural is constructed through diverse relationships in diverse settings. The politics of partnership with nature, as it is being shaped in the everyday lives of communities and women in particular, is a politics of rebuilding connections and of regeneration through dynamism and diversity.[43]

People's contribution to the development of an adequate *sui generis* system for plants needs to focus on three imperatives of ethics and ecology, recognition of creativity by communities, and economic equity. Shiva initiates a discussion in her writings about countries that need to have a strong legislation to allow exclusion of patents on life on grounds of public morality. Areas excluded from patentability need to be governed by non-monopoly regimes which protect people's rights to creativity and innovation.[44] This is the ethical and ecological imperative to recognise the intrinsic worth of all species.

Another imperative is for the equal recognition of creativity in diverse cultures. Diverse cultures have evolved different traditions of knowledge and innovation which need to be treated with respect and equality. Shiva has pointed out clearly that in the area of biodiversity, indigenous knowledge of farmers, tribals and herbals is the primary source of knowledge of properties of plants. This is an example of indigenous innovation. This may defer in structure, motivation and process from the innovation in industrial systems but it has its own merits. The third imperative that Shiva proposes is the economic imperative to provide all members of societies with health and nutrition. Monopolies in crucial areas to survival have been prevented through various mechanisms. She says that, it is because of this reason that food and health which are crucial to survival have been prevented from being monopolised by National patent laws (the Indian Patent law does not allow patents for living resources).[45] A new era of colonisation can be averted.[46]

5.1 The Theory of Enoughness as Praxis

Shiva advocates the philosophy of enoughness as being at the core of the ecological paradigm. Enoughness has become vital to the experience of a freedom that is inclusive of the freedom of all beings and all people.[47]

Enoughness becomes the basis of earth democracy and earth citizenship and creates the conditions of peace, both peace with nature and peace between people. On the other side of the spectrum is greed which drives resource conflicts, wars with the earth, and wars against people. According to Shiva enoughness is based on caring for the earth and society and this caring creates the imperative of sharing, of recovering the commons. A culture of sharing is a culture of peace.[48]

Notes

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2 Vandana Shiva, *Biopiracy: The Plunder of Nature and Knowledge* (Cambridge: South End Press, 1997), 126. (Henceforth referred to as *Biopiracy*)
3 Vandana Shiva, *Earth Democracy: Justice, Sustainability, and Peace* (London: Zed Books, 2005), 94. (Henceforth referred to as *Earth Democracy*)
4 Vandana Shiva, *Water Wars: Privatisation, Pollution, and Profit* (Cambridge: South End Press, 2002), 137. (Henceforth referred to as *Water Wars*)
5 *Water Wars*, 138.
6 Vandana Shiva, *Ecofeminism* (Nova Scotia: Fernwood Publications, 1993), 168. (Henceforth referred to as *Ecofeminism*)
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9 Vandana Shiva, *Staying Alive: Women, Ecology and Survival in India* (London: Zed Press, 1988), 56. (Henceforth referred to as *Staying Alive*)
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28 Vandana Shiva, *Ecology and the Politics of Survival: Conflicts over Natural Resources in India* (California: Sage Publications, 1991), 116. (Henceforth referred to as *Ecology and the Politics of Survival*)

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30 *Ecology and the Politics of Survival*, 124.
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32 *Ecology and the Politics of Survival*, 125.
33 *Ecology and the Politics of Survival*, 126.
34 *Biopolitics*, 149.
35 *Biopolitics,* 149.
36 *Biopolitics*, 149.
37 *Biopolitics*, 143.
38 *Biopolitics*, 149.
39 *Biopolitics*, 145.
40 *Biopolitics,* 241.
41 *Earth Democracy*, 32.
42 Vandana Shiva, *Close to Home: Women Reconnect Ecology, Health, and Development Worldwide* (London: Earthscan, 1994), 152. (Henceforth referred to as *Close to Home)*
43 *Close to Home*, 142.
44 *Protect or Plunder?*, 125.
45 *Protect or Plunder?*, 126.
46 *Protect or Plunder?*, 132.
47 Vandana Shiva, *Making Peace with the Earth: Beyond Resource, Land and Food Wars* (New Delhi: Women Unlimited, 2012), 262.
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10

The Indian Media Watchdog or Lapdog?

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Abstract: According to the Social Responsibility Theory of the Press, media is supposed to be a watchdog of all that goes on in society, especially the government. In a democracy this role gets amplified more than in other forms of government. For, press is the fourth pillar of democracy. In India during pre-independence times and in the immediate decades post-independence media played a stellar role in being the watchdog. With industrialization and commercialization of the media, driven mainly by a profit motive, the role of the watchdog begun to take a backseat. Besides, with economic liberalization and ending of the so-called "licence raj" in 1992 the Indian electronic media leapfrogged from one television channel to more than a thousand channels. This resulted in cut throat competition for TRP (Television Rating Point) among television channels with 24/7 news, reality shows and other programmes. From then on, with exceptions, the watchdog function was given a quiet burial and most media houses ran lapdog media in favour of the ruling party in power, the rich, the powerful and the corporates. This trend got accentuated from 2013 when media houses, according to reliable reports, were explicitly told to pull down the image of the UPA (United Progressive Alliance) government and promote the image of Narendra Modi as the new messiah of Indian politics. From then on there has been no turning back as far as media coverage of events in India is concerned: most media houses have become the mouth-piece of the ruling party dishing out false propaganda, pseudo-nationalism, religious hatred, and fake news in favour of the ruling dispensation and a desire to tarnish the image of the entire opposition, especially the Indian National Congress.

Introduction

Today we live in the post-truth world. This world is either ushered in partly by the media or the media just mirrors it; the media thereby performing its agenda and mirroring functions respectively. From the Christian perspective the roots of media go back to the prophetic times. While the prophets foretold what is in store for the people of Israel they also confronted the high and the mighty in society (including kings) to speak truth to power. In the process of speaking truth to power, many of them lost their lives. It is the same courageous prophetic witness that the media is obligated to embrace. The pertinent question is: Is the Media being a watchdog or is it increasingly becoming a lapdog of the rich, the powerful and the multi-national corporates? From pre-independence times to the immediate decades post-independence the Indian media played the watchdog role honorably. But since then the media in India seems to have abdicated its social responsibility and diluted its role of being a watchdog, especially of the government in power. There has been a noticeable tendency on the part of the media to align itself with powers-that-be, even to the extent of their being mouthpieces – Times Now, Republic, Zee Television being the prominent among them. It is done through distortion of facts and figures, self-censorship, offering paid news service, publishing fake news and so forth. These unethical acts of media houses got accentuated since 2013. Editors were sacked overnight for publishing stories unpalatable to the government or to its crony capitalists.

1. Media: Definition and Functions

Media are the information gathering and information disseminating sources. Media are channels of communication. Channels may vary from a simple blackboard to more complex television infrastructure. The three important functions of media are: inform, educate and entertain. As an answer to boredom media have come up with edutainment (Educating in an entertaining manner) and infotainment (informing in an entertaining fashion). In fact most newscasting today is infotainment resulting in the trivialization of serious issues confronting society. An extended version of these functions are: Instrumental (to achieve or obtain something); Persuasion (to exhort the audience to action); Control (to get someone to behave in a particular way); Expression (to express one's feelings or put oneself over in a particular way); Social contact (participating in company); Binding (to unify and create a basis for community); Alleviation of anxiety (to sort out a problem, ease a worry about something); Stimulation (response to something of interest); Role-related (because the situation requires it).

2. The Indian Media

To better understand the Indian media it is important to look at its historical evolution, even briefly. The history furnished below will throw more light on the significance of the topic and will provide a context to better grasp it.

2.1 The Ancient Period

Though India's national history is traced as far back as 4000 B.C.E., the history of its press is less extensive in time. In ancient times India was a land of kings and emperors. There was no press or newspaper in the modern sense of the term. Asoka the Indian emperor, used to publish the imperial edicts on rocks and pillars. During the Mauryan period (circa 321-185 B.C) there seems to have been a system of news-gathering, which has been mentioned in the Ordinances of Manu. The Mauryas under Kautilya treated it as a sort of intelligence gathering for administrative and political purposes. The system of communication started by the Mauryas seems to have lasted for a certain period. In the 10 century A.D, the Ghaznavi dynasty ruling the Punjab is reported to have used a somewhat a similar system in collecting news, especially about the enemies.

2.2 The Medieval Period

The Mughal dynasty established by Babur in 1526 seems to have had a well-oiled system of news-gathering. This was especially true at the time of Akbar the Great. The presence at his court of a *Waquiah Navis* or the news writer is well documented. *Waquiah Navis* were attached to the information offices set up in every provincial capital. Their reports played a great role in making important decisions and formulating policies. What historians term 'manuscript newspapers' seems to have existed during Aurangzeb's (one of the last of the Mughal emperors) rule. Calligraphy was used in writing news. The main readers of such newspapers were the soldiers. Indian Press historians also speak of the existence at the time of private newsletters written by news agent. "The news writers had their own sources of information and had made secret arrangements to procure news."[1]

According to Historians the first printing press in India was set up on 6 September 1556 in Goa, brought from Portugal. Jaao de Bustamante brought the press to Goa and is known as the pioneer Indian printer; it was mainly used for religious purposes and not for newspapers; Jaao Gonsalves, an Indian blacksmith, who accompanied Bustamante to Goa can be said to be "the first Indian to make types of an Indian script in India" … These types were used for the printing of St. Francis Xavier's *Doutrina Christa* in Tamil, the 'first book printed in an Indian language."[2] Some historians of the Indian Press would like to portray that the arrival of the printing press in Goa and Madras was largely for

the propagation of the Christian faith. Whereas the printing press came to the Eastern province, Bengal, due largely to political reasons. They also go on to point out that the advent of the press in India wasn't wholeheartedly welcomed either by the British rulers or by some sections of the Indian population. The British saw the press in India as a threat to their continued hegemony, whereas some sections of the Indian population resented the use of the press for the propagation of the Christian faith.

2.3 The 18th Century

The first Indian newspaper *The Bengal Gazette* or the *Calcutta General Advertiser* was due to the pioneering work of James Augustus Hicky, an ex-employee of the East India Company. The paper, a weekly, first appeared on January 29, 1780. It carried the news mainly of the small European community living and working in Calcutta. In the subsequent announcement regarding the policy of the newspaper, Hick said: *[the Bengal Gazette]* "was a weekly political and commercial paper open to all parties, but influenced by none."[3] In terms of content, printing and publication *Bengal Gazette* may have been a primitive one, but it gave birth to the era of Indian journalism, which was to play a great role in the shaping of democracy in India. Hicky is rightly remembered as the Father of Indian Journalism.

The paper's greatness lay in its undaunted and valiant fight for the liberty of the press. It upheld the freedom of the press as one of the great bulwarks of liberty. The paper upheld the freedom of conscience, of education, of speech, and of assembly which it considered to be the fundamentals of human existence. Hicky's courageous and resolute struggle against the authorities of the day set a great precedent for the rise of a free press in India. Following the example of Hicky's *Bengal Gazette*, many other English language newspapers were published from the three major provincial headquarters: Bengal, Bombay and Madras. They are: *Calcutta Gazette, Bengal Journal, India Gazette, Bengal Harkaru, Bombay Herald, Bombay Courier, Madras Courier and Journal of Commerce*. It is noteworthy that almost all the pioneer journalists were Englishmen. But they did not refrain from pointing out the bitter truth about the authorities of the time. Hence, there was a constant tension between the authorities of the government and the Press "on principles of freedom and control. The fourth Estate was vigorous in its criticism of the administration of the East India Company."[4] The authorities quite often tried, albeit unsuccessfully, to crush the press.

2.4 The 19th Century

In 1801, Wellesley came to the conclusion that to start an official gazette would be the best method of "silencing" the existing printing presses which were "an evil of the first magnitude…"[5] Although, the plan for a *Government Gazette* was eventually abandoned, in visualizing the need for a government medium to communicate with the public, Wellesley had anticipated his times. Around this time some Indians too began to show interest in starting newspapers. In 1816 Gangadhar Bhattacharya, a learned disciple of Raja Ram Mohan Roy launched the *Bengal Gazette.* It was primarily for the English educated elite. This paper, a weekly, lasted only for four years. But, Bhattacharya's effort set a trend towards launching more newspapers by Indians in the latter half of the 19 century.

At this time James Silk Buckingham came on the journalistic scene. He started the *Calcutta Journal* and is reported to have played a great role in the history of the press in India. He stressed the importance of a free press in order to check an irresponsible government, particularly in the absence of law-making machinery. The editor's function according to him was, "to admonish Governors of their duties, to warn them furiously of their faults and to tell disagreeable truths."[6] Buckingham is said to be one of the fiery champions of the freedom of the press in India. Eventually, Buckingham was deported because John Adam who succeeded Hastings as Governor-General saw the free and uncontrolled press as a great danger to the East India Company's regime.

The Indian language press too had its birth at the beginning of the 19 century: *Digdarshan* and *Samachar Darpan* (1818), *Sambad Kaumudi*, *Mirat-ul-Akhbar (Mirror of News)* (1821)*, Bombay Samachar* (1822) and others. John Adam enacted the Vernacular Press Act of 1823, which imposed great restrictions on the freedom of the press. It may be noted here that missionaries were the initiators of Indian-language journalism in various parts of India.

Between 1825 and 1857 the Indian press seems to have enjoyed relative freedom under the Governors-General of India, Lord William Bentinck and Sir Charles Metcalfe. The former is known in the pages of the history of India as "the liberator of the Indian press."[7] The Act of 1835 passed by Sir Metcalfe repealed the 1823 Press Regulations in Bengal and the Bombay Press Regulations of 1825 and 1827. While promulgating the Act of 1835 Sir Metcalfe said that to deny free expression of thought for all classes was to contend "that the essence of good government is to cover the land with darkness."[8]

In May 1857, the First War of Independence or the "Indian Sepoy Mutiny" broke out in Meerut. With that the darkest period of Indian Journalism set in. The government didn't want passions to go out of control and so a new Vernacular Press Act to regulate the press was promulgated on June 13, 1857. This measure came to be known as the "Gagging Act" because the main purpose was to restrain the circulation of printed books and papers and also curb the independent spirit of the Indian soldiers. The government suspected the Indian language press of encouraging sedition. With the Act operative for

a year the number of publications dropped from thirty-five to six and their circulation came down drastically. A number of Indian editors were jailed for publishing allegedly seditious news and articles. In the years that followed immediately though there was very little interference in the functioning of the press.

2.5 Role of English and Vernacular Press during Freedom Struggle

The Indian National Congress, for achieving political independence of India, was established in 1885. With it a new wave of nationalism arose and the tone of Indian newspapers changed. The language used by Indian journalists and some English newspapermen was inspiring, patriotic, insistent and effective. Increasingly newspapers acquired a political nature. And for the politically conscious Indians, newspapers became a forum for new reforms discussion. Many of today's large newspapers were born then — *The Times of India of Bombay*, The *Statesman* of Calcutta and *The Hindu* of Madras.

In the subsequent years the press grew rapidly in India and the government took note of the growing press criticism. With the spread of the Indian National Congress and the consequent wave of nationalism, a new era in the history of the Indian press had begun. The aspiration for political freedom was reflected in the writings of almost all Indian journalists. Towards this goal they tended to use strong and effective language.

2.6 The 20th Century

In the first decade of the 20th century the Indian press got divided between the liberals (moderates) and the nationalists (extremists). The nationalists were supported by papers such as *Kesari* and *Deshsevak* of Nagpur, in central India. To control such papers the British government passed the Newspapers (Incitement to Offences) Act VII of 1908, which empowered authorities to take judicial action against a paper publishing matters allegedly inciting rebellion.

During this time the liberals started their own daily newspaper *Leader* in Allahabad with Pandit Madan Mohan Malaviya being its main organizer. As hostility towards the British grew the press was one of the most potent instruments. The press, now spread almost to the entire country, quickened the ideas of justice and equality; and the so-called "seditious" ideas, as the authorities termed them, were being disseminated. In order to arrest its spread a more stringent Press Act I was enacted in 1910.

In the history of the Indian press Dr. Annie Besant's role has to be mentioned. Her *New India* based in Madras was instrumental for setting India on the path to freedom. Dr. Besant is gratefully acknowledged as "the torch-bearer of India's liberty."[9] She is also the originator in India of the idea of training young men and women in journalism. Her National University at Adyar, Madras ran the first full-fledged course in journalism.

Mohandas Karam Chand Gandhi's arrival in India from South Africa in 1915 was a great moment for the press in India. He was not new to journalism as he already published a newspaper *Indian Opinion* in South Africa. He soon launched two newspapers — an English and a Gujarati weekly — to disseminate his views on Indian independence. He wanted to run *Young India* and *Navjivan* on people's support and so decided not to accept advertisements.

His writings had a great effect on the government and fostered a spirit of independence among the public. At the same time, he set high standards of journalism as a profession in India. As the non-cooperation movement of Gandhi gained in strength, censorship of the press became stringent. There was widespread imposition of penalties, forfeiture of security deposits, banning of circulation and imprisonment of journalists. At this time the desire to have a national language newspaper was realized by the launching of *Aj* in Hindi from Benaras. *Aj* fully supported the Indian National Congress and its freedom movement.

In 1922, the *Swarajya* was started in Madras to spread Gandhi's ideas and principles of freedom. When Lord Reading became the Viceroy, the Central Legislature repealed the Newspapers (Incitement to Offences) Act of 1908 and Act I of 1910. Meanwhile with similar aims as *Swarajya* in Madras, *Forward* was launched in Bengal by C. R. Das.

Indian press grew from strength to strength and this phenomenal growth can be attributed to its support of the freedom movement. The following papers wielded considerable influence over the masses: the *Forward*, the *Amrita Bazar Patrika*, the *Indian Daily Mail*, the *Bombay Chronicle*, the *Hindustan Times*, the *Tribune*, the *Leader*, the *Hindu, Aj, Kesari*, and *Mathrubhumi.*

At this time Gandhi visualized the need for starting an English weekly which could be circulated throughout India. For this he sought financial help from a leading industrialist Ghanshyam Das Birla. Thus appeared the *Harijan* on February 11, 1933. The great popular response to the *Harijan* made Gandhi start various language editions of the *Harijan.* In his autobiography Gandhi writes: "One of the objects of a newspaper is to understand the popular feelings and give expression to them; another is to arouse among the people certain desirable sentiments; and the third is fearlessly to expose popular defects."[10]

In 1938, the *National Herald* was founded by Jawaharlal Nehru to give publicity to the workers of the freedom movement in Uttar Pradesh. Meanwhile, the *National Herald* published from Lucknow had to take the brunt of the government's ire against the press for highlighting the United Provinces' draconian measures against the press. The paper then was ordered to submit all the posters and headlines before publication. But this was practically impossible to be done. So the paper published news items without headlines.The government suppressed many newspapers and journals (92) and imposed heavy penalties payable within three weeks.

India attained independence on 15 August 1947. With freedom, the Indian press attained a new significance and had to assume new responsibilities. "To the consummation of Indian freedom the Press had made no mean contribution over more than half a century of the nation's struggle for liberation."[11] Lord Listowell, the last British Secretary of State for India commented soon after the Independence: "The Indian newspapers have every reason to be proud of the part they have played in the great constitutional change and of the good influence they have exercised on Indian opinion."[12]

From the foregoing history it is clear that the media (run both by the English and the natives) in the pre-independence times tried to be a watchdog of those in power. Some English journalists based in India exposed their own government's misdeeds in India and upheld the highest standards of journalism.

2.7 Indian Media Post-independence

In the decades immediately after the independence the ownership of media was entirely in the hands of Indians. The media played a great role in stabilizing democracy in the nascent republic and in the development of the country. To a large extent media was independent and played the watchdog role with a great sense of responsibility. The darkest period for the Indian media in the 20th century was during the emergency 1975-77, when most of the Indian media had to surrender to the authoritarian dictates of Mrs. Indira Gandhi, the Prime Minister at the time. Some media houses stood up to her autocratic regime.

3. Contemporary Media Issues in India

Journalistic Profession: Journalism in India is no longer a vocation, but a profession catering mainly to the interests of the rich, the famous and the powerful. The main interest of journalists seems to be to bring out a product that carries the so-called high society gossip and protect the business and socio-political interests of the elite. This seems natural given that most journalists in India come from the higher economic and caste strata.

Media Industry: The media today is an extended arm of the industry and at times an extended arm even of the government in power. This is due to the media barons' inordinate objective of money-making, the desire for influence and social prestige. Media leans heavily on advertisements, giving the impression that some media exist mainly for the advertisers. This undue dependence on advertising is bound to influence the editorial policy, independence, honesty and impartiality of media units to the extent that in some newsrooms the advertising department wields greater influence. Editorialization is part of the effort to maximise market reach and the accrual of profit. Journalism as service to society has been replaced by journalism aimed at profit and affluence for media promoters and media workers.

Sensationalism, Negativity and Triviality: Infotainment is the norm of news presentation — presenting news in the form and style of fiction: overstating facts, using colourful adjectives and sensational expressions. The other characteristics of contemporary Indian media are cynicism, negativity and deception. Even mainstream papers are employing tabloid style gossip, scandal, crime and disaster, which bring in increased circulation and take refuge in the claim that they are giving the public what it wants. With a few exceptions largely circulated and commercially successful newspapers are turning out to be more trivial than serious.

The Right to Privacy: On 27 February 2006 the Supreme Court of India, restrained the print and electronic media from publishing or broadcasting any clandestinely tapped telephone conversation, including that featuring Samajwadi Party leader Amar Singh. A Times of India news report interpreted the Supreme Court action as taking away the sting out of the new trend in investigative journalism in India. Can a broadcaster say it can surreptitiously record and broadcast any conversation, terming it to be in public interest? Asked the SC. Right to privacy in defamation cases cannot be invoked if 'the subject voluntarily thrusts himself into controversy or voluntarily invites or raises a controversy'.

Celebrity Mania: "Celebrity marriages, lost dogs, drunken brawls, trivial headline news and the sellout of mainstream journalism"[13]— this is the kind of image Indian mainstream media has nowadays. Activist and iconic actor Aamir Khan said, "Mainstream media has become like film media 25 years ago."[14]

Trial by Media: The tendency of the media to pronounce judgment even before a case has come to the court for trial and conviction. For instance in the cases relating to Bofors and Rajiv Gandhi, 2 G scandal, Aarushi Murder and so forth.

Fake Stings: Investigations have to be governed by public interest. But stories like the India TV sting about starlets and the casting couch - first of all, that's not of national interest.

Media Houses and Conflict of Interest: This is clearly illustrated by Mehta:

> A couple of newspapers have been reporting on an open secret of the media, the existence of private treaties. Under these, media houses invest in companies, which then receive favourable media treatment in turn, including column inches favourable to these companies. Bennett and Coleman pioneered this, but many other major institutions have followed. These deals are worth hundreds of crores. ... How deep conflicts of interest run in the Indian media, who is involved, what forms of advocacy or self-censorship

these impose, ought to be a matter of grave concern. But what is astonishing is how little space there is in the media to acknowledge that there are serious issues here.[15]

4. The Indian Media from 2013

Those Indians who exercise free thinking and reason have noticed a sea-change in the attitude of the media from 2013 leading up to the general elections in 2014 and after. Most Indian Media with a total lack of journalistic objectivity and reason bought into the false propaganda unleashed by the Sangh Parivar elements whose candidate for Prime Minister was Narendra Damodar Modi. Modi's sheer propaganda about his 'Gujarat Model' (when there was none at all) and his promise to replicate it at an all-India level if elected Prime Minister was almost wholly endorsed by the corporate media. This false media blitzkrieg is partly responsible for his party (BJP) getting a thumping majority in the Indian parliament and Modi becoming the Prime Minister. Once in power Modi was able to bring more media houses to his side through bribes, favours, threats and intimidation.

5. Media Ideology and Its Praxis in India

Media in general tend to adopt a centre-left liberal ideology. This is in keeping with media's inclusive nature as the fourth pillar of democracy. Whereas, media which embrace a right-wing or left-wing ideology do so to be a mouth-piece of the authorities holding these ideologies. In the process media would end up excluding the voices of some sections of society, which have grave consequences for the society at large. Besides, when media do so, it goes far away from the journalistic ethos that the media are supposed to uphold. From 2013 a major section of the Indian media seems to have consciously gone along with the right-wing ideology, the justification for which could be many. However, any number of justifications does not make this leaning right, as it would swerve far away from the objectives of the media.

These deliberations would help us to look at another aspect of the Indian media. Media is supposed to be a mirror to society – a reflection of reality. From 2013 a major section of the Indian media failed to present the realities of Indian society; rather the media was dishing out false reality or simulated reality and hyper reality. False reality has been that Indian people have been extremely happy with the government policies. This was sought to be confirmed by overplaying the results of various State and local elections. Media, by peddling up the tension on India's Western border, with Pakistan (because of the "surgical strikes" sporadic skirmishes) and Northern borders with China (because of occupation of Doklam by Indian armed forces) a simulated situation of safety and national security was presented. Going further the media endorsed the hyper reality of nationalism and patriotism.

6. The Lapdog Media

In the last five years (2013-18) it has been quite alarming to see how the practice of journalism has shifted from a profession where one took pride in being adversarial against those in authority to one where big media prides itself in being the conscience keeper of the state, of the 'nation,' egging the state on to battle in a more determined fashion against 'enemies,' be they external or internal. Someone commented that it's the taunt by a news anchor to a central minister that ultimately resulted in the surgical strike on the border with Pakistan. Today, the government or the people in authority seem to have successfully mobilized a section of the media (especially channels such as Zee News, Times Now, and Republic) to actually assist them in the attack on university autonomy, critical thinking, student protests and differences of opinion. Showing doctored clips for instance on JNU[16] students purportedly shouting anti-national slogans in order to incite public sentiment, is something very new and dangerous. Here is the use of media not to communicate the reality but to propagate ideology. This is a different use of the media altogether - one that is ideologically laden..

SiddharthVaradarajan, former editor of *The Hindu* and one of the founders of the online portal thewire.in explains the present tendency in the media:

> The media has always had problems in this country. I've been a journalist for 20 years, and have worked in media organizations in a situation where we've had four or five, may be six prime ministers: Narasimha Rao, H.D. Deve Gowda, Atal Bihari Vajpayee, Inder Gujral, Manmohan Singh, and now Narendra Modi, but the climate today is really quite different, in the sense that media proprietors are far more risk averse, far less willing to ask or have their people ask questions, and far more willing to clamp down on an interview, or a debate topic, or an op-ed. There's a sense in which certain kinds of questions will not be tolerated, and I think this is really what's alarming – that you still have media and academic freedom for all intents and purposes, but if important areas of enquiry are shut out and not aired, that creates a problem.[17]

In this way most of today's media conducts itself as lapdog media.

> There are two reasons for the muzzling of the press: One, the ruler does not want anyone to have a dissenting opinion and he wants everybody to agree to what is going on. Two, the ruler has a sense of insecurity. He is not confident and secure enough to say 'it doesn't matter, we can have a discussion where some people will take an opposite point of view and some people won't'. But when the ruler

is frightened of opposition and dissent, then he resorts to the idea of shutting people up or not allowing people to speak.[18]

One of the reasons why many have ceased to be a television news watcher is precisely because they find it absolutely indigestible. Total lies proclaimed from TV studios raise the blood pressure of the audiences; indeed to many, television watching has become injurious to health. One sits there and looks at what is being presented and it provokes one to wonder, how can they do this? In many channels, it is a deliberate misleading. In other channels, it is a refusal to ask questions. There is a crisis, for example, which involves the adivasi community, whether it is worship of their sacred mountain, whether it is the demand for a better life that is going on in central India and Bastar and so on; news channels have miserably failed to actually go to those adivasi villages and ask the adivasi people, why they are supporting or opposing the Naxals. With the exception of one or two channels, by and large, there is a tendency to have pontification from certain predictable media persons on every issue and that is really not what the media's role is. Media houses are refusing to have serious discussions. Many channels are unwilling to have even a half hour discussion every evening by people who are professionally equipped to talk about the subject for the fear of losing viewership, which need not be true at all.[19]

6.1 The Lapdog Media and the Ideology of the 'NATION'

One of the aspects of present day politics in India is that there is the ruling party, the Bharatiya Janta Party, and its parent organization the Sangh Parivar, and a host of affiliated bodies which give the RSS and the BJP plausible deniability. When they act and do things that are quite terrible, the government or the ruling party can say "well, we have nothing to do with them" – but they all essentially sing to the same broad tune. That tune, in logical terms has been Hindu nationalism and Hindu chauvinism, or the Hindutva ideology and we've seen elements of that ideology come into play in the last four years. There is the prevailing perception that somewhere down the line, not just the Prime Minister or the BJP or the RSS but the whole wider Sangh Parivar has latched on to the idea of the 'nation' and the 'nation under threat' as being a far more potent vehicle for their kind of politics.[20]

We've seen in the campaign against JNU, which is where in a way this whole thing started, where they accused students of being 'anti-national;' on the basis of shouting slogans, they accused them of being seditious. Then there is this whole controversy where politicians and people must say "*Bharat mataki jai*" and if you don't then somehow you are being anti-national. Next of course, the entire discourse over terrorism, the so-called surgical strikes, the campaign against black money, is all being cast in the language of "nation

khatre meinhai" (the nation is in danger) and if you don't stand with the government at this time, then somehow you are being unpatriotic.[21] Almost at every step of these happenings most media houses in India have sung in tandem the salience of the 'nation' dished out by the Sangh Parivar.

The nation, nationalism, Bharat Mata have acquired so much of salience today. There are TV channels now referring to every soldier killed as a 'martyr'. As a result the whole language of public discourse has become very overtly nationalist, which leaves many worried. The fact is "the middle class doesn't have the foggiest idea that it is consigning its vital identity of being 'the people' to the ritual flames of evening television day after day. The anchor is the new high priest of nationalism. In the name of nationalism, he exhorts everybody to sacrifice his or her identity."[22]

The high priests of television studios have succeeded in transporting the audience (especially the gullible Bhakts of the Sangh Parivar) into a simulated theatre of hyper reality of the glorious vedic times when spacecraft and planes existed and Narada was the first reporter and journalist. Media images and bytes seek to give the impression that for the first time in India's history those glorious times are going to be recreated in the present rule by the Sangh Parivar. The reality on the ground is sought to be replaced by the images (simulations). Media that endorse the Sangh version of myths and legends beam an excess of signs and meaning which in effect causes the effacement of reality. In the world of such hyper reality reason and logic disappear.

Conclusion

The Indian media during the British rule (even when it was run by individuals of British origin) and in the immediate decades post-independence acted as a watchdog to a great extent. The real suppression of the freedom of the press took place during the internal emergency 1975-77. The suppression was very courageously resisted by many media houses and their publications. Increased corporatization and commercialization of the Indian media saw the trend of media cowing down to the dictates of the party in power. This tendency became acute from 2013 when media became a willing partner in the propaganda war unleashed by the right-wing political party – *Bharatiya Janata Party* – and its parent organization the *Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh* (RSS). As it turns out today, the propaganda has been entirely false (the critics of the right-wing knew this all along) and it was deliberately undertaken. Once the BJP rode to power at the centre, based on this propaganda, there was no looking back – the media which had only bent began to literally crawl to the whims and fancies of the government and the *Sangh Parivar*. It was demanded of media persons that they first of all be nationalist and patriot. Most media persons and media houses seem to have acquiesced to this demand and in the process they have contended to act like a lapdog rather than a watchdog.

Notes

1 Nadig Krishna Murthy, *Indian Journalism* (Mysore: University of Mysore, 1966), 8.
2 Murthy, 10.
3 As cited in Francis Arackal, *The Indian Media: How Credible*? (Bombay: Better Yourself Books, 2010), 33.
4 Murthy, 22.
5 As cited in Margarita Barns, *The Indian Press: A History of the Growth of Public Opinion in India* (London: George Allen & Unwin Ltd., 1940), 78.
6 As cited in Murthy, 33.
7 Arackal, 38.
8 Arackal, 38.
9 Arackal, 42.
10 As cited in Murthy, 96.
11 As cited in Murthy, 111.
12 As cited in Murthy, 111.
13 Shoma Chaudhury, "Mainstream Media has become Like Film Media 15 Years Ago" *Tehelka*, 01 April, 2006, 01.
14 *Ibid*.
15 Pratap Bhanu Mehta, "People's Media?" <http://archive.indianexpress.com/news/people-s-media-/264489/3> (23 April, 2018).
16 Jawaharlal Nehru University (JNU) had been a scene of student protests and unrest since February 2016 over allegations of "anti-national" slogan shouting by some students in the campus.
17 Siddharth Varadarajan, "Romila Thapar: Media Today is not communicating reality but propagating ideology" in <https://thewire.in/136061/romila-thapar-media-nationalism-interview/> (28 August, 2017).
18 *Ibid*.
19 See Siddharth Varadarajan, "RomilaThapar: Media Today is not communicating reality but propagating ideology" in <https://thewire.in/136061/romila-thapar-media-nationalism-interview/> (28 August, 2017).
20 *Ibid*.
21 *Ibid*.
22 Ravish Kumar, "It is time for the middle class to march barefoot" in <https://thewire.in/170237/media-protests-middle-class/> (28 August, 2017).

11

Challenging the Process of A-signification of Tribal Land

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Abstract: This paper aims to critically reflect the nature of tribal land, the life associated with it, the complications involved when it is dispossessed, and the purpose behind the systematic denigration. Several efforts have been made to confiscate tribal land for selfish gains by 'outsiders' and at the same time several efforts also have been made by several people to safeguard it in various ways. One such is the promulgation of the Chotanagpur Tenancy Act (CNT Act) by J.B. Hoffmann, and the Santhal ParganaTenancy Act (SPT Act) because of which tribals of Chotanagpur, to a certain extent, are able to preserve their life and culture. The present atrocities against minorities, conversion issue, uniform civil code, non-implementation of the Sarna code in the census, Jharkhand Freedom of Religion Bill etc., in the tribal dominated States are related to tribal land and the life associated with it.

1. Introduction

"No matter where we are, we are always on the losing side," said a tribal activist from Ranchi during the protest against Jharkhand government's attempt to amend the CNT Act. This is the universal experience of subaltern people be it in India or anywhere in the world. The systematic elimination of these people from their original ecosystem, culture and tradition has been taking place everywhere. Land is the sum total of their identity. When the land is taken away, they end up being dispossessed of everything. The bourgeoisie

attitude of power-crazy mongers has only colonialized the weaker sections of the society. The post-independent Indian political system has failed to uphold the diverse cultures of ethnic people. Thanks to the messianic acts of persons like J.B. Hoffman and Constant Lievens who foresaw the colonial mindset and responded, effectively safeguarding to a larger extent further exploitation. The present paper deals with the a-significance of tribal land with special reference to the Chotanagpur plateau.

2. Significance of Land Narrative

2.1 The Metanarrative of Land

Food, shelter, clothing, air and water are basic requirements for our survival. Without these five elements one can hardly survive for long. Human beings are not just a bundle of material needs; rather they do have and need social bonding, and elements of culture, politics and spirituality. All these basic things can be merged into one word, 'land'.

Generally, land is understood as "the surface of the earth that is not covered by water."[1] But it is more than that. When it is demarcated by a boundary or ownership, it becomes a country. Further, land is a "surface of the earth and all its natural resources."[2] The natural resources include water bodies, mineral resources, and the produce of the earth. Apart from its geographical and political significance, land also holds a psychological dimension. "People call a place a land when they want to be mysterious or to sound emotional or old-fashioned."[3] This means that one's emotions, cultural lineage, and traditional value systems are attached to a particular area and its inhabitants. Therefore, land is *a surface of the earth with all its natural, social, emotional and spiritual resources*. Thus, 'land' encompasses habitat, food, livelihood, clothing, water, natural resources and the relationship among the inhabitants. It is as important as the mother for the healthy growth of a newborn baby; a vital life line for any living being, be it human or non-human.

2.2 The Indigenous Land Narrative

Indigenous people or tribals believe that *land* is a gratuitous gift of God. The benevolent Supreme Being lovingly created the world and all that is in it, and offered it to *human beings*. Therefore, land can neither be owned by an individual nor can it be alienated, surrendered or sold to an 'outsider' or a *diku*.[4] The *human being* in this context refers to the great grandparents (whom the Santals call "*haṛam*", "the Old") who in turn handed over the land to their children (*bhaia-bahin*, brother-sister, as the creation legend goes), the primordial parents from whom several clans emerged.[5] Thus, the land is given to the *original inhabitants*[6] of the place. As the clan increased, land distribution was undertaken with justice and equity[7] considering the need of everyone.

The current reality of land grabbing is not something new to the tribals. One can clearly observe this fact in their creation myth as, "the horse trampling the sculptures made by the grandfather" and the vigilant tribals along with their dogs chasing them,[8] as the dictum goes, 'the powerful subdue the powerless.' When the Aryan invasion took place the ones who were more advanced in technology, warfare, agriculture and power either subdued tribals or pushed them to *arid land*–not merely from the fertile agricultural and forest land but also from their own culture and tradition. Some tribes even had to adopt the Aryan culture by giving up their original traditions either fully or partially.[9] Bhils and Nagas of Madhya Pradesh, Khonds of Orissa, Bhuiny as of Bihar are some examples of this assimilation.[10] Tribes who did not like to be subdued migrated to adjacent places. They are commonly known as the Chotanagpur tribes.

Thus, the indigenous land narrative dates back to the original settlement in any locality. Due to the primitive nature of its narrative, the *dikus* left no stone unturned to manipulate and use them for their need and greed. While the indigenous narrative is weak, the messianic saving acts of people to safeguard their original intention have to be maintained as against bourgeoisie colonialist nature of the present '*dikus*.' The *present-day dikus* referred here are certain people with a fundamentalist or capitalist mindset, their institutions and associations, multinational companies, people of colonial mentality and certain political ideologies.

3. Colonial Mafia of the Past and the Present

3.1. Tribals as the Original Inhabitants

Originally, the Chotanagpur tribals were nomadic people. They lived on food foraging, hunting and occasionally clearing a patch of forest and cultivating food grains for a certain duration by unsophisticated technology.[11] As time went by, they began to establish themselves in perennial river banks. The tribals by their very nature have a community-oriented, egalitarian, tradition-based and ritualistic identity. A study of their oral narratives and culture would reveal the isolated nature of their settlement in the jungle area, accompanied by a backward economy, primitive technology, unstratified social structure and a system of governance under a chief.

With time, the Chotanagpur tribals settled and established themselves in the present region. Their presence and settlement in North-Western and Central India is much before the Aryans arrived. Thus, in every way, the tribals are the ādivāsi, *mool-nivasi* true to their name, the original inhabitants. By justice, settlement, care-taking of nature and ownership they are the custodians of the land, and by their divine law 'not to alienate it to aliens' is highly justified.

The British trade monopoly colonialized the country. For this they had to enslave the people of the place to acquire natural resources of which they were the protectors. Once they managed to win over the tribals by using 'divide and rule' and 'power' as tools, they began to exploit the resources by levying taxes through their appointed nodal and zonal collectors. These levy collectors acted as *zamindars* and later became landlords, by giving loans at heavy interest to the tribals. When they failed to repay, the *zamindars* confiscated their land and at times made them bonded labourers. Many had to leave their ancestral property and migrate to Assam and other distant places. Thus, the poor remained poor and exploiters became rich. Those who protested became the enemies of the powerful. It is here that J.B. Hoffmann and Constant Lievens became saviour figures of the tribals. Lievens studied law and helped them get back their lost land. He succeeded to a greater extent and earned the title, 'the Apostle of Chotanagpur.'

3.2 Outlook of the Outsiders

The Chotanagpur tribaldom and the land have been perceived by several people differently: as a fertile land for political gains, philanthropic research, evangelisation, Hinduisation, industrialisation, globalisation and other forms of economic growth. Based on their attitude to tribals and tribal land we can categorise the outsiders into three types.

3.2.1 Tribal Sympathisers

Tribal sympathisers manifest a patronizing attitude. They consider tribals and their culture a thing of the past, out-dated and anachronistic to the present age, and want them to get assimilated into the larger cultures and modern structures. The Hindu fundamentalists' belief is that the tribals are 'backward Hindus' and 'fallen Hindus' and therefore need to be completely assimilated into their fold.[12] At the time when cultural settlement wars were frequent, the winners either enslaved or eliminated the losers, or assimilated them into their fold. In British India the evangelists who worked with tribals neither forced them to change their religion nor alienated them from their ancestral land and culture, though the latter were encouraged to accept the new faith. Today under the banner of 'sympathiser,' saffronisation and sanskritisation is taking place.

Being a 'tribal' is not primitive or out-dated and anachronistic. Of course, tribals are poor economically and technically, but not poor in their culture, tradition, relation, moral values, equality and honesty. An apt example would be the domestic workers in many metropolitan cities. Those who dub them 'a thing of the past' are the very ones who use them *merely as means*.

3.2.2 Tribal Abettor

Tribal abettors see resources and cultures as a potential bait for self-gain. For them, building infrastructure and habitation, upgrading livelihood and connectivity are termed as development rather than human resources. In the name of rehabilitation, welfare, education etc., systematic detribalisation is taking place.

The *Momentum Jharkhand, the Global Business Summit-2017* is a living witness of this attitude. The *Indian Express* dated 18th February 2017, reported, "Momentum Jharkhand: State receives investment proposals worth 3 lakh crore. According to official figures, a total of 210 MoUs were signed with a total investment proposal of Rs 3,10,287 crore with at least nine departments."[13] The Chief Minister Raghubar Das said on the occasion, "The red carpet you are seeing now [referring to crores of rupees spent to shine the roads of Ranchi on this occasion] will remain spread forever. Twenty-four hours of the day the doors of my government are open for you... I have already sent them [Chinese manufacturing delegation] to identify land. In fact, I have asked two others also to identify land, which is not going to be a problem."[14] According to the report, on the very day 13 entities were allotted 136 acres of tribal land. Even the past government was no better. Tribals *have always been at the receiving end*.

It is not that the acquisition of land by the government has no positives. There is a principle of the greater good hidden in it. The resources available in Chotanagpur are enough to make India a global economic power or can at least list India among the most developed countries. Tribals are not against this. But the question frequently asked based on their experience is this: *development at whose cost, and of whom?* Can *the end justify the means* here? The word 'development' itself has become a frightening word. It is not that they do not want education, health care, clean roads, modern technology etc. In the name of displacement 2.40 crore people have lost their land, culture, language and livelihood and no one has been sufficiently compensated as yet. There is not a single proper success story or model of compensation for the displaced.[15] In Jharkhand no proper displacement, remuneration or assistance has been given to people who were evacuated from areas like the Chandil Dam site, the Jadugoda Uranium mines, other dam sites, coal belt in Dhanbad, iron ore sites of Noamundi owned by Tata Steel, and several other mining areas. Is this the development?

There is a hidden agenda behind every inch of development. One of the main reasons is a political gain. The major revenue for the previous Bihar government came from the present Jharkhand area. For political parties and the elite in Jharkhand the area is a fertile ground for investments. The second reason is the clamour for a Hindu nation for which the dissolution of tribals,

their culture and language is a must. This is very clear from the fact of not accepting Sarna as a religion, and not giving a *saran-code* for census.

For the tribals, the ancestral land is the whole universe[16]–the Promised Land–and when they are deprived of it they have nowhere to go (this is bondage). They have to fight back. But this is not the case with non-tribals whose world is where they live at present, because of their individualistic world-view. Outside their land tribals cannot survive except as a genetic inheritance.[17] Therefore, the struggle for existence takes prominence over development issues.

3.2.3 Tribal Defenders

Tribal defenders are the prophets of the kingdom who *uphold* their rights and traditions, *denounce* tribal sympathizers and abettors, and *announce* the well-being of minorities. The main reason for the emergence of tribal unrest was to safeguard and reclaim their land. The British revenue collectors and feudal lords mortgaged tribal land or sold it to non-tribals making the tribals landless and nomads for the second time.

When the atrocities against tribals were at their zenith some tribal leaders, supported by Christian missionaries, began to raise their voices against the exploiters. When the British army thwarted their attempt, certain movements emerged: Kol Rising (1832), Kherwar Movement of the Santhals (1871), Birsa Movement of the Mundas (1895), Tana Bhagat Movement of the Uraons (1914).[18] Mr. O'Malley writes about the causes of the Santhal revolt: "The prevalence of falsehood, the negligence of the *sahibs*, the extortion of the *mahajans*, the corruption of the *amla*, and the oppression of the police. All these grievances were due to… the presence of Bengali and other *dikku*, i.e. non-Santal immigrants, who had flocked in to carry on trade and money-lending among the Santhals."[19]

The story of extortion, land revenues and alienation of land to the *zamindars* in the Munda dominant area of Jharkhand brought about new revolution under the guidance of Birsa Munda. After the death of Birsa when the Munda agitation was taking a militant turn, the British under the guidance of Fr. John Baptist Hoffmann formulated laws to safeguard the land. These laws with the incorporation of the *Khuntkatti* system[20] of Munda land governance gave birth to the Chotanagpur Tenancy Act (CNT Act) which was eventually promulgated in 1908. Thus, Hoffmann became the *saviour* for the Chotanagpur tribe in safeguarding their land, and thus he became a master of suspicion for others. This Act safeguarded the remaining land not just of the Mundas, but the tribal land of the entire Chotanapgur from further alienation, till today. Following the CNT Act, a similar Act was drawn in the Santhal region, called the Santhal Pargana Act (SPT Act) in 1938.

3.2.4 CNT/SPT Acts as the Masters of Suspicion

The CNT Act prohibits transfer of tribal land to non-tribals, ensuring community ownership. The Act not only upholds the Mundari *Khuntkatti* system which restricted the transfer of tribal land to non-tribals, but also records several customary community rights over natural resources such as *jal-jangal-jameen* (water-forest-land), forest produce and its use.

However, in post-independent India, the CNT Act is not implemented in letter and spirit. The fear of the ruling elite is that this Act is a stumbling block to the economic development of the State. Several political parties have tried to amend it to suit their 'development-ism'. In 1996, the Bihar government amended Section 49 of CNT Act permitting the transfer of lands belonging to Scheduled Tribe tenants for the purpose of *industry and mining only*. The present Jharkhand government has amended and passed the said section in the assembly (and has sent it for the Governor's approval), allowing *transfer of tribal land for any public purpose such as road, canal, railway, cable transmission, water pipeline, school, colleges, university, Panchayat building, hospital, anganwadi etc., or any other activity which the State Government may add by way of notifications in the Official Gazette*. This amendment is extremely dangerous as it literally lifts restrictions on transfer of tribal land as laid down in Section 46, 47 and 48 of the Act. It would open the floodgates for non-tribals to buy tribal land which would lead to massive land alienation. The government of Bihar, while amending the Act in 1996, had in its wisdom removed all purposes except industry and mining. But the present Jharkhand Government wants to acquire land *for all purposes*. The amendment will adversely affect the present PESA Act-1996 (*The Panchayats Extension to Scheduled Areas Act*, a constitutional provision given to the traditional Gram Sabhas for self-governance), Right to Fair Compensation and Transparency in Land Acquisition, Rehabilitation and Resettlement Act 2013, Forest Act 2006 etc.[21]

The present Jharkhand government wants to amend the CNT Act to suit investors. The Prime Minister's 'development' agenda sees Jharkhand as backward and in need of development. The government thus amended the State's two important and longstanding Tenancy Acts, on Wednesday, November 23, 2016[22] and sent them to the Governor for approval. But thanks to several pro-tribal movements, the amendments were withdrawn by the same government after a year-long uprising.

4. A-significance of Tribal Land

4.1 Indigenous Identity and Reality

Two decrying aspects of the indigenous situation in India are the absence of real impermeable demarcation of tribal identity and the present existential

tribal reality. Even the Constitution of India does not sufficiently define the identity of tribals. At the most, it places them in the 'Scheduled' category. 'Scheduled' would imply a group of people named under a particular Section of the Constitution. On the other hand, sociologically, the word 'tribe,' 'tribal,' 'indigenous' have become metaphors for the most victimised sections of our society. When the identity of a group is itself not recognized, it remains either forgotten or disappears from the main stream. Several fundamentalist groups have been attempting to anoint these people as part of their fold, so as to totally wipe out the tribal group and their identity.

4.2 Evolution as Conquering the World

Growth and progress or evolution is the law of nature. Tribal culture too has undergone change from primitive to modernity over a period of time like any other cultures. Growth in the past two centuries was 'anthropocentric,' at the cost of material prosperity while the present trend is towards reclaiming the lost glory of material prosperity at the cost of human beings. The obvious effect is a change in the emphasis–from human values to human power. Power reshapes the material world. Therefore, from the modern narrative, one can infer the reality as 'conquering the world.'

If this trend continues at the present rate, undoubtedly, sooner or later tribal culture will become a part of history. In Nagaland, a 'Heritage Hill' has been erected to educate people that such cultures existed once upon a time. We are not saying that they should have been allowed to live as they were. That would be contrary to a progressive vision and amount to a 'stagnant growth'. The Platonic world-view is inappropriate to the post-modern era, and at the same time constructive elements of it cannot be given up. A system which was ideal a century ago need not be the best today. A creative way of thinking and adaptation is the need of the hour.[23] A person who is closed to the inherent goodness and beauty of a particular culture will only try to enslave and sanskritise it.

In the light of modern understanding and historical knowledge, it is wise to adopt a new way of life in line with ancient traditions. Just being proud of one's culture and tradition, and stubbornly adhering to it is not enough. Passivity or keeping the *status quo* will only keep the tribals stagnant without making any progress. Therefore, tribals should creatively respond to the changing times and assert their existence and worth.

4.3 Phenomenon of Closure

The quest for acquisition is leading to a *phenomenon of closure*. The *phenomenon of closure* is both in terms of freedom and cognition in the modern discourse. When the mind is full of negativities what emerges from it is only negativity. Such people can neither think of the freedom of the other nor of

any real developmental issues. Only a defect-free cognitive faculty can bring out a defect-free insight. The present quest of the frightened fundamentalist religion is to acquire land assigned to the vulnerable indigenous people in the Fifth and the Sixth Scheduled areas of the country for selfish gains. The constitutional provisions and CNT/SPT acts are so powerful that it is not easy to find loopholes and make tribals landless. Therefore, there is an attempt to follow the colonial pathway to break these laws: 'curtail the free movement' and 'divide and rule' and make the victims vulnerable to such an extent that they will have no other way but to accept the supremacy and way of life of the oppressor.

The phenomenon of closure by the oppressors not only closes real freedom and rationality, but also closes doors which allow the fresh air of freedom and insights to enter in. Thus, land acquisition and the eventual sanskritisation (which is already taking place) will gradually eliminate tribal culture and values.

4.4 Land Unification as De-unification

The European and South American countries colonized most of the world. The MNCs investing in mineral rich places in the country are no less opportunists than those colonialists and many other people and organizations.

Indigenous people are peace-loving, communitarian people who value unity and accommodation very much. Thanks to the encounter with modernity they are better equipped in technology today. But what is going unnoticed, hidden under the so-called progress, is the systematic estrangement the tribals feel. Land unites and de-landing separates. In the process of making India a 'country,' the very inception of the idea itself, is fragmented into unequal segments. The unification of the unequal segments is supposedly meant to bring better production and validation. But, it has proved to be otherwise. The division of States along language lines seems to be an utter failure. *One land, One nation, One language* and *One culture* is neither the philosophy of India nor the tradition of Jharkhand. '*Variety is the spice of life'* is the strength of this country.

The One Land–One Culture benefiting the rich Indian culture is only a myth. Indian culture is not only a 'Hindu culture' or just a 'tribal culture,' but a sum total of all the cultures. Every culture has its own uniqueness and within them there are sub-cultures with their own salient features. A totality of these make Indian culture. This is very much true with the indigenous people. Both Hinduism and the tribals as two prominent segments can never be unified or put in one mould due to several socio-cultural diversities. It may not be the right thing to do so either. One of the prominent reasons is that Hinduism, as understood today,[24] cannot remain intact without caste system. On the other hand there is no caste system among tribals. If tribals are assimilated into

the Hindu-fold, they have to be under the *varnashrama dharma* which tribals cannot accept. Therefore, assimilation and, at the same time, retaining their originality can take place only in that religion which can accommodate their culture and tradition.

4.5 The Fear of Losing One's Identity Vis-À-Vis Fear of the Inability to Assert One's Authority

For the indigenous people losing land is akin to losing their identity. On the one hand there is a fear of losing one's identity and on the other there is a fear of not being able to assert one's authority. What comes out of this is the fear of existence. Fear of existence is a reaction to the existence of the other, who poses an imagined or real threat to the one who is frightened. The resultant reaction can move in two directions: it can either challenge the other or integrate the other. When challenged the end result is devastating; when accommodated fear changes into love, joy and peace. In either case there is a loss in the original content, but this loss can be somehow compromised if the basic belief systems, identity, culture and tradition are retained in the creed they are assimilated into.

One can understand the plight of the indigenous people. It is a question of their survival and therefore, they are not hesitant to go to any extent to protect the land. But, what is Hinduism, the powerful, established and majority religion of the country afraid of? Is it the absence of the power to lord over, or is the purpose to have a holistic development, or has it got some other agenda? A very simple reason could be *the fear of its existence*.[25] This fear is not of the tribals, but of the other minorities of the country–Christians and Muslims.

The threat to Hinduism is from three sides: i) Materialism and agnosticism of the postmodern time leading to declining religiosity and numbers, ii) Growing world-wide population of other faiths and their strength creating uncertainty, iii) Literacy revolution brought about by Christian minorities (Christians are under 2.3% in India) which is creating social awareness and a great difference in society.[26]

To cope with the fear of asserting one's identity and authority, the ruling elite is trying to silence the voices of the common man: by ignoring the weak and diverting attention. As long as the oppressed people's movements, voices and struggles are weak and imperceptible, the frightened elite will tend to ignore them. At times they give an impression that nothing wrong has happened and everything is normal.

If this does not work, then they opt for the second option–*silencing the oppressed*. The main target group are the leaders of the oppressed. Often, the demand for justice is brought to the fore by charismatic leaders. The elite will stifle the movement by neutralizing the leadership by hook or crook. They allure them with money, power and position. If this plan fails the next step is

physical elimination. This is followed by silencing the potential leaders of the group, if needed.

In case of failure of both the plans mentioned above, the third trick is the *diversion of attention*. Human memory is often short-term. However brutal an incident might be, it is forgotten or at least bears less significance over a period of time. The frightened class, when it senses a mass movement, opts for a radical movement: on well-thought out diversions and distractions that dilute the original thrust of the mass movement and struggle. They effectively bring out 'development-ism,' 'regional autonomy,' 'constitutionality,' 'amendments' and 'law and order' weapons to divert issues.

However, a genuine well-being will have no opposition whatsoever whatever the situation may be; or at least it will survive all the odds posed against it. Somehow the beneficiaries will perceive the goodness with which the government wants to implement. But today, most of the welfare schemes of the government, however excellent, are not reaching the people because of the motive with which they are prepared and implemented. Viewed from this, the tribal unrest and fight for their land, is justified.

5. Conclusion: A March towards a New Horizon

There are many reasons for the lack of development in the tribal plateau: absence of a stable and morally upright power to govern, draconian state-laws, politicisation of socio-religious identity, inability to accommodate cultures other than their own, no definite time-bound programme, corruption, lack of knowledge of culture and tradition of the people, and the geographical setup. To a larger extent law is also culpable: there is a contradiction between norms and actual practices. Mostly, the present law makers are a handful of people from the majority religion (Hinduism) and at times deliberately chosen to disclose certain agendas. They are unaware of the ethos and traditions of the tribals. Therefore, their outlook tends to be biased. There is a clear reversal of the colonialism of the past in the present situation. During the colonial past, the 'outsiders' ruled with a sympathetic look. Today, in modern colonialism the 'insiders' have become 'outsiders,' and are ruling with an enslaving outlook.

One of the preconditions for transformation is placing *what* is to be transformed at the centre, and the *how* and *where* of transformation at the periphery.[27] One needs to have a genuine sympathy and openness for change. Development must be specific, measurable, time-bound and realistic. Genuine integration safeguards every culture, tradition, ethnicity, identity, class and structure. Democracy and Constitutional Rights are well protected in a genuinely integrated system. The democratically elected government has no moral right to impose something on a section of society under the guise of bringing it into the mainstream culture.

The present task for the tribals is to re-establish themselves as the 'Chosen People' like the Israelites in the Old Testament who once had a glorious origin (life in the Garden of Eden). This was hampered by invasions, deportations, enslavement, sanskrtisation, destruction (sin and captivity). Later, there was a messianic intervention and salvific hope. They were reunited and rejuvenated with the required armours to protect their original glory by means of law, education, awareness, self-esteem and assertion of their existence. Giving up one's own culture and tradition is equal to surrendering oneself into the hands of the '*dikus*.' Therefore, tribals wherever they are, should hold on to their language, culture, ethnicity and values which will be the real weapons to combat the forces of evil.

Notes

1 Cf. Cambridge Dictionary, s.v. "Land." Also, Oxford English Dictionary. See, <http://dictionary.cambridge.org/dictionary/english/land>; <https://en.oxforddictionaries.com/definition/land> (20 March, 2018).
2 Merriam-Webster Dictionary, s.v. "Land," <https://www.merriam-webster.com/dictionary/land> (20 March, 2018).
3 Macmillan Dictionary, <http://www.macmillandictionary.com/dictionary/british/land_1> (20 March 2018).
4 The word commonly used to refer to the exploiter or a foreigner is '*diku'* in Santhal / Munda / Ho languages. In its extended meaning, it refers to anyone who exploits tribals in any manner.
5 The pattern of the creation myth is similar in all the Chotanagpur tribal myths.
6 The 'original inhabitants' means the original settlers of the place. See, Narmadeshwar Prasad, *Land and People of Tribal Bihar* (Ranchi: Bihar Tribal Research Institute, Governent of Bihar, 1961), 7.
7 The present administrative structure is just opposite to this. See, Gnanam Prakasham, "Tribals and Their Rights to Livelihood: Tribal Right to Land in Madhya Pradesh," in *Tribal Issues in India*, ed. D.C. Sah and Yatindra Singh Sisodia (Jaipur, New Delhi: Rawat Publications, 2004).
8 Cf. S.C. Roy, *Oraon Religion and Culture* (Delhi: Gyan Books Publishers, 1928).
9 Narmadeshwar Prasad, *Land and People of Tribal Bihar*, 6-7.
10 For example, in Madhya Pradesh Kols and Gonds are considered tribes where as in Uttar Pradesh they are included under Hinduism.
11 Narmadeshwar Prasad, *Land and People of Tribal Bihar*, 8.
12 Narmadeshwar Prasad, *Land and People of Tribal Bihar*, 7. Shahana Munazir, "Divisive Integration," *Indian Express*, Pune Edition, September 25, 2017, 11.
13 Prashant Pandey, "Momentum Jharkhand: State receives investment proposals worth 3 lakh crore," *Indian Express,* Ranchi Edition, February 18, 2017, http://indianexpress.com/article/business/business-others/momentum-jharkhand-state-receives-investment-proposals-worth-3-lakh-crore-4530751/, accessed on 25 March 2017. For the official website of Momentum Jharkhand see, <http://momentumjharkhand.com/> (25 March, 2017).
14 *Ibid*.
15 Similar incidents are found in other states also. See, Smriti Kak Ramachandran, "Tribals displaced by Rourkela steel plant: ST panel calls top Odishababus," *Hindustan Times*, April 30, 2017<http://www.hindustantimes.com/india-news/tribals-displaced-by-rourkela-steel-plant-st-panel-calls-top-odisha-babus/story-yMZebvMKBm4ImkjsBDlPoN.html> (15 May, 2017).
16 This is the reason when they die the body is taken to their ancestral land where they are born and buried along with their ancestors.
17 The tribal titles represent the clan and tribe they belong to. Every title can be referred back to their original parents and the things whose custodians they are. For example, Ekka is an Oraon title which means 'tortoise.' These people are the protectors of a particular kind of tortoises. Kacchap is another title which also means tortoise, but a different kind of it. Therefore, what is meant by the word 'genetic inheritance' is that they will be remembered only for what they once belonged to and whose protectors they are.
18 For detailed history of tribal movements see, Philip Ekka, *Tribal Movements: A Study in Social Change* (Jashpur: Tribal Research and Documentation Centre, 2003). Also see, Kamal K. Mishra and G. Jayaprakashan, ed. *Tribal Movements in India: Visions of Dr. K.S. Singh* (New Delhi, Bhopal: Manohar Publications, Indira Gandhi Rashtriya Manav Sangrahalaya, 2012).
19 L.S.S. O'Malley, "Santal Paraganas," *Bengal District Gazetteers* (1900): 45-48.
20 *Khuntkatti* is a Munda term referring to a system of governance where the land belonging to a Munda family is acquired by the descendant of the same family. It cannot be sold to anyone else, not even to other tribes.
21 Smriti Kak Ramachandran, "Tribals displaced by Rourkela steel plant: ST panel calls top Odishababus",*Hindustan Times*, April 30, 2017 <http://www.hindustantimes.com/india-news/tribals-displaced-by-rourkela-steel-plant-st-panel-calls-top-odisha-babus/story-yMZebvMKBm4ImkjsBDlPoN.html> (15 May, 2017).
22 For the First Citizen of the state, the amendment of the Act is a "historic and unprecedented" step for development. But the same Governor on 25th of June 2017 declined to sign the amendment, giving a hard blow to the ruling government due to the mass protest throughout Jharkhand and Tribal dominant states of the country. P.A. Chacko, "CNT and SPT Amendment Bill-2006," *Indian Currents,* XXVIII, no.49 (5 December, 2016), <http://www.indiancurrents.org/cnt-and-spt-amendment-bill2016-1444.php> (5 September, 2017).
23 Suresh Sharma, *Tribal Identity and the Modern World* (New York, New Delhi: United Nations University Press, Sage Publications, 1994), 12.
24 There wasn't a strict 'caste system' during the Vedic times. If the present Hinduism accepts the Vedic Hinduism, then there is a possibility of assimilation, which the present Hinduism will not agree. The Vedic Hinduism is an accommodative culture, without any dogmas and heresies. Therefore, Buddhism, Jainism, Christianity and Islam flourished over the centuries. Now, making Hinduism as 'the culture' of India is against the very nature of Vedic Hinduism.
25 Raju Felix Crasta, "Fear of Existence as the Suppression of Integration," *velivada.com,*<http://velivada.com/2017/05/17/fear-existence-suppression-integration/> (28 June, 2017).
26 If at all some social revolution has happened, it is because of the 2% think-tanks the Christians' value education system has produced. It is this 2% who bring change in the society. Therefore, if the indigenous people are uniting and asserting their rights, it is because of the Christians. It is because of this, the Hindus are frightened. This is another reason Christians and their institutions are under threat throughout the country.
27 Narmadeshwar Prasad, *Land and People of Tribal Bihar*, 85.

12

Alternative Interpretations of the *Ramayana*

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Abstract: The *Ramayana* is a text that opens itself up to several interpretations, both within the text as well as in the several "tellings" of this relatively straightforward narrative. This paper returns to the living tradition of the *Ramayana* which has always been one of a hermeneutics of suspicion. It explores three strategies deployed by interpreters of this text – A) as critic, highlighting the counter-narratives within the text, B) as author, by scripting a counter-narrative, C) as *bhakt*, in a hermeneutics of trust. Contesting assumptions made in conventional interpretations of the Ramayana, this paper examines the evidences that present a reading against the grain, in an attitude of suspicion.

Introduction

A hermeneutics of suspicion, like the *tandava*, is an open-ended de-constructive act, enabling a reversal of the established order. It is the middle path between the subjective and the objective, faith and reason, the open and the closed, the realms of art and of science. The French philosopher, Paul Ricoeur, explains this dynamic as follows, "Hermeneutics seems to me to be animated by this double motivation: willingness to suspect, willingness to listen; vow of rigor, vow of obedience."[1] He invites a creative dynamic between appropriation and distanciation, between a close, involved experience of the text and a distanced, disenchanted analysis. This attitude of critical openness to the text

allows for us to go beyond surface meanings and appearances, to attempt a demystification that enables an unmasking of the text. In search of the true message of the text one must challenge the conventional and the familiar which fixate us in a homogeneous viewing of the world of the text and of our own; which maintains the status quo in favour of the privileged minority. A critique of suspicion, also reveals the creative possibilities "in front of" the text.[2] However, even these possibilities, precisely because they are coloured by the reader's own worldview and pre-understandings, must themselves be looked upon with suspicion. Ricoeur writes: "A tradition remains living, however, only if it continues to be held in an unbroken process of reinterpretation."[3] This has been the tradition of the *Ramayana*.

Yet, we have had to bear witness to the ravages of claims to absolute, final truths in the *Ramayana*, which close the doors on sanity and creativity. These 'truths,' arrived at in the absence of distanciation, birth a paralyzed telling that acts as a tool for political ends. The stench of its still-birth, dissuades from a creative, living, personal engagement. Ricoeur's theory of interpretation celebrates the interrelationship between interpretation and the interpreter, recovering it from sole authoritative truths.

In an attitude of suspicion, we will use the tradition of the *Ramayana* to challenge conventional, hegemonic and claims of only one true version. This paper returns to the living tradition of the *Ramayana* which has always been one of a hermeneutics of suspicion.

I. The *Ramayana:* A Living Tradition

Unlike the *Mahabharata*, with its complex interwoven stories, the *Ramayana* is a simple tale of Prince Rama and Princess Sita, their love and losses. The *Ramayana* is looked upon as a beacon of Indian values, showing us the enactment of an ideal that we can emulate. Thus, India inherits Valmiki's *Ramayana*, an ancient myth that becomes a national epic. "Even Occidental scholars agree that no work of world literature secular [but not separated from the sacred] in its origin has ever exerted so profound an influence on the life and thought of a people as the *Valmiki-Ramayana*."[4] It is a living tradition, a familiar story that we all claim to remember and know. In the perpetual act of constructing the Ramayana, we are constructed by it. There have always been regular recitations, annual religious performances to which are added, calendars, comic books, films, television serials and graphic novels. Its sheer reach and influence demonstrates that, "the epic's significance as a morality play would seem to outweigh that of philosophical systems like Sankara's *Advaita Vedanta* which are read by and taught through only a proportionately small elite."[5] *Ramcharitmanas* of Tulasidas enjoys even more popularity since it allowed for a shift from a Sanskrit to a Hindi telling. Morality is imparted through poetry, story-telling and performance in the figure of a *maryada-purusottama* – Rama. This ideal man, an embodiment of virtue is perceived as worthy of worship and emulation.

Prior to Valmiki the *Ramayana* had existed as an oral tradition for a long time, which itself allowed for multiplicity and changes in narration. Over the centuries, with the passage of time the Valmiki *Ramayana* saw modifications, additions, interpolations and colourings which reflected the culture of the region in which it was recited. Sharma illustrates the stages of development: "the *Ramayana* of Valmiki originally consisted of 6000 verses which were raised to 12000 verses and finally to 24000."[6] Moreover, even after being contained in a written text in the form of Valmiki's recording of the *Ramayana*, "the earliest and most prestigious" telling of the legend, A. K. Ramanujan points out that it is far from being the only telling of this narrative.[7] He has demonstrated, there isn't even a single, authoritative *Ramayana*. He tells us that he has, "come to prefer the world *tellings* to the usual terms *versions* or *variants* because the latter terms can and typically do imply that there is an invariant, an original or *Ur*-text usually Valmiki's Sanskrit *Ramayana*."[8]

Several tellings of the epic exist, not only in India, but across all of Asia. According to Desai, the retellings of *Ramayana* in the rest of Asia, are "diverse in content and quality" and "can be grouped as having two main categories of constituent elements: those derived from the Valmiki version and those from non-Valmiki sources."[9] With the dispersal of the narrative, particularly to other parts of Asia, texts emerge that can not only be read through a non-religious lens, but were also written as literary texts not religious ones. According to Desai:

> In many countries, the story has been given a local setting; the Indian names are used for important towns, sites, mountains, rivers, and lakes. The characters and the episodes are nationalized in the borrowing countries, identification of their origin being effaced. This is true for Java, Malaya, Vietnam, Cambodia, Laos, and Thailand. In China and Tibet alone, the story remains identified with India.[10]

Thus, the living tradition of the *Ramayana* is one of diversity, taking on the colouring of the people and place in which it is told.

II. A Hermeneutics of Suspicion Approach to the *Ramayana*

The Ramayana's narration, worldviews and implications have always been in flux. There has always been questioning of its 'meaning', a probing beneath the surface, a telling within a telling, which has always invited an unveiling and unmasking. The *Ramayana* is not only a canonical Hindu scripture, but it has also been described as *Mahakavya* (Great composition) and *Itihasa* (arguably translated as History). These epithets open the epic up to several

levels of reading – as a narrative devoid of any religious associations, as a text that uses it's narrative to convey religious doctrine and principles, and a literal reading that assumes every fact mentioned in the narrative to be true.

The *Rãmãyana*, in its appeal to the religious and the aesthetic, having captured the imagination and devotion of a people, can be twisted to serve different ends. Conservative Hindu nationalists, have simplified an open-ended narrative and staked claim to knowledge of the core nature of the *Ramayana*. Their hegemonic reading enforces a worldview that attempts to revive the golden age of Hinduism. Other hegemonic readings "such as Sagar's nationalist televised version, however, which ironically emphasizes an 'authentic' version of the epic, have exercised a dangerous and unprecedented authority to fix the story's meaning in harmful ways."[11]It is these readings of the *Ramayana* that have come to dominate the cultural consciousness and collective unconsciousness of India. The story we are most likely to hear, the one we come to believe as the true and only telling, is the distortion of this beloved tale into a grotesque monstrosity. However, the *Ramayana* tradition has always been one of a hermeneutics of suspicion. Implicitly and explicitly this tradition has challenged conventionally accepted readings and ideals of the *Ramayana*.

This paper identifies three ways of responding to inherent contradictions which are at odds with the text's apparent meaning–A) as critic, highlighting the counter-narratives within the text, or B) as author, by scripting a counter-narrative, or C) as *bhakt*, in a hermeneutics of trust.

A) As Critic: Counter-narratives within the Text

a) Rama as an Avatar of Vishnu?

As the embodiment of the values of the ideal man, Rama becomes a beacon for the common man to emulate. The *Ramayana's* success, which lies in "the prestige and *even divinization of the hero*," are rooted in "powerful fantasies" that are "central to the formation of the Indian personality, family and society."[12] However, scholars like Jacobi have asserted that the character of Rama as depicted in the second to fifth book of the epic is as human; and the transformation of the character from a heroic prince to a living incarnation of God took considerable time.[13] This is an important aspect, "since in the centuries after Valmiki his divinity is portrayed and believed in an increasingly literal fashion."[14]

In the first and last books (*Bala Kanda* and *Uttara Kanda*), believed to be later additions, he is described as god. A number of Western scholars have held "the suspicion...that those portions of the epic explicitly positing Rāma's status as an incarnation of Visṇu were deliberate, and unassimilable, sectarian interpolations."[15] It was only in the first century BCE that Rama began to be

associated with Vishnu, a phenomenon attributed to the growing popularity of the Vaishnava cult in India.[16] Rama as "thoroughly human and indeed liable to moral lapses" is "carefully explained away."[17] His depiction shifts from that of an extraordinary mortal to a divine being, come to destroy evil and preserve the world order. In the ninth and sixteenth century tellings of Kampan and Tulasidas: "Rama deserves worship and unqualified moral emulation."[18] Both Rama and Sita, "are divinized, especially in versions composed after the devotional or *bhakti* revival and the version of Tulasidas."[19]

b) The *Ramayana* as a Brahmanical Text?

Sometimes, in religious scripture, when contradictions arise they become "the source of religious mystery and the object of theological reflection."[20] As a text, the *Ramayana* opens itself to several readings. On the vital issue of caste it appears ambivalent at best and on occasion outright contradictory.

When in the forest, Rama kills to protect the sages, Sita presents the argument that "war will become Rama's moral (caste) duty only after he clearly resumes the duties of the warrior *varna* or class. For the present, as a forest ascetic, his obligation is to avoid violence."[21] This argument illustrates that mobility within the caste-system, a rigid hierarchical social structure, is possible.

In the *Uttara Kanda*, of the *Valmiki-Ramayana* there is the tale of Sambuka, a *shudra* who is beheaded by Rama for practicing austerities reserved for the upper *varnas*. However, as discussed earlier, the *Uttara Kanda* was not a part of the original *Valmiki –Ramayana*. Additionally, Valmiki, himself a lowborn robber, was not beheaded for performing rituals and teaching Rama's sons, instead Rama transforms him into a sage.

Similarly, the *Ramcharitmanas* by Tulsidas reveals contradictions in Rama's attitude towards caste. A conventional reading of the *Ramcharitmanas* would see it as a text upholding the Brahmanical order as seen in the famous lines: "A drum, a peasant, a Shudra, an animal, a woman – all these are fit to be beaten."[22] As Linda Hess points out, some interpretations of the text may see restoration of this order as the very purpose of the avatar:

> Ram was born on earth…for the sake of Brahmans, gods and cows. There are numerous admonitions about the importance of devotion to Brahmans and the evil that attaches to a person, place or age that is characterized by improper treatment of Brahmans.[23]

However, the text also contains the episode of Rama's interaction with Shabari, a tribal woman hermit and devotee, which acts as a counter-narrative. The manner in which Rama singles out this devotee amongst other ascetics in the forest to visit and his emphasis on *bhakti* (devotion) over other attributes, including caste when he addresses her, directly challenges such a reading.[24]

c) *Ramrajya* - the Ideal State?

Along with the mythological and religious, there is the political. In popular imagination, Rama is seen as the ideal king and Ayodhya as an ideal state in a Golden Age. As demonstrated in the *Ramayana*, Rama is submissive to the demands of his father and people, and his brothers are loyal to him. Although, causing sorrow and death Rama holds his duty to his father's promise over his duties as ruler and spouse. This sense of bounded duty to *dharma* is what dictates Rama's actions throughout the epic. He is tied to a duty that is "personal, social and political and depends on one's caste and familial roles."[25]

The *Ramayana* is not only a narrative that describes events in the life of Rama, but can also be read as a treatise on governance with the belief that *Ramrajya* as described in the epic is the prescription for an ideal state. However, here too it is possible to interpret the text in ways that challenge this reading. As Arshia Sattar points out, Valmiki's *Ramayana* describes not one, but three different states, "each located in and defined by a city: Ayodhya, Kishkindha and Lanka," corresponding to the three kinds of beings described in the text – humans, monkeys, and *Rakshasas* (demons).[26] Furthermore, "each of these cities reflects the nature of the beings that inhabit it" and in the description of the way of life in these three cities the *Ramayana* "also explores multiple dharmas."[27] In Sattar's analysis, there is a fourth world – the forest, "an indeterminate space where multiple dharmas can coexist."[28]

The differences between the codes of conduct followed in these three realms are applicable but not limited to relations between the sexes and the role of women in each of these cities. In Ayodhya, which is characterized by order, "women are chaste and submissive and stay well within their conjugal boundaries."[29] The norms of Kishkindha allow for the transfer of wives among brothers and also greater freedom for women as demonstrated by the counsellor role played by Tara to both Sugriva and Vali.[30] Lanka appears to give the greatest sexual freedom to its women to the extent that each of the women in Ravana's inner apartments "had come to Ravana out of love. None had been carried away against her will; they had all been won over by Ravana's personality."[31] Not only is the issue of consent essential among *Rakshasa* as evidenced in Ravana's conduct towards Sita, *Rakshasa* women also exercise more control over their sexuality.

This is evident in a crucial episode in the *Ramayana* – the mutilation of Shurpanakha, arguably the incident that causes the entire conflict in the *Yudha Kanda,* the sixth book of the epic. According to Sattar: "As a *Rakshasi*, Shurpanakha has the right to proposition men that she finds attractive, which she does when she sees Rama and Lakshmana."[32] Rama and Lakshmana, who are unfamiliar with any code of conduct other than the one followed at Ayodhya, react to what they think is licentious behaviour with an act of violence that precipitates a chain of events eventually leading to war. Thus, the imposition of Ayodha's ideals in the forest – a space that lies beyond the territory of the state – becomes the first act of war. The abduction of Sita and the war with Lanka – none of it would have been necessary if Rama and Lakshmana had acknowledged that there are other ways of living.

While conventional readings of the *Ramayana* have described *Ramrajya* as ideal governance and Ayodhya as the ideal state, the same text can also be used to question whether the universal application of these principles is warranted. All three cities – Ayodhya, Kishkindha, and Lanka are prosperous metropolises, administered according to their own code of conduct, until their way of life is disrupted by the arrival of Rama and his *dharma*.

B) As Author: Scripting a Counter-narrative

As Ramanujan has pointed out, Valmiki's recording of the *Ramayana* is far from being the only telling of the legend. Jaiswal has classified the ancient Indian narratives of the Rama legend into at least three tellings – "the Brahmanical, the Buddhist, and the Jain."[33] She points out that while Valmiki succeeded in giving the Brahmanical telling a concrete form, "divergent versions" may be found in the Buddhist and the Jain texts.[34] There is also the "Jain *Ramayana* of Vimalasuri, called *Paumacariya* (Prakrit for the Sanskrit *Padmacarita*)," which, "knows its Valmiki and proceeds to correct its errors and Hindu extravagances. Like other Jain *puranas*, this too is *pratipurana*, an anti-or counter *purana*."[35]

These tellings include alternative relationships amongst principal characters, places and episodes not found in Valmiki's text. For instance, in the *Dasharatha Jataka*, the earliest Buddhist documentation of the Rama legend, Sita is both sister and wife to Rama, and Dasharath is the king of Varanasi not Ayodhya.[36] A similar incestuous motif is carried forward in Jain texts like the *Vasudevahindi* of Sanghadasa and the *Uttara Purana* of Gunabhadra where Sita is described as the daughter of Ravana and Mandodari.[37]

These changes to the narrative have implications that correspond to the values extolled in these religions. Thus, in many of the Jain *Ramayanas*, the act of killing Ravana is performed by Lakshman and not Rama, who is "a non-violent follower of the teachings of Mahavira Jain."[38] It is important to note, however, that they are texts with religious associations. Rama in the Buddhist texts is a *Bodhisattva* and in the Jain tradition a *Salakapurusa*, one of 63 illustrious persons.

Kampan's Tamil *Iramavataram's* questioning of the ethics of Rama's killing of Vali goes further than Valmiki with even Lakshman raising doubts about his elder brother's decision to collude with Sugriva in this fraternal feud.[39] These tellings of the *Ramayana* do not question the divinity of Rama

but have by way of changes and alterations to Valmiki's text found other ways to question the actions of the protagonist of their narrative.

C) As *Bhakt*: A Hermeneutics of Trust

According to Felski, Ricoeur distinguishes between 'hermeneutics of trust' and 'hermeneutics of suspicion,' the former being "driven by a sense of reverence and goes deeper into the text in search of revelation."[40] While the 'hermeneutics of suspicion' approach to reading the *Ramayana* has always existed, simultaneously an interpretive tradition whose "primary concern" is to present the text as "a basically unitary and internally consistent narrative of real events" has also continued.[41] Felski states that the difference between these approaches is the difference between unveiling and unmasking.[42] The hermeneutics of trust, is a search for truth, a re-thinking and questioning of narratives in which faith is led by reason.

The several commentaries on Valmiki's *Ramayana* that were written from the 15th to 17th century serve as an example. Sastri has documented "as many as ten commentaries of outstanding merit" produced in this period.[43] These commentators find explanations for apparent inconsistencies in the text, delineate the relative chronology for events described in it, and repudiate passages that seem too fantastic. For instance, the incident during Hanuman's flight to Lanka where he encounters the giant serpent Surasa and swells to a gigantic size and then outwits her by abruptly shrinking in size has been dismissed by two commentators as later interpolations into Valmiki's original text.[44]

Another such tradition, documented by Hess, is that of commentaries of the *Ramcharitmanas* "that selectively questions the text to bring out what is troubling, perplexing, intriguing to its primary audiences."[45] Collections of doubts raised by devotees and answers provided to them were published in *Shankavalis* (literally, 'Garland of Doubts') authored by specialists on the text. It is important to note that the assumption is that the question is being posed by a *premi* (lover) of the *Ramcharitmanas*, whose faith is undisputable. Highlighting the difference in the attitudes of the posers of these questions, Hess states: "Scholars have problems, lovers have doubts."[46] She also points out that within this tradition of suspicion, "there is a limit to acceptable doubt: One must affirm the ultimate importance of faith in and love for Ram, a personal God experienced through these forms."[47]

III. The Return to the Secular

As illustrated earlier, the *Ramayana* which began as a secular text, took on a religious colouring. Yet, in some tellings and appropriations, it returns to the secular. The continuing process of adaptation to local contexts eventually led to tellings of the Rama legend being treated as secular texts. Java under the influence of Islam evolved the character of Sita as "a popular Javanese princess, the chaste and loyal wife of an exemplary ruler, Seri Rama — a secular hero and heroine."[48] In this telling, Rama and Sita lose all divine associations and are instead revered as ancestors of Javanese Kings.[49]

A similar secular rendition of the *Ramayana* can be found in Thailand where King Rama I, the founder of the Chakri dynasty presently in power, wrote a Thai version of the epic at the turn of the 18th century. This telling focuses on the episodes relating to the abduction of Sita and the war described in the *Yuddha Kanda* over other parts of the epic.[50] As Desai explains: "The Ramakirti, unlike the Valmiki *Ramayana*, is not treated by the Thai as a sacred religious book…The Ramakirti to the Thai is a noble and heroic literature which imparts aesthetic enjoyment and provides epic themes for painting, dance, and drama."[51]

Closer home, there is the example of the Mappila *Ramayana* in Kerala – a collection of folk songs on the theme of the *Ramayana* rendered in Arabic-laced Malayalam. The local oral tradition of the Malabari Muslims or Mappilas has suffered from poor documentation and at present only fragments containing certain episodes remain, but this Islamic *Ramayana* that weaves in discussions about Shariya Law into the epic is further proof of how the legend survives even when it has lost the religious associations ascribed to Valmiki's telling.[52]

Even as questions remain about the religious origins of the *Valmiki - Ramayana*, it is quite clear that translations and alternative tellings have evolved that no longer depend on its religious appeal and instead have only celebrated the aesthetics of its narrative.

IV. The World in Front of the Text

In stepping into the *other* world of the text which is at a distance from our everyday world, one is distanced from oneself, and in the process one's own horizons of thought expand and the lens through which one sees the world gains a new colouring, coming full circle to a return to oneself, enriching one's own being-in-the-world. The reader, in exposing herself to the text, allows it to also show her new ways of *being*. Hence, "to understand is not to project oneself into the text but, rather, to open up to an enlarged self, to incorporate into your world other possible worlds as portrayed by the text."[53] "There is clearly a circular structure in the hermeneutical function of distanciation: through disappropriation to appropriation, through losing to finding…It has to do with the structure of the hermeneutical circle, or maybe better: the structure of a hermeneutical spiral, because the reader does not return to the same point, but gets back transformed."[54] Through appropriation, the new meaning that is gained in the dynamic between the world of the text and the world of the reader or listener culminates in a new self-interpretation. This has been

illustrated through a telling of a tale about Hanuman and Rama's ring in which the listener entranced, enters the world of the text. Ramanujan summarises the story which ends with a recitation of a telling of the *Ramayana* in which, when Hanuman is leaping across the ocean, the signet ring slipped from his hand and falls into the ocean. Hanuman has to get the ring back quickly and take it to Sita. While the Hanuman in the tale is wringing his hands, a member of the audience, described as a lazy villager was so enraptured that he promises Hanuman that he would recover the ring. He then dives into the ocean, and returns to hand over the ring to Hanuman.[55] Ramanujan tells us that,

> …this story is about the power of the *Ramayana*, about what happens when you really listen to this potent story. Even a fool cannot resist it; he is entranced and caught up in the action. The listener can no longer bear to be a bystander but feels compelled to enter the world of the epic: the line between fiction and reality is erased…[56]

Further, the indolent villager becomes a changed man; a wise, respected village elder. Ramanujan reminds us that this is "what happens when you really listen to a story, especially the *Ramayana*."[57]

A discourse on the *Ramayana* has always invited an appropriation by the reader. This way of looking at a text, as proposed by Ricoeur, articulates the living, creative hermeneutic tradition of the *Ramayana*. The tradition of the *Ramayana* allows not just the creation of new meaning and new referents but new tellings that incorporate the context and lives of the reader or listener in the present. This is the logical end to which Ricoeur's role of the reader in his hermeneutics aspires.

Thus, Ricoeur's hermeneutics recovers an open text which cannot be closed. The very nature of the text is openness, in its availability to anyone who can read its language and its dependence on a reader for it to 'mean' something. Independent of the reader it is dead and disembodied. It lives in its engagement with the consciousness of the reader. Thus, its meaning exists with the reader and not in the primacy of the author's intention and originating situation to which we will never have access. Further, one telling inspires another telling, which enables absolutizing neither text nor the interpreting self, which is the logical end to which distanciation aims.

In not prioritizing one telling over the other, and in not pointing to an *Ur*-text, the tradition of the *Ramayana* opened itself to not just multiple interpretations and tellings but to multiple texts, equally valid, each judged independently. Thus, Ramanujan writes, "We read Kampan to read Kampan, and we judge him on his own terms - not by his resemblance to Valmiki but, if anything, by the extent that he differs from Valmiki."[58] This tradition of the

Ramayana should be preserved, since it is a refreshing approach to canonical scripture, reflective of a living religion that celebrates diversity. It allows for several texts, appropriated by a number of religions in diverse cultures, allowing for multiple ways of being in its interpretation of itself.

Conclusion

Since, the majority draw meaning and identity from the conventional, an attack on it is equivalent to sweeping the carpet from underneath their feet. A questioning of the religious and the social, and presenting alternative arguments which challenge the status quo, could have a negative impact on those who are not yet open or ready for it. Yet, an authoritative telling of the *Ramayana* which aims to stifle and bind in moral shackles a nation's identity, needs challenging. The many *Ramayanas* need to be celebrated pointing the way "to a pluralistic and creative morality of diverse models."[59] The strength of the *Ramayana* tradition ensures that not "even the most ruthless or reductive analysis can destroy a text that survives unscathed, thanks to its condition of infinite reproducibility, to be read anew by other readers."[60] A living tradition in flux warrants that "no interpretation of the Indian past can be claimed as a final and authentic one."[61] Every spectator or reader of the *Ramayana* participates in its experience, just as it was done centuries ago as an oral tradition, compelling its re-telling and inviting the reader turned story-teller to be the arbiter of its meaning. Thus, we in writing this paper and you, the reader in reading it participate in this *Ramayana* tradition. Yet, we each appropriate and inhabit our own *Ramayana* and make what we will of Rama and his tale.

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30 Ibid, 103.
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Part 3

Indian Hermeneutics of Suspicion: Insightful Leaders

13

Against Indian Majoritarianism
The Views of Ambedkar as the Leader of the Little Flock

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Abstract: This paper draws one's attention to Ambedkar's critique of Hindu majoritarianism which showed its ugly head when India made a transition from British rule to a sovereign nation. Positioning the Dalits as the minority, Ambedkar feared that Indian Independence from the British rule would prove to be the unbridled rule of the majority community (the Hindus), that would dominate over the minority and rule over them according to the wishes of the majority. To overcome their domination, Ambedkar pressed for A) separate settlement B) separate electorate, and C) constitutional safeguards for the Dalits, though they were not fully satisfactory in serving the purpose. Just as this paper dwells upon the processes, negotiations and compromises that panned out during this period between the majority Hindus and the minority Dalits, it seeks to throw light on the lessons we can learn from Ambedkar's critique to face similar situations in India today.

Introduction

We live in a period of political majoritarianism that is witnessed also in the two major democracies of the world, i.e. India and United States. The majority perceives the minority as a threat to their well-being. To stop this, the minority, who are feared will progress at the cost of the majority and usurp the resources which are rightfully also meant for the minority. It is against this background

of anti-minority sentiments that this paper tries to explore Ambedkar's critique on majoritarianism which arose in the context of India making a transition from British rule to a sovereign nation.

1. Situating Ambedkar's Views on Majoritarianism

"Unfortunately for the minorities in India, Indian nationalism has developed a new doctrine which may be called the Divine Right of the Majority to rule the minorities according to the wishes of the majority. Any claim for the sharing of power by the minority is called communalism, while the monopolising of the whole power by the majority is called nationalism."[1] This statement of Ambedkar, that exposes the nexus between Indian nationalism and majoritarianism, rose in the context of India's freedom movement that fought against the British rule to become a one sovereign independent nation of India, which Ambedkar feared would prove to be an unbridled rule of the majority community, i.e. the Hindus in an Indian context. Ambedkar's fear was not unfounded as he went on to point out that:

> Guided by such political philosophy the majority is not prepared to allow the minorities to share political power, nor is it willing to respect any convention made in that behalf as is evident from their repudiation of the obligation (to include representatives of the minorities in the Cabinet) contained in the Instrument of Instructions issued to the Governors in the Government of India Act of 1935. Under these circumstances there is no way left but to have the rights of the Scheduled Castes embodied in the Constitution.[2]

The latter part of the quote points to the Dalit minority's dismay over the Hindus failure to endorse a Dalits's right for self-representation in the governance of the nation inspite of the British Raj's mandate to include Dalits in the government. The disappointments and bitter experiences of Dalits such as this drove the chief architect of the Indian Constitution to become critical of Hindu majoritarian agenda and seek constitutional remedies.

2. Viewing Hinduism through the Prism of Dalit as a Minority

Just as Ambedkar was facing stiff resistance from the Hindu political leaders to garner an autonomous political space for his Dalit people, he started reading, reflecting, speaking and writing about the causes, effects and solutions to the problem of Dalit minority status in Indian society. Positioning himself as a Dalit in Indian society, Ambedkar digged deep into his social status as a deprived minority within Hinduism. This positioning gave Ambedkar an epistemic distance and logistical locus to look at the edifice of Hinduism from the margins. His social marginality provided him the required distance to gain a holistic and a critical view of the hierarchical centre of Hinduism.

In this regard, a Dalit minority's critique of the dominant Hindu order is worth an evaluation. His critique of Hinduism is primarily directed to the caste system. He identified six attributes of the caste system, each of which makes caste exclusive in character and a peculiar structure of governance in the Hindu society: 1. Caste as a divider of the Hindu population into small social segments through a process of endogamy prescribing marriages strictly within the caste. 2. Its fixation of the civil, cultural, educational and economic rights for each caste and continuance thereof by heredity without freedom to change, leaving no scope for individual proclivities, capabilities, preferences and predilections. Preventing social and occupational mobility, caste produces isolation and exclusiveness which is inimical to free social order. 3. Unequal entitlements of various rights among the castes and denial of all these to the SCs. Inequality in the distribution of rights is the core feature of the caste system which offers little scope to the lower castes for social and economic improvements as "they are deprived of rights to choose occupation, acquire property and receive education."[3] 4. The hierarchical and graded entitlement of various rights which increase in ascending order from untouchables to Brahmins. In such a system, "rights and privileges of higher castes become the disabilities of the lower castes."[4] For Ambedkar, "caste cannot exist in a single number. Caste can exist only as a plural number. They get interlinked to each other in unequal measures of social, religious, economic relations and rights."[5] In this unjust order of hierarchy, Ambedkar noted that it means not only that the Brahmins are placed at the top of hierarchy par excellence, that they are superior to most social beings worthy only of all special privileges, rights and entitlements; but also it entails that at the bottom of hierarchy are the untouchables treated as "sub-human or lesser human beings" unworthy of any rights. "In fact, the disabilities they suffer are so severe that they are physically and socially isolated and excluded from the rest of society. Isolation and exclusion of the untouchables is a unique feature of the Hindu social order."[6] Practice of "isolation and exclusion" among social groups makes them anti-social and inimical to one another, observed Ambedkar. Denial of equal rights to education is another core feature of the caste system. He rightly observes that the Hindu idea of formal education is quite narrow. Formal education was confined only to the study of the Vedas which was sponsored by the then states, the Hindu kingdoms. Such Hindu kingdoms lacked vision and interest in the establishments of institutions for the study of arts and sciences that concerned the life of the majority, namely the artisans, the merchants and others. In the absence of such a system, development of human capabilities through a method of teaching and learning did not take place which resulted in illiteracy of the masses. Thus 'illiteracy became an inherent part of the caste system by a process that was indirect but internal to Hinduism.'[7] Further, occupations and economic activities are treated as inferior or superior thus

maintaining hierarchy based on the principles of the pure and the impure. 5) Mechanism of enforcement through a process of social ostracism which imposes on the violators social and economic penalties besides social and economic boycott. Thus the sub-continent societies remained conformist and conservative. The static nature of India was perhaps overstressed by famous sociologist Max Weber who indicted Indian culture as anti-change. For Ambedkar, social transformation through revolution was possible in Europe because the weak had access to physical weapons in military service, political weapons in suffrage, and moral weapons in education. These weapons for emancipation were not withheld by the strong from the weak in Europe. But in India since all these weapons were denied to the masses by the wretched system of *Caturvarna*, there was no possibility for any social revolution.[8] 6) Divine justification for the origin and sustenance of the Hindu social system. According to Ambedkar, if there is one group that suffers the most in Hindu social order, it is the minority Dalits who have been denied by the majority of the Hindus not only their right to property but also their human rights.

3. Ambedkar's Critique of the Village System and His Proposal for Separate Settlement

Ambedkar's memorandum to the Cabinet commission in 1946, based on the resolutions of the Working Committee of the All-India Scheduled Castes Federation, critically examines manifold forms of discrimination and oppression faced by the Dalits in Indian villages, and proposes a rationale for the consideration of the Dalits as a separate social minority. They are: 1. The existing village system under which everyone knows who is a touchable or an untouchable is inherently capable of making untouchability permanent. Though it is a form of slavery, penal code does not recognise it as such because it is takes as part of the village system. No more effective method of enforcing slavery upon the untouchables and making untouchability permanent could have been found. 2. Placed on the outskirt of the village and having no access to water, education etc. of the village, the scheduled castes are 'a community apart, with no sort of communion with the caste Hindu residents of the village.'[9] 3. Having no land, they have no independent means of livelihood. Though placed in a situation of forced labour day in and day out, for the Hindu landlords, they remain there for fear of being driven away which makes them a cheap labour. There is neither avenue open nor financial resources available to them for earning independent living like producing and selling some products. Even if they found one, since the Hindu village is the only market they have, they would still remain pauper because no Hindu would buy from them. 4. In the villages, Dalits are forced into a life of degradation, dishonour, and ignominy from generation to generation. It is a state of eternal perdition. They cannot wear clean clothes, they cannot wear ornaments, they cannot eat rich

food, they cannot sit on a chair in the presence of a Hindu etc. 5. Village system makes it easy for the Hindus "to use the most formidable weapon of social boycott with which they always threaten the scheduled castes and which they use to hold them down and compel them to abandon any act of movement however beneficial it may be from the point of view of the scheduled castes, if it happens to offend Hindu interests or Hindu sentiments."[10] 6. "The tyranny of village Hindus upon the scheduled castes is so great and has become so pervasive"[11] that it would make the practice of democracy at the village level dysfunctional. For instance, in previous elections the village system did not allow the scheduled castes to choose a candidate of their choice from a Dalit community because Hindu villagers did not like the candidate.

Realising that in the village system Dalits would never be able to enjoy a free, full and honourable life as described above, Amedkar pressed for a separate settlement for the scheduled castes that would enable them to develop their fullest subject-hood as human beings and to enjoy economic and social security. To this end, he pressed for the inclusion of following provisions in the Constitution of India: A) Constitutional provision to relocate the Dalits from their present habitats to new scheduled castes villages. B) Constitutional mandate to establish a 'Settlement Commission' to create these villages. C) Unoccupied cultivable government lands to be handed over to the Commission for the purpose of making new settlements for the scheduled castes. D) Commission to be given the right to purchase new land from private owners to fulfil the scheme. E) Constitution to impose an obligation on the central government to release five crores to the Commission to enable the Commission to carry out its duty on their behalf. He also wanted the Hindus to meet the cost of settlement of untouchables in separate villages. His reasoning was that Hindus own everything; they own the land in this country and own the state. They control trade and every source of revenue and profit is controlled by them. "The untouchables are just hewers of wood and drawers of water. The social system helps the Hindus to have monopoly of everything. There is no reason why they should not be asked to pay the cost of this scheme when they practically own the country."[12]

4. Ambedkar against *Swaraj* and Independence?

Ambedkar had deep disbelief in majoritarian Hindu politics. For him, the majority in India is a communal majority. He feared that *swaraj* or self rule "would make the communal majority a subjective race. It would mean that a communal majority would be free to run the administration according to their ideas of what is good for the minorities."[13] For Ambedkar, such a state of affairs cannot be called democracy. Rather it would have to be called imperialism. During Indian National Congress' demand for self-rule, Ambedkar wrote: "Under *swaraj* of the Congress variety, the untouchables will have no way

to escape from the destiny of degradation which the Hindus and Hinduism have fixed for them."[14] The only way to overcome this predicament is to have Dalit representatives in the executive so that the administration would not be hostile and indifferent to them. In this context, he held that "if and when a *swaraj* government is established in India, the Hindus, the Muslims and the Schedule Castes - three parties in the country - should share the political power."[15] One of his many-fold concrete suggestions to make *swaraj* work for the minorities was that the representatives of the minorities in the cabinet should be elected by members of each minority community in the legislature by a single transferable vote. And he wanted such minister to enjoy autonomy and not given in to the pressure of the few dominant people. Hence, he held that such a minister (for that matter any minister) "shall not be liable to be removed except on impeachment by the House on the ground of corruption or treason."[16]

Though Ambedkar is projected as the non-supporter of the national freedom struggle, he made it clear that he was not an opponent of national government or of independence provided it ensured autonomy, education and welfare for the Dalit minorities. He also feared that the majority community would utilize political power to strengthen themselves and disenfranchise the rights of others. It is against this apprehension that he openly declared "I regard as more important the freedom of the scheduled castes in India, the community which has been the victim of domination and oppression for over 2000 years. I preferred to work for the uplift of my community rather than *swaraj* for the country."[17] He further made it clear that he wanted to raise the status of the depressed classes "on terms of equality with other communities in India"[18] so that they do not continue to remain servile to other communities in India.

Ambedkar's notion of *swararj* and nationalism stems from the dichotomy between the political and the social. While the Hindu nationalists laid overemphasis on the political almost ignoring the social aspect of nationalism, Ambedkar prioritized the social over the political. He wanted to achieve social freedom for all before a common struggle for political freedom from the British rule would be waged. When his plea fell on the dead ears of the Hindu nationalists, he chalked out multiple strategies in favour of both the freedoms side by side. To achieve the social through the political, he told his people: "I want to place the reins of government in your hands. You should share in the political power of the country on terms of equality with Musalmans."[19] In a meeting organised by three scheduled castes organisations in Kanpur on 31st January 1944, Dr. Ambedkar said: "we must resolve that in a free India of the future we will be a ruling class. We refuse to continue to play a role of subservience or accept a position in which we could be treated as servants, not masters."[20]

At the same time, he was aware that "the minorities cannot depend upon the representative form of Government but must seek protection in the form of guarantees of their rights."[21] Legal rights would have no meaning without sufficient safeguards in the Constitution of India especially in the context of the high caste vehemently opposing the efforts of the untouchables to secure equal rights with others. Due to lack of space, it is not possible to enlist the numerous efforts of Ambedkar such as memorandums to various commissions constituted by the British, letters to the Constituent Assembly, Draft constitution etc. In this regard, one of the Dalit scholars, Dr. Throat takes note of the three-fold approach of Ambedkar to provide safeguards for the Dalits in India. They are "claims for equal rights; remedies against violation of rights in terms of legal provision; and measures for equal access, share, and participation in Legislature, Executive, Administration, education and other public domains for the discriminated groups in the form of reservation policy."[22]

5. Ambedkar, Separate Dalit Electorate and Political Self-representation

One of the important solutions Ambedkar proposed for the minority Dalit communities in India to overcome their social sufferings was the separate system of political representation for the Dalits. Following Indian Muslims' initiatives for separate electorate in early 1900s, Ambedkar also set out to establish that Dalit communities in India are not part of a Hindu community. His reasons were five-fold: 1. While other religions divide the people into Muslims, Christians and Parsis to become a community, Hinduism divides peoples on the basis of caste and into touchables and untouchables, and puts the Dalits outside its fold. 2. The erstwhile 'untouchable' community shares nothing in common with the other 'touchable' caste communities in terms of beliefs, customs and social norms. 3. It has confiscated not only their property but their personality itself. 4. It has instilled certain theological beliefs so strongly among the caste Hindus (both Brahmins and non-Brahmins) that they refuse to accept the leadership of Dalit officers in British India 5. More importantly, it has denied citizenship rights to the Dalits. In this context Ambedkar observes:

> The untouchable is not even a citizen. Citizenship is a bundle of rights such as personal liberty, personal security, right to hold property, equality before law, liberty of conscience, freedom of opinion, and speech, right of assembly, right of representation in country's government, and right to hold office under the state. The untouchablity of untouchables put these rights far beyond their reach.[23]

In his preface to the Draft Constitution Ambedkar observed that "the view that the scheduled castes are not a minority is a new dispensation issued on

behalf of the High and Mighty Hindu Majority which the scheduled castes are asked to submit to."[24] But he contended that the scheduled castes are more than normal minority and that any protection given to the citizens and to the minority would be inadequate for the SCs because their social, economic and educational condition is much worse than that of the citizens and other minorities. "In addition to protection they would get as citizens and as minorities, the SCs would require special safeguards against the tyranny and discrimination of the majority."[25] His emphasis on constitutional provisions and special safeguards did not go down well with the Hindu majority; so much so that K. M. Munshi commented on Ambedkar's proposal with the following words of sarcasm: "If the scheme were accepted, the state would be a totalitarian apparatus run for the benefit of the scheduled castes in which the majority would be politically reduced to the status of second class citizens."[26] The political muscle power of the Hindu majority reached its climax when, Gandhi with his famous fast unto death, did side with the Hindu majority and created a situation of political crisis that made Ambedkar sign the famous Poona pact with Madan Mohan Malaviya to give up the Dalits' demand for separate electorate in favour of a joint electorate.

6. Constitutional Morality in Lieu of Hindu Ethos

The personal experiences of discrimination, humiliation and social exclusion undergone by Ambedkar, like those of millions of scheduled castes in India, made Ambedkar distance himself from the Hindu religion (that was built on a discriminatory caste system) and to eschew its norms, morals and ethos which only perpetuated and dealt inequality and injustice to millions of low caste and scheduled caste people. In place of the Hindu ethos and its book of *dharma shastras* that prescribed unfair norms and morals, Ambedkar then wanted to create a new document, the Constitution of India which was for Ambedkar more than a rule book for administering the nation. It is rather a source book for a new morality, a constitutional morality. While tabling the Draft Constitution in the Constituent Assembly on November 4, 1948, Ambedkar said:

> While everybody recognizes the necessity of the diffusion of constitutional morality for the peaceful working of a democratic Constitution, there are two things interconnected with it which are unfortunately, not generally recognized. One is that the form of administration has a close connection with the form of the Constitution. The form of the administration must be appropriate to and in the same sense as the form of the Constitution. The other is that it is perfectly possible to pervert the Constitution, without changing its form, by merely changing the form of the administration and to make it inconsistent and opposed to the spirit of the Constitution. It follows that it is only where people are saturated with constitutional morality such as the one described by Grote the historian that one can take the risk of omitting from the Constitution details of administration and leaving it for the Legislature to prescribe them. The question is, can we presume such a diffusion of constitutional morality? Constitutional morality is not a natural sentiment. It has to be cultivated. We must realise that our people have yet to learn it. Democracy in India is only a top-dressing on an Indian soil, which is essentially undemocratic.[27]

It is this undemocratic soil which he wanted to cure through important bills and corrective measures. One such effort by Ambedkar was the introduction of the Hindu Code Bill, which aimed at social reformation of the Hindu life in India soon after Independence. But this evoked vehement responses from many Hindu leaders including Dr. Rajendra Prasad, the first President of India, who said "new concepts and new ideas are not only foreign to the Hindu law but are susceptible of dividing every family."[28] While Nehru even split the bill into four subsets in order to defuse the opposition before submitting it to the assembly, the portion of the bill concerning marriage and divorce was deformed by amendments in September 1951, and finally it was buried and its spirit made to die. Deeply saddened by the turn of events around this bill, Ambedkar felt unsupported by Nehru and betrayed by others, and sent his letter of resignation from the government on 27 September, 1951. Realising that his long-drawn struggle to materialize this dream of a just and democratic India was fading away, Ambedkar even wanted to burn the very Constitution which he himself drafted. In one of his speeches in the Lok Sabha debates of 1955, Ambedkar also explained why he wanted to burn the Constitution, "We built a temple for a god to come in and reside, but before the god could be installed, if the devil had taken possession of it, what else could we do except destroy the temple?"[29]

Concluding Remarks: Lessons for Today from Ambedkar's Critique of Hindu Majoritarianism

Ambedkar's efforts to carve out an autonomous and respectable space for the Dalits in India proved to be an ongoing struggle against the stiff resistance that he faced from the majoritarian Hindus. This concluding section seeks to explore and view the implications of such a situation for understanding our context today in three different ways.

1. Ambedkar's Emphasis on the Social over the Political

One of Ambedkar's implicit critiques of majoritarian politics is that the latter failed to accord importance to the social freedom of the marginal people. While

Ambedkar kept on insisting on the need for social emancipation of the marginal communities alongside the political independence of the nation, the majority kept on advancing consistently the cause of the independence of India. In the name of political freedom from the British rule, Ambedkar feared that the dominant majority were not only overshadowing the social emancipation of the Dalits but were also bringing back a new form of high caste and majoritarian rule over the rest. It is from this fear that he wrote "If Hindu Raj does become a fact, it will, no doubt, be the greatest calamity for this country.… Hindu Raj must be prevented at any cost."[30] Today this fear of Ambedkar's has become a reality. In the current dispensation of majoritarian rule, the social is put behind the political and the national is, overtly or covertly, being advanced in the name of the majoritarian religion. In trying to homogenize the hegemonic ethos and the culture of the majority in the name of one nation and its unity, through processes such as mandating the singing of *vandemadaram*, banning of beef, introduction of Sanskrit/Hindi as a compulsory Indian language in the schools etc., what is actually happening today is the dismissal of diversity in the realm of the social. Differences in the social are asked to surrender and be sacrificed at the altar of the majoritarian version of the Indian nation.

2. Majoritarian Design of Inclusion

Amdekar's positioning of the Dalit as minorities and his critique of majoritarian politics is in fact a fight against the majoritarian sinister design of inclusion of the excluded minority Dalits, to deprive them of their agency and autonomy. In Gandhi's and Congress' denial of the Dalit's demand for political self-representation, one can see an emergence of a new political method in independent Indian nation, namely, the politics of majoritarian Hindu paternalism. This political style is also continued today by the current political dispensation, through various forms and strategies, to make the minorities of India part of the majoritarian framework according to the terms and conditions set by the majority, which the minority feel alienating and enslavening.

3. Politics of Victimhood

Just as Ambedkar was trying hard to obtain constitutional provisions and legal safeguards for the Dalits, Munshi resented Ambedkar's move and belittled the Dalits' legitimate demand for constitutional safeguards and state protection. Munshi's unfounded fear of majority becoming minority and the state becoming pro-minority is an insecure campaign that is advanced even today by the majority community in various forms and intensities. The insecure self (individual or collective) yielding to the politics of victimhood is not a non-occurrence among men, the high castes and the advantaged both in the civil life and in the church life.

Notes

1 B. Shiva Rao, *The Framing of India's Consultation: Select Documents, Volume 2* (Delhi: Universal Law Publication), 113.
2 *Ibid*.
3 Sukhadeo Thorat & Narender Kumar, "Introduction," in *B.R. Ambedkar: Perspectives on Social Exclusion and Inclusive Policies,* eds. Sukhadeo Thorat & Narender Kumar (New Delhi: Oxford University Press, 2008), 4.
4 *Ibid*.
5 *Ibid*., 5.
6 *Ibid*.
7 *Ibid*., 6.
8 C. D. Naik, *Thoughts and Philosophy of Dr. B.R. Ambedkar* (New Delhi: Sarup and Sons, 2003), 155.
9 Sheshrao Chavan, *The Constitution of India: Role of India Role of Dr. B.R. Ambedkar, Legend and Reality*, (New Delhi: Atlantic, 2007), 307.
10 *Ibid*., 308.
11 *Ibid*., 307.
12 *Ibid*., 219.
13 *Ibid*., 218.
14 *Ibid*., 221.
15 *Ibid*., 222.
16 *Ibid*., 219.
17 *Ibid*., 222.
18 *Ibid*., 223.
19 *Ibid*., 223.
20 *Ibid*.
21 Vasant Moon (ed.), *Dr. Babasaheb Ambedkar : Writings and Speeches*, *Volume 2* (Bombay: Education Department, Government of Maharastara, 1982), 443.
22 Sukhadeo Thorat & Narender Kumar, 'Introduction,' 45.
23 *Ibid*., 17.
24 Chavan, "*The Constitution of India,*" 221.
25 *Ibid*.
26 *Ibid*.
27 As quoted in A.G. Noorani "Ambedkar's Warning," <http://www.frontline.in/cover-story/ambedkars-warning/article9748353.ece> (7 October, 2017).
28 <http://indianexpress.com/article/opinion/columns/which-ambedkar-in-parliament-and-for-rss> (12 October, 2017).
29 *Ibid*.
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14

Gandhian Hermeneutics of Suspicion

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Abstract: Gandhi as a socio-political activist and critical thinker was the product of his times, engaging an emerging 'modern' India, responding to the concerns both critically and creatively. He called for a critical evaluation of everything and exhorted effective action. The tension between 'tradition' and 'modernity' was vividly seen in all spheres of life in India. Gandhian hermeneutics of suspicion is vivid in critiquing all that is non-Indian, Western systems and notions, outmoded traditions. At the same time it offered an alternative vision. His suspicion on the relevance of modern ideas to a country like India provides a systemic, insightful, significant and relevant interpretation of traditions. He appears to be a model of how one could be both critical and creative, traditional as well as modern, contextual and textual.

Introduction

Any thinker is the product of one's own times. Gandhi as a dynamic activist and a critical thinker engaged himself in the context of his times. Living in British India under colonial rule, Gandhi encountered the issues that affected him and his society and responded to them both critically and creatively. The questions that he raised on the Western ideas and systems that were inevitably entering the Indian polity and society, made him a real critic and interpreter of the context of his living. The changing realities within society and the internal issues of an emerging 'modern' India did catch his imagination and called for critical evaluation and effective action. The tension between 'tradition' and

'modernity' was vividly seen in all spheres of life - religions, society, ethics, political establishments, socio-economic movements. Gandhi as a successful activist in all societal, political and religious fields, emerged as a contextual thinker who did involve himself and contributed to new ways of thinking in Indian society and politics.

1.Gandhian Hermeneutical Tool

Our preliminary observations on Gandhian hermeneutics of suspicion are: firstly, Gandhi seemed like he was critiquing all that is non-Indian. Secondly, his mind appeared to be fixed on an idea that many Western systems and notions were not suited to Indian context and they were merely an imposition or invasion. In confronting these issues, he offered a principle that changing aspects of religion, ethics, economics and politics does not entail giving up traditional modes of thinking and acting. Tradition could never be ignored. Tradition always served as a text to be read and re-read in a given context of modernity.

Another aspect of Gandhian hermeneutics is to offer an alternative vision along with critiques on various spheres affecting human life. In critiquing modern industrialised mode of production Gandhi offered cottage industry as an alternative. Rural development was presented as a response to urbanization. The critique of modern democracy, monarchy and colonial rule, witnessed a revival of theocracy in terms of *Ramrajya.* He proposed it as against Western modes of thinking on social order and structure based on French revolutionary principles of fraternity, liberty and equality. With regard to social structure, order and organization, Gandhi preferred to uphold *varnadharma,* rather than support the Ambedkarian proposal based on Western principles of equality. In all, Gandhian response to the modern thinking, ideas and systems was based on his allegiance to tradition and on his efforts to safeguard traditional values. In fact, it seemed that Gandhi had conveniently taken refuge in tradition, avoiding direct confrontation with modernity. His suspicion was on the relevance of modern ideas to a country like India, which had been mostly shaped and guided by the idea that tradition offered all solutions and it had been significant, relevant and trustworthy at all times. Time tested traditional values were offered as 'all-time' answers to many modern questions.

The paper attempts at illustrating the Gandhian hermeneutics of suspicion on the issues that confronted him and his society. By doing so we aim at application of Gandhian hermeneutics of suspicion, in the wake of our contemporary concerns dealing with tradition and modernity, liberal free trade, globalized market economy, technological growth and relevance of ethical-religious value systems. We shall also try to critique his own critique of everything pertaining to human life. We would also attempt to assess whether his suspicion of the relevance of modernity holds good and also if his proposals

for alternatives are really time tested and correct, and proved successful in the human emancipatory project during the post-colonial period.

2. Material Economy to Human Economy

Gandhi's critique of modernity, colonialism, capitalism and industrialization emerged from his traditional outlook on human beings, cultural underpinnings on rural economy, religious convictions, on sacredness in humans and equality among them, personal principles of self-respect and self-governing, and social positioning of indigenous people in colonial rule. Economy is not to do with mere increase of material wealth but to serve the humanity at large. The political form of rule as colonialism, modern scientific and technological advancements, economic theories of communism or capitalism and large scale industrial productions, are basically founded on the principles of mere material economy. Gandhian critique on them led to the consideration of humans in economy, rather than humans for economy. Economy is to serve humanity. His paradigm shift was from material economy to human economy.

In *Indian Home Rule* written in 1908, Gandhi predicted the downfall of Western civilization on the grounds that its industrial system was changing the natural order, exalting the status of the machine and lowering the status of the human being. Mass production, power of the machine with its era of material abundance reduced human capability and treated human beings only as another tool of production rather than producers themselves. Common man, the former producer of wealth, or material and artistic value, now became a servant of the power machine, a degraded being, pushed into the shadow of devalued entities.[1] For this reason, Gandhi offered an alternative solution of production of cotton clothes, *khadi,* by human hands, using wooden spin-wheel. Though criticized as a time consuming and less efficient method of cloth production, Gandhian *khadi* project stood its ground as an alternative mode of production.

The condemnatory confession of contemporary society that productive power becomes destructive power reaching the impasse of nuclear weapons, fear of universal destruction that these instruments might bring in, brings to mind the warning Gandhi made decades ago. Gandhi strongly condemned inhuman development, "Economics that ruins one's health is false, because money without health has no value. Only that economy is true which enables one to conserve one's health."[2] Fear becomes the dominant note and factor in western civilisation today.[3] Mass production without the human touch turns out to be mass destruction of the human being. When products become more important than the producers, the use of these material products could only be mere tools without any real purpose. Even in a communistic mode of economy where everyone is catered according to one's own need, Gandhi opined that basically it aimed at distribution of wealth and profits to the agents of production. Due justice for the labourers is appreciable for it aims at human

economy. Yet, his criticism could be summarised in terms of communism which tries to 'economize' humans, rather than attempt at 'humanizing the economy.' Even in communist protests Gandhi viewed demanding for a 'share' in the profit more as a driving force than as humanizing the economy. Human beings are made to be slaves to their work and economic welfare. Against a communistic mode of protesting and arguing for the workers' welfare, Gandhi offered *antyōdayā* and *sarvōdayā,* emancipation of the last and of all, envisioned workers as producers and beneficiaries of their production. For him even the political scheme of *swaraj,* self-rule is to emancipate rural folks, as he says, "the key to *swaraj* is not the cities but the villages."[4] In response to the capitalist mode of production Gandhi emphatically stated that in large scale production, human labour is undermined and human alienation from the product is evident.

3. Gandhian Value-Orientation Vs. Value-Neutrality in Science

Relationship between religion, science and ethics reveals a perspective completely different in Gandhi. For him, science with its knowledge can never be allowed to replace the core ethical and religious values. Human dignity and respect for life became paramount in Gandhian thought and action. For instance, regarding vivisection in science, he strongly wrote:

> I abhor vivisection with my whole soul. I detest the unpardonable slaughter of innocent life in the name of science and humanity so-called, and all the scientific discoveries stained with innocent blood, I count as of no consequence… And I see the day clearly dawning when the honest scientist of the West will put limitations upon the present methods of pursuing knowledge.[5]

In the name of scientific knowledge that would help humanity in future, present scientific experimental methods are not to be left unbridled. At the risk of human life and disrespect for human dignity, uncontrollable experimental activities argue for the future benefits of humanity. Gandhi strongly criticized such a rigorous mechanical attitude towards human persons and other living creatures.

Gandhi argued that there can be no study of fact/truth which goes against values.[6] For him, no scientific activity could be value-neutral. Similarly, there can be no value that does not affect the state of affairs in this world. He uses equivalence of importance to both science and values. Science cannot ignore values and values are to make some impact in society. In ancient thought, for instance with the Greeks- the pioneers of Western thought and culture, there was no distinction between knowledge and values. After the mechanical view of nature emerged, especially in the Newtonian era, and significantly after the Cartesian epistemological revolution, insistence was placed upon a sharp

distinction between the objective and subjective dimensions in the knowledge-seeking enterprise. Since science was regarded as rational and objective, factual and experimental, moral, religious and cultural values were considered to be beyond the purview of science. Rigorous scientific temper had made claims to be value-neutral. The scientific orientations pleaded for a non-judgmental approach with regards to their methods, presumptions, approaches and even results which might turn out either to be 'good' or 'bad,' 'right' or 'wrong.' Such value-neutral approaches had made significant progress in the history of science. Being considered an authority unto themselves, scientists had made tremendous headway through researches, even to some extent of ignoring the cautions and cries of value-oriented persons and traditions; for, the fear of loss of significance of their traditional values, societies and systems wielded ways to combat 'unbridled' scientific researches that claim for value-neutrality. Gandhi, the one speaking for value-oriented science, made his critique of science and its progress.

Gandhi was not a lonely voice against the value-neutral approach of science in humanity. In the history of human thought value-neutrality has been strongly challenged by philosophers of science, sociologists, historicists, humanists, and even by scientists themselves. Goals in science are show pieces of the need for value-consideration. Science involves several types of goals like epistemic goals, practical goals and personal goals of scientists. These goals have the purposes of advancing human knowledge with explanations and predictions; transmitting knowledge to the next generation; increasing technological power; improving standards of life; personal goals for name, fame, money, openness and readiness to take risks, having intellectual properties, sharing and preserving resources etc. Taking into account the goals of science and scientists, the role of value judgements and ethical considerations are due. Much more in the contemporary context, value-consideration in science has become crucial and urgent with the uncontrollable explosion of war technology, ecological degradation and the bio-ethical issues arising from present day scientific activities and results.

Value-neutrality in science is based on two factors: fact-value dichotomy and a sceptical attitude. Fact-value dichotomy is well expressed in the following words of Pereira, "Science is for what 'is,' not what 'ought to be'; science can only describe, not prescribe."[7] Both facts and values are thoroughly interdependent, without any significant difference between the so-called scientific values like justification, coherence, truth etc., and that of moral or aesthetic values.[8] As truth is considered as having a scientific value, its relevance, interests and significance in social contexts are also equally important. Removing the value-considerations from a scientist is to remove his/her humanity as well. One cannot suppress his/her value judgment. For Gandhi, scientists are not seeking for merely objective truths and knowledge, but truths

that are interesting, useful, and valuable to humanity as a whole. Hence, in the mind of Gandhi, attempts of science at right knowledge, objective truth and universality are to be rooted in moral or religious values serving human purposes. "I know how in the name of truth and science inhuman cruelties are perpetuated on animals…"[9] Value-neutrality is criticized by Gandhi as there can be no fact without a value. For Gandhi, all pursuit of knowledge and future measurements will have to take note not merely of its consequences for the human family but for all that lives, all creation. Such knowledge alone is truly science for it will comprise 'facts' of the science of existence or living. Then, theory will not be divorced from practice, nor will the personal be divorced from the social and the professional.[10] Dichotomy of fact and value can no longer be accepted even though scientists claim that such imposition of moral, religious and cultural values on to scientific activities would lead to hampering of the scientific temper and spirit of research. Objectivity of science, as argued by the adherents of 'value-neutrality,' might be lost in case such 'value-considerations' are to be taken care of. For Gandhi, human values were more important than scientific facts.

Scepticism subjects everything to a severe scrutiny, demanding openness to check whether one is misguided or not. Though scepticism is part of rationality in science, consistent and absolute scepticism is not possible, even in science. One needs to be reasonable even in being sceptic.[11] Taking into consideration value-orientations, social responsibilities of scientists do not give room for developing a void or vacuum in the society. For Gandhi, without morality, any scientific development can only be distorted. Any development in science and technology is not a non-social concept and progress. "It would be highly irrational to overestimate the powers at the disposal of science and the scientists in the humanization of advances in science and technology. It is still less rational, in fact, irresponsible, to ignore the active socio-ethical humanistic stand taken by the scientific community."[12] As long as scientists are humans, they are part and parcel of human society and are bound by, at least, certain values accepted and practiced in the human community. The value that demands science to enhance and enrich humanity and alleviate its sufferings and the damage to the environment is a social-responsibility.

For Gandhi, the methods of science cannot be divorced from the truths of science, nor the pure science from its applications, for instance, in atomic research and its applications in the destructive atom bomb. Even the advantages of applied science for 'peaceful' purposes do not deter Gandhi from holding this view:

> My love of nature-cure and of indigenous systems does not blind me to the advances that Western medicine has made in spite of the fact that I have stigmatized it as black magic. I have used the harsh term and I do not withdraw it, because of the fact that it has countenanced vivisection and all the awfulness it means and because it will stop at no practice, however bad it may be, if it prolongs the life of the body and because it ignores the immortal soul which resides in the body.[13]

Thus, for Gandhi, a scientist who is from the society has to be for the society. One cannot cut oneself off from humanity and keep the scientific activities apart from human concerns. Any scientific method or approach should take into consideration value-orientation. Sometimes, it might contradict the traditional values held by the community, but Gandhi insisted that all that was given in the modern scientific field was not to be taken as absolute comprehension of truth as such.

Insisting on the ethical dimension of economics, further he says, "Rome suffered a moral fall when it attained high material affluence. So did Egypt…"[14] And equally he did not hold a view that only traditional wisdom has to offer a holistic view of reality. However, he preferred to hold a view that tradition is not to be thrown out as outdated but needs only to be reinterpreted to suit our times. The scientific methods and results are not to claim 'extra-value-systems' outside human realm but to keep the humanity at large to benefit from the scientific researches. He had a strong view that science should keep its value-oriented activities for the betterment of humanity.

4. Globally Competitive Vs. Rural Emancipatory Economy

Profit oriented market economy often projects human beings as enterprising and achieving so as to increase their wealth and comforts. "Western nations today are groaning under the heel of the monster-god of materialism. Their moral growth has become stunted."[15] With the arrival of new economic policies in international trade relations, where competition in the manufacturing and distribution of goods is seen as a norm of healthy interactions the globalized market has undermined the local economy. Maximizing the profit alone seems to be the motive in a globalized competitive economy. In such a capitalistic project, human welfare declines. Even anti-capitalist crusades by socialist movements have failed to offer an effective alternative. Socialist movements have been characterised by its distribution of the fruits of production, and workers' control or elevation of the workers, in determining the ends and means of industry.

Ever since the dawn of the industrial revolution, there is an inner revolt clamouring for humanizing the industry. Control of the industry on the determination of potency and ability of workers to produce has dampened the spirit of emancipation. Impotence and regimentation of the average industrial worker are levelled against the human emancipation. Regimentation

of the workers has destroyed the desire for responsibility and the exercise of initiative. The demands of higher social status for the workers by way of right is offered as an alternative in anti-capitalist movements. The initiatives and responsibilities to take control of the industry so as to emancipate the workers were the welcome change. And then socialist emphasis shifted from the issue of responsibility to that of higher wages, where the sole motive and objective of labour and labour agitation had become 'money'. Today, we see that every section of society demands more and more money, increments and for cash differentials. The aims of socialism have come to be expressed in monetary terms. The trap of competition, monetary economy, globalisation has engulfed humanity.

In contemporary India, public sectors are disinvested due to labour problems connected with less creativity and responsibility of the workers. There has been an observation about how there is no responsibility or initiative seen in the workers. Everyone looks for remuneration without real 'working'. Fruits of the industry are the most coveted assets. With no labour being invested with creativity, initiative and responsibility it is relatively difficult to expect desired fruits, the profit. Failure of cooperative societies is the best example in contemporary India.

Nationalisation of industries, as in public sector undertakings and cooperative societies, are now seen as a great liability due to the above factor of non-creative, non-responsible work-force. These industrial activities have now gradually been abandoned as they fail to play a great role in the industrial and economic growth of the country. More and more private players are on the scene, offering a solution, as they demand to 'work and get paid.' The increase of private companies demanding creativity and responsibility is viewed by the failing public sector industrial workers as a capitalist profit making process. The profit is shared only by the owners or share-holders of the company, not the workers. In such cases, without addressing the issue of creativity and responsibility, the cries of the labour unions are that the government buy shares in big companies to ensure a just distribution of the profits, the fruits of industry. Without much thought to initiatives and responsibility to increase productivity, such unrealistic demands are aired out.[16]

In such a context of fragmentation or degrading of the workers, accepted as a fact today, and both capitalist globalization and socialism aiming at only 'profit' and 'wages,' a Gandhian hermeneutics of suspicion views life as being reduced to monetary terms. The struggles characterized by the dual process of getting and spending money are increasingly becoming perpetual. All that matters are wages. Gandhi calls for a spiritual revaluation of such capitalist competitive economy so as to bring in emancipatory development. Gandhian critique tries to address the heart of western industrialisation. He tries to

fashion an economic order which insures the triumph of spiritual values and thus of human wholeness.

As the greater part of India is found in her villages, Gandhi gave great importance to rural development. "If the village perishes India will perish too. It will be no more India."[17] Rural economy alone is not the concern, but for Gandhi a village has a great potential for human development. Rural atmosphere is hailed by Gandhi as conducive to the holistic wellbeing of human beings. He said, "Actually the village, not the city, is the place for the development of the mind."[18] The human being is intimately related to our experience of nature around us. In fact, the mindscape emerges from the landscape. The geography shapes human thinking and acting. Ideological differences in human thought could be attributed to the geographical differences of humans living in different environments. Rural and village folk are much more integrated persons than urban people. Forest-dwellers everywhere are less often overcome by evil desires than city-dwellers. One who is living in an artificial setup would lack actual and real relationships. Today with climate change discussions and debates, activities and policies, what is evident is that humans have alienated themselves from the environment and thus have become alienated from it. For development one needs to avoid distancing from mother earth which is not often encouraged. The Gandhian emancipatory economy calls for safeguarding the integrity of creation and the promotion of symbioti relation.[19] Gandhi promoted cottage industries and focussed on rural development not merely as a rejection to the capitalist competitive mode of production but for enhancing human emancipation through holistic development of all. Symbiotic relation binding the whole of creation, is held together by the universal and all-pervading Spirit of Truth.[20] The ontological principle of oneness becomes an existential ideal for Gandhi.

5. Gandhian Paradigm for Holistic Development

Eventhough Gandhi was not an economist in the strict sense of the term, his understanding and idea of economics and development was based on freedom and concern for the ordinary people. He confesses that he knew very little of economics and was even asked to stop experimenting in matters of economics at the expense of the public.[21] He helped to acquire a different vision of life and development, where the basic human needs are satisfied. India as an emerging fast-growing economic power, still lacks in prosperity and progress to millions of people living in rural areas and urban slums. Gandhi was concerned about economic policies that would make individuals and nations unhappy and so the poor will become poorer and the rich richer.[22]

Looking at economy not merely as a mode of the 'demand-supply' paradigm, Gandhi envisions economy for holistic development. He couples the material aspect of economy with socio-spiritual aspects of life, namely inner

conscience, charity towards others, truthfulness and sincerity. He claims to have followed his deep inner voice even in matters of socio-economic-political concerns, believing that "our inner wisdom can give a deeper understanding of human growth and development than formal studies can do."[23] Development is not merely accumulation of wealth or increase of comforts but life that is lived 'simply' and 'contently.' As he calls, "There must be a return to simplicity and proper proportions."[24]

For Gandhi, *Satya*, truth is the mode of being, being what we should be, an experience of wellbeing. He kept it as the goal of development.[25] Profit-motive alone does not make economy helpful for humans. By such economic development humans are made subservient to feel the need for things manufactured, even without a need for it. The capitalist economy makes one feel the need for it, while actually speaking one can live without it. We become victims of economic materialism and consumerism.

> All the while conveniently forgetting that its greatest achievements are the invention of the most terrible weapons of destruction, the awful growth of anarchism, the frightful disputes between capital and labour and the wanton and diabolical cruelty inflicted on innocent, dumb, living animals in the name of science, 'falsely so called.[26]

Development without sincerity and truthfulness of serving the need of humans often turns out to be a 'regress' rather than a 'progress' for the humanity. "Development is authentic only when it promotes the total well-being of persons, who constitute a just society and maintain the integrity of creation."[27] With destruction of one's well-being and the safe environment no development is sustainable. Further he says, "Economists do not take men's conduct into account but estimate prosperity from the amount of wealth accumulated and so conclude that the happiness of nations depends upon their wealth alone."[28] Thus for Gandhi, holistic development takes place only by taking into consideration the overall growth of humans, with all material, spiritual, social and ecological concerns.

Conclusion

Gandhi does not offer a 'philosophy,' because he had little interest in academic philosophy as he expressed impatience with abstract, technical, philosophical analysis and theorizing. For him they seemed irrelevant or even an obstacle to immediate pressing concerns. He was a man of action, a moralist, and a practical idealist, who believed that any theory is useful if it is put into transformative practice. Taken at face value, Gandhi is misleadingly simplistic. But significant are his assumptions and critiques which are systemic, insightful, significant and relevant to his times and for us too. His critique on the western

model of democracy, capitalist mode of production and development left us an impression that he remained indomitable in his spirit on principles and values that he held as truth. As seen above, we presume varied perspectives of critiques of Gandhi on scientific methods and discoveries, emerging industrial economy and religious encounters, relativization of ethical values and political assertions of the locals, and these expressed his hermeneutics of suspicion. He interpreted different systems of thought and activities, with a critical outlook, and offered an alternative vision of society and politics without giving up traditional notions. He appears to be a model of how one could be both critical and creative, traditional as well as modern, contextual and textual.

Notes

1 Wilfred Wellock, "Gandhi and Western Materialism," in *M.K. Gandhi,* Vol. 7 of *Political Thinkers of Modern India,* ed., Verinder Grover (New Delhi: Deep & Deep Publications, 1990), 828.
2 M.K. Gandhi, *The Collected Works of Mahatma* Gandhi, Vol. 8. (New Delhi: Publication Division, Ministry of Information and Broadcasting, 1958-84), 268.
3 Wilfred Wellock, "Gandhi and Western Materialism," in *M.K. Gandhi,* 829.
4 M.K. Gandhi, *The Collected Works of Mahatma* Gandhi, Vol. 63. 417.
5 M.K. Gandhi, *Young India,* December 17, 1925; see M.K. Gandhi, *My Religion,* compiled by Kumarappa Bharatan (Ahmedabad: Navajivan Publishing House, 1955), 81.
6 Anuradha Shah, "Religion, Ethics and Science," in *Journal of Indian Council of Philosophical Research,* Vol. X., No.2 (Jan-Apl, 1993), 33.
7 Ariyapala Pereira, *Science and Human Values* (New Delhi: Global Vision Publishing House, 2005), 127.
8 Hilary Putnam, "Beyond Fact/Value Dichotomy," in *Realism with a Human Face.* Ed. James Conant (Cambridge: Harvard University Press, 1990), 135-141.
9 M.K. Gandhi, *Young India,* October 31, 1931, M.K. Gandhi, *My Religion,* compiled by Kumarappa Bharatan (Ahmedabad: Navajivan Publishing House, 1955), 13.
10 Anuradha Shah, "Religion, Ethics and Science," in *Journal of Indian Council of Philosophical Research,* Vol. X. No. 2 (Jan-Apl, 1993), 33.
11 Todd C Riniolo and Lee Nisbet, "The Myth of Consistent Skepticism – The Cautionary Case of Albert Einstein," *Sceptical Inquirer* (May/June 2007), 50-51.
12 Ivan Frolov and Boris Yudin, *The Ethics of Science: Issues and Controversies* (Moscow: Progress Publishers, 1989), 352-353.
13 M.K. Gandhi, *Harijan,* August 11, 1946; see M.K. Gandhi, *Truth is God,* compiled by R.K. Prabhu (Ahmedabad: Navajivan Pulishing House, 1955), 107.
14 Raghavan Iyer, ed., *The Essential Writings of Mahatma Gandhi* (New Delhi: Oxford University Press, 1993, 11th reprint, 2004), 95.
15 RaghavanIyer, ed., *The Essential Writings of Mahatma Gandhi*, 97.
16 We assess that the failure of 'workers-sharing-the profit' model, is due to lack of creativity and responsibility. The aim is only to share in the 'profit.' Secondly, the return of Capitalist model of 'work-and-get paid' brings back the element of 'de-humanising' the labour. In both cases, Gandhi feared that the goal of industrialisation, either in Socialist economical system or in Capitalist mode of production, is 'profit,' 'monetary benefits,' and 'payment.'
17 M.K. Gandhi, *The Collected Works of Mahatma* Gandhi, Vol. 63, 241.
18 M.K. Gandhi, *The Collected Works of Mahatma* Gandhi, Vol. 63, 420.

19 Subash Anand, "Authentic Development – Some Gandhian Criteria," in *Jnanadeepa,* Vol. 10/1 (Jan 2007), 8.
20 M.K. Gandhi, *An Autobiography: The Story of My Experiments with Truth* (Ahmedabad: Navajivan Publishing House, 14th rep, n.d.), 420.
21 Raghavan Iyer, ed., *The Essential Writings of Mahatma Gandhi*, 93.
22 M.K. Gandhi, *The Collected Works of Mahatma* Gandhi, Vol. 8, 371.
23 Subhash Anand, "Authentic Development – Some Gandhian Criteria," in *Jnanadeepa,* Vol.10/1 (Jan 2007), 6.
24 M.K. Gandhi, *Indian Home Rule or Hind Swaraj* (Madras: G.A. Natesan, 6th reprint., 1947), 23.
25 Subhash Anand, "Satyagraha: A Theological Model for India," in *Hindu Inspiration for Christian Reflection: Towards a Hindu-Christian Theology* (Anand: Gujarat Sahitya Prakash, 2004), 179-180.
26 Raghavan Iyer, ed., *The Essential Writings of Mahatma Gandhi*, 83.
27 Subash Anand, "Authentic Development – Some Gandhian Criteria," in *Jnanadeepa,* 8.
28 M.K. Gandhi, *The Collected Works of Mahatma* Gandhi, Vol. 8, 371.

15

Asghar Ali Engineer
A Muslim with a Difference

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Abstract: Asghar Ali Engineer is an exceptional Islamic progressive Indian thinker of the 21st century. He is a Muslim with a difference because of his bold and radical approach to Islam. His contribution to the reform movements in Islam is commendable and unparalleled, especially in the field of secularism, human rights, inter-faith dialogues, women empowerment and Islamic democratic thinking. He could rightly be described as a "secularist" because of his adherence to a particular kind of secular values; he could be called a "human rights activist," because of his energetic participation in various socio-political movements and campaigns; he could be labeled as a "liberal Muslim" because he continued to oppose the upper caste, upper-class politics of Muslim elites. Engineer exhorts the present generation Muslims to re-read and re-interpret the Qur' anand *Shar'iah* in light of scientific advances. With regard to inter-religious dialogue one should show true religious spirit and should have the readiness to know the truths in other religions. Any sense of superiority about one's own religion, however subtle, defeats the very purpose. Since Muslims can, indeed must, willingly accept the fact that they belong to different nationalities they must opt for democracy rather than theocracy.

1. Introduction

Asghar Ali Engineer was born on 10 March 1939 in Salumbar, Rajasthan, India, as son of a Bohra priest. He was trained in Qur'anic *tafsir* (commentary), *tawil* (hidden meaning of Qur'an), *fiqh* (jurisprudence) and hadith (Prophet's

sayings), and learned the Arabic language. He graduated with a degree in civil engineering, and served for 20 years as an engineer in the Bombay Municipal Corporation.

He began to play a leading role in the reform movement in 1972 and was selected as General Secretary of The Central Board of Dawoodi Bohra Community. In 2004 due to his criticism of the Dawoodi Bohra religious established, he was expelled. In 1980, he set up the Institute of Islamic Studies in Mumbai to create a platform for progressive Muslims in India and elsewhere. In 1993, he founded 'Center for Study of Society and Secularism' to promote communal harmony. He authored more than 50 books and many articles in various national and international journals.

This paper centers on the works of Asghar Ali Engineer, mainly his hermeneutics on the Qur'an, his approach to women, his view on secularism, democracy, interfaith-dialogue and how he is a Muslim with a different thinking. His approaches to Islam and its teachings are very much radical in the sense that he is looked with suspicion in the Islamic circles, but as far as I am concerned, his views and approaches are the need of the time or inevitable to the pluralistic and democratic framework of the modern world, especially that of India.

2. Engineer's Hermeneutics of Qur'an and Sunnah

Every Holy Scripture is a historical as well as human product, so also the Qur'an and it can be interpreted in different ways. The Qur'an is not a closed book, with only one set of specified meanings. Being rich in symbolism, it can be interpreted in different ways by different people and new ways of understanding the text also emerge as a result. Engineer argues that, like all other human products, interpretations of the Qur'an carry the imprint of their times. Therefore these interpretations, to varying degrees, reflect the truths of the Qur'an but cannot claim to represent the divine truth in its entirety. Since the interpreters of the Qur'an, like other human beings, are members of certain social groups, located in specific spatio-temporal and social contexts, their understandings of the Qur'an are naturally coloured by their own location.[1] Therefore, it is clear from the view of Engineer that the Qur'an cannot be said to be free from human biases.

Further Engineer argues that, Qur'anic text is also a partial reflection of the Arab society, naturally, as its primary addressees were Arabs. The text, in as much as it is the reflection of Arab society, should be weaned from its value-structure; and it is this value-structure which is fundamental, not its Arab society-related injunctions.[2]

According to Engineer four values - justice ('*adl)*, benevolence (*ihsan*), reason ('*aql*), and wisdom (*hikmah*) serve as the basis of the Qur'an's entire revelation. Thus, for him the basic purpose of the divine text is to bring human

beings closer to God or Allah and exhorts them to work for the welfare of the society basing on these principal values.[3]

Further Engineer appeals for a contextual reading of the Qur'an and argues that the legal pronouncements in the Qur'an as well as in the *Shari'ah* do not have a universal validity across space and time. Thus, as far as he is concerned the legal pronouncements in the Qur'an or *Shari'ah* do not have fundamental importance than the basic values that infuse the text. Rather he insists, they are specific to the particular context of seventh century Arabia when the Qur'an was revealed. To impose them in today's world would be not only old-fashioned but also a violation of the Divine Will.[4] In fact, not only the Qur'an but also any Holy Book should take into consideration the particular social context in which it was revealed.

Applying mechanically the legal pronouncements of the Qur'an borne out of the social context of seventh century Arabia and in to today's context is against the Will of God and the intention of the Prophet. Hence Engineer opines that, it is the duty of the believer to deal judiciously with the Hadith, to extract the fundamental values that underlie in them rather than to follow them to the letter. Based on these values, new laws and structures need to be evolved in accordance with the needs and demands of today's times, that may indeed differ in form from those of seventh century Arabia but which would be based on the same ethical impulse.[5]

Therefore, he argues, Muslims today must develop a new understanding of their faith, a new theology, and a new jurisprudence. Here, we can see Engineer as a different Islamic thinker or a progressive Muslim because, by going directly to the Qur'an, he by-passes centuries of tradition as developed by the *'ulema*. He views the schools of *fiqh* of the traditional *'ulema* as representing a fossilized religion that stresses the letter of the law above its spirit and lacks the capacity to come to terms with the challenges of modernity.[6]

According to him it is unfortunate that Islamic jurisprudence has lost the dynamism it had in earlier centuries. There were more than hundred schools of jurisprudence of which not more than seven survived. Now, Muslims follow these schools but make no effort to bring about a change in view of the new problems arising in the modern world.[7] This cannot be done by traditional jurists (*fuqaba*). They are trained only in traditional Islamic jurisprudence and oppose any deviation from the medieval text produced by the then jurists. Whenever they are asked any question relating to juristic problems, they answer simply by referring to these medieval texts, without in any way, applying their mind to changes which have occurred in the society and the new problems believers are faced with.[8]

In short, as for Engineer, the Qur'an is open to a variety of interpretations, and can be used to justify a diverse range of political projects. His primary

concern is to develop a theology of Islam that is rooted in and relevant to the particular context in which the Muslims of India find themselves placed.

3. Engineer's Views on Women's Rights

All human beings, irrespective of religion, are creatures of God, made from one set of primal parents, and in that sense, equal in His eyes. All human beings both men and women are 'of inestimable divine value' and hence must not just be equally respected, but also equally loved. The Qur'an indeed gives equal rights to women unambiguously (surah 2:228). Thus women interpreting the Qur'an from their perspective, would benefit from the rights given to them by the holy book. In some cases problems also arise because Qur'anic verses have been interpreted in the lights of certain *ahadith; ahadith* is also need to be critically evaluated.[9]

Even if the Qur'an and Sunnah (tradition of the prophet) give equal rights to men and women in Islam, Engineer says that, Muslim women are far behind their counterparts in other parts of the world. Muslim women arguably suffer more because of *Shar'iah* rules whose interpretations are projected as "divine" and 'immutable,' when in fact it is not. This illusion persists among Muslims (men and women) perhaps only because *Shar'iah* is based on the Qur'an and the Hadith.[10]

Engineer vehemently criticizes the existing marriage practices in Islam and male domination. He accuses that, one of the key values of the Qur'an, namely, *adl* (justice), became secondary when it came to women's rights. Whether Islam allows what is now called 'marital rape'? Islamic jurists in all probability will say, yes. After paying the *mehr* (money given to the bride by the bridegroom before marriage) amount, according to Islamic jurists, the husband acquires the right over her and she cannot refuse the 'right' of her husband to come near her.[11] However, if we look at the Qur'anic pronouncements, it is not so. *Mehr* is certainly a necessary part of Islamic marriage and without paying *mehr,* husbands cannot have physical relations with his wife. But it is not true that as soon as she pays, it becomes his unconditional right to have physical intimacy with her.[12]

Taking evidences from the Qur'an Engineer strengthens his arguments. He says, the Qur'an nowhere says that a husband acquires a right over his wife's body after he pays *mehr* to her. It is a very crude conception of marriage. The Qur'an is so sensitive to her rights that it allows her even to refuse to suckle her child, if she decides. Just consider this important verse (65: 6) "Lodge them where you live according to your means… And if they are pregnant, spend on them their recompense, and consult one another in a fair manner and if you both disagree, let another woman suckle the child." This verse makes it clear that man cannot even force his wife to suckle his child and if she does, he has to pay her. Nikkah (marriage) and *mehr* do not make him

'owner of her body'. Thus, a woman alone has the right over her body, not her husband. Unfortunately, traditional Islamic jurisprudence has ignored many pronouncements of the Qur'an in order to read the Qur'an under the influence of patriarchal values.[13]

By taking further evidences from the Qur'an Engineer argues that marriage is a contract in Islam, what the Qur'an calls *ghaliza* (strong covenant) (surah 4:21). However, any contract is subject to certain conditions especially when it comes to marital contract between two human beings.[14] That is why the Qur'an, while describing marriage a covenant, goes much beyond it and treats this relationship between two human beings as tender and sensitive.

The Qur'an considers husband and wife as *libas* (apparel, garment) for each other (2:187) thereby implying that marriage or sexual desire is much more than a natural instinct like hunger or thirst. It has a higher end and marital contract is a means of protection, comfort and embellishment for each other. Thus, describing husband and wife as each other's *libas*, the Qur'an has beautifully describes this relationship.[15]

Also, the Qur'an describes this relationship as *mawaddah* and *rahmah* (30:21), i.e., love and compassion and also seeking solace in each other (*li taskunnu*). This is a very sensitive description of marital relationship. Force and compulsion has no place in it. It will destroy this relationship. *Mawaddah* and *rahmah* are the basis of this relationship.[16] Marriage cannot persist without love and sacrifice for each other. It is not like a piece of land that one can acquire right over, after paying for it.

Here, Engineer exhorts the present generation Muslims to re-read and re-interpret the Qur'an, in the light of the new awareness of woman's sensibilities and to construct a new jurisprudence. He says, traditional jurisprudence has been deeply influenced by the medieval patriarchal values and women lost many of their rights which the Qur'an had given them.[17]

In short, Engineer believed that women should be treated as equal to men, and said that people who support an unjust order, or remain silent in the face of gross injustices are not religious people. Women's inequality topped his priority list of injustices. There is a great need today to restore those rights to women and give them their dignity which was taken away from them.[18] It is regrettable that Muslim men have taken away what was given to women by the Qur'an, by inventing a dubious Hadith which directly contradicts the Qur'anic teachings. They are being treated as less intelligent than men, which is an insult to Allah's creation.

4. Engineer on Islam and Inter-Faith Relations

India is a secularist democratic country and in India different world religions co-exist in a harmonious way, but on some occasions there occurs communal clashes and intolerance between religions. As far as Engineer is concerned

endorsing better relations between Muslims and people of other faith is one of his main concerns. He has been involved in several inter-faith dialogue initiatives, both in India as well as abroad, and has written extensively on the subject. To be religious today is, in fact, to be inter-religious. To ignore the question of religious pluralism and the need for harmonious relations between people of different faiths is very pernicious to the secularist framework of India.

In his book *Secularism, Democracy and Muslim Experience in India* Engineer says inter-faith dialogue has to be a much deeper encounter between faiths which must bring out not only good and desirable elements but also problem areas and conflicts and how to resolve these problem areas."[19] Inter-faith dialogue should be followed by an attempt at conflict resolution, to make it more useful.

According to Engineer, when we come to inter-religious dialogue we should observe some strict discipline also. Those who are heading these dialogues should show true religious spirit and should have the readiness to know the truths in other religions. Any sense of superiority about one's own religion, however subtle, defeats the very purpose. A sense of superiority has ways to assert itself through our ego, individual as well as collective. Engineer asserts that, 'one must realize that no religion can ever be based on falsehood though their faith and traditions may differ for a number of reasons.'[20]

Another argument Engineer puts forward in this regard is that, one should understand that religion and religious communities are two different entities. Religion remains in the theological domain whereas religious communities exist in secular space with secular interests and what comes into conflict are not religious theologies but secular interests of those communities.[21]

It is the basic Islamic beliefthat, a Muslim is supposed to believe in all the 'Revelations of God' (Torah, Psalms, Gospels and Qur'an) and all the prophets of God. Therefore, Engineer says that all religions come from the same source, the one God, and reflect the Truth in different ways. As the Qur'an insists, God has sent prophets to all nations, and all of them have taught the same basic religion or *din*, *al-Islam*or 'submission' to God. Various prophets taught the same religion, but some prophets were assigned with teaching a new law (*shar'iah*) which was meant to suit the particular conditions of the people to whom they were sent.[22]

On the basis of the above explanations Engineer calls for people of various faiths to dialogue with each other on the basis of what they have in common. Participants in inter-religious dialogue, he insists, must abide by certain basic rules. He says,

> They must not assume that their religion is superior to those of others. In addition, they must not simply tolerate other faiths but, in fact, respect their teachings and their integrity. They must also not been motivated by any desire to convert others to their faith. Rather, dialogue must be impelled by a desire to move towards discovering the Truth, which can be approached by being open to multiple expressions of truth that one encounters through dialogue.[23]

In short, when we say about inter-faith dialogue, we should understand that it does not mean accepting the belief systems of another religion rather accepting the other religion and their ritual practices as it is and showing or expressing the readiness to study or know the truths of other religions. Hence, to ignore the question of religious pluralism and the need for harmonious relations between people of different faiths is very pernicious to the secularist framework of India.

5. Engineer on Islam and Secularism

Is Islam compatible with secularism? Both non-Muslims and orthodox Muslims feel that Islam is not compatible with secularism. Fundamentalists among them like Abul Al'a Maududi totally reject secularism as anti-Islamic and *harm (forbidden/not permitted)*. Here we see the shift in Engineer's thinking. According to Engineer Islam is declared to be incompatible with secularism because in a secular state there is no place for divine laws (theocracy) and the secular laws are unacceptable to Islam. It is believed that in Islam, religion and politics cannot be separated.[24]

It is to be noted that in seventh century Arabia there was no concept of secularism as a philosophy of humanism. In fact, one does not find clear enunciation to the effect that religion cannot be separated from politics in Islam in any early Islamic source. Because, before the advent of Islam, there was no state concept or structure in Mecca or Medina. There were obviously no written laws, but only tribal customs and tradition. A state structure began to evolve only after the death of Mohammad.[25]

Further Engineer elucidates the reasons why Islam is incompatible with secularism. He says there were various factors such as the conquests, internal strife among the Muslims, struggle for power and many other factors that created strong pressures, so much so that the caliphate itself did not survive. It was ultimately replaced by monarchy and dynastic rule, which was totally against the spirit of the Qur'an. These changes became inevitable under the fast growing situation. The Islamic jurists had to come to terms with these new developments and legitimize them somehow. Besides these reasons he says, in most of the Muslim countries, including India, Islam was embraced by the weaker and poorer sections of the society, for it appealed to them due to its emphasis on equality and justice. They had not felt the need for modernization

and remained under the tight grip of traditional *ulema* who were anyway opposed to the process of secularization.[26]

On the basis of the present day Muslim world Engineer explains that there are different political systems in different Islamic countries from monarchy to military dictatorship, to limited democracy to democracy, but it will be naïve to blame Islam for this. One has to look into the political history of the country rather than search for its causes in religious doctrines.[27] Thus, for Engineer, the position that religion and politics cannot be separated in Islam is a later historical construct than a Qur'anic doctrine.

In formulating a theology of Islam suited to the contemporary Indian context, Engineer deals at length with the debate on the relation between Islam and politics, in particular with the notion of the Islamic state. Engineer argues that:

> The Qur'an contains no mandate or blueprint for an Islamic state, for its main concern is not with the state but, rather, with society. It speaks, he says, of an 'ideal society', and not of an 'ideal polity.' Prophet Mohammad was not commissioned by God to establish a state, although he did so in Medina. To insist on an Islamic state, either, as in India, where Muslims are a minority, or in Muslim-majority countries, is thus against the Divine Will, for the historical *shari'ah*, the corpus of law that Islamists see the 'Islamic state' as charged with implementing, has little or no relevance in today's age, having been formulated in a completely different context.[28]

As a progressive Muslim, Engineer contends that nations are a product of shared culture, history and locality. Religion alone cannot be the basis for national identity. The Muslim *ummah* then is purely a religious unity and not a political community that includes all Muslims. The treaty of Medina between the Prophet and the Jews and pagan Arabs of Medina defined all of them as members of one single *ummah*, the denizens of Medina. This clearly suggests, Engineer argues, that nationality is not determined by religion.[29] On the basis of the above arguments Engineer clearly pronounces a radical view point as far as the present day Muslim politics is concerned. He says,

> The project to create a pan-Islamic polity based on the notion of the Muslim *ummah* as a political unit is not only impractical, but, in fact, is contrary to the practice of the Prophet. Since nationality is thus seen as based on shared locality and culture, Muslims can, indeed, must, willingly accept the fact that they belong to different nationalities and that in most cases, as in India, they share their nationality with people of other faiths.[30]

Hence, he underlines the fact that theocracy theory of Maududi and such other fundamentalists*ulema* is impractical and against the spirit of Qur'an and Prophet.

6. Engineer's Democratic Concerns

This topic is very much connected to what is discussed above about secularism, because both are two sides of a coin. Is Islam undemocratic by nature of its teachings? Why doesn't any Muslim country have a democratic set up? Why almost all Muslim countries are governed either by kings, sheikhs and military dictators or have a semi-democratic set up? For these questions Engineer answers with a counter question. Is Islam responsible for this state of affairs of Muslims? Or can any religion be democratic or undemocratic? He says, Islam was born in a society where there was no formal political structure of state machinery. It was essentially a tribal society without any ruler or formal state structures -no written laws, only tribal customs.[31]

A truly democratic society should not only accord equal opportunities to all citizens and make them equal before law but should also see that it is so in practice. Mohammad tried to form such a society in his time. However, the Muslims States today treat non-Muslims as second-class citizens and deprive them of equal rights. The modern democratic society accords Muslims, wherever they are, and equal political rights, even when in minority though the Muslim countries -not all, but many-do not do so.[32] He further states that the Islamic democracy, as prevailed in the days of Mohammad and four Caliphs could not be revived again. All succeeding regimes in Arab as well as the non-Arab world were dynastic and had nothing to do with elective principle. Islamic political culture became more and more feudalized.[33]

The Islamic society, thereafter, never saw the return of the early Caliphate period, despite several attempts by idealists. Though the rulers often styled themselves as Caliphs, but in fact, they were absolute rulers. These political developments also had its impact on Islamic jurisprudence in many ways. The '*ulema*, who interpreted the Qur'an and Hadith, did so under the influence of feudal values. Many of them went against the spirit of Islam and justified the feudal hierarchy and monarchial system. Thus, the islamic world was ruled by corrupt and power-hungry monarchs and kings (Hosni Mubarak, Muammar Al-Gadhafi etc.).

Engineer states that the entire Arab world lacks any mass leader of any caliber as the authoritarian rulers use highly repressive policies and do not allow any such leader to emerge. He states some of the examples of democracies in the Muslim world such as Egypt, Malaysia etc., but says that these countries are supported by '*ulema* who are the moral authorities of Islam and the rulers are using Islam to legitimize their rule. Besides, any movement for human

rights is condemned as Western conspiracy against Islam, even though human dignity and freedom of conscience is central to the teachings of the Qur'an.[34]

In Engineer's view it is the economic and political conditions that are more responsible for the lack of democracy in Islamic world than Islamic teachings. However, the Muslim intellectuals must reflect seriously on the question as to why Muslim countries still have not been able to usher in true democracy, despite the claim that Islam is most democratic in spirit. Without democratizing the Muslim world, no worthwhile changes can be made. Absence of democracy means subjugation of the masses and modern reforms will not be possible without ushering in democratic governance[35]

Based on the above said arguments, Engineer proposes some solutions[36] to establish a democratic set up in the Islamic world.

a) **Freedom of conscience**: Democratic governance is not possible without ensuring freedom of conscience, which is the very foundational principle of democracy, which does not exist in any Muslim country worth the name.
b) **The Islamic *Shar'iah* should be reformulated**: Islamic law was compiled in different social and political environs and most of the inferences were drawn by the '*ulema* in their own socio-political conditions. Hence, it needs to be reformulated. The inference drawn by the '*ulema* or *fuquba'* cannot be treated as divine. The expert jurists and modern lawyers from the community need to come together to change some of the *Shari'ah* laws in the sphere of what is called *mu'amaalt*.
c) **Gender equality**: The laws, as they obtain today, are heavily loaded against women, while gender equality is an integral part of any democratic culture. Some of the Muslim countries do not even permit women to drive, citing Islamic regulations.
d) **Freedom of religion**: Many Muslim countries have substantial non-Muslim populations. In democratic governance, it is necessary to ensure freedom of religion. Muslim minorities enjoy equal democratic and political rights in non-Muslim or secular countries such as in Europe and the United States of America. This must be ensured to non-Muslims in Muslim countries too, not for the sake of reciprocation but based on fundamental human rights. However, in most of the Muslim counties, even Muslims do not enjoy democratic rights, let alone non-Muslims. Separate electorate, if it exists in any country, should also be done away with for it breeds discriminatory practices. There should be joint electorate for all Muslims and non-Muslims.

e) **Lastly**, **respect for human rights:** It is highly necessary in a democratic political culture. Without this, there cannot be a truly democratic culture. Muslim intellectuals should ceaselessly strive to ensure human rights for all citizens in Islamic countries. It is this human rights culture which will strengthen democratic forces and do away with feudal culture.[37]

Thus Engineer seeks to argue that democracy is not only not foreign to Islam, but actually contained in it. He suggests that in the present age the most appropriate form of that *shur'a* (governing councilin Islam) is political democracy, which, while it differs in form from the *shur'a* practiced by the Prophet and the early Muslims, preserves and promotes its fundamental values and spirit. In this way, for both Muslim majority countries as well as countries where Muslims are a minority, the most Islamically acceptable form of the polity in today's context would be a secular, democratic state wherein all religious groups are granted equal rights and freedoms, and governed according to laws made by the representatives of the people. The scope of the *shari'ah* should be restricted to the private sphere. The secular, democratic state is able to legislate on matters that traditional *'ulama* as well as Islamists consider as having already been covered by God's laws.[38]

7. Critical Appraisal of Engineer's Views

It is an undoubted fact that Engineer is an unparalleled Islamic Indian scholar, but most of his views are not in line with most of the Islamic scholars. While admitting the multiple readings of the Qur'anic text, Engineer implicitly suggests that his own reading of the text is normative. The struggle for social justice, peace and harmony, Engineer's principal concerns, thus determines how he reads the Qur'an. At the same time, he fails to reply to the claims of other Muslims who might offer radically different readings based on a different set of values that they see as underlying the Qur'anic text. He replies that his purpose is to develop a contextual understanding of the Qur'an; for, the manner in which both the context and the political project are defined inevitably influences how the text is read.

It is a claim by most of the Muslims that scriptures other than the Qur'an are corrupted, only the Qur'an is uncorrupted. For that Engineer argues that these scripturalist traditions as they exist today remain in their pristine purity, as revealed to their prophets, and that, hence, Muslims must regard them as true, (because their source is from the same God) which is a notion not many Muslims would agree with.

Further, Engineer's views on Islam and politics, is mainly in line with secularism and democracy. He bases his argument on the Qur'an and Prophetic tradition, but many Islamic scholars considered Mohammad as the head of the

state of Medina or the political community of Medina. Similarly, Engineer's invoking the principle of *shu'ra* to legitimize political democracy is also inspired by his own politics, and does not emanate directly from the Prophetic example itself, for although the Qur'an advised the Prophet to consult his followers, he was not bound by their advice. Likewise, as per Yoginder Sikand, in order to provide 'Islamic' sanction to political democracy he reduces Islam to a set of values, and restricts the application of Islamic law to the personal sphere, paying scant regard to the concept of law in early Muslim history.[39]

8. Conclusion

In short, it appears that Engineer's own theology of Islam is determined, above all, by his considerations that emanate from outside the Qur'anic text, and, in several crucial respects, bears little relation to the ways in which Islam has been understood by Muslims throughout history. His understanding of Islam is indelibly shaped by his concern for social justice and inter-communal harmony, of course.[40] However, given the fact that in many parts of the world today conflicts involve Muslims and people of other faith, these being generally defined as 'Islamic' *jihads* by radical Islamists, Engineer's creative approach to the Qur'an offers us an alternate way of imagining Islam and Islamic rules for relations between Muslims and others. In turn this way of approaching Islam presents Islam as an instrument of peace instead of a tool for war and bloodshed, which can help counter the appeal of radical Islamism and help work towards the peaceful resolution of many conflicts in which Muslims are involved at present.

Notes

1 Yoginder Sikand, "Asghar 'Ali Engineer's Quest for an Islamic Theology of Peace and Religious Pluralism," <http://www.svabhinava.org/MeccaBenares/YoginderSikand/AsgharAliEngineerIslamicTheology-frame.php.>
2 Asghar Ali Engineer, *On Developing Theology of Peace in Islam*, (New Delhi: Sterling Publications Pvt. Ltd., 2003), vii.
3 Yoginder Sikand,"Asghar 'Ali Engineer's Quest for an Islamic Theology of Peace and Religious Pluralism."
4 Asghar Ali Engineer, *On Developing Theology of Peace in Islam*, 42.
5 Yoginder Sikand, "Asghar 'Ali Engineer's Quest for an Islamic Theology of Peace and Religious Pluralis."
6 *Ibid*.
7 *Ibid*.
8 Asghar Ali Engineer, *Islam Restructuring Theology* (New Delhi: Vitasta Publishing Pvt. Ltd., 2012.), i.
9 *Ibid.*, 4.
10 *Ibid.*, 3.
11 *Ibid.*, 4.
12 *Ibid.*, 5.
13 *Ibid.*, 7.

14 *Ibid.*, 6.
15 *Ibid.*, 7.
16 *Ibid.*, 7.
17 *Ibid.*, 8.
18 Asghar Ali Engineer, *On Developing Theology of Peace in Islam*, 58.
19 Asghar Ali Engineer, *Secularism Democracy and Muslim Experience in India*, (Gurgaon: Hope India Publications, 2010), 23.
20 *Ibid.,* 23.
21 *Ibid.,* 24.
22 Yoginder Sikand,"Asghar 'Ali Engineer's Quest for an Islamic Theology of Peace and Religious Pluralism," accessed date is not known.
23 *Ibid*.
24 Asghar Ali Engineer, *On Developing Theology of Peace in Islam*, 39.
25 *Ibid.*, 40-41.
26 *Ibid.*, 42-44.
27 *Ibid.*, 48-49.
28 Yoginder Sikand, "Asghar 'Ali Engineer's Quest for an Islamic Theology of Peace and Religious Pluralism," accessed date is not known.
29 *Ibid*.
30 *Ibid*.
31 Asghar Ali Engineer, *On Developing Theology of Peace in Islam*, 81-82.
32 *Ibid.*, 83.
33 *Ibid.*, 86-87.
34 *Ibid.*, 89.
35 *Ibid.*, 90.
36 *Ibid.*, 90-91.
37 *Ibid.*, 90-91.
38 Yoginder Sikand, "Asghar 'Ali Engineer's Quest for an Islamic Theology of Peace and Religious Pluralism," accessed date is not known.
39 *Ibid*.
40 *Ibid*.

16

Bishop as a Patriot
Azariah's Negotiations Between Indigenization and Nationalism

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Abstract: The paper is set against the eventful life of V.S. Azariah (1874 – 1945), the first ever Indian Anglican bishop, and the first bishop of the Anglican diocese of Dornakal. It deals with the negotiations of Azariah, starting with his own Church's attempts at indigenization, in the Orientalist imagination of its Western Leadership. As Modern India's foremost leader of Dalit Mass Movements he comes into conflict, both with Gandhi and with Ambedkar, on the issue of Dalit conversions. After a brief introductory note, and a framework of suspicion, the paper unfolds itself in three main sections: Azariah's negotiations with indigenizing Christianity; Azariah and Gandhi: Companions-in-Arms, in Conflict and; Azariah and Ambedkar: Divergent Paths of Identity Assertion. As the work progresses, subtexts like conversion, democracy, secularism, freedom of religion, agency and subjecthood of the subalterns, would be revisited and unmasked. The short concluding note, asks whether the questions of identity, religion and nationalism, placed by Gandhi, Azariah and Ambedkar, under mutual provocation, have not returned to haunt us in our own "Post-Nehruvian" times. The work concludes with a challenge, drawing inspiration from Azariah to embark on a journey towards the emergence of a post-denominational and post-ritual indigenous Indian Church.

1. Introduction

Bishop V.S. Azariah (1874 – 1945), who was the first ever Indian Bishop of the Anglican Church, hailed from the Tirunelveli district of Tamil Nadu. He had the singular credit of having been one of the pioneers of the ecumenical movement. As the first Indian bishop of the Anglican Church in India, and also the first bishop of the newly formed diocese of Dornakal, he stood out as modern India's most successful leader of the depressed class and non-Brahmin conversion movements to Christianity. From this platform of leadership, he came into conflict with Mahatma Gandhi, who resisted the indigenous Christian missionaries, who were 'converting' the Harijans.[1] He also had an encounter with Ambedkar, against the background of Ambedkar's inviting the depressed classes to leave Hinduism, to convert to other religions.[2] "Azariah's life seems to embody, contain, and sum up many of the difficult tensions of his age, in the areas of religion, culture, and political ideals, a metaphorical 'human recapitulation' of the many social transformations which accompanied the transition from empire to independence."[3]

More than being an exercise in critical biography, much less in hagiography, the thrust of the present work is self-consciously interpretative, under the theme of the "Hermeneutic of Suspicion," enquiring into the struggles of an ordained leader of the Church, negotiating between his own Church, in the throes of indigenization on the one hand, and the growing tide of nationalism in the country, in the twilight of the British *Raj*, on the other.

2. Towards a Framework of Hermeneutics of Suspicion

In this section, we build up a hermeneutical framework of suspicion, in view of analyzing the different layers of negotiations, engaged in by Azariah. "… [H]ermeneutics of suspicion, in other words, is a term applicable to a diverse range of critical frameworks. While psychoanalytical feminism, New Historicism, and postcolonial criticism, to name just a few current approaches, are characterized by obvious differences in focus and method, they share the conviction that the most rigorous reading is one that is performed against the grain, that the primary rationale for reading a text is to critique it by underscoring what it does not know and cannot understand."[4]

2.1 Heidegger, Gadamer and Habermas in Conversation

In this process of building up a hermeneutical framework, the Heideggerian Copernican Revolution in Hermeneutics, achieved by the "*Destruktion*", is of inspiration to us. It is a process where, ontology is transformed under the *guidance or question of* being, and hermeneutics is transformed as the art of unmasking of the hidden, unspoken and the *unthought*. This gives rise to a new understanding of hermeneutics, conducted against the horizon of "language" inscribing it with a primordial ground for suspicion.[5]

Gadamer builds upon this Heideggerian "ontological turn" in hermeneutics, and stresses on tradition.[6] Habermas's chief criticism against Gadamer is that his stress on tradition is forgetful of the distanciation from the text of tradition. In the absence of distance, our ability to criticize rationally the powerful discourses, driven by interests and power which lead to various forms of domination, is weakened.[7]

2.2 Ricoeur's Dialogical / Programmatic Contribution to the Debate

Ricoeur enters into the debate between Gadamer and Habermas, wherein there is apparent opposition between Tradition (Gadamer) and Critique of Ideology (Habermas), through his hermeneutic of suspicion, which, rather than cancelling out the opposition, between the stances of Gadamer and Habermas, foregrounds the complementarity between the two positions. The thematic of "Hermeneutic of Suspicion" has reference to the three Masters of Suspicion: Nietzsche, Freud and Marx. The toolkit of hermeneutics of suspicion has as its components, distanciation or alienation from tradition, depth semantics of the text, critique of ideology and the element of self-understanding. Ricoeur's call for the reanimation of traditional sources of communicative action reawakens a sense of political responsibility, towards creative transformation, through cultural change. Further, a philosophy of living metaphor, which dwells on the richness of symbols, is also part of the Ricoeurian hermeneutics of suspicion.[8] While it is true that the three masters were busy about unmasking and destroying false consciousness, they cannot be labelled as mere skeptics. Rather, "All three clear the horizon for a more authentic word, for a new reign of Truth, not only by means of a 'destructive' critique, but by the invention of an art of interpreting."[9]

2.3 Suspicion of Suspicion: Towards a Spiral and Networked Reading

In the context of the genealogical approach to the contributions of the Masters of Suspicion, we have to move from a *reading* under suspicion to an *allied* reading, a reading in networking, respecting the text as an *agent within the network*, a process, where the text and the interpreter are both participants.[10] "The solidarity in 'solidarity reading' would not then refer to the political identity of the author, but rather to the frame in which multiple and conflicting struggles solidify around, through and within a text."[11]

" … Ricoeur distinguishes between a hermeneutics of suspicion and a hermeneutics of trust, between a reading which tears off masks and one which seeks to restore and recollect meaning."[12] "What is needed is both a hermeneutics of suspicion, but also a suspicion of that suspicion!"[13] "… [A] suspicious hermeneutic does not automatically remove a text from circulation but may also endow it with fresh vitality by hooking up to new agendas,

debates, and audiences. Animus, after all, can inspire a fervid and concentrated attention, an exceptionally diligent focus on the object that is being critiqued."[14]

3. Azariah's Negotiations with Indigenizing Christianity

In this section, I bring together the different aspects of the negotiations of Azariah with his own Church, which was struggling to indigenize itself, a process more inspired by a section of the leadership who were of Western origin and of Orientalist[15] inspiration. Azariah did have his own view of the identity of the Church/Christianity in India, and his own evolving programmatic for indigenizing the Anglican Church in India. The conflicting paradigms of identity and indigenization also entailed a play on the hermeneutics of suspicion. I intend capturing the salient points under the themes of "Give us Friends"; Indigenization of the Structural/Cultural Grid; Indigenization as Agency-Informed Partnership; Beyond Denominationalism: Radical Indigenization; and Well-being as Salvation: Earthiness of Indigenization.

3.1 "Give us Friends"

A definitive voice against the dependence of Asian Churches and the undermining of their legitimate subjecthood and freedom sounded loud and clear at the Edinburgh missionary conference of 1910. The huge assembly of over 1200 white men and women were dotted by 19 delegates from the global South. Among the few participants from Asia was V.S. Azariah who would become later the Anglican bishop of Dornakal, Andhra Pradesh. His was one of the most remarkable speeches in the assembly. Working with people in the dusty soil of remote Indian villages, and noticing the ways of missionaries, Azariah was convinced that doing a lot of mission work may not signify much, unless we enter into the world of the people and relate with them as subjects. There was need of an approach that respects them, their experiences and their unique ways.[16] "You have given your goods to feed the poor. You have given your bodies to be burned. We also ask for love. Give us FRIENDS!"[17]

The distanced approach to mission, where the Asian co-workers in mission, and the people of the mission, found their agency instrumentalized, stood in need of a turn-around. The people are not mere objects of mission. Where there is friendship and mutuality, the door of freedom is open for people to understand and appropriate Christian faith in their unique way, and to give shape to their own communities of faith or Churches.[18] The people, in their agency, are readers of texts of their own lives and the lives of others, and hermeneutes of suspicion. This is amply testified by the shift in readings, in the life-text of Azariah himself.

Young Azariah, given his childhood-experience of Christianity in Tirunelveli, did not feel Asian conversion to Christianity to be an Asian subordination to the West, and emerged in the public space as a member of the

YMCA. He grew up to its leadership ranks and embraced the ideal of missionary activism at the threshold of an era which became increasingly antagonistic to his vision of national regeneration via conversion to Christianity.[19] He had struck deep friendships with the members of the YMCA, who were Westerners, especially in the person of Eddy George Sherwood with whom he shared ideological common ground. In 1896, he enjoined his colleagues in the YMCA, on the need of sympathy, love and friendship, in the mission-field that was India.[20]

Though he could get into the shoes of the Indian, in his hurt feelings, he never considered himself a victim, but rather, himself equally capable of racial hatred. In this context, without idealizing Indian practices, he likened the caste prejudices to the very western prejudices he abhorred.[21] Nevertheless, in the run up to his ordination, as the first ever Indian Anglican bishop of Dornakal, he did have taste of the paternalistic, overbearing and patronizing attitudes of the Western colonial missionaries. As Azariah was trying to build up his identity as an Indian Bishop, even during the preparation for his ordination, Bishop Whitehead of Madras, his mentor, and his wife Isabel Whitehead were intruding into his personal space, with their Orientalist imagination, with regard to his Episcopal attire and regalia.[22] The symbolic indignities Azariah experienced during this time of identity formation and identity related anxieties, communicated to his wife Anbu, formed the texture of the genealogy of his Edinburg Speech, centred around the theme, "Give us Friends". In it, he was giving expression, to his annoyance over Mrs. Whitehead's patronizing ways, and to his resistance to the paternalism of the assembled missionaries.[23] The speech was revelatory of his commitment to an indigenization, from bottom-up, with dignity, with respect for the agency of himself and his people, the emergence and the expression of the *Homo Dialecticus*[24] in him.

In spite of the opposition of the condescension of many missionaries, and more especially from the Telugu Christians, Azariah, the Tamil outsider, from the Thinneveli Christian Nadar background, one without a college degree, was consecrated bishop of Dornakal in 1912. He was chosen, as he symbolized what many Britons considered as genuinely Indian peasant masses, rather than the westernized upper classes, with rising national aspirations and European pretensions.[25] In spite of being an *outsider*, he became a friend, an *insider*, if we are to go by this testimony of the flock of Dornakal, regarding Azariah, in comparison, with other Tamil missionaries.[26]

3.2 Indigenization of the Structural/Cultural Grid

Azariah saw Christianity, neither as alien to India, and so to be subordinated to nationalism, nor as an agent of imperialism. His vision was to indigenize Christianity within the vast Indian subcontinent and transcending both in India, and the world, the divisions that blunted the Christian message. The Indian

Missionary Society (IMS) and National Missionary Society (NMS) were, by far, the largest and most ambitious missionary endeavours, which were organizationally rooted in the soil of India, and which were networking with the other native Indian churches. Under Azariah's leadership, both IMS and NMS became remarkable examples of movements that achieved independence from and equality with western missionary societies without developing any major strain in working relationships. The Protestant Christian missionaries were catering to caste, regional and ethnic aspirations, but in near total isolation from the political nationalist movements.[27]

Azariah advocated both 'structural indigenization' (by which the control of western missions was transferred to Indians) and 'cultural indigenization' (by which western style institutions and forms of religious expression were transformed into their Indian equivalents). He was committed to building a self-sufficient church under an Indian priesthood and to planting the roots of Christianity deeply in Telugu soil. However, he was also committed to maintaining the Indian church's membership both in the multi-national Anglican Communion and in the 'universal' church. He was never comfortable with the more radical doctrines of the educated, urban-based 'cultural indigenizers' who rejected the traditional institutional church and orthodox theology in favour of allegedly more 'indigenous' alternatives derived from non-Christian models.[28] He had developed educational techniques for instructing the villagers about topics such as prayer, without making them dependent on foreign concepts. For example, Azariah had abandoned the set form of the Telugu Lord's prayer, ending with the Aramaic 'Amen' and permitted converts to devise forms, more tailored to their own needs.[29]

3.3 Indigenization as Agency-Informed Partnership

The Jerusalem meeting of the International Missionary Council (1928) urged missionary societies from 'older churches' to establish relationships with 'younger churches' based on partnership rather than leadership. Following the direction provided at Edinburgh and Jerusalem, Azariah took the lead at the 1938 International Missionary Council meeting at Thambram in stressing that the Church should be the centre of missionary activity as 'the divinely appointed instrument of evangelism to the world'. He was very intimately associated with all the developments related to missionary partnership, as President of the National Christian Council of India, Burma and Ceylone (NCC) from 1928 to 1945.[30] The indigenization strategies, as well as the movement towards the autonomy of the churches, also drew inspiration from the political ferment of the national movement, though he himself kept away from involving in the movement of nationalism. In a sermon delivered on the 121st anniversary of CMS in London, Azariah emphasized on the need for autonomy and financial independence and sustainability of the indigenous churches.[31]

Azariah also considered the missionary policy of withholding the right to both self-government and self-propagation until Indian congregations were financially independent, to be founded upon a fundamental theological error.[32] Going along with his programmatic of indigenization, he asserted the autonomy and agency of the growing indigenous churches. He wished that the indigenous churches had autonomy, without strings attached. "For Azariah, whether or not European missionaries occupied prominent positions in his diocese or financial support came from the West was less important than whether or not those positions and that money were placed under the clear authority of the native church."[33] Azariah's most visible contribution to indigenization was his Dornakal Cathedral, which mixed architectural elements and symbolism from Hindu, Muslim and Christian traditions into a wholly unique synthesis.[34]

3.4 Beyond Denominationalism: Radical Indigenization

According to Azariah, denominationalism was an alien export from Europe. To Indian Christians, Western denominational boundaries were 'totally meaningless' and destructive of their unity as a community. It permitted Indian converts of different castes to preserve and even strengthen their social separations by joining churches of different denominations.[35] The process of overcoming Denominationalism was considered by Azairah, as part and parcel of the process of indigenization, paving way to a more impact-filled Christian witness, in a non-Christian land.[36] Azariah was intimately involved with all of the major personalities and organizations who pioneered South Indian ecumenism.[37]

He often described church unification as part of larger program of church indigenization. '*We must have one Church*. He wanted a Church of India, to be a Church where the Indian religious genius can find natural expression. Azariah's struggle to unite different denominations was ultimately successful, with the formation of the Church of South India, in 1947, two years before his death.[38]

3.5 Well-Being as Salvation: Earthiness of Indigenization

Azariah had a positive view on non-Christan faiths and a willingness to integrate elements of Indian culture into Christian life. This was an expression of his pastoral vision, whereby the Church might serve the dual role as an agent both of cultural change and cultural continuity. Bishop claimed that Christianity possessed power to bring cleanliness, power to civilize, power to drive away degrading habits, power to raise economic status and to make the illiterate village, an effective witness. "Azariah's gospel message contained not 'the power of God unto salvation' but also 'a power of God unto rural up-lift, unto economic freedom and unto social advance. In short, it contained the 'secret of national regeneration'."[39] "God's servants cannot be messengers

of God and his salvation without being also ministers of health and good-living."[40]

The primordial posture of the subaltern being the daily struggle for survival, well-being, which is primordially socio-economic in character, is salvation and wholeness,[41] as Azariah, the keen hermeneute of the people, intuited from his flesh and contact with the flock. In the identity and existence of the subalterns, religiosity and political economy are entwined, the *Homo Economicus* and *Homo Ritualis* merge into each other, in the space of an *Economic Sacred*.[42] Gandhi too, like Azariah, was keenly aware of this interrelationship between political economy and religion. "Whereas religion to be worth, anything, must be capable of being reduced to terms of economics, economics to be worth anything must be capable of being reduced to terms of religion and spirituality."[43]

4. Azariah's Negotiations with Nationalism

In this section, we attempt at capturing in broad outlines, Azariah's negotiations with nationalism, as reflected in his intersections with Gandhi, especially their conflict on the thorny issue of conversion of the depressed classes. We will also be taking note of the encounter between Azariah and Ambedkar, on the same issue of conversion of the depressed classes.

4.1 Azariah and Gandhi: Companions-in-Arms, in Conflict

Azariah agreed in some ways with Gandhi's *Hind Swaraj*, in its criticism of Westernized Indian professional doctors and lawyers for betraying India's innate spiritual values. He also shared much of Gandhi's frustration and resentment toward patronizing Westerners and their institutions, but he never either fully adopted or decisively rejected Western cultural norms or political legitimacy.[44]

He had an alliance with Gandhi, opposing the Communal Award of 1932, by which separate electorates were to be awarded to the minorities and the depressed classes. Azariah worked under the logic that Communal Award would undermine his objective of identifying the Indian Christian with aspirations of a prospectively independent and politically unified, though culturally pluralistic Indian nation. Though the Poona Pact eliminated the double voting privilege, it did not include Christians in the general electorate. There was now growing competition for depressed class political allegiance, and this raised the potential danger that Christian evangelism and its mass conversions[45] of untouchables might be used as political instruments. Gandhi stepped up attacks on Christian missions, implying that their work was secretly political because it was stealing Harijans from the Hindu fold. This propelled Bishop Azariah into a heated debate with the Mahatma over the extent and legitimacy of mass

conversions among depressed classes. In 1936 and 1937, Gandhi's criticisms of Christian missionary activity increased both in frequency and bitterness.[46]

There was an attempt at reconciliation initiated by India Conciliation group between Gandhi and Azariah, Gandhi's principal Indian Christian adversary.[47] The Gandhi-Azariah-Pickett meeting, the subsequent controversy, and further statements from Gandhi on conversion worsened the suspicion of many Indian Christians (and other religious minorities) that modern organized or what Professor Romila Thapar has called 'syndicated' Hinduism was becoming too closely associated with nationalism.[48]

4.2 Azariah: A Patriot, and a Hesitant Nationalist[49]

Azariah was urging his flock to support the Congress' initiatives against drinking, rural indebtedness and illiteracy, as an expression of the Indian Christian's civic commitment.[50] Invoking Queen Victoria's 1858 proclamation on religious toleration, the *Magna Carta* of the Indian people on religious tolerance, Azariah argued against the preferential treatment of any religion and challenged Gandhi's many insinuations, that by converting from Hinduism, Indian Christians had betrayed their native heritage and forfeited their legitimacy as nationalists.[51] He was countering Gandhi's philosophy of religion, that implied that all religions were merely different paths to the same truth, and considered it as Gandhi's legitimizing his own newly aggressive and hegemonic relativism, under the cloak of religious tolerance.[52]

Though advocates of the Communal Electorates criticized that leaders like Azariah were not realistic enough to perceive the potential dangers in their stance, Azariah never abandoned his visionary public campaign for a politics that transcended petty gain-seeking.[53] While endorsing the general cause of India's freedom, he asked whether the Indian Christians, eighty-five percent of whom were those belonging to the depressed classes who have been living in slavery and degradation, might not be deprived of liberty and fundamental material and religious rights by dominant caste Hindus in an independent India.[54] Though in the early 1930s, Azariah had belittled the suggestion that Christians would face increased dangers in an independent India, towards the end of the decade, Azariah became concerned that the Indian church might suffer serious persecution in the future. He was of the view that the Indian Church was not threatened, not so much by outright barbarism, as by subtle oppression and intolerant interference. Yet he was hopeful that such a crisis has not come to India, and probably it may never come, because of the Indian genius for toleration, accommodation and sufferance. Yet he did not discount the possibility of a persecution of Christians in independent India.[55]

4.3 Azariah and Ambedkar: Divergent Paths of Identity Assertion

As indicated, the new electoral arrangements, following the grant of separate electorates in the Communal Award, and the subsequent Poona Pact in 1932, conversion, or more often the threat of conversion, was made a powerful political tool for depressed class leaders to gain concessions from dominant caste groups. Threats of conversion made in Western India by B.R. Ambedkar (first in 1935) and in Travancore by leaders of the Izhava community (especially in 1936) gained widespread attention during this period. Ambedkar's much-publicized Yeola Conference announcement in 1935, that he would lead a mass movement out of Hinduism, was greeted with skepticism and caution, by the Christian leadership. It was considered by them, to be a move to draw social and political mileage, rather than being an authentic religious statement. Nevertheless, Azariah saw these mass movements, including the demand for Temple Entry, to be playing a providential role, like many other spiritually ambiguous political events of the past. He agreed with Bishop Pickett, the expert on the study of the mass movements, that such movements were an 'natural' way for India. Consequently, they were ready to invest human and financial resources for mass movements of conversion. He considered 1930s to be a *kairos* for mass movements into Christianity, as an alternative to Hinduism.[56]

In spite of all these high expectations, an event of a humbling nature led Azariah to re-invest confidence in the effectiveness of long-term ecclesiastically based missionary endeavours, than in the superficial promise that untouchables might be brought *en masse* into the church by the persuasive power of any political leaders. In 1936, a personal interview with Ambedkar deeply embarrassed and disturbed Azariah. Criticizing the church for its denominational disunity which impeded the political objectives of the untouchables *en bloc,* as well as for the persistence within it of caste prejudice, Ambedkar asked Azariah, 'If we become Christians can we all be united in one Church wherever we live? And will we be entirely free from all saste prejudice?' Later on, Azariah reminisced his embarrassment, 'I have never felt so ashamed in my life because I couldn't say YES to either question – I could only come away in disgrace.' Azariah often recalled Ambedkar's criticism of Christianity when seeking support in his later years for the unification of churches in South India.[57]

5. Conclusion

It is time now, to gather the fruits of the hermeneutical journey of suspicion we undertook in the company of Azariah, in his negotiations with indigenization of his own Church, as well as in his negotiations with nationalism. The fears of Azariah, about the future of the depressed classes, would seem to have been misplaced, as the Nehruvian Idea of India unfolded, which committed itself

to be a democratic, secular and socialist republic.[58] But in the Post-Nehruvian India of today, under the shadow of a *Hindurashtra*,[59] the questions of Azariah, the patriot, though a hesitant nationalist, seem to be returning to haunt us; Especially if the atrocities being perpetrated against the Dalits, women, the Third Subalterns and the Minorities, on a quotidian note, with all the banality, obfuscations and the culture of post-truth and alternative facts shrouding them, are any testimony. Azariah was a people's bishop and a people's hermenute, and a hermeneute of suspicion, if we are to go by the interrogations, the unmasking he brought to the enterprise of indigenization and nation-building under the avowed and unabashed rubric of Christianization. This was coupled with a new thrust of soteriology, of well-being as salvation, evolved by him, the pastor, who knew the smell of the soil, in which, and the sheep with and for whom he worked. His art of *spiral*, *networked reading* of the signs of the times, places and the people beckon us, in turn, to become hermeneutes of suspicion, cultivating an alternative reading and weaving an alternative narrative, with and for our people in a new language of identity, recognition and respect.[60] "Would we be friends to one another, in the nation?" "If we become Christians can we all be united in one Church wherever we live?" "And will we be entirely free from all caste prejudice?" Challenged by these questions, both of Azariah and Ambedkar, would we embark on an Indian ecclesial journey, daring to imagine and initiate a process, towards the emergence of a Post-denominational and Post-ritual Indian Church?

Notes

1 Susan Billington Harper, *In the Shadow of the Mahatma: Bishop V.S. Azariah and the Travails of Christianity in British India* (Cambridge: William B. Eerdmans, 2000), 300 -18.
2 *Ibid*., 312-13.
3 *Ibid*., 6.
4 Rita Felski, "Suspicious Minds," *Poetics Today* 32, no. 2 (Summer 2011): 217.
5 Purushottama Bilimoria, "Towards a Creative Hermeneutic of Suspicion: Recovering Ricoeur's Intervention in the Gadamer-Habermas Debate," 4, <https://www.bu.edu/wcp / Papers /Cont / Bili.html.> (6 October, 2017).
6 *Ibid*., 7.
7 *Ibid*., 7-9.
8 *Ibid*., 9-10.
9 G.D. Robinson, "Paul Ricoeur and the Hermeneutics of Suspicion: A Brief Overview and Critique," *Premise* 2, no. 8 (September, 1995), 12, accessed 7 October, 2017, http://individual.utoronto.ca/bmclean/hermeneutics/ ricoeur suppl/ Ricoeur_Herm_of_ Suspicion.htm.
10 Stephen Quibb, "From Suspicion to Solidarity," <http://arcade.stanford.edu/ content/ suspicion-solidarity> (03 October, 2017).
11 *Ibid.*
12 Felski, "Suspicious Minds," 228.
13 Robinson, "Paul Ricoeur and the Hermeneutics of Suspicion".
14 Felski, Suspicious Minds," 231.

15 Orientalism was an immense enterprise by the West, to gather enormous amount of data of the colonized nations, to study the colonized peoples, as objects, as well as their customs and traditions of the colonized, for the purposes of administration and control, not respecting their subjecthood. See Edward Said, *Orientalism* (Routledge, Kegan & Paul, 1978).
16 Felix Wilfred, "Identity and Legitimate Autonomy of Asian Churches: Some Critical Reflections," in *Church on Pilgrimage: Trajectories of Intercultural Encounter*, ed. Kuncheria Pathil (Bengaluru: Dharmaram Publications, 2016), 298.
17 V.S. Azariah, "Address at the World Missionary Conference", as quoted in Harper, *In the Shadow of the Mahatma*, 147-148.
18 Wilfred,"Identity and Legitimate Autonomy of Asian Churches," 298.
19 Harper, *In the Shadow of the Mahatma*, 46.
20 *Ibid*., 66.
21 *Ibid*., 66.
22 For the details, see *Ibid.*, 138-47.
23 *Ibid*., 148-49.
24 Steven M. Parish, *Hierarchy and Its Discontents: Culture and the Politics of Consciousness in Caste Society* (Delhi: Oxford University Press, 1993), 100. The expression, *Homo Dialecticus*, coined by Steven Parish, stands for the human being in resistance to the hierarchy, even while standing within the hierarchy, under the metanarrative of *Homo Hierarchicus,* which inscribed by the binary of purity/pollution is deployed to interpret the South Asian reality, of hierarchy.
25 Harper, *In the Shadow of the Mahatma*, 129.
26 *Ibid*., 195.
27 For this section on the general thrust of Azariah for transcending the divisions in Christianity in India, and the world, and for the founding inspiration of IMS and NMS, I have relied on *Ibid., Chapter-3, entitled "Indigenous National Base: A Nonpolitical Missionary",* 67-90.
28 *Ibid*., 207.
29 *Ibid*., 211.
30 *Ibid*., 212-13.
31 *Ibid*., 213.
32 *Ibid*., 218.
33 *Ibid*., 218-19.
34 *Ibid*., 262.
35 *Ibid*., 238-40.
36 *Ibid*., 235.
37 *Ibid*., 236-37.
38 *Ibid*., 240-43.
39 *Ibid*., 263. See in this context, see G. Aloysius, *Religion as Emancipatory Identity: A Buddhist Movement among the Tamils under Colonialism,* (New Delhi: New Age International Publishers, 1998), 1-12, for the conceptual framework of "Religion-in-Society", where the religion of the subalterns is seen, as being constructed by them, in the context of the socio-economic and cultural forces, in dialectical interaction in their lives.
40 Harper, *In the Shadow of the Mahatma*, 265. See in this context, see Lisa Mitschell, "'To Stop Train Pull Chain': Writing histories of Contemporary Political Public," in The *Indian Economic and Social History Review* 48, no. 4, 469-495, on the need of creating a critical civil society/political public, beyond the elitist and bourgeois civil space.
41 See Felix Wilfred, "What is Wrong with Rice Christians?: Well-being as Salvation - A Subaltern Perspective," in Felix Wilfred, *The Sling of Utopia: Struggles for Different Society* (Delhi: ISPCK, 2005).

42 See Jose Maliekal, *Standstill Utopias: Dalits Encountering Christianity* (Delhi: ISPCK, 2017), 142-173.
43 Mohandas Karamchand Gandhi, *Young India*, 15 September, 1927, as quoted in Christopher Key Chapple-Mary Evelyn Tucker, *Hinduism and Ecology* (Cambridge, Massachusetts: Harvard University Press, 2000), 227.
44 Harper, *In the Shadow of the Mahatma*, 293.
45 In relation to the debate on conversion, see Rowena Robinson and Sathianathan Clarke (eds.), *Religious Conversion in India: Modes, Motivations and Meanings* (Delhi: Oxford University Press, 2003); Rowena Robinson and Joseph Marianus Kujur (eds.), Margins *of Faith: Dalit and Tribal Christianity in India* (Sage: New Delhi, 2010); Rudolf C. Heredia, *Religious Disarmament: Rethinking Conversion in India* (Gyan: New Delhi, 2014) Sathianathan Clarke, Deenabandhu Manjala, and Philip Vinod Peacock (eds.), *Dalit Theology in the Twenty-first Century*: *Discordant Voices, Discerning Pathways*, (New Delhi: Oxford University Press, 2010).
46 Harper, *In the Shadow of the Mahatma*, 300-16. See in this context, the enlightening and nuanced article, Nishikant Kolge, "Was Gandhi a 'Champion of the Caste System?: Reflection on His Practices," *Economic and Political Weekly,* LII, no. 13 (April 1, 2017), 42-50.
47 For the entire saga of this attempted process of reconciliation, at the heart of which was the Bishop Azariah's and Bishop Pickett's meeting with Gandhi at Nagpur, and the controversies surrounding the reporting of it, see Harper, *In the Shadow of the Mahatma,* 318-38. No minutes of this crucial meeting is available; as the transcript of the minutes, kept by Mahadev Desai seems to have disappeared from the record.
48 *Ibid*., 338-39.
49 For a philosophical approach to the narrative of nationalism, as different from the dominant narrative of nationalism, see Mohinder Singh, "Tagore on Modernity, Nationalism and 'the surplus in Man,' in *Economic and Political Weekly,* LII, no. 19 (May 13, 2017), 46-52.
50 Harper, *In the Shadow of the Mahatma*, 340.
51 *Ibid*., 341.
52 *Ibid.*, 342-43.
53 *Ibid*., 342.
54 *Ibid*., 343.
55 *Ibid.*, 343-344.
56 *Ibid*., 306-10.
57 *Ibid.*, 312-13.
58 See Rajeev Bhargava, "Democratic Vision of a New Republic: India, 1950" in *The Promise of India's Secular Democracy*," ed. Rajeev Bhargava (New Delhi: Oxford University Press, 2010), for a succinct treatment of the uniqueness of the founding ideals of Indian secular democracy, as envisioned by the founding fathers, especially the ideal of substantive equality, overcoming the evils of the metanarrative of *Homo Hierarchicus*, governing the South Asian reality, inscribed by the binary of purity/pollution.
59 See Happymon Jacob, "When the paradigm shifts: on PM Modi's new brand of politics," *The Hindu*, 10 August, 2017, for a genealogical analysis of the Modi's brand of politics and governance, which even goes beyond the Vajpayee regime, which was still working under the Nehruvian paradigm.
60 See *Humilaition: Claims and Context*, ed. Gopal Guru (New Delhi: Oxford University Press, 2013), for a collection of essays by noted social scienists, on the thematic of the politics of recognition and related themes of equality and respect for the other. See also Felix Wilfred, "Rethinking Nationalism with the Poor," in *The Sling of Utopia*, 104-34; also Felix Wilfred, "Dilemmas and Trajectories of Peace" in *Concilium*, 2015/1, 13-20.

17

Re-Claiming Sree Narayana Guru for a Kerala Today

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Abstract: The following study is undertaken with the intention that it would contribute to a deeper understanding of the socio-religious situation of Kerala at the turn of the century. The teaching of the Narayana Guru would become accessible and intelligible to those who are barred from such an understanding since the primary source materials are in languages which are not easily learned or understood. My aim of study is to enable the readers to an emphatic understanding of the role and contributions of Sree Narayana Guru in awakening the socio-religious consciousness of the *Ezhavas* in their historical struggles in getting acceptance and respect in Indian society. It is also my earnest desire, hope and prayer that this study would stimulate interest among scholars for further investigations and study into the works of Sree Narayana Guru which are not yet completely translated from the original language.

Introduction

The modern Hinduism has had several eminent reformers, teachers and leaders such as Raja Ram Mohan Roy, Swami Vivekanda, Mahatma Gandhi and Sarvepalli Radhakrishnan, to name a few. Most of these men have received worldwide attention either due to their ability to re-interpret the ancient ideals of Hinduism and its relevance to modern man or due to their charismatic leadership. Sree Narayana Guru has not received this kind of world-wide attention, although he was also one of those in the same tradition of advocating

socio-religious freedom and educational opportunities. So in this context I would like to make an attempt to reclaim Sree Narayana Guru for a Kerala of today.

1.1 Birth and Childhood

Sree Narayana Guru was born in A.D. 1856 in Chempazhanthy, a quiet little town, about 12 kilometers north of Trivandrum, the capital of the then Indian Native state of Travancore. Trivandrum is today the capital of Kerala, one of the most fascinating States of India, nestling in the north-west corner, with the Western Ghats in the east and the Arabian Sea on the west forming its main borders. He was born in the ezhava community where they were driven into suffer humiliation of being untouchables, branded so by the society held under the fist of Brahmin domination.[1] He was initiated to the ordinary life in 1882 with a formal marriage, but he dissociated from it and took to *Sanyas* (renunciation) immediately.[2]

"There were two communities in Kerala known generally as Nairs and Ezhavas, who formed the largest castes in that state. Nairs were sudras belonging to the hierarchy of the Varna (caste) system and so were counted among the cluster of the higher castes known as Savarnas (those having castes)."[3] The Ezhavas were an unapproachable caste belonging to the group of castes outside the Varna System and were, therefore, Avarnas (outcasts, those not in the caste purview). Sree Narayana Guru was born an Ezhava.

1.2 Socio-Ethical Situation

There is evidence in the birth-place of Sree Narayana Guru that in the past, Nairs and Ezhavas did cooperate closely with each other without, be it noted, violating the polluting distance between them. The highly numerous, sturdy agriculturist Ezhava, who was the traditional toddy-tapper, too, proved to be a strong arm for the chieftains in the frays. There is, for instance, a temple of goddess Bhagavathy which belongs to the Ezhavas near the birth-place of the Guru where the festivals were conducted jointly by Nairs and Ezhavas. Two platforms on two sides of the temple still bear witness to the custom, whereby the Ezhavas and the Nairs cooperated in conducting the ceremonies at shrines, even though they took care to sit apart while doing so.[4]

Untouchable, unapproachable, and down-trodden, as the Ezhavas happened to be, there were even in those dark days a fair sprinkling of Vaidyas or physicians among them practicing Ayurvedic system, whose texts were in classical Sanskrit. Naturally, therefore, there were Sanskrit scholars of high caliber among them. In fact, the entire landscape of Kerala is peppered with Ezhava Vaidyas (physicians) and Sanskrit scholars so much so that one could state that ayurveda and, for that matter, Sanskrit, too, survived among the masses in Kerala due to the Ezhava Vaidyas. Of course, the Namboodiri Brahmins

were considered the repositories of Sanskrit and Sastras like Ayurveda. But they were inaccessible to the ordinary run of men and their number was small.

1.3 Boyish Mischiefs

The great poet Kumaran Asan, who was to the Guru what Swami Vivekananda was to Sree Ramakrishna Paramahamsa, records that Sree Narayana Guru or rather Nanu as he was affectionately called, was a mischievous boy. The instances of mischief given by Asan are, however, significant and revealing. The little boy would take special delight in running out to touch the lower caste people and then go straight to the orthodox members of the family to touch and pollute them. Fruits and sweets specially reserved for the gods were the main targets of these foraging raids. Those were the childish pranks of this boy who later became an Advaithin, i.e., a person who saw everything in the universe as the manifestation of the *one.*[5]

> According to Romain Rolland,
>
> The Great Guru Sree Narayana's teaching was permeated with the philosophy of Sankara… He was, one might say *Jnanin* (one who has knowledge of self) in action, a grand religious intellectual, who had a living sense of the people and of social necessities. He has contributed greatly to the elevation of the oppressed classes (there were two million of them) in south India, and his work had been associated at certain times with that of Gandhi.[6]

1.4 Believer of Non-Dualism

The Guru was an Advaitin (believer of non-dualism) in the sense in which Sankara Acharya was, but with a difference. In his sixteen years of preaching Advaita philosophy and establishing it as the sublime contribution of India to the world of metaphysical thought, the Acharya had created an elite who were to carry on his tradition. The Guru carries on the tradition, but in doing so extends it so as to become a *Jnanin* (follower of the path of knowledge of self) in action incarnated for the benefit of the suffering multitudes.

1.4.1 Struggle against Casteism

Within a period of less than half a century, he had metamorphosed the depressed castes of Kerala from dust into men who could stand on their own legs as self-respecting human beings. Thanks to his activities, they could walk on the public roads with complete freedom. The roads around temples were thrown open to them in 1925 and the temple authorities were forbidden by law in 1936 to refuse entry to the untouchables into the temples, years before anything like it happened in other parts of India.

Where once they were not admitted into schools, they were freely granted admission within two or three decades and before 1947, the untouchables had established on their own dozen colleges along with high schools and other educational institutions. When Sree Narayana Guru started his mission in 1895, there was not a single employee among the lower castes in government service, not even an employee drawing a salary of five rupees. By 1947, there was a significant number of them working as government servants, some of them holding highest posts. Narayana Guru`s teaching on caste has two dimensions. First, by the example of his life and word, he proved to the Hindus that "it (caste) was silly phantom."[7] Even as a boy he was noted for his caste breaking activities.[8] There was no caste distinction among his followers. Once he said: Some still think that I belong to this community or that creed. It is now years since I gave up such distinctions. I also arranged that those who join the order at my Ashram shall have no such limitations.[9]

1.4.2 Philosophy of Guru

It was some sort of peaceful bloodless revolution which he achieved. Whenever there are down-trodden, underprivileged groups in the world, message of Sree Narayana Guru, "Educate that you may be free"; "organize that you may be strong"; "Industrialise that your financial status may improve"[10] has relevance at all times. These three essential steps for social progress were suggested by Guru. He believed in the necessity of an organization to fight against social evils. Thus once he opined that organization should bring all men together. Religion must have the freedom of faith, must be acceptable to all cultural people, and must lead all people to ultimate aim. Then the *sanatana* principle *One Caste, One Religion, One God*[11] will be acceptable to such a religion.

1.4.3 The World

The world is understood as material; the reality underlying it is taken for granted or said to be matter. It in some mysterious way is a configuration of energy. On the other hand, the existence of world conceived in Philosophy especially in *Advaitha Vedandh* as visualized by Sree Narayana Guru is a bipolar one- the objective phenomena perceptible to the senses forming the pole, and the corresponding ideas or concepts formulated in the mind of the perceiver forming the other.

Everything we conceive by the human mind is given a name. In a way, we understand, thus we become aware or capable of stating that the world (prapanja) is constituted of innumerable concepts, innumerable names, and the corresponding innumerable objects. Narayana Guru in this sense defines the world as:

Names in their thousands,
Concepts in their thousands,

And the externally existing,
Objects in their thousands,
Corresponding to each of them-
These together form the world.[12]

Every experience, we know involves the three basic facts called *thriputi*.[13]

1.5 One Religion (*Oru Matam*)

According to Guru "All these programmes have however, to be based on deep religious faith that the supreme ONE alone exists and all that we see are only its variegated manifestations."[14] Every man's face is different from that of every other man and yet no one ever doubts that we are all human beings and therefore sons of the same father in heaven. Let us see in detail what he meant by *Oru Matam.* The concept of one religion is found in the *Matamimamsa* or so called the Critique of Religion.[15]

The life and activities of Sree Narayana Guru represent that he was a Vedantist, (believer in Vedanta) pure and simple. He had the yogic experience of a Supreme Identity "in which oppositions and all contraries, even of being and not-being are resolved."[16] Through that experience he realized that the worlds and gods of the ordinary man's religion were levels of reference and symbolic entities which were neither places nor individuals but states of being realizable within oneself. The characters and events in the puranas may not be all historically authentic. Nevertheless, they possess the superior reality of religious mythology. The greatest of the puranas, the Bhagvatha, states that the tales are not to be taken as literal truth. They are intended to lead men to wisdom and detachment. These and other great truths were demonstrated by the Guru to the masses through a series of idols of Siva, Subramania, Ganesa and a lighted lamp, a plaque with a great thought engraved on it, and Aum, the mystic syllable, engraved on a mirror, covering it all by an Advaita Asrama where devotees of different faiths meditated in the same prayer-hall, studying and living together as partners in a common quest. The entire programme was a demonstration in concrete images, and finally in the absence of images which represent the higher significance of idol-worship. Through that process, the Swami taught people to apprehend the idea that religious rites so far practiced by them could be adapted towards a visible representation (if one may use that expression here) of the vedantic doctrine of the non-duality of the Divine Being.[17]

Narayana Guru did not try to establish a model for a new, unitary religion, nor did he propound any dogmas to sustain his concepts. His teaching was based an integral view of life. According to him there are not any artificial division of life in to the mundane or profane and the sacred: God is universal father of all and all life is His life, all activity is His; to realize this basic

unity is true religion, and in the eyes of God all are his children and so we are brothers and sisters.[18] What Narayana Guru advocated was that the ecumenical spirit of modern Christendom be applied to all other world religions so that they might achieve a beautiful unity in diversity.[19]

1.6 One Caste (Oru Jati)

Advaita philosophy becomes pointless unless it teaches men to treat their fellow men as equals. In Kerala, the greatest obstacle to such conduct was the abominable caste system. Naturally, therefore, the Guru's message of universal love was expressed in the idiom of the people of Kerala, when he said: one caste for man.

He did not command that the householder should rise up and have the mystic experience of a supreme identity with the ONE. They were not to worry themselves about a fuzzy understanding of Vedanta either. They were simply to love their fellowmen as themselves and it would follow as the day the night, they would precede towards universal love, love of the Lord, our God.[20]

The famous saying of Jesus Christ that there are only two commandments comes strongly to my mind in this context.

> "The Lord our God is one Lord.
> And thou shalt love the Lord thy God
> With all thy heart, and with all thy
> Soul, and with all thy mind, and
> With all thy strength: this is the first
> Commandment: And the second is like this, namely:
> "Thou shalt love thy neighbour as thyself.
> There is no other commandment
> Greater than these" (Mark, 12/29-30).

The unlawful atrocities committed by the higher castes on the lower castes have been mentioned earlier. The fact, however, is that no caste including the Namboodiri Brahmin was exempt from the miseries and the humiliations suffered on account of the superstitions and customs prevalent in Kerala. The eldest son alone of a Namboodiri could marry within the caste, leaving many a Namboodiri women to suffer compulsory maidenhood all her life or become one of the several wives of a Namboodiri, who could in some cases be old enough to be her father. Their sufferings can be grasped better by reading the novels and short stories written by great Namboodiri women writers than by reading dry pages of history. The younger members could have morganatic connections with Nair women, but the children were not only deprived of inheritance, but were also prohibited to touch their father, lest they pollute him! Sree Narayana Guru never raised his voice against the higher

castes because he understood that the villain was not any caste or individual, but superstition.[21]

The whole social milieu would have made you laugh if it were not for the tragic implications behind these farcical situations. Oilmen were a caste by themselves. But even among them, the oil crushers formed a caste inferior to the oil-mongers. Even people of the same caste would not intermarry if they happened to live on the opposite sides of certain rivers. Sometimes even a road would do the trick. You may marry into a caste, but your wife would be forbidden from entering the kitchen in your house. Truly could one say that the Kerala of those days was a *'Wonderland'* of superstitions?[22]

The sad part of it all was that the caste system functioned by a series of kicks, the last man, poor fellow, kicking the cat. In this hierarchy of kicks, the Ezhavas too were by no means innocent. While they yearned for admission into temples of the higher castes, some of the temples consecrated for them by the Guru were not thrown open to castes below them. In other ways, too, they tried to maintain superstitious superiority over others. Swami admitted the lowest castes into the institutions at Varkala and Alwaye. Several Ezhava leaders followed suit and had the lowest caste boys as domestic servants and cooks. The implication of such a practice can be appreciated better when it is remembered that in India of those days, a domestic servant soon became, so to say, a member of the family. Those of us Indians who are over forty years of age still remember how old domestic servants used to chastise us children, just like uncles. Castes came closer to one another-when the lower caste people were admitted into that elastic family circle.[23]

The Ezhavas who numbered several lakhs were divided into Thiyyas, Chovans, Thandans, etc., who did not intermarry. Swami's advent very soon molded them into one community throughout entire Kerala. The temples, institutes, hostels, etc., of the Ezhavas were thrown open to all castes. When several branches of the Ezhavas who had so far lived more or less in closed circles were brought into one big community, thereby becoming the largest caste; the Nairs and others too combined together and formed bigger groups or societies for their own betterment. Further, the repercussions of Sree Narayana Guru's activities resulted in all castes of Kerala opening their eyes and taking vigorous action to reform their own customs and rites. By this time, i.e., the early decades of the twentieth century, the reform movement and activities of the Arya Samaj, the Brahmo Samaj, the Ramakrishna Mission and the Servants of India Society had spread their influence in Kerala society, thereby accelerating and informing the social movements here with modernizing tendencies.[24]

The Namboodiris of Kerala, who were counted as the most orthodox of Brahmins, now became one of the foremost of radical communities in India. Their revolutionary activities on the fields of widow remarriage, etc., were

most amazing. The Nairs formed a society on the lines of the Servants of India Society and effected most significant changes in social life. The Pulayas stood up as men conscious of their rights. Happily, however, there was no violent animosity in Kerala in those days towards such activities by different castes.[25]

The seed for it all was sown by Sree Narayana Guru who had thus in his own unremarkable way upturned the virgin soil of orthodoxy and brought forth a goodly harvest of welcome changes within a short span of 50 years. Kerala is unique in that the untouchable castes here have progressed much more and much faster than in other States of India. This great progress was achieved without shedding a single drop of blood. Although, the earlier struggles by the lower castes against oppression had produced violent fights with the vested interests, the movement for self-dependence in their rise in the social arena under the leadership of Sree Narayana Guru was obstructed, if at all, in a more civilized manner. As against that, there were famous instances in those days where the higher castes came out to help and lead the movement of the untouchables for their rights. The Satyagraha at Vaikom mentioned later in this paper, provide example of this co-operation.[26]

Through his life and words Narayana Guru proved to the world that one can live a free life without a belief in caste. At least for him the traditional explanation of caste ceased to exist. Every human being is a member of one Jati or species without superiority, inferiority, hierarchy, or heredity. This, in essence was the message of Sree Narayana Guru which he tried to spread through his concept of One caste for man.

1.7 One God (Oru Daivam)

The concept of 'One God' associated with monotheistic religions such as Judaism, Islam, and Christianity, is not totally absent in Hinduism. In characterizing Hinduism as a religion of many gods, one forgets the fact that a belief in God existed in Hinduism in the particular philosophy which emphasized One Ultimate Reality - Brahman.[27] Therefore, an attempt to review the concept of one God from a religious as well as a philosophical perspective of Sree Narayana Guru would be useful here.

Sree Narayana Guru was convinced both by philosophical reasoning and by several years of spiritual experience that the non-dualism of Sankara is the ultimate truth. But when he looked at Kerala, the land which produced Sankara, he could not see the transcendental philosophy of Advaita translated into the life of the common people or even among Sankara's own Brahmin community. Deeply disturbed by this situation, Narayana Guru, accepting Advaita as the metaphysical basis for man's practical concern in the world, devoted his whole life to showing the world that Advaita can be translated into action.[28]

The essential difference between Sankara and Narayana Guru lies in their application of Advaita to the realm of practical life. Sankara, in his short

life, propounded the theoretical aspects of Advaita. But Narayana Guru in his forty years of active public ministry, demonstrated the relevance of Vendanta for practical life. He combined the Advaita Vedanta theory of the oneness of Brahman (*ekatmavada*) with the theistic Vendanta practice of love and service. The Buddhists and Jains teach the service of man as man, while the theistic vedantists propound the service of man as 'part' of God. Narayana Guru on the other hand, taught that we should serve man as man because he belongs to one humanity (jati or caste) and because we also acknowledge that Atman, the reality in man, is non-different from Brahman. Thus, Sree Narayana Guru, in his revaluation of Advaita philosophy in terms of practical ethical life, combined theoretical Advaita with the Bhakti practice of loving service by refusing to neglect empirical (*vyavaharika*) reality at the expense of transcendental reality.[29] Institutions founded by him and after him remain as the extension of his message. Let us see some of them in brief.

1.8 S.N.D.P. Yogam Dharma Sangam

The Sree Narayana Dharma Paripalana Yogam or S.N.D.P., as it is popularly known, was a society founded in 1903 under the leadership of Guru for the propagation of the ideals of Sree Narayana among the masses and for the upliftment of the down-trodden castes of Kerala. The Swami's ideal which was one of universalism was not affected by this circumscription of the Society's leadership because every one of them working under the Guru, heart and soul,was for the upliftment of all depressed castes. They were the more willing group to follow the Guru on the score that the Guru was born in their midst. That was all.[30]

This uniformity of the S.N.D.P.'S. membership facilitated the smooth management of the Society. The Ezhavas were numerically the largest caste, a factor which lent strength to their movements. They had a pivotal position, being at the top of the hierarchy of the untouchables and just below the Nairs. What they achieved inspired all castes below them to emulate their move for betterment, and induced the higher castes to examine and improve the customs and ways of their respective castes. The Ezhava tradition of Vaidyas (physicians) and Sanskrit scholars, landlords and rich men on top among them equipped them for quick progress up the social ladder. Their leader was a great saint and so the whole movement was imbued with a spiritual aura. Moreover, they had already made some trail movements earlier towards bettering their position in life, and achieved some success although those attempts involved some sporadic violence. They, therefore, welcomed this opportunity of struggling with greater dignity and aplomb.

The S.N.D.P.[31] now had its vast annual gatherings. They were graced in its earlier days by the presence of the Guru who gave them guidance and determined the tenor of the deliberations. People assembled in hundreds and

later in thousands, some special meetings having more than half-a-lakh of people who listened in pin-drop silence to speeches made without the aid of loud-speakers. Those meetings would very often be addressed by the higher castes and also by officials including the Diwans of Travancore and Cochin.

The disabilities of the depressed castes dropped one by one like leaves in autumn until at last they could walk along public roads without fear of polluting anyone, use roads around temples, get admitted to schools, colleges and hostels, secure jobs in government service and even have certain percentages of jobs reserved for different groups of castes-and then finally came the entry into temples in 1936. Travancore was the first State in India to grant that privilege to all castes. What a miraculous achievement for the Guru who passed away or attained his Samadhi as the saying goes in 1928. To think that all this was gained by the untouchables as a whole within a space of thirty years and without creating any bad blood is indeed wonderful.

When Sree Narayana Guru felt that SNDP yogam either moving away from his teachings or that it could no longer support his original ideas he started Sree Narayana Dharma Sangam only for Sanayasis (Organisation of sanyasins). The aim was to propagate the dharma of Guru. Some of its members sees Sree Narayana Guru as a social reformer and not *an avatar of Ishvara* (Incarnation of God).[32] The Kerala High Court on 2 September 2016 stated that Sree Narayana Guru is one of the greatest social reformers and not *an Ishvar avatar*. And *Gurumandiram* housing his statue cannot be treated as a temple.[33]

1.9 Relevance of Guru's Teachings

Today, Sree Narayana Guru's life, his message, and his activities have urgent and specific relevance to India in particular and the world at large in general. The Guru's slogan of *'One Caste, One Religion, One God'* is an elevated expression of humanism which recognizes the value of a human being as being supreme. A value that simultaneously recognizes all human beings as being equal, irrespective of all social divisions. This universality of oneness of humanity, in a sense, manifests the finest elements of rational thought and philosophy that emerged in the course of the advance of human civilization in these lands. As "different rivers flow through different courses to merge in the ocean."[34] so do different human beings through the practice of individual beliefs and faith eventually merge with humanity as a whole. This is humanism of the highest variety. In the context of the concrete conditions in India today, the Guru's philosophy has a very strong relevance. The recent incidents of attacks on the Dalits and other marginalized sections of the Indian people highlight the need to adhere to the values propagated by the Guru – 'the oneness of humanity'. Likewise, in the context of the growing communal polarisation

in India which targets and attacks people of other religions, Sree Narayana Guru's philosophy has a strong relevance today.

Sree Narayana Guru has an important relevance to meet the current challenges that threaten the unity and integrity of India whose religious, linguistic, ethnic, cultural, regional diversity is unmatched by any country in the world today. India's unity and integrity can only b**e** protected and strengthened by strengthening the bonds of commonality that run through this diversity. India's social stability and equanimity will only implode if any effort is made to impose any form of uniformity – religious, linguistic, cultural, etc., upon this diversity. Unfortunately, it is precisely this that is being sought by the current campaigns of the communal forces in India.

Today, Narayana Guru is understood, believed, and followed by different people in different ways. There is only little agreement between the representatives of the major groups and organizations that have taken upon themselves the responsibility of spreading the word of the Guru. In Kerala, Narayana Guru's name is rightly and wrongly associated with the S.N.D.P. Yogam. From the very name, it is easy to see that the founders of the organization derived their inspiration from Narayana Guru and wanted to foster his teachings as something similar to the dharma of the Buddha. In the course of three fourths of a century, the Yogam has gone in a tangent that is now considered by many people as an unfortunate deviation to exclusive communalism, the very rancor that the Guru wanted to cure the people of. At present Sree Vellappally Natesan is the General Secretary of the SNDP. Even the SNDP has formed a party called Bharat Dharma Jana Sena (BDJS), it has parted ways with Guru's teachings by having many liquor bars in the state, where Sree Narayana Guru had said no to liquor.

Conclusion and Critical Appreciation

The advaita philosophy of the Guru will prevent mutual co-operation and professions of oneness from deteriorating into a carnal philosophy of human pragmatism. The message of "One caste, one religion, one God for man" should not have a commercial mentality behind it, if the United Nations and other world bodies are to succeed in their mission. Sree Narayana Guru's message has a universal significance and relevance for all times. If the teaching of "*One Caste, One Religion, One God for Man"* is viewed from the perspective of *an advaitin*, it would become clear that man should attempt to attain the Ultimate Truth not by discriminating between man and man, religion and religion, or between god and god, but by discriminating between reality and unreality. To sum up we can say that the teachings of Sree Narayana Guru has a great importance as it helps to see human beings as they are, rendering mutual respect and appreciation to one another.

Notes

1 Vijayalayam Jayakumar, *Sree Narayana Guru: A Critcal Study* (New Delhi: D.K. Printworld Publishers, 1999), iii.
2 Vijayalayam Jayakumar, *Sree Narayana Guru: A Critcal Study,*12.
3 Murkot Kunhappa, "Sree Narayana Guru" <http://www.sreenarayanaguru.in/content/preface > (15th August 2017).
4 *Ibid.*
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6 Murkot Kunhappa, "Sree Narayana Guru" (Online).
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18

'Deconstruction' in J. Krishnamurthy's Teachings
A Hermeneutical Approach

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Abstract: This research paper begins with the introduction to Jiddu Krishnamurthy's life and teachings. Next, his views on key concepts of life like God and religion, truth, freedom and perfection, life, self and liberation, mind, education, human relationship are explored. Further, an attempt is made to present Krishnamurthy as a 'master of suspicion' in the light of the 'deconstruction' of traditionally established epistemological forms or set up, traditional understanding of religion and God, that he aimed at. Concluding remarks contain an evaluation of his teachings and views.

Key-words: Life, freedom, truth, education, thought, self, conditioned mind, liberation, authority, religion and tradition.

Introduction

Jiddu Krishnamurthy born in 1895 into a south Indian family, was first noticed by C.W. Leadbeater, who claimed that the boy had an extraordinary aura which revealed the fact that the boy was a completely selfless human being. Later, Krishnamurthy was raised by Dr. Annie Besant of the Theosophical Society, and to some extent by C.W. Leadbeater. He was groomed for some years for a major spiritual role and was to become a world-wide teacher, around whom a large international organization formed itself. However, he dissolved this

group and proclaimed that truth could not be organized. According to him, such organizations are inimical to spiritual life. Further he insisted that, "truth is a pathless land" and he opposed all traditional teachings, religions, authorities, systems, and writings. Over six decades he spent his time lecturing and holding discussions with people around the world. He established schools ranging from elementary to high schools, under the auspices of various Krishnamurthy Foundations - in India, England, America, and Canada. He was educated privately, that is tutors were appointed for him and his brother, although he seems to have joined some institutions and prepared for some examinations of the London University.

Krishnamurthy passed through intense spiritual experiences at Ojai. The death of his brother brought about a great revolution in his whole psyche. It shocked him profoundly and inspired him to think about the very basis of all existence afresh. He declared himself to be the teacher of humanity and dedicated his life to the cause of setting humans free from ignorance, illusion, fear, and belief. He preached that truth is a 'pathless land' and cannot be approached by any path whatsoever - by any religion or by any sect.

1. Key concepts in Krishnamurthy's teaching

1.1 General view of life and manifestation

For Krishnamurthy life has been maimed and bound, and truth has been limited and conditioned, and this is the cause of disorder and disintegration that we are facing today. He used the term 'life' in two different connotations - life that we live in this world which he calls the manifestation and in the second understanding of life, he treats life as an essence of being which manifests through name and form, which he also calls 'life in freedom'. Life as an 'expression' is conditioned by law whereas life as 'freedom' cannot be conditioned or limited by any law. In his concept of 'life as relationship' he deals with rather 'action' as relationship, that is 'to be is to be related'.

1.2 Liberation

Individuality is merely a segment in totality. Liberation then is the freedom from the limitations of individuality, from separateness and from the struggle and strife involved in individual existence. Unlike the Buddhist concept of 'nirvana' he declared that, it is not annihilation, it is constructive, positive, and all-inclusive, and not exclusive. Further he maintains that, liberation is life immortal, it also implies freedom from the fear of death, from the fear of non-being, and from the illusion of ego, from the identification of being with a particular form.

1.3 Truth

Krishnamurthy integrating truth with life holds that, life is the manifestation of Truth, of Reality, where the eternal expresses itself in transitory form. The pursuit of truth cannot be divorced from the pursuit of life. So, Truth lies in the fulfillment of life and not in the escape from life.

While discussing the approaches to Truth, he expressed his discontent regarding the traditional ways of 'masters' or 'gurus' who usually are approached for guidance. According to him such a mediator is unnecessary. However, he does not deny the importance of mediator in the absolute sense. For him, a guru's role should be like that of a signpost. But people rather than seeking truth for themselves, start worshipping the signpost.

1.4 Views on thought

According to Krishnamurthy, thought is the result of accumulated experiences. In simple words, thought consists of ideas, and an idea is nothing but a sensation associated with a name. Both the material of thought and experience is the same because both deal with the identification of ideas. Due to the fact that our mind persists in division, it refuses to recognize the unity of thought and feeling and as a result emphasizes one or the other. This is a sign of fragmentation of consciousness.

Unless the mind is emptied of the past, of the influence of the known, of all psychological memory, craving and desire, it cannot approach the new, which is imponderable. So, thought being a reaction of memory cannot be independent and creative.

The thought functions essentially as a complex instrument of memory, and acts as a conditioning factor since thought itself is conditioned by traditions, values, habits, culture and so on.

1.5 On God and Religion

Krishnamurthy does not support the idea of God being a Power external to man, controlling and guiding his fate, rewarding for good deeds and punishing for evil actions. These comments are radical and controversial, since he maintained that there is no God except a man purified, and there is no Power external to man which controls him and guides him. However, what he means by 'man purified' is that, he/she becomes one with the Absolute Truth. He identifies God with Unconditioned, Absolute Truth. He distinguished between religion and religionism.

1.6 On mind and self-knowledge

Krishnamurthy understands the concept of self or 'I' as the consciousness acting as the framework of reference, the centre of evaluation, resistance and

conflict, and merely an idea without actuality. It is the practical device of the mind for conducting the routine business of life and as such it has a certain value, a practical conventional validity.

According to Krishnamurthy, the self can only be discovered in the mirror of relationship, because it is only in our response to the movement of life, in our action, that we express our self. Hence, self-knowledge should not be confused with self-consciousness, which consists in identification with idea, and not in freedom from it. As to know oneself, is to be oneself, and further to be oneself is not to desire to be what one is not. Therefore, to be oneself is to be choiceless in awareness, to act without any reservation and without being conditioned by fear.

The 'conditioned mind'is the consciousness as conditioned, which interprets perception in relation to the self-centre, and thereby sustains the identification caused by ignorance as if we are a self-existing entity in time. This conditioned mind is incapable of discovering the truth, as its perception is distorted by the interpretation of self-centre.

1.7 Man as a moral and social being

Krishnamurthy holds each individual responsible for one's own conduct and for the world that he creates around himself. We, humans are made responsible to an external authority and we observe that, there is a struggle inside us against this authority. Because the true sense of responsibility arises in us from within the individual, out of love for life, out of the understanding of oneness of life, out of freedom from the illusion of ego. He grants 'absolute freedom' to humans, who are free either to remain in bondage or to liberate life within them. The limitations of individuality are not only self-imposed but are self-sustained also. He believes that, what we are witnessing today is that, life is in bondage and humans live by self-deception, but it is absolutely his/her freedom to realize one's potentiality, which one is destined for. He observes that, all the social, political, and religious authority has failed to instill in us a sense of true responsibility.

1.8 Education

In order to bring about a new social order based on love and the action of intelligence, he stresses the need to impart right kind of education to children. They should be brought up in such an environment that, they should not inherit the consciousness of the older generation, which is infected with the disease of fragmentation, that perpetuates the social problems. So, he feels the need for educating the educators. It must be the concern of the parent and the teacher to develop an integrated individual.

2. 'Deconstruction' in Krishnamurthy's teachings

Analysis done by the social scientists, philosophers, and hermeneuticians generate meanings through variety of interpretations. Krishnamurthy as a teacher and as a social thinker aims at the reinterpretation and deconstruction of some of the key concepts, which influence our life and culture. Hence, he may be presented as a 'master of suspicion'. The hermeneutics of 'suspicion' operates with a commitment to unmask "the lies and illusions of consciousness". Although he does not offer a system of philosophy, yet tries to connect life, truth, happiness, liberation, freedom, consciousness, thought, mind, education, and society by the use of language and terms, which have different connotations at a deeper level, away from traditional language. He insists that humans should seek Life Divine, Pure being that is unconditioned life. To carry out this task, he should seek freedom from the limitations imposed by personality, freedom from the isolation of individuality, and freedom from separation. To attain a lasting, permanent, indestructible happiness should be the goal of all humanity. In this process, he warns that we should not get caught in any tradition or any form of thought. It will be worthless if the goal is intellectually accepted from outside or faithfully assimilated from tradition or borrowed form a religious leader.

It is well known that, Indian tradition offers many paths to liberation. Vedic tradition offered polytheistic, monotheistic, pantheistic, superstitious and magical or thoroughly mystical and philosophical, religion of love, religion of knowledge, religion of action. The principal subject matter of the Brahmana portion of the Vedas deals with the sacrificial form of worship and the very same Vedas in the Upanishad portions prescribe an absolutely speechless, detailless and actionless form or path as the only means of attaining salvation. The tantrika path engages in seemingly ugly, horrible, and objectionable practices in the darkest hours of mid-night at the cremation ground; while the Vaishnava tradition engages in removing the minutest particle of dust in the temple of the Lord and carefully anointing the body of the Lord with the marks of sandalwood paste. The three paths discussed in Bhagwad Gita - Karma-yoga, Jnana-yoga and Bhakti-yoga have their origin in Vedas and Upanishads. There are detailed injunctions about the rituals to be performed in all these paths to attain salvation. Likewise Buddhist tradition offers Ashtangika marga or eightfold path to salvation and Jainism introduced 'Nirvana' as a form of salvation, which they preached as attainable through suppression of natural desires. Christianity as an established religion offers 'the Way of the Cross' as the path towards salvation, while Islamic religion insists on the worship of Allah, based on teachings from Koran, alone as the path to liberation.

According to Krishnamurthy, all these paths are obstacles on the way to liberation for individuals belonging to various faiths. He observed that, these

paths create confusion, they are contrastive as well as exclusive, and hence are a source of imposing on us a 'constructed life'. His teaching consisted in the dismantling of all these established forms or paths to liberation.He preaches that instead of living in this 'constructed life' each individual has to discover one's own path and liberate life, not his self/ herself. He observes that the term 'God' is widely misunderstood and misconceived, and so it lead to a variety of interpretations of the term. He is not against religion wherein communion with the Divine, the realization of oneness of Life and freedom from the limitations of personality constitute religion. However, he maintains that the identification of religion with its external structures - the organizations, symbols and rituals, etc., which we may call 'religionism' - conditions our life and mind; thwarts our freedom to realize or liberate life. As mentioned above he insists that, each individual has to find a path for oneself to realize oneself. He rejected whatever is given from outside or external authority - that is from a Guru, scriptures, rituals or doctrines and maintains that, at the most they may be treated as signposts. He rejected the already established paths as authorities in the journey of liberating life. Essential character of all these established systems which repels him is that, they presuppose action which is based on idea. This action involves the process of becoming on a higher level for instance, in the spiritual field. But in reality it only perpetrates the self and is the creator of divisions of the consciousness. Thus, the fundamental problem remains untouched without any solution. For every 'I' the path has to be self-created and here he comes close to Heidegger's thought that, 'As I walk, I make my way'. He attacked religion yet for another reason, that it has failed in shaping human relationships and this fact is responsible for all kinds of social evils.

Since society is the manifestation of many individuals living together, the evil in society reflects the deficiencies of its constituent members. The constant threat to the world peace, the process of disintegration at work in the present social set up, the prevailing social disorder engendering economic exploitation and the class struggles, agitations by the various sections of society - all are revolts against the established authority indicating the fact that, the individual is in turmoil. We observe widespread suffering all around the world. The modern civilization has proved ineffective to curb the jealousy, hatred, comparison, competition, ambition are the causes of unhappiness. It is proved that application of scientific knowledge to the ways of living can bring about more comforts but not happiness, which is based on good human relations. There is no life in isolation. We identify ourself with our possessions and so are incapable of love and affection. Since possessiveness is a form of self-expansion, which is a cause of conflict and strife in social relationships. This is the way how our relationship to things gets reflected in our relationship

to people. Therefore, Krishnamurthy believes that religion has failed in its endeavor to create a good society.

Many people turn to a spiritual teacher in search of this happiness but Krishnamurthy warns that, the idea that another person can save us is a comfortable illusion. He discards all traditions - Astika and Nastika alike, as authorities and experts on society and religion and so on. He is of the opinion that, "where there is authority and a mere adjustment to it, there cannot be fulfillment. Each individual has created his authority through fear and the desire for security. You have to understand your own desire, which is creating authority and to which you are a slave."[1] Any authority imposes on us certain ideals that are set up for us by tradition, by government, by education, by society, by religion and by environment in which we live. Our subservience to authority kills our initiative, creativity and it dulls our intelligence. Thus, it works against our freedom and is to be discarded.

Since he rejected all authority, including that at the epistemological level also, it may be inferred that he rejects the age old traditional Indian system of imparting knowledge through guru-shishya parampara. According to him a guru's function is not to awaken the intelligence of the seeker, but to help him realize the obstacles to it. To put it in his own words, "The guru cannot awaken you, all that he can do is to point out what is. Truth is not a thing that can be caught by the mind. The guru can give you words, he can give you an explanation, the symbols of the mind, but the symbol is not the real, and if you are caught in the symbol you will never find the way."[2] He claimed that his own method too, cannot be reproduced for or duplicated by others.

He is unhappy with religion because it is misused by people and it has failed in its task. But he rejected religionism vehemently. He offers an alternate interpretation of the traditional concept of liberation. According to traditional understanding, whatever the religious dogmas or scriptures or systems of philosophy may have to say in theory, what is actually understood and held in mind by the followers or adherents, is the idea that liberation essentially lies in the negation of existence. In other words, as a common man we find that our existence is understood or perceived in our everyday life, being the ordinary members of society, as people belonging to various professions and so on. There is a dichotomy here in understanding the concept of liberation – as put forth by religious scriptures and the concept as understood by a common man. The religious scriptures are pushing the common man to seek something which is beyond this world. But as human beings we are convinced about the reality of this world. Now, according to scriptures, liberation is accepted intellectually as the supreme value of life. However, in actual practice it is considered to be a remote possibility, to be realized in a series of countless lives with the grace of God. As ordinary human beings, we are not sure when we are going to achieve this goal which is not well defined. This is one of the

reason why J. Krishnamurthy emphasizes that everybody has to find truth for oneself, which is a 'pathless land'.

3. Evaluation of Krishnamurthy's teachings

Krishnamurthy declared himself to be the world teacher and in August 1929 announced the dissolution of the 'Order of the Star' stating that he was not satisfied with the 'other' as the authority or imposition of other's ideas. In the metaphorical sense, he liberated himself from the bondage of his physical and causal body.[3] The rejection of the authority that he later advocated in his talks, rather stems from his own existential circumstances.

His concept of 'choiceless awareness' and his simple approach, which brought about a revolution in the minds of people of yesteryears, still continues to influence the young minds of today. Freedom from the authority whether of the 'gurus' or scriptures is the need of the hour, especially in case of fake gurus on the one hand, and the intentional and purposeful interpretation of the scriptures to benefit only a chosen few or with a gender bias. Since, he made an attempt to uproot the very causes of the social evils, he deserves appreciation for such a bold endeavor.

Krishnamurthy deserves praise for his innovative teaching which is truly impartial and religiously neutral as far as human relationship is concerned. His concept of 'conditioned mind' is appealing and leads to quest for freedom in every aspect of our life. He observed the evils of established social set up as an impact of traditional frozen religions or epistemological forms. Many thinkers are inspired by his teaching and find it as a form of 'philosophical counseling', which may open up various ways for 'applied philosophy' to strengthen our cultural, social set up through moral transformation.

He redefined the concept of salvation in his teachings. He introduces a conceptual change in it. According to him, liberation is the fulfillment of the creative process of life and manifestation, and as such cannot be sought as an escape from the conflict and struggle of self-conscious existence away from our life. It is positive, constructive and it is totally, purely a psychological transformation which can only be brought about through voluntary and intelligent action of understanding of the whole significance of life on the part of each individual. Thus, it is not a static goal and humans need not escape to another world in search of this happiness or truth, as it is to be sought in this life itself. He insists on 'liberating life' within us and not on we attaining 'liberation' as a distant goal. He makes it a part and parcel of our practical life. In order to liberate life individual should withdraw from all unessential things and this must be reflected in our daily activities of life. An individual has the power to bring it about and therefore institutions sheltering recluses of various descriptions are in fact working for his/her anti-withdrawal. True renunciation,

for him, can never be collective or institutionalized and thus is skeptical about the traditional approach.

Moving to the other aspects of Krishnamurthy's teachings, on keen observation one finds that, he seems to take away every hope and belief, every idea and image without filling the gap caused thereby. True, that he did not build any philosophical system or supported any philosophy in particular, however, his speeches and conversations, dialogues and talks reflect the influence of philosophical ideas of Shankaracharya's Advaita and Brahman, Kant, Sri Aurobindo and Hegel and others, although in a different linguistic garb. R.K.Shringy in his book, *Philosophy of J. Krishnamurthy: A Systematic and Critical Study* observes that he experimented "with words and concepts, rejecting some, modifying others and inventing new ones."[4] What is even more disturbing is the fact that, he makes acrude attempt to tie the loose ends of his philosophical ideas which are put forth in a fragmentary manner. Sometimes in a dialogue, whenever these fragmentary expressions in dialogues thwarted his communication or posed as obstacles and he could not provide a convincing reason for his position, he used to introduce altogether a new and different concept to shift the attention of the people.

As mentioned earlier Krishnamurthy adopted the method of dialoging to communicate his ideas. David Bohm the world renowned physicist and J. Krishnamurthy collaborated and entered in dialogues to investigate into nature of 'thought', language and meaning, truth and so on. After many years of close relationship, there was a rift in their relationship due to the facts like Krishnamurthy believed that Bohm had understood his teachings only in a superficial manner while Bohm was disappointed with Krishnamurthy's skeptical attitude towards others as incapable of knowing truth and also regarding controversies about Krishnamurthy's celibate life. Krishnamurthy, shortly before his death "declared that no one had ever truly understood his teaching; no one besides himself had experienced transformation"[5] The burning questions for Bohm were, had Krishnamurthy really been free from conditioning? If yes, then why did his behavior at times seemed very much trapped by his ego? This observation is supported by yet another statement from Renee Weber, a celebrated author who had dialogues with many world famous scientists and sages in her book, *Dialogues with Scientists and Sages: The Search for Unity*. Regarding an interview with Krishnamurthy she writes, "Krishnamurthy does not want to be in a book with other people, with ideas different from his own."[6]

On Krishnamuthy's death, Osho the thinker in his discussion titled "Death of the mystic, J. Krishnamurthy" recognized his efforts to help humanity to be more intelligent and mature. However, he commented:

> Krishnamurthy failed because he could not touch the human heart; he could only reach the human head. The heart needs some different approaches. This is where I have differed with him all my life: unless the human heart is reached, you can go on repeating parrot-like, beautiful words—they don't mean anything. Whatever Krishnamurthy was saying is true, but he could not manage to relate it to your heart. In other words, what I am saying is that J. Krishnamurthy was a great philosopher but he could not become a master. He could not help people, prepare for a new life, a new orientation.[7]

Similarly, some of the readers also observe that, he did not involve himself in helping people and to that extent there was lack of commitment on his part.

Uppaluri Gopal Krishnamurthy finds Jiddu Krishnamuthy's teachings contradictory, since on one hand he denounced traditional systems and on the other opened meditation schools. Similarly, he was much bothered about the crippling effect of conditioning but then he established schools which fostered more conditioning. He talked of simplicity and warned people not to follow him as a guru, but he took enough care and measures to preserve his teachings for the future.

On his idea of 'emptying of the mind completely' in order to know the reality, it may be pointed out that, it simply isn't possible to erase the "hard drive" of the brain without either being dead, or in a comatose vegetative state. People like Krishnamurthy who claim to be able to enter into a state of pure awareness where things are seen exactly as they are – they may be deluding themselves. The fact that human consciousness is a filter of Reality, is an undisputed neuro-scientific fact, well known even in the 20th century.

He preached about the unknown as 'formless thought' and truth as 'pathless land'. His exposition of life is not historically new, but his 'way' and technique seems to be original, that derives its validity from his own experiences. According to him, an individual can bring about the mutation of the mind, liberating it and liberating life from the fragmentation of consciousness. So no authority either internal or external is required. But the question remains as to how an individual reach this 'formless thought'? Is it possible? By nature our thinking requires some form or frame, which makes our thinking limited. This frame assists mind in constructing the world. His idea of a 'formless thought' becomes simply an abstraction. Similar treatment may be given to his concept of truth as 'pathless land'. If we are caged at present and are supposed to get freedom from the known, to reach the 'unknown', is it not a 'Utopian thinking', talking about a 'cageless cage'? Is it because there is no clarity about how it is going to be actualized or what it could be? By the logic of his own

thought, he remains confused. It may be also observed that his foundations are already crystallized and have acquired a certain form. Therefore, it is absurd to talk about 'formless form'.

Krishnamurthy's teachings end in 'open-ended closure'. It is a forever growing process and so no liberation or moksha is possible. Further, he reduces the path, to truth or liberation to personal aesthetics, where our ego also plays a role. Therefore, Krishnamurthy reaches the same point from where he had started talking about 'fragmented consciousness', therefore the whole exercise is circular in nature. Again, the fact that truth is one or many remains inconclusive. The proof of the pudding lies in eating it. Therefore, ultimately individuals have to reject external authority, but accept self-authority and bring about 'relative results' in Krishnamurthy's hermeneutics of concept of liberation.

Notes

1 J. Krishnamurthy: Talks, Latin America, (from Authentic Talks by J. Krishnamurthy in Latin America, pub. by Star Publishing Trust, Hollywood, Calif, 1935, p. 80.

2 J. Krishnamurthy: Talks, New Delhi, 1941, p. 108, as found in the book authored by R. K. Srhingy, *Philosophy of J. Krishnamurthy: A Systematic and Critical Study* (New Delhi: Munshiram Manoharlal, 1988), xi.

3 The 'physical body' and the 'causal body' is a metaphorical expression. The Theosophical Society has been conceived as the physical body of the Spirit of Krishnamurthy, since he was brought up there by its members, and the 'Order of the Star' has been conceived as his 'causal body', because this institution was created to proclaim the Teacher in him.

4 R. K. Srhingy, *Philosophy of J. Krishnamurthy: A Systematic and Critical Study* (New Delhi: Munshiram Manoharlal, 1988), xi.

5 F. David Peat, *Infinite Potential, The Life and Times of David Bohm* (New York, United States, Basic Books, 1996), 299.

6 Renee Weber, *Dialogues with Scientists and Sages: The Search for Unity* (London: Routledge and Kegan Paul, 1986), 220.

7 Desh Kapoor, "What Osho said about J. Krishnamurthy and on his death", 7th January 2013, <http://www.patheos.com/blogs/drishtikone/2013/01/what-osho-said-about-j-krishnamurti-and-his-work-on-his-death> (1 September, 2017).

19

Osho's Redefinition of Spirituality
A Necessary Paradigm Shift to End Religious Violence in Multi-Religious India

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Abstract: Religious system as ethical, social, political and economic is indispensable element for human society. Religious pluralism is characteristically Indian because India is the cradle for many native religions. During its millennial history, India has embraced and assimilated various foreign religious traditions. Thus, religious tolerance has become a much-appreciated trait of its heritage. It was believed that differences among various belief-systems would never be a cause for tension, misunderstanding, conflicts, and violence. Whereas for the past few decades, they have become the context for religious riots while they are employed as tools by extremist religious groups for their personal, communal, and political gains. India's religious pluralistic context can´t be done away with at any cost for it has been enjoying good reputation for it from all other countries. This paper, drawing inspiration from Osho's hermeneutics of suspicion, makes an attempt to present a paradigm shift in the foundational principle of spirituality, a shift from old paradigms of religions to a new paradigm of spirituality. This paradigm shift is characterized by several necessary leaps that constitute the core of this new spirituality. In my opinion, the new Existence-based spirituality would make religious environment still richer whereby peaceful coexistence of all religions be possible.

Introduction

Many predicted that religions would disappear at the wake of the 21st century due to rapid growth of science and modern civilization but it did not happen. However there were a few thinkers, such as Sri Ravi Shankar, Jiddu Krishnamurthy, Juggi Vasudev, and Osho who propagated a profound change in understanding religion and discarding unhealthy religious elements.

Religion in itself is good. It has contributed a lot for the good of humanity and continues to play a vital role introducing changes in the lives of many people. Especially it has done a remarkable service in giving hope to the weak and the suffering. However, humans were never at rest on account of this fundamental human phenomenon. Misunderstandings, tensions, conflicts, violence, and wars were unleashed in the name of Religions in the history of humankind and at times religions became the breeding grounds of violence. Religious violence is perpetrated by religious fundamentalists on the grounds of religious texts, doctrines or dogmas, cults, gods & goddesses, religious institutions and precepts. Sometimes it becomes a reaction to the above-listed, when they become oppressive structures.

Religious conflict may take two forms: conflict between religions and conflict between the religion and the state. The first type of religious conflict is common in those countries with multi-religions and the second type is widespread in those countries or states whose religion is single. India suffers religious conflicts in either ways. It is a curse in general and a setback for democracy and secularism as well. In a survey entitled, "Global Restrictions on Religion Rise Modestly in 2015, Reversing Downward Trend," Pew research centre for religion and public life in 2015 declares that India is the fourth worst country in the world for religious violence. Religious attacks carried out in India, hate-speeches and irresponsible religious comments of political leaders of Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) and its allies after the formation of its government in 2014 give some credence to the above-mentioned survey report.

What is the real problem in India? And why is it unable to stop religious violence? There are general factors such as illiteracy, poverty, and unemployment which are conducive to perpetuate religious violence. Religious diversity, though it seems to be a quite simple and a common phenomenon, has been the most basic, sufficient, and pregnant ground for religious violence in India. But violence could be eliminated by adhering to a healthy religious spirituality. Hence, there is a need for a paradigm shift from old, sickening, and extremist religious fervour to a new, true, and healthy spirituality. Osho's reinterpretation of spirituality is a good paradigm shift which might safeguard the spirit of secularism guaranteed by the Constitution of India.

Religious Pluralism and Violence in India

Generally religious violence is incited on two ideological grounds, namely political and religious. Religious violence on the ground of different religious ideologies is common in many countries. For example, religious conflict in countries, such as Nigeria, Myanmar, Bangladesh, Pakistan, Afghanistan, Kenya, Somalia, and India is due to differences in religious ideologies. Religious pluralism in India is more complex and at the same time vibrant, because of its many native and foreign religions, such as Hinduism, Buddhism, Jainism, Zoroastrianism, Sikhism, Islamism, Judaism and Christianity. However, the high sensitive context for religious violence in India is not the same as in Europe and America. European and American context of religious violence is mostly due to grudge and retaliation. They are payed back for organizing overseas military operations against religious and cultural sectarian terrorist groups around the world, such as Boko Haram, ISIS, Taliban, and Al-Qaeda. Hence religious violence in Europe and America is based on political grounds. India's context for religious violence is something different and peculiar. It is related to clash between domestic religions and between extremist religious groups.

Religious diversity is one of the defining characteristics of secular India. Hence, religious pluralism and tolerance are India's pride. The trace of India's religious maturity and its heterogeneity regarding religion dates back more than three thousand years ago. Yet behind all the beautiful stories of different religious communities living together, adapting some aspects of one another's customs and practices, and even sharing the religious festivals, there have been traces of religious violence. In ancient India, though there were religious conflicts among Vedic Hinduism, Buddhism, and Jainism, they were labeled as healthy ones. It was said that those religions competed with each other in defending their doctrines so as to have more followers. But later on, hatred among these religions became a real issue, when Hinduism (from 7th to 12th centuries, A.D) persecuted Jain and Buddhist communities.[1]Still later religious violence was fuelled by partition between Hindu-majority India and Muslim-majority Pakistan in 1947, and also by the rise of Hindu nationalism in the 1990s.[2]

Even though politicization of Hinduism is said to be the reason for recent religious violence, the primary impetus for religious violence in India is religious fundamentalism. Almost all religions in India have had and are still having the tendency/inclination to be associated with some fundamentalist elements. Hindu nationalism, Sikh separatism, Christian Evangelism, and Islamic extremism are driving forces behind periodic outbreak of religious violence in India.[3] All these perverted ideologies come from the misinterpretation of the

fundamentals of religion, such as creeds, dogmas, belief-system, cults, priests, religious authorities and religious precepts.

Causes for India's Religious Diversity

There had been five major causes, such as geographical distance, ethnic diversity, diverse faith or spiritual experiences, Mughals' invasion, and finally British colonization. However, in the 21st century, to still harp about Mughals' invasion and British colonization is ridiculous. The differences arising out of geographical distance and ethnic diversity can be sorted out by means of technological and cultural globalization. But the phenomenon of religious diversity remains a long-standing challenge.

Religious diversity is basically doctrinal. Spiritual experience is individual and personal one, while doctrine is developed out of communal spiritual experience.[4] Doctrinal difference becomes ideological difference when intolerance grows among religions, and religious conflicts in general are anchored on ideological differences. Osho questions the authenticity of the existing religions on ideological ground. For Osho, the reason for religious diversity is simply the failure to see the essence or the centrality of religion. Thus, the principal cause for religious conflicts is a failure to grasp the lifeblood of religion.

Some might argue from different perspective and may think political ideologies as the cause for religious violence in India. Political reasons cannot be the cause because they are very recent development in the history of religious violence in India. The cause for religious conflicts in India stems from religious pluralistic context. Therefore, if the doctrinal differences are sorted out and individual spiritual experience is given its importance, all other contextual hurdles can be handled effectively for believers' better coexistence. Now the question is: Can the context of religious pluralism be changed? If not, can we find a common ground to maintain harmony and to assure a peaceful co-existence to all Indians? Changing the context is not possible at least now because India is still religiously fundamentalistic. But Osho sought and propagated the possibility of creating a single spirituality and thus, a single religion. He questions: Why there must be many religions? Why can't there be one single religion when actually there is one single science?[5] Or in other words, when there is one science for outer reality, why cannot there be a single religion for the inner reality of man? It is a very logical and peculiar question which no one ever asked. This question invites humankind to think differently and place it back on the right track towards the ultimate foundation of all religions. Osho foresees the sure possibility of setting up a true religion by effecting a foundational change in spirituality.

The Foundation Principle for True Spirituality

Even pseudo-religions or pseudo-spiritualties[6] have belief-system, creed, dogmas, cult, religious commandments, etc., as their foundational principles. They are ignorance-oriented, fear-oriented, greed-oriented, logical, calculative, and cleverness-oriented,[7] whereas true spirituality is existence-oriented. Existence without any qualification as human existence, animal existence and so on, is the foundational principle of true spirituality. Thus, anything that is existent is respected so as to create cosmic existential consciousness.

Why should Existence be the foundational principle for true spirituality? How can it be a common ground for all religions for their peaceful co-existence? First of all, it is Existence that is prior and most fundamental to everything else. Secondly, true spirituality as inner science moves towards Existence, the life. Thirdly, as Osho says, Existence is spaciousness which is bountifully spacious for creativity and productivity. Existence gives infinite spaciousness with no boundaries, accessible for infinite possibilities.[8] Fourthly, Existence is positive and therefore, no negative thought and action can come from it. Finally, Existence is freedom having two functions: first aims at liberating people from all pseudo-religions which kept them slaves and isolated from oneself and from others as well and the second aims at enhancing Existence.[9] Osho registers, "To me, there is no god other than life itself, and there is no temple other than existence itself. Then everything becomes a divine celebration."[10] Existence has to be the point of departure for religious unity, for paradigm shift in religion and also for the creation of a true and universal religion of enlightenment, a spirituality suitable for India. Thus, the foundational principle cannot be a concept or name of god, a creed, a belief-system, a code of worship, a cult, a dogma and not even a founder of religion. All these cannot be unifying principles because it is on account of all these, people are divided in the world, especially in India. For example, in recent years the ban on cow slaughtering has become a contentious issue for cow is considered to be holy by some Hindus.

The Paradigm Shift

The term, "Pseudo-religion" is a framework consisting in a set of ideas, theories, and assumptions of old religions as major paradigms. The old religious paradigms are belief-systems, dogmas, creeds, commandments, gods & goddesses, cults, institutions, priests, temples, and many more. The new paradigm for true spirituality and thus true religion is Existence itself. It is a common ground and a foundational principle on which true spirituality can be anchored.

The BJP and its religious allies also put forward a new paradigm shift called Hindutva. Hindutva is argued to be cultural nationalism. And BJP tries

to redefine it as Indian culture and heritage.[11] But analysts say that Hindutva is connected to Hindu nationalism rather than cultural nationalism. If Hindutva refers to that which is Hindu than Indian, consequently it is bound to exclude the rest of the religions in India. Ipso facto, it cannot be the proper paradigm shift to foster harmonious co-existence of all religions in India. Hindutva may favour uniformity but not unity. In other words it aims at one nation, one culture, one people, and one leadership based on Hindu religion and culture.[12]

Why Paradigm Shift?

Indians are known for their religiosity in every aspect of life. "Spirituality is indeed the master-key of the Indian mind; the sense of the infinite is native to it."[13] Indian religious consciousness has evolved to a remarkable degree through a long standing history of spiritual life lived and transmitted by our ancestors. Until the beginning of 20th century India had been promoting a centripetal spirituality whereby the center of all religions was consciousness. Whereas for the past few decades the religions, including Hinduism, have adapted centrifugal spirituality, a mode of spiritual progression in which religions move away not only from the Centre "the consciousness", but also from one another through their fascinating false ideologies. There is no room for converging point among the current religious ideologies stemming as Hindu nationalism, Sikh separatism, Christian Evangelism, and Islamic extremism. It is imperative that we reverse the process from centrifugal to centripetal. In fact, the paradigm shift aims at the convergence of different spiritualities to the primordial Centre – Existence.Osho's writing highlights the paradigm shift which comprises of several leaps. They are as follows:

1. The Leap from Intellect to Intelligence

A leap from intellect to intelligence is necessary to understand the profundity of Existence. Intellect is not the same as intelligence. Intellect is past-oriented, calculative, logical, and methodologically scientific inasmuch as it involves dissection and analysis. It can grasp Existence only at the abstract level. It is very easy to indoctrinate the people who live at the mind level to get involved in religious riots. Dogmas, creeds, and precepts are the products of the intellect. Hence, it is the intellect that divides religions and discriminates people. In fact, mental existence is the lower level in the ladder of the hierarchy of Existence; where as intelligence, being paradoxical and synthetic, strives to uphold realities as whole. Existence needs to be seen as whole and not parts. Intelligence enables people to perceive the underlying principle of unity in every reality and appreciate it. It is in the wholeness there lies beauty, life, and grace.[14] Where there is intelligence, there is understanding of Existence, unity, and collaboration. A man of intelligence (of true religion) always aspires for

things of higher value and works for unity and common good. India desperately needs a religion of intelligence not of intellect to uphold secular values.

2. Leap from Mind (Meditation) to Mindlessness (Dhyana)

Mindlessness is "dhyana" which refers to the state of awareness, consciousness, freedom, and spontaneity. It means transcending the dictates of the mind, heart and body so as to contemplate and remain in profound "stillness."[15] Osho recalls the words of Daiten, a Zen master: "You are life – eternal life, you are existence – eternal existence; you are pure no-mind."[16] The true religion advocates "no-mind-existence." It means not to subject ourselves blindly to mental products, such as creeds and dogmas. All isms such as, Atheism, Theism, Hinduism, Islamism, Communism, Marxism, Buddhism and Christianity are the products of the mind. People are divided by these isms and their creeds and religious practices.[17] But on the contrary while transcending the mind, one can witness to the ultimate reality of bountiful Existence, which is the core, the beginning and the summit of the true religion. This is the source of new dawn of bliss, blessings, love, and compassion. The realization of the truth of Existence frees the mind from indulging in violence, wars, and terrorist's attack.

When people confine themselves within the framework of mind, they remain judgmental towards themselves, others, and others' way of life, worship, and culture. Judgment is past-oriented, for it comes from past experiences, while existence is here and now. Past represents all that is acquired in the process of socialization, such as beliefs, behaviours, customs, future aspirations, etc.[18] It plays an important role in nurturing religious violence in India. For instance, the destruction of Babri Masjid on 6th December 1992 was a flagrant act.

3. Leap from Conscience to Consciousness[19]

Conscience designates all knowledge while consciousness indicates emptiness. There is Hindu conscience, Christian conscience, etc., but consciousness as such is neither Christian, nor Hindu, nor Islamic, etc. Conscience divides people and consciousness unites. Consciousness is like a mirror and he who has consciousness just reflects himself to the situations and responds to the situations spontaneously.[20] At this stage whatever one does is right because it fits in and harmonious with Existence.[21] Consciousness brings light to the whole life. Thus, one can harm neither himself nor the other. We are in-the-Existence and our consciousness is not separated from Existence. Thus, one remains united with the universe. One becomes graceful, blissful, and blessing to others. Conscience is the root cause for all wrong doings in the history. Therefore, a leap from conscience to consciousness forms integral part of the paradigm shift.

4. Leap from Reaction to Response[22]

Religiously responsible man is self-disciplined and does not act from memory, from past experience. If one acts influenced by the past, he/she either repeats the past or reacts to it. In any kind of religious violence, the instigated and misguided mob just reacts indulging in vandalism such as: burning, killing, banning, and demolishing. He/she acts blindly drawing conclusions from the past.[23] Whereas a religious person is the one who responds spontaneously and as well adequately to the situations of life with consciousness.[24] He/she always does good in conformity with the core of his/her existence. Jesus says, "The man of spirit lives like a spirit" (John 3:8). A truly religious man is a man of spirit and of Existence.

5. Leap from Revolution to Rebellion

A leap from revolution to rebellion requires self-transformation. Through revolutionary activities, one dares to bring about drastic changes in the society. On the contrary, to be rebellious is one of the important virtues of being an authentic religious.[25] Rebellion refers to an individual with a unique and critical vision. It flows from one's authenticity and religiousness. A rebel is the one who reflects critically to uphold the truth so as to live here and now.

6. Leap from Personality to Individuality

A good personality is the aspiration of everybody, because it has got social approval. There is a saying in Tamil: "Ooroduothuozhugu" (literally translated as "Conduct yourself in accordance with the larger society"). It means that a good personality gets along with society and does not dare to do anything contrary to what society believes or expects. Descartes asked us not to accept anything as true unless and until we have the evident knowledge of its truthfulness.[26] Only individuals can be critical, not society. Since personality is societal, it cannot be critical and authentic. A true religion does not advocate personality but individuality. Personality has inclination to lead people to mob mentality.[27] General observation establishes that religions are interested to create personality and not individuality. For example, there can be many personalities in reference to religious belief systems like Hindu, Christian, and Muslim etc. But there cannot be any individuality bound by religious beliefs.

Religious fundamental groups are composed not of individuals but of personalities which are fundamentally social. The one who has sheep mentality, follows the crowd not knowing what is right and wrong. He/she believes that the crowd cannot be wrong. His/her rightness and wrongness is decided by the crowd. Truth has nothing to do with the crowd, but it belongs to the individual. Crowd will not ask the 'why'; it will do what it is asked. Since personalities have common mind, all that they carry in their minds is not theirs but acquired

from teachers, religious, priests, and political leaders, etc.[28] A spirituality which is oriented towards Existence needs a leap from personality to individuality.

7. Leap from Conversion to Conversion-free

"Ghar Wapsi" is a much talked about term these days in India. It is a Hindi word meaning "Home Coming." This word refers to a movement or an activity of reconverting or bringing converted Christians and Muslims back to their original Dharma, mostly Hinduism and it is primarily organized by Hindu outfits, the RSS and the VHP. The movement of "Ghar Wapsi" is said to be a reaction to religious conversions being carried out in different parts of India in the past. In the true religion, there is no point of religious conversion, even if it is reconversion. Religious conversion becomes meaningless, because religious conversion is based on belief-system which has already been questioned and refuted by Osho. People get converted because they doubt – they doubt in the authenticity of their source religion and its belief-system. By converting themselves to another religion people again suppress their doubt, because the religion they get converted to is again another belief-system just like the previous one. Generally religions repress doubt by proposing belief.[29] For example, the mere fact that a blind believes in light does not testify that he has seen the light.[30] In the same way, believers have not seen the truth; but they simply assume it. Osho calls the suppression of the basic nature of man, i.e., curiosity or doubt as the mistake of religions.[31] Osho's true religion or spirituality is not belief-oriented, but gives emphasis on experience, awareness, and consciousness. It does not suppress doubt by replacing it with belief-system, but rather enhances it to the next stage, that is awareness. In other words Osho's spirituality replaces belief with 'awareness.' The leap from conversion to conversion-free affirms that anyone who has an authentic experience of the Existence won't opt for another religious conversion but will uphold awareness. In other words, he/she, of course, will have conversion, but his/her conversion would be from 'belief' to 'awareness.'

The Implications of the Spirituality of Existence for India's Current Situation

This spirituality is proposed as necessary for India at present: Firstly, because after coming to power at the centre, BJP and its allies have intensified their propagation of Hindutva, which in reality is a distortion of Hinduism. It is a grave threat to India's thirst and commitment to remain and function as a secular nation enshrined in the Constitution. Secondly, this spirituality will inspire theologians of all religions to create a theology of the immanent presence of God, which is Existence itself, whereby religion will emerge and move from down to upward – from earth to heavenward. Thus, Existence reaches new heights where Existence is prioritized over peripheral, offensive,

and disagreeable ideologies on which differences are perpetuated. Thirdly, internalization of the existential spirituality will transform people to have a life-affirmative approach and respect for life. Hence an antagonistic[32] and masochistic[33] attitude towards life simply upholding sorrows and sufferings as great religious virtues will gradually disappear. For, Existence is primordial and anything other than that is abstract. Existence-based spirituality promotes and enhances life. Fourthly, it will bring religions together on the basis of its foundational principle called Existence and assure a mutual respect and peaceful co-existence of all religions. And finally, it will unite people irrespective of their religions so as to collaborate for a better India addressing the issues such as poverty, unemployment, illiteracy, and economic inequality.

Possible Limitations of the Existence-based Spirituality

The precondition proposed by Osho to uphold Existence-based spirituality is a limitation as well as a challenge in itself. That's "the material needs of man must be fulfilled". In fact, many prominent Indian mystics including Mahavir and Buddha hailed from arich family background. Osho asserts, "Without outer richness nobody becomes aware of the inner discontent."[34] One can search for that which fulfills the inner thirst only when his material needs are fulfilled. For, man's first need is material and is the foundation for the spiritual. Once material poverty is eradicated, then one will be able to see the inner spiritual poverty. When outer is poor, the inner also will be poor in the sense that the understanding of religion or spirituality will not be as expected, healthy, and mature. This is the reason why the poor's prayer is generally oriented towards fulfilling the outer and this is the reason why God is being personified as judge, king, giver, etc.

Osho has two arguments for his standpoint: the first is the dichotomy that exists between the West and Eastern countries. The West has become affluent. Therefore, it starts seeking to fulfill the inner needs by moving towards the East which is rich in spirituality. The East was rich once and out of its richness it gave birth to spiritual richness. But now it is just the opposite. India has become poor materially and spiritually as well. India has to share its rich spiritual tradition to the West and the West its material richness, so that each gets fulfilled.

The second argument is the context in which Indians got converted into foreign religions. One of the main reasons behind conversion was poverty.[35]

Literally speaking perfect material fulfillment may not be feasible and therefore, Existence-based spirituality remains an illusion or may be a rare phenomenon achievable only by mystics. The ultimate question that arises is: Why cannot there be aharmony between poor outer or material poverty and rich inner or rich spirituality? In other words, why cannot the poor be spiritual? Spirituality can also be cross-dimensional with the poor outer and

the rich inner. The perfect example would be Jesus Himself who maintained the inner richness, that is, the spirituality of Existence and poor outer, the material poverty. The spirituality lived and taught by Jesus disapproves the precondition that Osho advocated. Spirituality can also be paradoxical with materially poor outer and spiritually rich inner. For the realization of this new paradoxical spirituality, all that is needed is the feeling of being content with what one has. Even with poor outer, one can create rich inner.

Existence-based spirituality is highly mystical. People who follow popular piety and expect miracles in their religious endeavors may not pursue such a highly intellectual spirituality. They are happy with whatever they do with their religion. Even Osho himself regrets that he could not help the ordinary people whose expectation is to cope up with the demands of ordinary day-today life.

Existence-based spirituality at times may turn to be solipsistic, if it is self-centered. An authentic experience of Existence cannot be kept within oneself. This experience has to be shared with others. For, together we participate in Existence. Hence one's life orientation changes gradually and surrenders wholeheartedly to the Existence. In fact, St. Paul's God-experience is a perfect example to affirm the Existence-based spirituality. He acknowledges that, "it is in him we live and move and have our being" (Acts 17:28). Indeed, it is in the Existence that we live, move and have our being. How can one discover a profound and sacred meaning of his existence? It is possible for those whose life is seen and lived in relation to the Existence. The experience of Existence within oneself urges to be at the service of the others. Therefore, spirituality of Existence helps people transform their lives and lead a life in accordance with Existence-based virtues such as respect, love, compassion, care, and responsibility.

Finally, Existence-based spirituality may seem to undermine the differences in religion but it is not so. Osho tends to put aside the differences for a while so as to highlight the unity of religions on the basis of fundamental principle, Existence. The differences are nothing but the different ways of living and practicing the Existence-based spirituality. For example, one can serve human life through charitable works; another can preserve nature; still another can work for world-peace. But all follow the same spirituality of Existence. There are differences in the names of god, in rituals, and in creeds, but all these differences will only reflect different cultures and traditions of the one and the same spirituality of Existence. Therefore, the differences are not denied. On the other hand, they are recognized, retained, and made solid and authentic, because they flow from the spirituality of Existence.

Conclusion

Osho criticized institutionalized religions and adopted instead a mystical religion. Since he was convinced of only one mystery, i.e., Existence, he ruled out categorically the possibility of many mystical religions. The differences are simply related to dogmas, doctrines, names of gods & goddesses, cults, priests, and precepts. The main objective of the seven articulated leapsis to help people go beyond the differences so as to embrace the true spirituality, and live its implications in their personal, social, and religious life.

Osho's intuitive understanding and realization of the meaning of Existence, which he calls the centre of his spirituality is deep and significant. His spirituality is something which is not against our human nature, but rather it fulfills it and becomes indeed existential. When one adopts his mysticism, and lives his/her nature, he/she is able to say that he/she has dignity; for Existence is in one's home; one is not an outsider. Osho affirms that first of all we are earthly-bound, and therefore, spirituality in accordance with our earthly nature is best required to taste this earthly life to its fullness.

Religion is man's intrinsic potentiality that starts from the core of his being moving upward to Existence. If this is true, sooner or later people will embrace true religion. In Sartre's terminology, we can say that everybody is destined to be religious. For, all are in the Existence and Existence is what is real. In consonance with Heidegger, one can say that this religion is our ultimate possibility. If anyone wants to live an authentic life, he/she is drawn to choose this religion. For Osho, only Existence is. Christians believe that God is Existence in primary sense, then he is love, knowledge, mercy, etc., and they also believe that God has the characteristic of being immanent in the world with the name *Immanuel* "God with us". God himself announces that he first "IS," and then he acts: "I am Who I am" (Exodus 3: 14). A religion rooted on Existence is authentic because it is built on the fundamental reality which is self-evident. This assumption goes hand in hand with the teaching of Christianity. Osho does not want to use any name to this ultimate reality, Existence, because names for him represent ideology and ideology represents mind, and finally mind represents old religions. His affirmation, "Except life, there is no God," makes it clear that one can consider Existence as God. In this sense, Osho's spirituality is relevant for all Indians.

Notes

1 Judith E. Walsh, *A Brief History of India* (New York: Facts On File, Inc., 2006), xiv.
2 *Ibid*.
3 C.D. Naik, *Buddhism and Dalits: Social Philosophy and Traditions* (Delhi: Kalpaz Publications, 2010), 23.
4 Christine Axt-Piscalar, "Liberal Theology in Germany," in *Nineteenth Century Theology*, ed. David Fergusson (Oxford: Wily Blackwell, 2010), 274.

5 Osho, *The Book of Understanding* (New York: Harmony Books, 2006), 65.
6 Pseudo-religion is the term which Osho uses to designate all institutionalized religions as opposed to true religion or spirituality which he advocates. See, Osho, *The Book of Understanding*, 157. The terms, "Old religion," "Past religion" and "Pseudo-religion" are interchangeably used in this article.
7 Osho, *Belief, Doubt, and Fanaticism* (New York: St. Martin's Griffin, 2012). 183-196.
8 Osho, *Bornwith a Question Mark in your Heart* (New York, Zurich and Mumbai: Osho Media International, 2012), 32.
9 Osho, *I Celebrate Myself: God is no Where, Life is Now Here*, 261; see also, Osho, Osho, *Born with a Question Mark in Your Heart,* 39.
10 Osho, *The Book of Understanding,* 76.
11 "Hindutva: The Great Nationalist Ideology," in BJP official web page at http://www.bjp.org/index.php?option=com_content&view=article&id=369:hindutva-the-great-nationalist-ideology&Itemid=501 (26 October, 2017).
12 Prakash Louis, *The Emerging of Hindutva Force: The Ascent of Hindu Nationalism* (New Delhi: Indian Social Institute, 2000), 81.
13 It is a quotation from Aurobindo as found in Peter Jarvis and Mary Watts, *The Routledge International Handbook of Learning* (London & New York: Routledge, 2012), 527.
14 Osho, *The Book of Understanding,* 152-153.
15 Osho, *I Celebrate Myself: God is No Where, Life is Now Here,* 28.
16 Ibid., 111.
17 Osho, *I Celebrate Myself: God is No Where, Life is Now Here,* 37-38.
18 *Ibid*., 93-94.
19 Osho, *The Book of Understanding,* 190.
20 *Ibid*., 190-192.
21 Osho, *Moral, Immoral, Amoral: What is Right and What is Wrong?* (New York: St. Martin's Griffin, 2013), 82.
22 Osho, *The Book of Understanding,* 212.
23 *Ibid*., 216.
24 Osho, *I Celebrate Myself: God is No Where, Life is Now Here,* 42.
25 Osho, *Krishna: The Man and His Philosophy* (Mumbai: Jaico Publishing Company, 2006), 67.
26 Rene Descartes, *Discourse on Method and Meditations on First Philosophy*, trans. Donald A. Cress (Indianapolis /Cambridge: Hackett Publishing Company, 1998), 18.
27 Osho, *The Book of Understanding,* 161.
28 *Ibid*., 162.
29 Osho, *I Celebrate Myself: God is no Where, Life is Now Here,* 19.
30 *Ibid*., 19.
31 Osho, *The Book of Understanding,* 73. See also, Osho, Belief, *Doubt, and Fanaticism,* 68.
32 Osho, Ecstasy: *The Language of Existence* (New Delhi: Diamond Pocket Books PVT. LTD., 2003), 16.
33 Osho, *I Celebrate Myself: God is No Where, Life is Now Here*, 1.
34 Osho, *The Book of Understanding*, 46.
35 Osho, *The Book of Understanding*, 48.

20

Kancha Ilaiah and Post-Hindu India
Possibilities and Challenges

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Abstract: The paper looks at Prof. Kancha Ilaiah's political philosophy, especially his contribution to the unity of the Dalit, OBCs and other downtrodden masses. Ilaiah is a vivid critic of caste and the Aryan/Brahmin domination of the indigenous masses. As such he is strongly criticizes the Hindutva movement. He has earned a lot of enemies who oppose him in all aspects. A recent controversy over one of his books even made the Supreme Court to uphold the right to freedom of expression. Ilaiah in this book has rightly accused the corporate trading caste/class of India as social smugglers who smuggle people's money and hide it and thus destroying the economy of the country. Ilaiah has meticulously recorded the sad plight of the Indian Dalits in the present political scenario. He says that the Dalits are treated like buffalos. In India though the maximum amount of milk is produced by the buffalos, the Aryan/Hindutva ideologists praise and revere only the cow. Same way though the most productive people are the Dalits in any area be it agriculture or industrial labor, the Dalits are not getting their due respect or recognition in the society. They are downtrodden and oppressed and often expelled or rejected by the mainline Indian society. Ilaiah provokes the Dalits to join hands with the other downtrodden communities like the OBCs, tribals, and SCs and revolt against the oppressors even if it leads to violence.

Introduction

Caste is one of the major factors which divide the Indian society even though we have been part of this civilized world from ancient times. Caste/*Varna*/*Jati*

is a form of racism introduced into the Indian subcontinent by the Aryans who were invaders and were light skinned than the aborigines or the indigenous people of the land. Romila Thapar suggests that the emergence of the Vedic culture in the post-Harappan period gave the ideological legitimacy to the caste system in the subcontinent.[1] Caste system later developed to what P. L. Narasu identifies as a, "crippling disease."[2] It is a system of social stratification which lies at the very root of Indian social structure.[3] The caste system became so oppressive to the level of perpetuating categorical oppression on the indigenous people in all walks of their life. There was a time when the indigenous people of India, now identified as Sudras, Dalits, Tribals, etc., through divine sanction were denied opportunities for education and proper livelihood by the so-called upper castes, say the Brahmins. Education was reserved to the three upper strata of the Indian society, namely, the Brahmins, the Kshatriyas, and the Vaishyas, all of whom belonged to the Aryan race. The guru-sishya methodology used in ancient Indian education helped the Brahmins to uphold their supremacy in areas of teaching and learning and they were able to keep the religion in their control by being the religious heads of the temples and by being the administrative counsellors to the kings and chieftains.

When India came under British control the scenario changed. The English introduced English education to Indians mainly because they needed clerks, constables, cooks and other helpers to assist in their administration of India. In this situation education became open to all Indians regardless of caste or creed. The opening of education to the once deprived masses became a serious issue and threat for the dominating castes because the development in the lower strata of the society disturbed the power structure of the so-called high castes. The ideology of Hindutva was developed by the once privileged castes to counter-act the hindrance in the social structure. In order to maintain the *satus qu*o the *Hindutvadis*[4] are willing to go to any level of atrocities and abuse. Kancha Ilaiah comes in to this scene as one of the most important critics of Hindutva in the present era.

Background

Kancha Ilaiah Shepherd[5] is an Indian political philosopher, author, and activist for human rights. Ilaiah rose to international fame through his controversial book "Why I am not a Hindu"[6] a book titled after the international best seller and controversial book "Why I am not a Christian"[7] by Bertrand Russell. In this book Ilaiah strongly asserts that he was not born "a Hindu."[8] The simple reason he gives for that is that his parents never knew that they were Hindus.[9] He goes on giving details of how different are the gods and goddesses of the Dalit and oppressed castes when compared to the so-called higher or dominating (Aryan) castes. He further suggests that the idea of him being a Hindu came to his mind only when he entered the school.[10]

In his writings Ilaiah uses the collective term "Dalit-bahujans"[11] to refer to the downtrodden Other Backward Castes and the Scheduled Castes. This is a good approach because it brings the non-Brahminic, the Non-Aryan or the so called non-upper castes of the *Varna* system in to a single fold. In this approach he unifies the majority of the Indian society in to one family. Unity of the oppressed, a concept which threatens Hindutva is proposed by Ilaiah and thus he is seen as a serious threat by the Hindutva agents. Ilaiah is a vivid critic of Brahminic/Hindutva ideologies. His books such as *God as Political Philosopher: Buddha's Challenge to Brahminism*,[12] *Buffalo Nationalism: A Critique of Spiritual Fascism*,[13] *Post-Hindu India: A Discourse in Dalit-Bahujan Socio-Spiritual and Scientific Revolution*[14] etc., provide alternative arguments against the dominant Brahminic/Hindutva agenda.

Recent Controversy

Kancha Ilaiah has written widely on the dignity of labour and production. In a book titled *Turning the Pot, Tilling the Land: Dignity of Labour in Our Times,*[15] Ilaiah upholds the importance of the labouring communities. He rightly points out that, "our society suffers from lack of dignity of labour because in the frame work of the caste system any process that involves labour is projected as undignified."[16] Ilaiah traces the origin of caste system to "a few non-labouring groups."[17] He further says that,

> The promoters of caste system created a philosophy, according to which the educated intellectual classes should not be involved in the production of food, in pot-making, in leatherwork, in cleaning tasks, carpentry, weaving, etc. Such an understanding destroyed the dignity of labour. Over a period, with every labour oriented activity treated as undignified, the educated sections of the society forgot the fact that labour is the source of life.[18]

Inequality became rampant because the labouring class was seen as a low living by the lazy class. Upward mobility was denied systematically by saying labour is hereditary and a person gets in to a caste through birth.

In the ninth chapter of his book *Post-Hindu India: A Discourse in Dalit-Bahujan Socio-Spiritual and Scientific Revolution,* Ilaiah introduced the concept of "social smuggling" which is related to economy.[19] For Ilaiah social smuggling as a phrase "is an economic process of exploitation, where it means earning in business and not investing back into society."[20] He accused the Brahmin-Bhaniya castes for smuggling the resources of the society through their business endeavours and for hiding it for themselves and thus destroying the economy of the country.

Recently Kancha Ilaiah fell into controversy because of a new booklet titled 'Samajika Smugglurlu Komatollu' (Vysyas are Social Smugglers), a

translation of the above mentioned chapter from his earlier book *Post-Hindu India*. The angered Vysya/Bhaniya communities staged protests and burned Ilaiah's effigies. A death threat to Ilaiah was issued by Telugu Desam Party's Member of Parliament T.G. Venkatesh. The MP gave a statement that Ilaiah should be publically hanged.[21] The death threat to Kancha Iliaah and the subsequent attacks he faced is to be taken very seriously in the present context in which our nation is placed. The recent murder of journalist and activist Gauri Lankesh is a lesson we have to keep in mind. Anyone who opposes Hindutva and the right wing political ideologies are silenced by various means, and those who withstand the means are silenced by the gun. India has witnessed the rise of such political murders in recent times. The whole world saw the opposition to Ilaiah as an opposition against freedom of speech and expression. Internationally and nationally forums and individuals stood in support of Ilaiah.

Meanwhile a case was filed in the Supreme Court to ban the above said book. In a historic verdict the Supreme Court of India has upheld the freedom of speech and expression and thus dismissed the petition seeking to ban the book. In the verdict a three-member bench comprising Chief Justice Deepak Mishra, Justice A.M. Khanwilkar and Justice D.Y. Chandrachud pointed out that banning the book would amount to infringing on the freedom of expression and speech guaranteed by the Constitution.[22] Ilaiah in an article in the *Indian Express*has expressed his happiness profoundly. He said, "This verdict has given a new life to the freedom of expression in India at a time when intellectuals, writers, and journalists in the country were living in an atmosphere of fear. The verdict encourages scholars from oppressed communities to conduct research on castes and communities without fear."[23]

Ilaiah and Hindutva

Ilaiah is a strong critic of fascism and Hindutva. He identifies Hindutva with Brahminism. He says, "The weakest mind and body of some Indians, over a period of time, constructed a notion of Brahman. This notion of Brahman is Anti-Human. This notion has been constructed in primitive times in an underdeveloped language called Sanskrit. The concept Brahman constructed a Human living process in seclusion and non-engagement with nature and labour…" Ilaiah further adds that, "The Brahman, for example, has shown cow as superior animal to Human. The followers of Brahman have considered production as pollution. Establishing a belief of animal superiority to Humans is exceptionally de-humanizing. The Brahman introduced animal worship as worship of divine."[24] Ilaiah has remarkably stated that, "Now more Dalits are being killed in the cow belt. The cow protection policy of the RSS has become a Dalit destruction policy. Dalits, across political affiliations, realise that in the

name of cow protection the Dalit/Adivasi cattle economy and food resources are being destroyed."[25] He elsewhere has said,

> Being a Dalit is like being a buffalo in India. Most of the milk to consume comes from the buffaloes, but it is not treated at par or worshipped as a cow. It is the same predicament of Dalits, as they are the most productive. Dalits mean creativity and productivity, but they are not even allowed to enter a temple. They should fight against this in alliance with other backward classes.[26]

He has recorded the sad fact that, "This is the only nation in the world to have passed laws that protect one animal and its progeny even if it means the death of human beings, Dalits and Muslims."[27]

The Brahminical forces have kept Indian society divided for centuries. Now activists like Ilaiah are bringing awareness among the masses to withstand the hegemony of Brahminism. According to Ashish Nandi, "Hindutva is the ideology of a part of the upper-caste, lower-middle class Indians, though it has now spread to large parts of the urban middle classes. The ideology is an attack on Hinduism and an attempt to protect the flanks of a minority consciousness which the democratic process is threatening to corner."[28] Shashi Tharoor says, "Hindutva has nothing to do with Hinduism as a faith or a religion, but rather as a badge of cultural identity and an instrument of political mobilisation."[29]

In 2009 Ilaiah radically proposed a Post-Hindu India.[30] It is his vision for India to be a land of equality and progress. He believes in the necessity of the collapse of Hinduism if at all India has to become an egalitarian society. He argues for the reassertion of Dalit-Bahujan religions as a counter culture. Ilaiah identifies the Dalit-Bahujan communities as unpaid teachers, subaltern scientists, productive soldiers, subaltern feminists, social doctors, meat and milk economists, unknown engineers, and food producers. He identifies the oppressors as social smugglers, spiritual fascists and intellectual *goondas*. He predicts a civil war. A war between the oppressors, who are numerically a minority and the oppressed Dalit-Bahujans, who in numerical terms are the vast majority of the Indian population. Ilaiah predicts that the civil war will turn into physical violence.

The present political scenario speaks otherwise. Hindutva is in steady growth. Media is controlled by politicians, close to the Sangh Parivar. Social Media are becoming channels of saffronization. During the last few years we are witnessing the murders of the writers and social activists who have been upholding rational thinking, who have been opposing the hold of caste, who have been opposing the politics in the name of Hinduism. Urban as well as rural youth are interested in fascist ideologies. Anarchy is the norm of the day. Already there is a civil war like situation. Warring of ideologies is on the

rise. There are wars in the spiritual dimension related to creeds and religious ideologies. Will the Dalit-Bahujan masses heed to the voice of revolutionary thinkers like Kancha Ilaiah? Will there be a social transformation in the near future? Will such a revolution bring peace?

Conclusion

Post-Hindu India! India is a land of plurality and diversity. As a nation the need of the hour is tolerance in all spheres of life. Pluralism is an ideology which must be upheld by all. All people of India must co-exist as Indians. All religions and religious leaders must promote the unity of humanity. While discussing his philosophy of life in a recent article Ilaiah focuses on universality. He says, "All Human beings are universal in nature. This knowing of my universalness makes me think my commonalities with other human beings and my identity as an individual being, who is part of the larger universe. That makes me think my universality is larger than my particularity."[31] Such a broad outlook is needed in order to coexist as humans.

Fascist religious ideologies must not be allowed to make a dent in the fabric of the nation. Co-existence of all religions and ideologies is a possibility in this postmodern era. Let every experience stay as a meaningful little narrative. Equality of all must be the agenda of the government and must be implemented. As a nation the Brahmins, the OBCs, the Dalits and Tribals can live as one if there is no more discrimination based on birth, colour, and creed. A secular outlook can bring about change.

Notes

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3 Padma Chaean Dhal, et.al., *Indian Society and Culture*, (New Delhi: Atlantic Publishing, 2013), 4.

4 The people who uphold Hindutva ideology. Mostly the Brahmins and the other high castes, which belong to the Aryan fold. Organizations like RSS, VHP, Bajrang Dal, Shiv Sena, Hanuman Sena etc are proponents of Hindutva ideologies.

5 Ilaiah added a surname Shepherd. He explains the reason, "by changing my name I am owning up to my ancestry. My caste, the shepherds, is called by different names in different parts of the country: Kurubas in Karnataka, in Telangana they are Kurumas. Whereas Brahmins have their names in a Sanskritic, pan-Indian forms such as Sharma and Shastri. But we could not get a pan-Indian name in the Sanskritic tradition or in any language derived from it. Now, I have adopted English as the language to identify my ancestry. When I take on a name that symbolises my productive capacity, I am getting out of the caste system. I am taking pride in my productive contribution." Cited in "*Good Shepherd: Dalit Thinker KanchaIlaiah on Name, Caste*" by Sudipto Mondal from <http://www.hindustantimes.com/india/we-need-a-new-god-says-dalit-thinker-kancha-ilaiah/story-ooWKO6iUKLAXv7qFqEW4ML.html> (12 May, 2018).

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17 Ilaiah, *Turning the Pot, Tilling the Land: Dignity of Labour in Our Times, 90.*

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21

The Tenets of Humanism in Different Stalwarts

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Abstract: One of the hermeneutic suspicions to be highlighted is the need of presenting humanism with a few stalwarts who firmly support the cause of human persons. Humanism as a trend or philosophy contains different tenets with its own suspicion developed and presented by different thinkers. The stalwarts of humanism have initiated critical attitude toward established ideals in Indian society. Definition of humanism, various tenets and its salient features lead to the stalwarts who have ventured to promote the spirit of humanism in the contemporary Indian scenario. M. N. Roy played a major role to promote humanism in the Indian situation. The basic elements in Roy's radical humanism are three: freedom, reason, and morality. Another humanistic thinker is Rabindranath Tagore who represents the poetic, the cultural wing of literary humanism in the east. He appreciated the spirit of scientific quest adventure, its practical approach, its political idealism, and social realism. Jawaharlal Nehru, one of the prominent humanists from the Indian soil, endeavoured to accentuate humanism linking the destiny of human with democracy, secularism, and socialism. His approach was so human that it brought the picture of a sensitive nature deeply affected by the suffering. This paper is an attempt to establish that any system or ideology cannot exploit and suppress the interests and inclinations of human person.

1. Introduction

India as a sub-continent is pregnant with various ideologies and ideals. They have complementary and contrasting effects. Some of them like materialism,

scientism, anthropocentricism, consider human person as the axis of any development whereas spiritualism, theo-centrism, fundamentalism, and chauvinism do not give due respect to human persons. Hence the need arises to develop a hermeneutic of suspicion in Indian context with our Christian ethos as we are Christian philosophers. One hermeneutic of suspicions to be highlighted is the need of promoting humanism with a few stalwarts as this paper pursues to do.

The term humanism is the talk of all the religious leaders, political and critical thinkers, and social activists. It is a fashion to voice humanism at the public assemblies as well. But the basic question arises as to whether everyone has its clear notion. Humanism is the oldest of different ideologies. The philosophy of humanism is practically as old as human civilization, which recognizes the value or dignity of human person and makes him/her the measure of all things. It somehow takes human nature, its limits, or interests as its theme. The philosophy of humanism presents a specific and forthright view of the universe, the nature of human beings, and the treatment of human problems. It is a multi-faceted philosophy, congenial to this modern age, yet fully aware of the lessons of history and the richness of the philosophical tradition. It has its ultimate faith in humankind. It believes that human beings possess the power or potentiality of solving their own problems, through reliance primarily upon reason and scientific method applied with courage and vision.[1]

It is vivid that the philosophy of humanism is opposed to all theories of universal determinism, fatalism, or pre-determinism. It trusts that human beings, conditioned by the past, possess genuine freedom of creative choice and action, and are, within certain objective limits, the shapers of their own destiny.[2] Humanism as a trend or philosophy contains different tenets which were developed and presented by different thinkers in their own philosophical system. Indian hermeneutics of suspicion invites us to have critical and suspicious attitude toward established and enmeshed ideals in Indian society.

2. Definition of Humanism

Humanism is a philosophical and literary movement started in Italy during the fourteenth century. The early nineteenth-century German educator, F.J. Niethammer, coined the word 'humanism', meaning an education based on the Greek and Latin classics.[3] Humanism is a series of interrelated concept about the nature, character, powers, and values of human beings. Humanism finds its origin in Greek Philosophy. For instance, Protagoras (485-410) is regarded as the founder of Greek Humanism because of his maxim "Man is the measure of all things."[4] Greek Humanism tries to exalt the dignity of human beings because he or she is a questioning being endowed with rationality and free will.

Humanism is nothing but Human-being-ism, which means devotion to the interest of human beings.[5] It is because human life is the source and measure of all human values. It rejects the super naturalism of the past and pronounces the ideal of service for the cause of human welfare. It recognises human beings as creative, cultural, and spiritual rather than biological entity. Humanism is an inclusive term giving importance to Anthropocentrism[6] than Theo-centrism. It uses the method of reason for solving problems that directly help for one's survival and to lead a meaningful existence. As per this definition, Humanism concerns about the dignity, morals, values, and limitations of human beings.

The humanist must rise above petty jealousies, vain-glory, envy, pride, hatred, passions, and narrow parochial allegiances. Nothing human should be alien to him or her. Sloth, mental heaviness, schizophrenia, and irreverence should yield to activity, dexterity, and the cultivation of the balanced intellect. If he/she does not have the patience to hear the glory of people belonging to different nations and races he/she cannot be a writer of permanent worth. He/she must not use vulgar and rustic words and sentences - must breathe a message of goodness and welfare. A humanist cannot afford to inculcate vengefulness, religious intolerance, perfidy, treachery, deceit, trickery, wrath, unnecessary pugnacity, rancour, and malice.[7]

3. Various Tenets of Humanism

The significance of humanism rests on three conditions namely, elimination of present inequality between nations, the promotion of equality and justice within one and the same nation and finally the attempt at all-round perfection of human race. Thus, humanism proclaims that real progress of human race lies in "equality of material comfort and security of livelihood as well as moral and intellectual perfection, universal peace, and political liberty."[8]

The importance of humanism induces every thinker to contemplate and formulate the main tenets of the philosophy of humanism. William Strawson proposes four tenets of humanism in his work, *The Christian Approach to Humanism*.

There is no supernatural power upon which man can call to help him in his life.

This life on earth is all that man can ever know and it is full of wonder and interest and it challenges that man needs look no further than his present life in his attempt to find meaning in his existence.

The rule by which man can guide his actions is found within himself. It is the rule of love, which is to be regarded as self-evidently supreme and must be applied to all human situations if man is to survive.

Man can lead a good life without the aid of supernatural ideas and man himself is fully responsible for developing the resources of the world through the application of science to economic, political, and social problems.[9]

Humanism is a constructive philosophy that goes far beyond the negating of errors in thought to the whole-hearted affirmation of joys, beauties, and values of human living. This is a viewpoint that can be grasped without difficulty by the people of every culture and country. Indeed, Humanism already is the functioning of millions upon millions of human beings throughout the globe who are daily striving to build a better life upon this earth for themselves, their children, and their fellow beings. To humankind not yet altogether aware of its own good and goal, Humanism offers an inclusive programme of philosophical and ethical truth that can play a leading role in the future of the race.[10]

4. Salient Features of Humanism

Human beings have several qualities like common sense, ethics, imagination, intuition, memory, and reason which are most effective in a society where they are recognised as of equal universal value and so are integrated into our moral life. These qualities are the tools of the human condition. Moreover, we can learn how to use these qualities. We can normalise the use of them so that much of the time we hardly need to stop in order to consider them. Highlighting the important qualities that are human, we can trace out the salient features of humanism in the following way:

1. Humanism finds its root in the rational philosophy first created in the West in ancient Greece. Many regard Socrates as the first and greatest of the Humanists. They value knowledge based on reason and hard evidence rather than on faith.
2. Humanism, being secular ideology, rejects the concept of a personal God and regard humans as supreme. From this belief naturally follows:
   a) The preciousness and dignity of the individual person as a central humanistic value;
   b) A rejection of a created universe in favour of the theory of evolution and a universe that obeys natural laws;
   c) The belief that full responsibility for the future of the world, its political systems, its ecology, etc., rests with humans. There is no God in heaven to intervene and save us from a disaster.
3. Humanism believes that much historical progress has arisen from the conflict between organised religion and secular society in which the former beliefs and practices have been organised with secular beliefs.
4. The humanism feels that religious groups' promises of immortal salvation or fear of eternal damnation are both illusory and harmful.

5. The humanism accepts democracy and rejects both theocracy[11] and secular dictatorships as political systems that are dangerous to individual freedoms.
6. The humanism values freedom of inquiry, expression, and action. It has a history of combating bigotry, hatred, discrimination, intolerance, and censorship. It has also energetic supporters of the separation of Church and State.
7. The humanism tends to have very liberal beliefs about controversial ethical topics, like abortion, corporal punishment of children, death penalty, enforced prayer in schools, homosexuality, physician assisted suicide, etc.
8. The humanism believes that moral values derive its source from human experience. It regards life here on earth to be particularly precious. It is highly motivated to alleviating pain and misery around the world. Its followers are active for refugees, human rights, anti-death penalty, environmental groups, etc.[12]
9. Humanism teaches the cultivation of the spirit of optimism. Amidst encircling gloom and sorrow, it pleads for the incorporation of the spirit of conquering youth aspiring after gaining novel experiences with vigour, zest, and vitality.[13]
10. Humanism symbolises adventurousness, quest, a spirit of enquiry and scrutiny, an elastic responsiveness to the rising demands of the situation and an organic capacity for assimilation, adaptation and adjustment. These qualities have to be retained for life as they make life interesting and enjoyable.[14]

5. The Prophet of a New Humanism – M. N. Roy[15]

Roy puts forward a humanistic ethics that exalts the sovereignty of human in the axiological hierarchy of freedom and justice. Human person is undoubtedly a product of the physical universe, yet he/she is rational because of the emergence from background of the harmony of physical universe. Roy stands for creative powers of human person. Human creativity has to be recognised not on the basis of faith and credibility of spiritual sanction, but on the basis of solid testimony of vast scientific researches, which testify to the creative nature and activities of human person.[16]

Roy claims to re-assert the sovereignty of humans by stressing that history is the record of human activities and society has no business to impose itself as on humans. Man is the arche-type of society. He has a free nature in the sense that it is highly creative. Man derives his sovereignty not from any transcendent super physical Being, but from his creative achievements in the understanding and partial conquest of nature. The radical humanism is

not one based on speculation. It is the philosophy based on a synthesis of the achievements of modern science and knowledge.[17]

The basic valuational elements in Roy's radical humanism are three: Freedom, reason, and morality. These elements are not separate from each other, and also not speculative or a priori. They are crystallizations of the experiences gained through historical evolution. They are the symbol of human creativity.

5.1 Freedom

Freedom is a real social category and dominant incentive to an emancipated life. Freedom is not transcending this physical. It has to be realised by man on this earth. Roy does not indulge in the distinctions of inner freedom or outer freedom, because some people, on the basis of inner freedom, believe that there is soul inside the physical body, in which he does not believe.[18] Roy traces the roots of freedom in the concept of struggle for existence and self-preservation. The quest for freedom is the continuation of the biological struggle for existence at the emotional and cognitional levels.[19] Freedom is the fundamental urge and motivating power of social advancement and collective progress. In it, reason plays an important role. Reason is the chief faculty in human life. For Roy, reason is based on human habitation in a law-governed and law-determined universe. Man is habituated to think about the constitution of the universe.

Intellectual enlightenment is essential for human freedom and welfare. The potentiality of freedom is latent in human. By virtue of being free, man can attain spiritual freedom by removing the shackles of traditional ecclesiasticism, and unscientific supernaturalism. The realisation of freedom depends upon the awareness by man of his creative powers. Only spiritually and morally emancipated individuals can create a free and better society; spiritual emancipation is the pre-requisite for social and political liberation.[20]

The radical humanism of Roy sees man in the context of sociability, which may be enriched today by having a firm faith in democracy. The essence of democracy is to foster the notion of participation, relationship, or citizenship. Roy accentuates the primary importance of the individual and recognises the supreme worth of the individual for the radical and rational reconstruction of society. He does not believe in the totalitarian solution of human problems. The totalitarian claims of organisation, regimentation, and co-ordination must not be allowed to subvert the freedom of the individual. He does not favour authoritarianism and the current practice of parliamentary democracy, because it is full of grave defects.[21]

The radical humanism of Roy is opposed to the monopoly of capitalism with its proliferating combines, trusts, and cartels. Contemporary capitalism creates many harmful effects to the common interests of human beings. It

is essential to do away with monopoly-capitalism, if the larger interests of humankind are to be protected. He also envisions that parliamentary democracy is not suited to the needs of man, because social and economic inequalities reduce it to a verbal force. Even liberal capitalism with its theory of Laissez-faire threatens the very foundation of democracy.[22]

Radical humanism propagated by M. N. Roy does not favour state-socialism; it favours some sort of economy based on widespread decentralisation and a spirit and practice of co-operation. In other words, it stands for co-operative economy, in which production should be carried on with the sole purpose of serving human needs, particularly of those, who are tyrannized over and have no means of livelihood. Co-operative economy supports mutual help and promotes the ideals of both liberty and equality.[23]

Roy insists on the primacy of values and that inculcates the supremacy of the eternal urge of freedom. As a scientific materialist, he regards human life as an end to satisfy the desires that man has in his nature, and that is the search for freedom, truth, and knowledge. Democracy will succeed only when spiritually free individuals assume the conduct of public affairs. He pleads for the purifying influence of human virtue upon all social, economic, and political affairs. This can save man from many trials and troubles in the contemporary world situation.

According to Roy, party politics implies the denial of democracy; it implies that people cannot do anything by themselves; it is a denial of the potential intelligence and creativity of all people, of the sovereignty of all. Democracy is an empty concept if sovereignty does not mean the ability of the people to do things themselves. The very logic of radical humanism requires that the party be dissolved and the radicals should work in intelligent co-operation with each other, evolving institutions and organisations in the light of their experience consistent with the character and quality of preferred social order. To abandon party politics implies the belief that men can choose the path and proceed along it, actuated by their reasoned perception of the common good and loyalty to it. The dissolution of the party was dictated by the logic of radical humanism and was backed also by the empirical evidence that political parties engaged in the scramble for power could not serve the cause of democracy and freedom.[24]

In radical humanism, the freedom of the individual is exalted to such an extent that it mystifies the entire scope of freedom itself. Man is creative and needs freedom for his own emancipation, and the establishment of the primacy of values. Man is not wholly free and creative. He does not have an independent existence. He has certain limitations, which do not allow him to act in a way he likes. Therefore, the individual's supremacy is limited.

6. Rabindra Nath Tagore (1861-1941)[25]

Tagore represents the poetic, the cultural wing of literary Humanism in the East. He appreciated the spirit of scientific quest adventure, its practical approach, its political idealism, and social realism. He believes in the external nature with a sense of inner most feelings of life. His humanism stands for enjoying nature by the creative human spirit. It is joyful harmony, and not brutal struggle, with nature, that can give happiness to man.[26]

In all spheres of human life, Tagore wishes people for adjustment and not for any hostile relationship either with man or society of nature. The spirit of harmony provides relief from despair, passivity, and pessimism. It reveals the beauty and order in the world. It also removes conflicts and contradictions. Truth consists not in facts, but in the harmony of facts.[27]

The harmony of facts lessens the prevailing tensions and therefore, the ideals of synthesis, love and spiritual adjustment, fellowship and co-operation, among all people and societies of the world are always desirable. Tagore gives to the organised man 'the gospel of unity and harmony'. Even in the midst of sorrows and sufferings, trials and troubles, he sees the vision of peace and love. He feels that the great festival of man has been progressing. He always dislikes the narrow relationships and dividing walls between man and man. It is said that Tagore concentrated his attention on "concrete humanity as an organic whole", essentially based on spiritual foundations. He holds that man has to be interpreted in the perspective of the eternal; and the supreme person dwells in the personalities of all living individuals of the world.[28]

The true man is a social, sensitive, and imaginative being and not a mechanical entity or political animal. For the existence of man, society is essential. The primacy of social obligation is necessarily needed in human relations. For the good and well-being of society, there is a need of "social mutualistic co-operation". Extension of love and sympathy is also necessary for human welfare. People should not be blind to the sorrows and sufferings of the neighbours. Tagore does not deny the need of state; but the modern man needs the collective good and social altruism inherent in man.[29]

Tagore poetically pronounced a belief in God; but that God is not apart from man. The individual human beings are the replica of the creative super-spirit. Man represents the creator, and the individual man is only a unique modelization of God. From this he seems to convey that the real service of man is the real service of God. Man is the replica of God and the supreme spirit of that is expressing its eternal creativity through mankind and through external objectivised nature.[30] The cultural humanism of Tagore glorifies man in the name of God, exalts the spirit of humanity, for it represents a qualitatively higher manifestation of the infinite being than the objects of external universe.

It is the dignity and the supreme vocation of the empirical being to enjoy the blessedness of the compresence of this spirit. The Supreme Being does not live in temples and golden homes. It lives in those, who till the soil, build the road, write books, and compose poems, and therefore, the courage to fight for the vindication of freedom of these human spirits is a true homage to the Supreme Man.[31]

The cultural humanism of Tagore condemns the narrow type of nationalism, because his thought stands firm for the spiritual fellowship of all people and conceives the coming era of the great federation and fellowship of all. It means the undying spiritual unity the noble purpose of which is to cherish love, moral freedom, and spiritual harmony. The essence of any civilisation is the quest for the love of humanity and not the accumulation of material power and pelf. The humanism of Tagore always stresses the need of cultural synthesis, for whatever is good, beautiful, and useful must be learnt and be assimilated for the benefit of larger humanity. Tagore wished for the evolution of cosmopolitan humanist culture to be nurtured and enriched by the contribution of all religions.[32]

The poetic humanism of Tagore could be enlisted that man occupies the highest place in the world, man is truly social, sensitive and creative being, reality is human and man makes it through his own creativity, man has the incessant and insatiable urge to transcend himself and universal love and brotherhood are essential for man and society.[33] Tagore expresses the quest for universal humanism and emphasises that men should make available to all men the significant values of every culture and bind them into a peaceful brotherhood.

7. Secularistic Humanism of Jawaharlal Nehru[34]

Nehru endeavoured to accentuate humanism linking the destiny of man with democracy, secularism, and socialism in India. His humanism is essentially an outcome of the contemporary social situation in the world. His approach was so human that it brought the picture of a sensitive nature deeply affected by the suffering and inhumanity that people have inflicted upon others. Being a brave fighter for the cause of common people, he was a hater of injustice and exploitation.

The greater part of Nehru's humanism centres round human person and nature, the secular affairs, and material interests of mankind. It has an immense faith in human person. He holds that it is easier for one to deny God, but it is very difficult to deny human person. The unique faculty of thought and reason in human person made greater attraction to Nehru. He defines the better type of modern mind as "practical and pragmatic, ethical and social, altruistic and humanitarian…. Humanity is its god and social service its religion. From such ideals he evolves his concept of scientific humanism."[35]

His humanism and liberality are fostered by an inner respect for the individual self. The mind temper of the humanist prevails all through, and the relation with other individuals is often enough based on a tender human touch. He does not believe in theories and ideologies which perturb the beauty of inner life and mar human aspirations of aesthetic sense. As he has expressed his indelible faith in the domain of nature, Nehru is a naturalist and his approach was always, more or less, scientific and humanistic.[36]

The Secularistic Humanism of Nehru holds that man is responsible for what he may become. All human problems, relating to human society, can be solved only, when all people stand firm to work. He emphasises that the gallant fight of human person against the odd elements, their courage that conquers nature itself, their limitless endurance, their high endeavour and loyalty to comrades and forgetfulness of self, and their good humour in the face of every conceivable misfortune, show that human person has power and potentiality of solving their own problems. In the midst of disaster, human person has not lost his/her dignity or faith in the values cherished.[37]

Though the future of humankind is uncertain, yet "man can see part of the way leading to it and can tread it with firm steps, remembering that nothing that can happen is likely to overcome the spirit of man which has survived so many perils."[38] Human person, in Nehru's humanism, is really capable of understanding and solving their own problems; their responsibility is greater than anything in the universe.

As a humanist, Nehru does not stand for any supernatural help in redressing the difficulties of human beings. The present one is the only world in which he believed.

Essentially I am interested in this world, in this life, not in some other world or a future life. Whether there is such a thing as a soul, or whether there is a survival after death or not, I do not know, and, important as these questions are, they do not trouble me in the least…. But I do not believe in any of these or other theories and assumptions as a matter of religious faith. They are just intellectual speculation in an unknown region about which we know next to nothing.[39]

Nehru holds that religious differences that have done great harm to mankind, should not be tolerated in a secular national state. He wanted to make secularism a kind of common interest, a sort of religion for all. Human person should consider the service of humanity as the first and foremost duty whatever religion they may have. He advocates that the best approach to the solution of human problems is areligious, i.e., avoiding religious clashes and conflicts, and without resorting to any religious means. Nehru did not want to renounce any part of the genius of people and the only way to utilize it is to have a common faith in secularism.

The concept of secularism is something dynamic and static. It is scientific approach opening new ways and provides means for human integration, harmony, and unity. He highlights that the word 'secular' stands for this worldliness, and aspires for no other world than where man is born, grows, and lives in, and also it stands with no attachment to any religious faith or creed; nor does it stand for annihilation of any religion; it is purely areligious.[40]

Keeping this secularism as base, Nehru develops his humanism keeping human welfare and human action as intertwined. He keeps his feet firmly grounded in humanism, the basic tenets of which are democracy, socialism, and peace. Freedom of the individual is the keynote of Nehru's concept of humanism. He holds that "we believe in democracy, equality, and removal of special privileges and we have set ourselves the goal of developing a socialistic pattern of society through peaceful means."[41] Hence the ultimate aim of Secularistic Humanism should be the development of human person, peace, and social order. There should not be any exploitation of human person by human person in a humanistic society. Nehru looks upon socialistic humanism as a growing, dynamic, and something which is not rigid, as something which must fit in with the changing conditions of human life and activity in every place.

8. Conclusion

The history of philosophy both in the east and west has gone through various stages picturing human person as the centre or keeping him/her at the back sheet? Cosmocentric, theocentric, spirituocentric, and anthropocentric ideals highlight the importance of academic pursuit in the spirit of suspicion. In the evolution of thoughts, the stalwarts of humanism give us vividly a bright picture of dynamic humanism regarding human person as the centre of study and investigation.

All humanists, however, believe that man and nature are closely related to each other. They are inseparable twins. Human person is considered to be endowed with innate urge for freedom and human nature is creative and his/her creativity has no limits. The free and creative nature is part and parcel of human person. This creativity is the real source of continuity of right relations among human beings. Human person is the creator of human values.

Another fundamental element in all types of humanism is human society. Human person is related to society as closely as to nature. Society is the real home of human person and it gives all individuals an organised life, a life of co-operation, and competition. A lively participation with fellow-beings is the fact of human existence and this is human involvement in this world. All humanists realise the need of varied cultivation in human life. Hence, humanism as a theory of human person, society, and nature, runs through all human relations; and humanists, throughout the ages, have enriched the humanist traditions.

Notes

1 Corliss Lamont, *The Philosophy of Humanism* (New York: Half-Moon Foundation, INC, 1997), 6.
2 *Ibid*., 7.
3 Edward Craig, ed., *Routledge Encyclopaedia of Philosophy*, Vol. 4 (London: Routledge, 1998), 533.
4 Vishwanath Prasad Varma, *Philosophical Humanism and Contemporary India* (Delhi: Motilal Banarsidass, 1979), 5.
5 D.R. Bali, *Introduction to Philosophy* (Bangalore: Sterling Publishers Private Ltd, 1989), 235.
6 This term comes from Greek words *anthrōpos* meaning man, human being, and *kentron* centre. It is an outlook that places mankind at the centre of the universe; a tendency to ascribe a particular significance to human beings and to human concerns in the general scheme of things. Theo-centrism refers to God as the centre of concerns. Ref. Thomas Mautner, *The Penguin Dictionary of Philosophy* (London: Penguin Books, 2000), 27.
7 V.P. Varma, *Philosophical Humanism and Contemporary India*, 9.
8 Devraj Bali, *Introduction to Philosophy* (New Delhi: Sterling Publishers Pvt, Ltd, 1989), 239.
9 William Strawson, *The Christian Approach to Humanism* (London: An Edinburgh House Press Book, 1990), 15.
10 Corliss Lamont, *The Philosophy of Humanism*, 16.
11 It is derived from two Greek words *theos* god + *kratia* power, might, strength. It is a form of government in which God is recognised as the supreme civil ruler, whose laws are interpreted by priests or other divinely guided officials. Ref. Thomas Mautner, *The Penguin Dictionary of Philosophy*, 562.
12 These features are summary of *A Humanist Manifesto* prepared in 1933, endorsed by 34 leading Humanists.
13 V.P. Varma, *Philosophical Humanism and Contemporary India*, 53.
14 *Ibid*.
15 M.N. Roy (1886 – 1954) is one of the selfless leaders of modern India – a valiant fighter for freedom and one of the best political minds in Asia. His real name is Narendra Nath Bhattacharya from West Bengal. He changed his name to Manabendranath Roy and became attached towards radical views. On the issue of the participation in the anti-fascist war he broke away from Indian National Congress and formed the Radical Democratic Party. In 1946, he came out with his philosophy of New Humanism. His Twenty-two theses are the synthesis of comprehensive philosophy of life and also vision of a New Order. Ref. Verinder Grover (Ed.), M. N. Roy, *A Biography of His Vision and Ideas* (New Delhi: Deep & Deep Publications, 1998), viii – xii.
16 M.N. Roy, *New Humanism: A Manifesto*, (Culcutta: Renaissance Publishers Private LTD.,1961), 48.
17 D. R. Jatava, *Social and Humanist Thinkers: Indian and Western*(Jaipur: INA Shree Publishers, 1998), 82.
18 M. N. Roy, "Fragments of Prisoner's Diary," Vol. II, (Culcutta: Renaissance Publishers Private LTD., 1945), 38.
19 M. N. Roy, *New Humanism – A Manifesto*, (Culcutta: Renaissance Publishers Private LTD.,1961), 52 – 53.
20 D. R. Jatava, *Social and Humanist Thinkers: Indian and Western*, 84.
21 M. N. Roy, *Materialism*, (New Delhi: Ajanta Publications, 1940), 10-12.

22 M. N. Roy, *The Problem of Freedom*, (Culcutta: Renaissance Publishers Private LTD.,1943), 131-140.
23 D. R. Jatava, *Social and Humanist Thinkers: Indian and Western*, 85.
24 R. L. Nigam, *Radical Humanism of M. N. Roy, an Exposition of His 22 Theses*, 37.
25 Rabindranath Tagore (1861-1941) was a great poet from Kolkata. He is a cultural leader of eastern spiritualism and inner humanity of the world. He was awarded the Noble Prize for Literature in 1913 for his book of poems *Gitanjali*. For more details of his biography, refer, Kumkum Battacharya, "Tagore, Rabindranath" in Johnson J. Puthenpurackal (Ed.,) *ACPI Encyclopaedia of Philosophy,* Vol. II (Bangalore: Asian Trading Corporation, 2010), 1361-1365.
26 D. R. Jatava, *Social and Humanist Thinkers: Indian and Western*, 106.
27 R. N. Tagore, *Creative Unity, 1950*, 10.
28 D. R. Jatava, *Social and Humanist Thinkers: Indian and Western*, 106.
29 R. N. Tagore, "The Religion of Man," 1940, 15,
30 R. N. Tagore, "Stray Birds" 1945, 56.
31 R. N. Tagore, "The Religion of Man", 1940, 120.
32 D. R. Jatava, *Social and Humanist Thinkers: Indian and Western*, 106.
33 R. N. Tagore, "The Religion of Man", 1940, 17.
34 Pandit Jawaharlal Nehru (1889-1964) played a central role in India's struggle for freedom from British colonial rule. He was Prime Minister for seventeen years, and tried to shape the nation's future as a modern, secular, and democratic state. He was visionary, idealist, scholar, and statesman of international stature, and also an outstanding writer. His three most renowned books – *An Autobiography*, *Glimpses of World History* and *The Discovery of India* – have acquired the status of classics. For more details of his biography, refer, George Panthanmackel, "Jawaharlal Nehru" in Johnson J. Puthenpurackal (Ed.,) *ACPI Encyclopaedia of Philosophy* Vol. II (Bangalore: Asian Trading Corporation, 2010), 964-967.
35 M. N. Das, "The Political Philosophy of Nehru", 1961, 34-35.
36 D. R. Jatava, *Social and Humanist Thinkers: Indian and Western*, 135-136.
37 Jawaharlal Nehru, "*The Discovery of India*", 1960, 22.
38 *Ibid*., 23.
39 *Ibid*., 15-16.
40 D. R. Jatava, *Social and Humanist Thinkers: Indian and Western*, 139.
41 Jawaharlal Nehru, *Glimpses of World History*, Vol. II (New Delhi: Penguin Books, 1934-35, 1955), 284-285.

22

"Creative and Critical (Un) Reading of Dravidianism – Caldwell and Periyar"

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Abstract: Robert Caldwell (1814 – 1891) and E.V. Ramasamy Periyar (1879 – 1973) have influenced and are influencing Contemporary Indian Philosophy especially in South India, Tamilnadu. Their impact and influence is seen is seen in politics, society and the philosophical mindset of the people of the people. Robert Caldwell was basically was basically an European from Ireland, a linguistic scholar and the Anglican Bishop of Tirunelveli, presently a CSI (Church of South India) Diocese. Periyar was a social activist, politician, rationalist and reformist. The concept of Dravidians or Dravidianism is very important for the south Indian politicians especially Dravidian parties like ADMK (Anna Dravida Munetra Kazhagam - Anna Dravidian Development Party), DMK (Dravida Munetra Kazhagam - Dravidian Development Party), DK (Dravida Kazhagam - Dravidian Association), MDMK (Marumalarchi Dravida Munetra Khazagam - Reformatory Dravidian Development Party) and many other institutions like the Dravidian University at Kupam, in Andhra Pradesh etc. Many of these parties and institutions are against the influence of the Bhraminical Hinduism of Aryans and the imposition of the Hindi language in India, as in India; since the Aryans are considered by these people as alien. The Dravidians are the original sons of the soil. This theory and philosophy were promoted by E.V. R. Periyar and the other parties. It is time to reread and examine these concepts in view of the welfare and common good of all people.

Introduction

Robert Caldwell (7th May 1814 – 28th August 1891) was a missionary and linguist who academically established the Dravidian family of languages. He served as Bishop of Tirunelveli from 1877. He was described as a "pioneering champion of the downtrodden."[1] The Government of Tamil Nadu has created a memorial in his honour and a postage stamp has been issued in his memory on 7th May 2010. A statue of Caldwell was erected in 1967 near Marina Beach, Chennai, as a gift from the Church of South India.

He was born at Clady, then in County Antrim, Ireland of Scottish Presbyterian parents. He studied Arts between 1829 – 1833 in Dublin. He was educated in the University of Glasgow. He developed a liking for philosophy and theology due to the influence of a professor of Greek language and a promoter of Anglicanism. He became a priest of the Congregationalist Church.[2] At the age of twenty four Caldwell came to Chennai (Madras) on 8th January, 1838 as a missionary of the London Missionary Society and joined the Society for the Propagation of the Gospel Mission (SPG). He was married to Eliza Mault (1822 – 99) and had seven children.[3] He was ordained as an Bishop in 1877.[4]

1. Caldwell's Comparative Grammar

A Comparative Grammar of the Dravidian or *South Indian Family of Languages* is one of his best known works. In his works he used the word Dravidian to separate the languages spoken in South India from the other more Sanskrit-affiliated languages of India. He proved in his work that Tamil, Kannada, Malayalam, Telugu and some other languages spoken in Pakistan and Afghanistan also belong to the Dravidian language. The other languages according to him are affiliated to Sanskrit and to the Indo-European language family. Many linguists accepted and confirmed Caldwell's work.[5]

2. Caste System Dehumanises

Caldwell was against the caste system. He fount it as something very bad even before Ambedkar and other advocates of equality. He stressed the need for reform as he found the caste system as an exploitive, violent and dehumanising ideology which served the interest of only the high caste Hindus. He told the oppressed community that they are distinct and not Hindus and emphasised that they are indigenous Dravidians. He used the term Aryan for the non-Dravidians. He also showed the Dravidian culture as superior to the foreign culture of the Aryans.[6] He wanted to give an identity for the low caste people and thus brought renaissance in South India especially in Tamil Nadu.[7]

3. Caldwell's Comparative Grammar

He used the term *Dravidian* to separate the languages spoken in South India from other Sanskrit–affiliated languages of India. Apart from the main South Indian languages of Tamil, Telugu, Kannada, Malayalam, Tulu, the Brhui language spoken in Pakistan and Afghanistan also belongs to the Tamil language family. Prior to Caldwell scholars of 19th century considered Tamil and other South Indian languages to be rooted in Sanskrit and affiliated to the Indo-European language family.[8] Caldwell, in his Grammar, not only analysed the linguistic affinities of the Dravidian languages but also formed certain theories on the Dravidian languages which gave a rude shock to the dominant position that Sanskrit had held. His theories also led to polarity between Brahmins and non-Brahmins, between the Northern Sanskrit and Southern Tamil thus inaugurating un unpleasant North–South controversy.[9]

Caldwell's *A Comparative Grammar of the Dravidian or South Indian Family of Languages* was prescient in recognising that the Dravidian languages constitute a distinct language family. Caldwell took the conclusions he had arrived at with respect to the Dravidian language family's distinctive features in a radically new direction by claiming that Tamilians, particularly those from the lower castes like Chanars, constituted a community distinct from other Hindus. He also considered Dravidians as indigenous people and wanted to free them from their high-caste oppressors, whom he referred to as foreign and "Brahminical" to signify the Hinduism of the high-caste. He proved that the Dravidians had been subdued by Brahminical Aryans. The content of the whole book is pejorative, outrageous and paternalistic with the aim of liberating and bringing equality for the people who were suppressed unduly for so many centuries. The whole of his studies represent a pioneering effort to understand religions completely foreign to the British mind. In the domain of Dravidian linguistics though, it remains a respected work today.[10]

4. Literary Works

Besides his research work in the languages, he was also involved in archaeological work especially in the history of Tirunelveli. He studied palm leaf manuscripts and Sangam literature and made several excavations, finding the foundations of ancient buildings sepulchral urns and coins with the fish emblem of the Pandyan Kingdom. His work resulted in his book *A Political and General History of the District of Tirunelveli* (1881) published by the Government of Madras Presidency. His works lasted more than fifty years. His works, published in both languages coupled with his position in the both Indian and English society gave stimulus to radicalisation of the Non-Brahmin movement. As pointed out by Dr. M.S.S. Pandian, Caldwell's contribution to

the cultural awakening of the region is unmatched during the last two hundred years. Some of his notable works include the following:

- *Christianity and Hinduism*, A lecture addressed to educated Hindus published by the Society of the Propagation of Christian Knowledge in India, London, 1879.
- *A Comparative Grammar of the Dravidian or South Indian Family of Languages*, Harrison, London, 1856.
- *The Inner Citadel of Religion*, S.P.C.K., London 1879.
- *The Prince of Wales in Tirunelveli* and *From Delayay Street to Edeyngoody*, London S.P.C.K., 1876.
- *Observations on Kudumi*, J.J. Craen, 1867.
- *Report of the Edeyankoody District for the year ending 30th June 1845*, London, Society of the Propagation of the Gospel, 1847.
- *The Relation of Christianity to Hinduism*, R. Clay, Sons, & Taylor, London, 1885.
- *The Three Way-marks*, Christian Vernacular Education Society, Madras, 1860.
- "A Political General History of the District of Tirunelveli," in *The Presidency of Madras, from the Earliest Period to its Cession to the English Government in A.D. 1801*, Madras, E. Keys, 1881.

Some of the works written about him:

- Kumaradoss, Y. Vincent (2007), *Robert Caldwell - A Scholar – Missionary in Colonial South India*, Delhi, ISPCK, ISBN 978 – 81 – 7214 – 958 -1.
- Christdoss, DA, *Caldwell Athiacher (Tamil)*, Danishpt, Bethel publications, 1980.
- Ravindran, Vaitheespara, *The Unanticipated Legacy of Robert Caldwell and the Dravidian Movement*, South Indian Studies, I, January – June 1996.
- Shroder, Ulrik, "No religion, but ritual? Robert Caldwell and the Tirunellveli Shanners," in *Brunder, Michel*, Primus books, 2011, ISBN 9789380607214.
- Sivaram D.P. on "Tamil Militarism - `Chapter 6," *Bishop Caldwell & the Tamil Dravidians*, Sangam Org, 1992.

5. Dravidians

Among the Indians, about 72% are considered as Aryans and 28% of as Dravidians by some people. Aryans are considered as foreigners but Dravidians as indigenous people. Now there are more than two hundred and fifty million people belonging to the race of Dravidians. This kind of understanding and division took place in 1816 itself by Francis Whyte Elis and it was furthered

and finalised by Robert Caldwell in 1856. There are more than 86 languages belonging to the Dravidian family as on 17 November, 2016.[11]

6. Periyar E.V. Ramasamy (1879–1973)

Periyar E.V. Ramasamy was born on 17th September in 1879 at Erode, Madras Presidency, British India, presently called Erode District, Tamil Nadu. He passed away on 24th December 1973, at the age of 94, in Vellore, Tamil Nadu.. He was an activist, politician and reformist. He was a member of the Indian National Congress until 1925, and in 1939 became head of the Justice Party and changed its name to *Dravidar Kazhagam*. He also started the Self-Respect Movement and Dravidian Nationalism. His wife Nagammai died in 1933 and later Maniammaai (1948 – 1973) co-operated with him in all his endeavours. He was also awarded by UNESCO in 1970.[12] The party Dravidar Kazhagam later spilt into different groups. He also advocated for an independent Dravida Nadu (Land of the Dravidians).

He himself experienced numerous incidents of caste and gender discrimination, even though he was born in a wealthy family of Balijas. He travelled to countries such as Britain, Malaysia and Russia which had influenced him. He propagated the principles of self-respect, rationalism, women's rights and eradication of caste. He opposed exploitation and marginalisation of the non-Brahmin Dravidian people of South India.

He was popularly known as "Periyar" meaning 'respected one' or 'elder' in Tamil. He removed his caste title *Naicker* from his name at the first provincial Self-Respect Conference of Chenggalpattu. He could speak Kannada, Telugu and Tamil. He had completed until fifth standard and then continued his father's business. He considered and perceived that religion is used only as a mask to deceive innocent people. Therefore he warned the people against superstitions and priests.[13]

6.1 Kasi Pilgrimage Incident

In 1904, E.V. Ramasamy went on a pilgrimage to Kasi to visit the revered Siva temple of Kasi Vishwanath, one of the holiest sites of Hinduism. There he witnessed begging, floating dead bodies etc.

At the worship site there were free meals offered to guests. To Ramasamy's shock he was refused meals, which exclusively fed Brahmins. Due to extreme hunger, Ramasamy felt compelled to enter one of the eateries disguised as a Brahmin with a sacred thread on his bare chest, but was betrayed by his moustache. The gatekeeper at the temple concluded that Ramasamy was not a Brahmin, as Brahmins were not permitted by the Hindu *Shastras* to have moustaches. He not only prevented Ramasamy's entry but also pushed him rudely into the street. As his hunger became intolerable, Ramasamy was forced to feed on leftovers from the street. The discriminatory attitude of Brahmins

at the temple dealt a blow to Ramasamy's regard for Hinduism, for the events he had witnessed at Kasi were completely different from the picture of Kasi he had in mind, one of a holy place which welcomed all. Ramasamy was a theist until his visit to Kasi; after which his views changed and he became an atheist.[14]

6.2 Vaikom Sathyagraha (1924 -1925)

In Vaikom, a small town in the Kerala State, then Travancore, there were strict laws of untouchability in and around the temple area. *Dalits*, also known as Harijans, were not allowed into the street around and leading to the temple, let alone inside it. Anti-caste feelings were growing and in 1924 Vaikom was chosen as a suitable place for organizing a *Satyagraha*. Under Ramasamy's guidance a movement had already begun with the aim of giving all castes the right to enter temples. Thus agitations and demonstrations took place. On 14 April, 1924 Ramasamy and his wife Nagamma arrived in Vaikom. They were immediately arrested and imprisoned for participation. Ramasamy and his followers continued to give support to the movement until it was withdrawn.

Ramasamy spent spent most of his lifetime striving to remove social inequality. He gave non-Brahmins a sense of pride based on their past. He wanted to prevent child marriages, encourage love marriages as well as educational institutions. Propagation of the philosophy of *Self-Respect* Movement became a full-time activity of Ramasamy since 1925.

6.3 International Travel (1929 – 1932)

Along with a group of people he travelled to Malaysia, Singapore, Turkey, Ceylon; in Europe – Germany, England, Spain, France, Portugal, Greece, Russia; and in Africa Egypt. He was very much attracted to Russian Communism.

6.4 Opposition to Hindi

In 1937, when Chakravarthi Rajagopalachari became the Chief Minister of the Madras Presidency, he introduced Hindi as a compulsory language of study in schools, thereby igniting a series of anti-Hindi agitations. Ramasamy organised anti-Hindi protests in 1938 which ended with numerous arrests by the Rajaji government. He explained that the introduction of Hindi was a dangerous mechanism used by the Aryans to infiltrate Dravidian culture. It would completely destroy their culture. Cutting across party lines, South Indians rallied together in their opposition to Hindi. There were recurrent anti-Hindi agitations in 1948, 1952 and 1965.

6.5 Dravidar Kazhagam (1944 onwards)

Ramasamy converted the Justice Party to Dravidar Kazhagam or "Dravidian Association."[15] It continually fought for liberation of women, women's education, widow marriage, setting up orphanages and mercy homes. In 1949 one of the members of DK, Conjeevaram Natarajan Annadurai, came out of DK and formed the Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (DMK – Dravidian Advancement Association). DMK advocated the thesis that the Tamil language was much richer than Sanskrit and Hindi in content. Ramasamy organised a rally to Marina beach to burn pictures of the Hindu god Rama. He was arrested and confined to prison. In 1958 during the All India Official Language Conference in Bangalore he stressed the need to retain English as the Official Language of the Union instead of Hindi. Close to his last years, an award was given to him by the United Nations Educational Scientific and Cultural Organization (UNESCO) and it was presented to him by Union Education Minister, Triguna Sen in Madras (Chennai), in 1970.

6.6 Thoughts on *Thirukkural*

Ramasamy hailed *Thirukkural* as valuable scripture which contained many scientific and philosophical truths. He also praised the secular nature of the work. Periar, the name which has come to be associated with *Thirukkural*, opined that the ethics in Kural (short for *Thirukkual*) was comparable to the Christian Bible. He also asserted that due to the secular nature of *Thirukkural*, it has the capacity to be the common book of faith for all humanity and can be at par or above the Holy Books of all religions.

All the parties including PMK – (Pattali Makkal Katchi), DPI – (Dalit Panthers of India), Mayawati, former Chief minister of Uttar Pradesh, were attracted to the philosophy of Periyar. In 2007 a film titled Periyar was released and it was sponsored by the government. Film stars like Kamala Hassan and Sathyaraj were also fascinated by his philosophy.

6.7 Equality of Women

Periyar was a social reformer and crusader for the liberation of women from the male dominated Hindu society. He did not accept the notion that women in society have been a real stumbling block to progress. He did not wish to confine women to the kitchen, to bedecking themselves with jewels and ending up with innumerable problems of marriage.[16]

6.8 Promoter of Rationalism and Secularism

He was a free thinker in the beginning of the twentieth century. He expressed his rational thoughts freely and fearlessly. He was a secularist and wanted to free people from the clutches of religion. He was against compartmentalizing

people on religious grounds. His atheism was meant for breaking caste domination, elitism, hegemony, ritualism and pre-determinism. His secular movement was popularly called the Self-Respect Movement, and it was started in 1925 and was directed towards Dravidian uplift. [17]

7. Common Threads between Caldwell and Periyar

1. Both these great personalities have influenced the thinking of the people of South India especially in Tamil Nadu.
2. Clear thinking for creating an atmosphere of equality among human beings and eradication of caste system was the common motives of these two great thinkers.
3. Both were rationalists: Caldwell based it on his research and findings and Periyar based it on his reason and thinking which was very much influenced by Caldwell.
4. Both are respected by a majority of the people of Tamil Nadu regardless of their origin and difference inherent in them.
5. Both of them spent most of their lifetime in Tamil Nadu.

8. Differences between Caldwell and Periyar

1. Caldwell is basically a Christian missionary and was influenced by the thinking of his ecclesial background i.e. Presbyterianism and Anglicanism in the context of Roman Catholicism in Ireland. But E.V. Ramasamy was a staunch Hindu by birth and he was also influenced by his religious background but in a negative way as he himself personally experienced in the temples, especially in Kasi and in other places of worship.
2. Caldwell had an European background as he was from Ireland but E.V. Ramasamy was an Indian by birth and had the background of the Tamil and Telugu culture.
3. Caldwell was the pioneer of creating Dravidian culture but E.V.R. imbibed it thus carrying it forward effectively to the people.
4. Caldwell was a learned scholar but E.V.R. was a rationalist and did not have much educational background but more of the business background of his time.
5. Caldwell perhaps had the winning of souls as the ultimate motive but E.V.R. had the aim of freeing the people from superstition and promoting life with self-respect.
6. Caldwell belonged to the 19th Century but E.V.R. belonged to the 20th century.
7. Caldwell did not have many followers but E.V.R. had many followers and his thoughts are often quoted by almost all the politicians of Tamilnadu.

9. Impact and Outcome of their Thoughts

- Due to their influences the development of Tamil is very much seen and felt.
- The ordinary and local people have grown up educationally and politically and stand for their rights without any much fear.
- Superstitions and blind beliefs have not come down because of them.
- Christian missionaries and their thoughts have been welcomed and received acceptance among many people.
- Many of the downtrodden people are holding responsible offices in politics, educational institutions and industrial houses.
- Brahminical influences in all spheres of life have greatly reduced.
- Principles of Secularism and Democracy are being upheld due to their philosophy.
- Fundamentalism is under control and rationalism is prevalent to a great extent.

10. Argumentation

If such persons had not come forward, the whole of India could have become a victim of a high caste, fundamentalist and brahminical movement which would have shown their ugly faces. The local culture continues to exist and grow because of their philosophical trend of mind, which is manifested at every level in Tamil Nadu. They taught that compartmentalization of all Indians into two groups namely as Aryans and Dravidians is not accepted by all. There are also other groups like the Sino-Mongloids and Austroloids etc.[18]

11. Application

The principles of rationalism, secularism and research into the richness of every language are to be further developed taking inspiration from these great thinkers. Every culture is rich. Every language is rich. Some are recorded and some are not recorded. Every language has the right to exist. Especially the mother tongue is to be promoted. Everyone should be encouraged to learn the mother tongue. Unfortunately, many of the local languages in India are disappearing because of the domination of Hindi and English. Caldwell and Periyar were open to all cultures and languages. They brought respect and reverence for the local culture. Many of the tribal and indigenous people are forgetting their languages and their script due to the influence of English and Hindi. Every linguistic group in India should have the right to have a primary education in their own language. The local language has to be part of the curriculum. It is sad that some of the schools do not have the local language in their schools. It is once again a sign of colonialism and Brahminical domination.

Conclusion

Robert Caldwell and E.V. Ramasamy have influenced the culture of India especially south India. They have awakened the minds of the people to know their dignity and to stand up. As an outcome of such thinking, their language and culture is very much preserved and liberated from the age-old thinking of the Brahmins. Such propositions are falsified, due to the education and awareness of these great philosophers and reformers thinking in the 19th and 20th century. The society has a lot learn from them and their reach has to be promoted with the touch of forgiveness and love. Re-reading and re-visiting the thoughts of these great men is needed and relevant not only for now but for all time, to create a society of love and brotherhood in the whole universe with equal respect and reverence to everyone and every culture not condemning and putting down another's culture and self-respect.

Notes

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